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Assembling between Alignment and Tension

A Sociological Study of The Satanic Temple

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Abstract
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This dissertation applies an assemblage-informed analytical framework to the empirical case of The Satanic Temple (TST) to examine a contemporary religious movement engaged in social change. It explores how dynamics of alignment and tension shape the assemblage of TST, including its negotiations of stigma. Grounded in the sociology of religion, the study analyses TST across multiple levels: its positioning in relation to wider society, its internal cohesion and its enactment through individual practice. Particular attention is given to the role of value alignment, discourses, and aesthetic and emotional regimes in processes that stabilise or fragment the assemblage, as well as to how these dynamics are reflected in practice across digital and physical social spaces.

Empirically, the study draws on a mixed-methods design comprising digital material produced within TST, an online survey, semi-structured interviews, and participant observation. The study demonstrates how perspectives of alignment and tension, assemblage and practice can be integrated into a coherent analytical framework for the study of religious movements. It highlights how synergies between regimes of social ordering contribute to processes of territorialisation that stabilise the assemblage of TST, while tensions surrounding leadership, governance and activism generate processes of deterritorialisation. The findings confirm and extend previous research by demonstrating that activism alone cannot account for the assembling of TST. Stigma constitutes a central analytical concept, illuminating how the movement assembles under conditions of stigma and how members employ various forms of stigma management. The study also challenges understandings of alternative religiosity as primarily individualised by demonstrating how personal practices are shaped through collective frameworks and situated within broader socio-political contexts. Beyond the case of TST, the dissertation highlights the analytical value of assemblage-informed approaches for understanding dynamics in religious movements as relational processes of becoming.

Keywords: The Satanic Temple; New Religious Movements; Activism; Stigma; Assemblage Theory; Sociology of Religion.

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Dedication

Like the falling rocket's lights, this thesis traces assembling at a moment in the middle: between form and dispersion, coherence and lines of flight. It is dedicated to those who unsettle our preconceptions.

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Contents

1. Introduction 11
1.1 Aim and Research Questions 13
1.2 Scope and Outline 14
1.3 On the Category of Satanism 17
1.4 The Cultic Milieu Lens 21
1.5 Satanism as Tension and Alignment 28
1.5.1 Socio-Cultural Positioning 28
1.5.2 External Antagonism 33
1.5.3 Internal Tensions and Fragmentation 34
1.6 The US Social Landscape 36
1.6.1 Religion in Public Life and Christian nationalism 37
1.6.2 Values, National Mood and Demographics 39
1.6.3 Contemporary Satanism in the US 41

2. Theoretical Framework 43
2.1 Alignment and Tension 44
2.2 Religion as Assemblage 47
2.3 Dimensions of Practice Within the Assemblage 52
2.4 Stigma 55
2.5 Analytical Levels 58

3. Methodology 61
3.1 Digital Material 63
3.2 Survey 65
3.3 Interviews 70
3.4 Observations 73
3.5 Data Analysis 75
3.6 Positionality and Ethical Considerations 77

4. The Satanic Temple and Wider Society 83
4.1 Demographic Composition 83
4.2 Discontent as Tension 86
4.2.1 An Emotional Regime of Discontent 86
4.2.2 Discontent With Christian Nationalism 91
4.2.3 Discontent With Abortion Access 95
4.3 Visions of a Good Society 98
4.3.1 Separation of Church and State 99
4.3.2 Religious Pluralism as a Contested Terrain 102

4.4 Strategies and Alliances for Socio-Political Change 108
4.4.1 Engagement in Campaigns 109
4.4.2 Solidarity for Diversity 113
4.4.3 Alliances for Activism 116
4.5 Summary 119

5. Individual Practice and Stigma Experiences 121
5.1 Individual Practice 121
5.1.1 Practice Aligned With Shared Values 122
5.1.2 Co-Production of Practice in Communal Contexts 127
5.1.3 Negotiating Religion and Religious Others 133
5.2 Satan's Stigma 142
5.2.1 The Heavy Mark 142
5.2.2 Stigma Management 152
5.3 Summary 161

6. Internal Dynamics and Institutionalisation 163
6.1 "I Came for the Activism and I Stayed for the Community" 163
6.1.1 Forms of Participation 163
6.1.2 Patterns of Alignment 168
6.1.3 Coming Home and Satanic Joy 170
6.1.4 Goth or Not? Aesthetic Regimes 177
6.1.5 Communal Practice 186
6.2 Balancing Institutionalisation 192
6.2.1 Polity Tensions 192
6.2.2 Negotiating Activism 203
6.2.3 Looking Forward 210
6.3 Summary 211

7. Conclusion and Discussion 213
7.1 From the Cultic Milieu to the Milieu of Assembling 214
7.2 Assembling in Conditions of Stigma 215
7.3 Emotional Regimes of Belonging 218
7.4 Alignment Through Tension? 220
7.5 Spirals of Territorialisation and Deterritorialisation 224
7.6 Limitations of the Study 229
7.7 Assemblage as Relational Becoming 230

Bibliography 233

Appendix I 243

Appendix II 261

Appendix III 267

List of Figures

Figure 1. Distribution of Americans on Christian Nationalism Scale. 39
Figure 2. Overview of the empirical material included in the study.....62
Figure 3. Thematic areas covered by TST Survey 2024.....66
Figure 4. Overview of survey-based studies on Satanism 69
Figure 5. Overview of conducted interviews. 72
Figure 6. Religious upbringing. 85
Figure 7. How important for you are the following TST campaigns? 110
Figure 8. In which of these campaigns are you personally involved? 110
Figure 9. The Salem Art Gallery, the headquarters of TST 143
Figure 10. How often, if ever, do you worry that the following might happen because of your engagement with TST?.....145
Figure 11. Perceived unequal treatment outside TST by identity aspect.....149
Figure 12. How comfortable do you feel or would you feel to 'come out' 155
Figure 13. Aesthetic regimes I.. 180
Figure 14. Aesthetic regimes II.....181
Figure 15. Interior of The Salem Art Gallery. 189

Abbreviations

ATP	American Trends Panel
CoS	Church of Satan
GSS	General Social Survey
NRMs	new religious movements
PRRI	Public Religion Research Institute
RLS	Religious Landscape Study
SoCC	Satanists of Color Coalition
SRA(S)	Satanic ritual abuse (scare)
TST	The Satanic Temple
TSTTV	The Satanic Temple television channel

1. Introduction

Since its first appearance in the American public space in early 2013, The Satanic Temple (TST), with its religious practices and advocacy efforts, has attracted media attention and controversy. Seen by some as a mere joke, by others as a dark cloud on the horizon—and by still others as a necessary challenge to Christian nationalism—TST has raised questions about the meaning of religion and the premises of religion's role in a modern liberal democracy (Laycock 2020). From a sociological perspective, the emergence of TST can be understood as an example of a new religious movement within the Satanic milieu, positioning itself as an actor for social change.

There are several ways to situate the emergence of TST. One is to underscore how the trajectories of contemporary Satanism are entangled with the broader landscape of religion in public life in the United States, including the legal infrastructures governing religious freedom, the rise of Christian nationalism, and shifting cultural values. In the last two decades the Supreme Court's jurisprudence has legitimised religious manifestations in public institutions such as religious monuments on public grounds, confessional after-school activities, and prayer at city council meetings. Religious organisations outside the Christian majority have begun to seek equal representation in the public sphere, which in several cases resulted in protests, controversies, and lawsuits (Bentele et al. 2013; Wexler 2020). The desire for a legitimate place as an alternative religious group in a public space dominated by Christian religious manifestations led Malcolm Jarry and Lucien Greaves[1] to initiate a chain of events that led to the founding of TST.

Jarry and Greaves first bonded over a conversation in which they both agreed that public schools were prison-like institutions (Laycock 2020: 27f). Given their intense feelings about school policy, it is unsurprising that TST's first public intervention addressed Florida Governor Rick Scott's bill permitting students to promote religious ideas at school events (Ng 2013). TST organised an event in support of the bill, declaring that their organisation "embraces the free expression of religion, and Satanists are happy to show their support of Rick Scott who [...] has reaffirmed our American freedom to practice our faith openly, allowing our Satanic children the freedom to pray in school" (The Satanic Temple to Rally n.d.).

[1] Malcolm Jarry and Lucien Greaves are pseudonyms that the co-founders use both within TST and to represent the organisation to the wider public.

For many outside the movement, TST first entered public consciousness through its high-profile campaign to install a Baphomet statue alongside a Ten Commandments monument on the grounds of the Oklahoma state capitol—a symbolic and legal intervention that generated extensive media attention and debates about religious pluralism in the US (Chokshi 2013; Oppenheimer 2015). Public visibility increased further with Penny Lane's documentary *Hail Satan?* (2019), which introduced the organisation to global audiences and also sparked my initial academic interest in TST.

While media reports on the public activities of TST have debated whether the whole thing is a politically targeted prank, a dangerous cult, the beginning of a new religious movement or all of the above, TST has expanded its advocacy on a spectrum of issues, attracted (according to the founders) thousands of new members, initiated a series of lawsuits and grown into a full-fledged organisation with local branches.

Many of the campaigns and the legal battles in which TST has engaged—from religious representation in public fora to its involvement in debates on reproductive health rights in the US—would not be possible without its positioning as a religious organisation. As Laycock (2020: 125) notes, "TST *became* a religion as they attempted to participate in a larger conversation about religious freedom".[2]

As a religious community and an actor for social change, TST has two types of involvement: congregations and campaigns. Congregations focus mostly on building community, while campaigns focus on specific issues and work to bring about social change. There are different levels of involvement in TST and these can change over time. Actors may become members of a local congregation and engage with that community and/or participate in TST's campaigns. However, people who donate to TST's campaigns are not necessarily members and many of them may not even consider themselves Satanists. Participants in TST's community may gather at events such as concerts, film nights or conferences organised by the religious group, or they may meet online and stay in touch through social media and other digital means. Active members can also be ordained as ministers of Satan.

Taking its place in an increasingly polarised society, with several schisms in its record, and after some major organisational restructurings, the future of TST remains uncertain—yet its role as a religious and activist movement warrants scholarly attention.

[2] TST has been involved in processes concerning its religious recognition since its inception. As Sullivan (2005) argues, American law does not recognise religion as a stable category; rather, religion is continually produced through legal interpretation in response to specific disputes. As she concludes, "legally encompassing the religious ways of people in an intensely pluralist society is most likely impossible" (2005: 138). According to Greaves, the organisation's recognition by the Internal Revenue Service (IRS) in 2019 should be understood as a formal acknowledgement of TST as a religion (Dickson 2019). Colin (2021) similarly argues that the district court decision in Satanic Temple v. City of Scottsdale (No. 2:18-cv-00621) affirms TST's status as a religious organisation within a legal framework.

1.1 Aim and Research Questions

The aim of this dissertation is to apply an assemblage-informed analytical framework to the empirical case of TST in order to examine a contemporary religious movement engaged in social change. The study adopts a social-constructivist epistemological perspective, focusing on processes of alignment and tension that shape the movement's assembling as a new religious formation and as an agent for social change, including its negotiations of stigma. To examine this assembling between alignment and tension the study analyses TST across different levels: its positioning in relation to wider society, its internal cohesion, and its enactment as individual practice. Particular attention is paid to the role of value alignment, discourses, aesthetic regimes and emotional regimes in stabilising or fragmentating the assemblage, and to how these are reflected in practice across digital and physical social spaces. Further discussion of the assemblage perspective and the role of discourse in it follows in Chapter 2.

By synthesising conceptual frameworks attentive to assemblage formation, alignment, and practice, and through their empirical application, the dissertation contributes to theoretical and methodological discussions within the sociology of contemporary religion. It advances an analytical approach applicable beyond the specific case of Satanism, and relevant to the study of movements in which religion and work for social change are intertwined.

The dissertation is guided by the overarching research question:

> *How do dynamics of alignment and tension shape the assemblage of The Satanic Temple?*

To explore this general question, the study addresses the following sub-questions, each examined in a separate empirical chapter:

> *How does The Satanic Temple assemble in relation to wider society?* (Chapter 4)

> *How does The Satanic Temple assemble through participants' negotiations of Satanic practice and stigma?* (Chapter 5)

> *How does The Satanic Temple assemble through internal dynamics and institutionalisation?* (Chapter 6)

The order in which the micro, meso, and macro levels are approached in this thesis implies an openness to rearrangement, with no analytical level considered primary or a necessary starting point. Instead, it reflects the study's theoretical orientation—approaching religion as an assemblage—that

emphasises tracing the links, movements, and interplay between these analytically constructed levels.

1.2 Scope and Outline

The primary motivation for this study has been theoretical curiosity. My research engagement began with a broader question concerning how religion and activism intersect, and TST offered a particularly productive case through which to explore this relationship. My choice of TST was also informed by a sustained interest in the lived experience of community—especially within an emerging religious movement that emphasises individual autonomy while simultaneously cultivating a shared identity and practice.

This empirical exploration of TST does not centre on the official narrative as articulated by the movement's co-founders Jarry and Greaves. Instead, the material reflects experiences, attitudes, and practices from the perspectives of other actors that engage in the movement. Results are derived from four primary sources: survey responses, interviews, digital material, and observations. Rather than focusing on a single local congregation as a delimited case, I chose to investigate a broader landscape of diverse forms of engagement. This decision was a practical response to the nature of the field itself, in which local groups form, dissolve, or discontinue their affiliation, and individuals appear and disappear over time.

Collection of empirical material was conducted during a period marked by internal fragmentation within TST, as well as heightened polarisation and socio-political tension, particularly in the US and Canada where most of the interviewees and respondents reside. 2024 was a super-election year, and the American presidential campaign was characterised by deep ideological divides and escalating hostility. Canada also underwent a significant political crisis that culminated in the resignation of Prime Minister Justin Trudeau in early January 2025. These developments likely influenced both the recruitment process and the responses gathered during the study.

Interviews and insights from the digital material reflect the perspectives of a deeply involved group. Of the 11 interview participants, 9 belong to a highly engaged subgroup, serving as ministers of Satan, members of local congregation leadership, or both. One interviewee was pursuing the ordination program for ministers, which provides access to leadership roles within local congregations. TST's religious services, which constitute the larger part of the digital material, are led by ordained ministers, with discussion panels consisting of both ministers and regular members, thus again incorporating viewpoints from those with significant involvement in the movement. In contrast, the survey captures a broader membership: among 136 respondents, most identify as

members or non-member allies (n = 94; 69%), while about a third hold ministerial or organisational roles (n = 42; 31%).[3]

Approaching the assembling of TST may generate expectations that this study is going to trace the young religious organisation's development across time, treating emergence as a chronological unfolding from beginnings to later stages, suitable for before/after comparisons. Such a model of process-as-temporal-sequence can be analytically productive. However, I adopt a relational understanding of emergence informed by assemblage theory. My interest in assembling dynamics is therefore directed at a specific temporal configuration of links and relations among heterogeneous elements across micro-, meso-, and macro-levels.

This distinction is crucial. A chronological process model would necessitate a longitudinal design. Given my theoretical perspective, such a design is neither methodologically necessary nor desirable. Rather than producing an exhaustive account of TST's origins or situating its doctrine within the wider context of Satanism—tasks more closely aligned with approaches taken by the history of religions or systematic theology—this project employs TST as a case through which to develop a theoretical model for understanding a contemporary religious group. My sociologically informed analysis therefore focuses on what Deleuze and Guattari (2013: 22, 26) describe as a moment "in the middle", in which multiple relations within the assemblage are already in motion, accelerating and continually reconfiguring. Still, the empirical material should be understood as a cross-sectional capture of alignments and tensions that in some form or another pre-date the study and that will likely continue to transform the assembling of TST beyond it.

The assemblage approach also clarifies how core themes, such as concerns about church–state entanglement, are treated. While this issue is indeed foundational in TST's public discourse (as demonstrated by Laycock 2020 and Colin 2021), the aim here is not to emphasise its centrality at organisational level. Instead, I analyse how this concern is articulated, negotiated, and made meaningful within the 'intermezzo' under study, and more specifically how members (rather than co-founders) express, feel and link this concern to other aspects of the current assemblage. In other words, acknowledging that church–state critique plays a crucial role in TST's top–down formation does not render contemporary member-level expressions self-evident: rather, it invites examination of how these articulations interact with emotions, values, and visions of a good society and appropriate activist practice.

This point applies to the study of TST's schismatic tendencies as well. One possible approach would be to examine schisms through movement texts or spokespersons' statements, foregrounding schism as a leader-driven

[3] Unless otherwise stated, all percentages in this thesis, both from the 2024 survey of individuals engaged in TST and from other surveys discussed, are rounded to the nearest whole number; consequently, totals may not sum to exactly 100 per cent.

organisational event. In this dissertation, I take a different methodological route and approach internal tensions as relations within the assemblage, manifested in member-level practices and negotiations. Once again, this bottom-up perspective does not deny the importance of institutional proclamations; rather, it investigates tendencies of fragmentation and homogenisation as they emerge in lived practice.

*

In this introductory chapter, I establish the foundation of the study by presenting its objectives, research questions and scope, situating the inquiry within previous conceptual work and studies on Satanism, and outlining the sociocultural context in which TST operates.

Chapter 2 develops the theoretical lens through which I analyse the empirical material. It introduces alignment and tension as a theoretical perspective, frames religion as an assemblage, and considers stigma to be an important aspect within this assemblage. The chapter foregrounds the role of value alignment, discourses, aesthetic regimes and emotional regimes as dimensions of practice through which processes of stabilisation and fragmentation are produced in the assemblage. I conclude the chapter by outlining how these theoretical perspectives inform the analytical approach, demonstrating how they enable an understanding of TST as both individual and collective practice situated in a specific context.

In Chapter 3, I turn to method, detailing the qualitative approach that combines a survey, interviews, digital material, and participant observation. This chapter also addresses analytical strategies, ethical considerations, and highlights how researcher positionality shapes knowledge production.

The empirical analysis unfolds across three chapters. In Chapter 4, I examine TST's assembling in relation to its host society. The analysis focuses on demographic composition, socio-political attitudes and aspirations, as well as strategies for activist engagement. Attention is paid to how value alignment, discourses, and emotional regimes contribute to the assembling of TST as both a religious and a socially engaged movement.

Chapter 5 moves to TST participants' everyday experiences and practices, analysing how members craft ritual while negotiating belonging within a shared moral framework, and navigate the stigma associated with Satanism.

Chapter 6 shifts focus to internal dynamics within TST, exploring how the movement is assembled through various forms of participation, resources and governance practices. The chapter foregrounds the role of value alignment, aesthetic regimes and emotional regimes as factors that bring cohesion. It also traces the frictions that arise in relation to processes of institutionalisation and decentralisation.

Finally, in Chapter 7, I reassess the analysis in relation to the aim and research questions. I revisit previous research and reflect on the implications for

understanding the central theoretical concepts, synthesising how alignment and tension shape the assembling of TST across multiple scales—from societal positioning to internal processes and everyday practice. In doing so, I articulate an analytical approach that extends beyond this case, relevant to the study of movements in which religious formations and projects for social change are intertwined, and opening up further lines of inquiry.

1.3 On the Category of Satanism

In this section, I focus on definitions of the category 'Satanism', because such conceptual work does more than delineate a scholarly field—it actively shapes it. In line with the thesis's social-constructivist approach[4], definitions help construct what counts as Satanism both within and beyond academia. They influence how researchers formulate their questions, which actors and practices become analytically visible, and feed back into the movements themselves, where groups can strategically mobilise available definitional frameworks.

This is particularly relevant for my study because groups such as TST, which emphasise rationality and scientific knowledge, actively engage with academic work on Satanism by including it in recommended reading lists and educational programmes for ministers. This engagement underscores the dialogical relationship between scholarly discourse and the assembling of a religious movement. The reflexivity of this process was also evident in my interviews with TST members. Interviewees sometimes referenced academic concepts such as 'identification' and 'attribution', and occasionally cited scholars of Satanism when articulating their own experiences. For these reasons, how Satanism is defined, classified and conceptually approached in the literature is crucial for understanding how boundaries and legitimacy are negotiated within the religious movement.

Satanism scholars have proposed definitions and classifications with different emphases. Early definitions of Satanism consistently locate it within the domain of witchcraft and ritual magic. One of the first sociological accounts of Satanism frames it as "a worship of the Judaeo-Christian Devil, which is, at times, only a symbol and, at other times, very literally real", emphasising that "varying degrees of fundamentalism exist among Satanists" (Truzzi 1972:

[4] While both terms have at times been used interchangeably and at other times to signal different emphases (Hjelm 2014: 6), I use the term 'constructivism' rather than 'constructionism', as I find that it more clearly foregrounds the critical and emancipatory potential of the paradigm. The 'constructiv[e]' element of the term emphasises that disciplinary approaches should be open to refinement, and that an awareness of the constructed nature of social realities can contribute to processes of social transformation. By retaining the 'social' in the concept, I also underline that my approach does not frame sense-making as an individual cognitive process, but as a product of situated and power-laden social interaction.

23). While witchcraft, which Truzzi places in the same branch of occult currents as Satanism, positions itself as a pre-Christian suppressed knowledge, Satanism takes shape as "a kind of inverted Christian sect" (Truzzi 1972: 24). In a later formulation, Truzzi (1974: 639) conceptualises Satanism as the Black Witches branch of modern witchcraft.

Furthermore, Truzzi (1972) observes that there are different forms of engagement with Satanism: some Satanists are solitary and some belong to groups. He contends that Satanic groups display considerable diversity and identifies four main types. One type reflects an inverted form of Gnostic Christianity. Another is centred around eroticism, including interest in pornography, sadomasochistic practices, and flagellation. A third is associated with drug subcultures. The fourth, and by far the most prominent at the time, is the Church of Satan (CoS) which Truzzi describes as hierarchically organised and defines as a church rather than a cult.

Similarly, Alfred's (1976) ethnographic study, based on covert participant observations between 1968 and 1973, situates the CoS within what he terms "organised black-magic groups", describing it as the most institutionalised element of the witchcraft landscape of that period. Continuing in the same classificatory tradition, Melton's (2003) *Encyclopaedia of American Religions* places Satanism within the so-called "Magick Family", together with Ritual Magick, Witchcraft, Neo-Paganism and Voodoo.

Partridge (2004) situates both Satanism and Paganism within the broader field of Western occulture[5], while explicitly warning against conflating the two. He notes shared features such as deity symbolism, emphasis on self-development, and hedonistic values, particularly in left-hand path traditions. Drawing mainly on the CoS's founder Anton Szandor LaVey, Partridge characterises Satanism as "a self-religion or human potential spirituality which utilises the rebellious, offensive, and provocative symbolism of the figure of Satan" (2004: 82). At the same time, he acknowledges that some branches of Satanism adopt a theistic orientation, complicating simple categorisations.

Introvigne (2016: 3) identifies social structure and ritual practice as essential criteria, defining Satanism as the organised and ritualised worship of the biblical Devil. His definition remains inclusive of groups that interpret Satan abstractly or anchor the figure's meaning in non-Christian religious frameworks, provided that the names Satan or Lucifer remain central identifiers. Introvigne observes that literal adoration of evil is rare, as most Satanists attach positive meanings to Satan.

In contrast, van Luijk (2016) prioritises the relational aspect to Satan—real or assumed—over institutional or ritual dimensions. Drawing on Bellah's

[5] Partridge (2004: 84-85) conceptualises occulture as a diffuse reservoir of symbols, practices, and ideas from which individuals selectively draw. It operates as a shared cultural resource, shaping both committed spiritual engagement and more casual or aesthetic forms of participation. In this sense, occulture supports highly individualised religiosity while simultaneously enabling common repertoires and broader cultural circulation.

conception of religion as symbolic acts that connect humans to ultimate conditions of existence, van Luijk (2016: 2) defines Satanism as "the intentional, religiously motivated veneration of Satan", preferring "veneration" to "worship" to include non-theistic forms. He restricts the figure of Satan to its Christian context, arguing that the biblical Satan must dominate a person's religion for it to qualify as Satanism.

Faxneld (2017: 25) offers a broader formulation, describing Satanism as "a system in which Satan is celebrated in a prominent position". Granholm (2009a, 2013) reconceptualises classification as a reflexive methodological issue. He grounds scholarly categorisation in actors' self-understandings, proposing what he considers less negatively charged categories, namely 'left-hand path' and 'post-Satanism'.[6]

According to Petersen (2009: 224), a minimum of four factors are required to define a group as organised Satanism: "self-religion, antinomianism, the use of certain 'S'-words, and a formulated ideological genealogy, often in the form of some relation to Anton Szandor LaVey". In later work, Petersen adopts a broader sociological perspective that combines Paul Heelas's concept of 'self-religion', Colin Campbell's notion of the 'cultic milieu', and a discursive approach. Petersen (2011: 13) thus frames contemporary religious Satanism as "a number of antinomian 'self-religious' discourses and practices utilised by a bewildering number of groups and individuals acting in a heterogeneous 'satanic milieu'".

Extending these definitional efforts, Petersen and Dyrendal (2012) suggest that Satanism is shaped by two distinct but interrelated discourses: 'discourses on the satanic' drawing on Christian understandings of Satan as evil, and 'satanic discourses' that reflect self-declared Satanists' interpretations of Satan as a positive symbol. Discourses on the satanic are related to moral panics and construct an imaginary Satanism "as the Other of Christian or secular culture" (216). Satanic discourses, on the other hand, go back to anti-religious and establishment critique from the age of Enlightenment and Romanticism, mostly manifested as a literary tradition, but their wider dissemination is a more recent phenomenon.

Occulture, in Partridge's understanding, provides a base for socialisation or priming within the Satanic milieu (Dyrendal 2008, Petersen and Dyreldal 2012, Dyrendal et al. 2015). The consumption of popular culture with devilish motifs contributes to dedicated Satanists' rhetorics of being 'born' a Satanist or 'coming home' to Satanism. Occulture provides a rich bank of sources for Satanists' individual meaning-making, characterised as pick-and-mix or

[6] Granholm positions 'left-hand path' as a distinct branch of Western esotericism, characterised by pronounced individualism, an emphasis on personal spiritual development and self-deification, a psycho-physical conception of the human, a this-worldly orientation, and an antinomian stance towards dominant religious and cultural norms. The narrower term 'post-Satanism' refers to groups that incorporate Satanic elements without self-identifying as Satanic, or that draw on alternative mythological figures (e.g., the Temple of Set).

bricolage. In this formation of Satanism, "cultural processes of dis- and re-embedding" (as conceptualised by Giddens) of Christian elements play a significant role, yet Satanism cannot be reduced to an inverted form of Christianity (Petersen and Dyrendal 2012: 215). Within the hypothetical course of socialisation in the Satanic milieu, Petersen and Dyrendal (2012: 224) emphasise the interaction of several additional factors: "Through a combination of intellectual 'fit', emotional support, and social networks, our young Satanist can gradually develop the resources, practices, and attitudes necessary to internalize a 'satanic identity' and express it together with others".

*

My approach diverges from previous conceptual contributions in that I do not seek to propose a new definition of Satanism. In this respect, it resonates with Laycock's (2020: 87) move away from fixed beliefs, practices, or ideologies, instead understanding Satanism as an 'imagined community' (in Benedict Anderson's sense), in which "every self-identifying Satanist holds a mental conception of a Satanic tradition with which they feel a sense of connection". While acknowledging the methodological utility of working terminology—particularly in establishing and delimiting a subfield—I refrain from adopting a strict definition. This choice is motivated by three considerations.

First, attempts to establish minimum criteria for religion in general, or for specific forms such as Satanism, tend to reproduce the logic of the world religions paradigm problematised by Masuzawa (2005). Guided by Adorno's (2000) principle of non-identity, I do not assume that all Satanic groups necessarily share common characteristics. Non-identity thinking encourages exploration beyond similarities and directs attention to particularities, allowing the heterogeneous, the irreducible, and even the alien to become visible. It thus enables a more open engagement with the distinctiveness of TST as an assemblage situated in a particular temporal and socio-cultural context. This position is in line with lived religion approaches' move away from "pre-defined understandings of religion as a starting point of analysis in favor of an emphasis on the activities and interpretations of individuals" (Knibbe and Kupari 2020: 159).

Second, avoiding definitional closure positions this study outside authenticity discourses. While conceptual frames of 'authentic' Satanism may serve emic religious claims and, in TST's case, advocacy goals, such frames risk marginalising those deemed 'inauthentic'. Rather than asking what 'religion', 'Satanism', or TST are as sets of characteristics, I instead direct attention to the becoming itself, understood as an ongoing, relational, and contingent process.

Third, this approach is in line with assemblage thinking, which is fundamental to my theoretical framework. It is directly informed by Deleuze and Guattari's (2013) understanding of becoming—not imitation, identification, or the production of a subject that fits an existing category, but an invitation

to move beyond the categorical. “We fall into a false alternative if we say that you either imitate or you are”, Deleuze and Guattari argue (2013: 277). Accordingly, this thesis focuses not on the stasis implied by representing a category (of religion) but on the processual logics of becoming. The analytical perspective is directed not toward Satanism as a religious category but toward TST as a specific becoming. This thesis therefore explores several of the aspects emphasised in previous definitions empirically through the lens of alignment. It expands the scope beyond the discursive dimension to include emotional and aesthetic regimes, rituals, and celebrations. These are accessed primarily through practitioners’ individual reflections, rather than through analysis of canonical texts alone. This shift allows attention to be placed on the power-laden and socially patterned alignments and tensions through which TST forms as an assemblage. It includes how members recognise shared values and how they translate them into activist aims and everyday practices; how they engage or disengage with TST at local, national, and transnational levels; and how they negotiate boundaries.

1.4 The Cultic Milieu Lens

A recurring set of questions in the sociology of religion concern why new religious movements (NRMs) arise, what their social locus is in terms of demography, how NRMs form and develop, and what these processes reveal about broader patterns of social change and religious innovation (Beckford 1975; Bromley and Shupe 1979; Stark and Bainbridge 1985; Bruce 1990; Dawson 2009). Such questions have shaped much of the classic and contemporary research on alternative spiritualities and emergent religious formations such as TST, often framed within larger narratives of individualisation and secularisation.[7]

The purpose of this subsection is to examine how these issues have been addressed in previous research by critically unpacking Campbell’s concept of the ‘cultic milieu’. Given its influential status as a framework within scholarship on alternative religiosity, including contemporary Satanism, the cultic milieu perspective warrants careful consideration. As noted in the previous section on definitions (1.3), Petersen (2011) characterises contemporary Satanism as embedded in a heterogeneous Satanic milieu, positioning it as a sub-milieu within the broader cultic milieu. Discussing both the analytical

[7] Among scholars working in this field, the assumption that secularisation entails the disappearance of religion from the public sphere has increasingly been debated and problematised. Rather than viewing contemporary societies as ever more secular in the sense of being less religious, concepts such as de-secularisation and post-secularisation have been proposed to account for the continuing presence and transformation of religious and spiritual expressions. (Stevenson et al. 2010: 327–228).

potential and the limitations of the cultic milieu as a concept allows me to demonstrate why it cannot adequately account for TST's formation.

Much of the conceptual work on NRMs engages with ideas that go back to Max Weber and Ernst Troeltsch (Swatos 1976), which imply that groups like TST are essentially or functionally different from churches—the dominant template of religious organisation in the Western world—and that a religious group's relation to the social order is important to categorising it as a church, sect, mystic group, or cult. My own theoretical framework of tension and alignment (presented in the next chapter) recalls this tradition, as it foregrounds relational positioning.

Campbell's (2002) extension of the classic conceptualisations of religious formation builds on Troeltsch's idea of mysticism and contrasts cults—as expressions of mysticism—with sects. Sects are structured, doctrinally defined and enduring. Cults, by contrast, are loosely organised, individualistic and transient. They emphasise first-hand mystical experience rather than institutional forms. Campbell places individual cults within a broader cultic milieu—a persistent cultural underground that contains heterodox beliefs and practices. This milieu is diverse but still united through shared characteristics such as marginality, mutual tolerance and an ideology of seekership. It encourages syncretism, high turnover and continual innovation.

In what follows, particular attention is paid to dimensions of the concept of the cultic milieu as addressed in related research—namely, an emphasis on syncretism and innovation, the accommodation of deviant science, an individualistic orientation, and their implications for understanding processes of secularisation. By engaging with these aspects, I also prepare the ground for an alternative analytical perspective that can capture the assembling of TST as a religious movement oriented towards social change.

Syncretism and Innovation

While Campbell's conceptualisation of the cultic milieu draws attention to similarities across otherwise diverse and often ephemeral movements, it also has analytical limitations. Its treatment of syncretism as a specifically cultic characteristic is open to question. Most scholars would agree that empirically all religious beliefs and practices are historically specific amalgams of ideas and behaviours with a myriad of individual variations, rather than pure forms. This opens space for an approach that can account for both fluidity and the relational processes through which temporary stabilisation is achieved.

Closely related to debates on syncretism and religious bricolage—especially regarding the incorporation of diverse sources, including popular culture, and its relationship to claims of religious legitimacy—are concepts such as 'invented' religion (Cusack 2013), 'fiction-based' religion (Davidsen 2013), 'hyper-real' religion (Possamai 2012), and Chidester's (2005) analysis of popular culture–inspired religions as performances of 'authenticity'. These

approaches share an interest in religious formations that draw on diverse cultural resources.

Possamai (2012) conceptualises such phenomena in terms of 'hyper-real religion', emphasising the increasing entanglement of religion, consumption, media, and popular culture in contemporary societies. He argues that this trend is likely to expand, driven by the affordances of online spaces, which enable experimentation with identity and belief with reduced stigma. Similarly, Cusack (2013, 2016) highlights the significance of play, creativity, humour, and fiction in meaning-making, arguing that 'invented' religions often blur conventional distinctions between the serious and the playful. Drawing on examples such as Wicca and Discordianism, she maintains that while NRMs generally imitate features characteristic of traditional religions, invented religions do so in a more self-reflective manner: they acknowledge their status as constructed traditions while using the ludic as a source of meaning-making and identity construction. Contributing to the scholarly discussions of play as a form of sincere engagement, Wilcox (2018) employs the notion of 'serious parody' to analyse the Sisters of Perpetual Indulgence. She sees their earnest identification with nuns, reclamation of cultural symbols, and parody of the Catholic Church as a means of creating space for political activism and community service. Serious parody is thus conceptualised as "a strategy of ludic, performative politics" operating at the intersection of religion, activism, and queerness (Wilcox 2018: 3).

Particularly informative for this thesis are the contributions of Davidsen (2013), Taira (2013a), and Laycock (2013), who shift attention away from questions of authenticity and towards the ways religious legitimacy is established, justified, and negotiated. Davidsen's term 'fiction-based' captures formations such as Jediism and the Tolkien-inspired Elven community that draw on concepts, rituals, and identities derived from specific fictional narratives or genres. While acknowledging the strictly fictional character of the narrative, participants in these communities nevertheless employ it as a resource for meaning-making and identity construction. Importantly, Davidsen (2013: 391) calls for greater attention to "how fictional sources are combined with conventional religious elements in fiction-based religion, and how religionists legitimise their use of fiction".

Similar concerns are evident in the work of Taira (2013a) who proposes an alternative approach to examining so-called invented religions by situating them within broader discourses on religion. He encourages scholars to link individual cases to their wider social contexts in order to conceptually map the growth of such groups. From a discursive perspective, the question of whether these religions are authentic is irrelevant, he argues; the key point is that the label 'religion' operates as a strategic instrument of power that produces real and tangible effects. It facilitates the formation of collective identities, mobilised to secure public legitimacy and obtain certain rights and benefits. In this

way, invoking 'religion' discursively enables marginal actors and communities to gain visibility and assert their voice in the public sphere.

In the same vein, Laycock (2013) addresses the conceptual tension between parody and realness in relation to invented religions (such as the Neo-American Church from the 1960s and the more recent Church of the Flying Spaghetti Monster). He situates the creative and purposeful use of the grammar of established religions by such groups within two broader contexts: the Western invention of religion as a universal, culturally independent category with a specific set of features, and the role of Western democratic governance in determining what counts as legitimate religion. Laycock emphasises that parody religions often pursue political objectives that challenge dominant understandings of religion and their translation into policy. The seriousness of such groups becomes salient when these groups expose underlying hegemonies: "The pretence of joking wears especially thin when adherents of these parody religions appear before Senate committees or take legal action to pursue the same rights and privileges afforded to established religions" (Laycock 2013: 20).

These perspectives resonate with the assemblage approach adopted in this thesis. Rather than describing religious practice within TST as syncretic, the focus is on how heterogeneous elements become linked and stabilised through processes of alignment. The emphasis is therefore not only on what components are assembled, but also on how their combination is legitimised or contested.

Deviant Science

Campbell's inclusion of the religion–science axis is valuable; however, his association of the cultic milieu with deviant science oversimplifies the complex ways in which such groups negotiate both conventional and heterodox scientific discourses. For the present study, the relationship between religion and science is relevant in examining how TST constructs legitimacy through its emphasis on rationalism and non-superstition.

Given that occultism is often construed as deviant science, Truzzi (1974) contends that the study of the occult should be situated within the sociology of knowledge. Yet, he observes that "[a]lthough much occultism stems from mysticism and anti-scientific philosophical premises, much of it is naturalistic and pragmatic" (629). Drawing on Weber's typology of authority—traditional, rational-legal, and charismatic—Truzzi further argues that Satanic groups such as CoS typically ground their authority not only in charismatic leadership but also in rational-legal claims.

Notably, Lewis (2003) identifies shifts in the character of authority within LaVeyan Satanism. Initially, the CoS relied primarily on rational authority, rooted in a secularist worldview and LaVey's appeal to science. While charismatic authority was short-lived after LaVey dissolved CoS as a formal religious organisation, traditional authority grew stronger: successors, such as

Michael Aquino (founder of the Temple of Set), reproduced traditional modes of legitimation by elevating LaVey as a quasi-sacred figure ("Black Pope") and treating The Satanic Bible as if it were revealed scripture. In modern Satanism outside CoS—such as loosely organised groups and online Satanist fora—Lewis observes a new emphasis on rationality and a critical stance toward The Satanic Bible.

As Lewis (2010b) argues, the prestige of science, whether attached to science proper or emic notions of empirical proof, is also mobilised by traditional religions to frame their beliefs and practices as rational and legitimate.[8] In his typology of strategies through which religions appeal to the authority of science, Lewis gives Satanism as an example of a naturalistic worldview. This classification, I argue, aptly describes TST given its strong emphasis on non-superstition and rationalist principles. However, in the case of TST, another mode identified by Lewis is also applicable: terminological/rhetorical apologetics, which involves the strategic deployment of scientific and technological language to reinforce legitimacy. Lewis (2010b: 35) further notes that "a different way in which religions, especially controversial NRMs, seek legitimacy is by actively encouraging social scientific studies of their groups".[9]

Petersen (2010) distinguishes between rationalist and esoteric forms of Satanism. This distinction rests on whether authority is grounded in scientific or esoteric knowledge. He argues that LaVeyan Satanism, as well as most Satanic discourse, "could be understood as a blend of scientific and religious discourse," giving rise to "a wide variety of 'creolizations' or 'syncretisms' on a religion–science axis" (68). Like Truzzi, Petersen (2010: 76) argues that "rationalist Satanism also utilizes traditional and charismatic legitimation strategies"; he applies Hanegraaff's concept of "esotericized secularism" to rationalist Satanism, describing it as an "anti-religious thrust that attempts to build a tradition on a disenchanted worldview".

Valuable for this discussion is also Hammer's (2003) analysis of emic epistemologies, which offers an account of how legitimacy is constructed in NRMs through reference to science. Hammer (2003: 44) employs George Herbert Mead's concept of Significant Others—positive and negative reference points used in identity and worldview formation—to explain how movements position themselves epistemically. Among the strategies Hammer identifies, the most relevant for this discussion is 'scientism', defined as

[8] As Plaisance (2016) demonstrates, the adoption of scientifically inspired religious discourse is not a new phenomenon, but can already be observed in nineteenth-century Spiritist and Theosophical writings.

[9] As Beckford (2003: 154) observes, controversial NRMs tend to use research findings to shape their image in the mass media in a more positive light, and their high levels of "self-reflexivity", together with active engagement with research, constitute a dimension that makes the study of NRMs more complex. Despite similar tendencies towards encouraging academic engagement, researchers have at times struggled to gain access to Satanic groups (see Chapter 3).

> the active positioning of one's own claims in relation to the manifestations of any academic scientific discipline, including, but not limited to, the use of technical devices, scientific terminology, mathematical calculations, theories, references and stylistic features—without, however, the use of methods generally approved within the scientific community, and without subsequent social acceptance of these manifestations by the mainstream of the scientific community through e.g. peer reviewed publication in academic journals. (Hammer 2003: 206)

This strategy often manifests through a rhetoric of rationality. Significant Others function not only within scientism as a discourse of authority, but also as rhetoric tools in emic strategies of traditionalisation, through which historical pasts and culturally distant traditions—real or imagined—are selectively appropriated and recontextualised to lend authenticity (Hammer 2003: 33).

Individualism

Campbell characterises the cultic milieu as largely devoid of "dogmas, sacraments, ministry or indeed any formal organisation", which leads him to frame it as markedly individualistic (2002: 27). At the same time, he notes that "a variety of organizational forms can be seen within this framework," and that "the formal character of the cultic institutions derives from the nature of the cultural tradition of which they represent deviant forms" (Campbell 2002: 28). This disjunction within Campbell's account—between diffuse individualism and emergent organisational forms—provides a useful point of departure.

Despite being active for little more than a decade, TST has established formal tenets, developed a partly codified ritual dimension, built an organisational structure, and placed strong emphasis on community alongside individual autonomy. However, Campbell largely interprets instances of institutionalisation in relation to the internal culture of seekership within the cultic milieu, rather than shaped by opportunities and constraints in the wider social and legal context, or the groups' engagement in social change.

As early analyses of the 'religious revival' in the US during the 1960s and 1970s suggest, emergent groups have long navigated legitimacy and institutional form—dynamics already visible in the emergence of organised Satanism with the CoS. Zaretsky and Leone (1974) observe that NRMs influence one another as they adapt to the conditions of their host societies. Their trajectories are shaped by both internal dynamics within the field of NRMs and by precedents established through legal struggles for recognition and constitutional protection. In this sense, TST's organisational development cannot be understood in isolation from its positioning *vis-à-vis* legal constraints in its host society.

As Wexler (2020: 158) argues, pushing boundaries associated with the First Amendment[10] in the US is not about isolated battles but reflects a broader pattern:

> non-Christians—including both Atheists and members of minority religious groups—have begun to demand their place in American public life. Groups like the Summum, the American Atheists, and the Satanic Temple have asked to have their monuments erected on government property. Various Atheist groups, Wiccans, and others have put up temporary religious displays alongside creches and other Christian holiday symbols in public parks and buildings. […] Secularists and Satanists have started their own after-school clubs in the classrooms of public schools across the nation.

Within this context, the adoption of recognisable religious features—such as the Seven Tenets, rituals, holidays, ministerial roles, and an organisational structure—enhances TST's prospects of meeting legal criteria for recognition as a religion, thereby strengthening its claims to equal representation in public space. Furthermore, if individualism is a defining feature of the occult milieu, as Campbell argues—and by extension of the Satanic milieu, given scholars' emphasis on Satanism as a form of self-religion—then for TST this emphasis on individualism is both institutionalised and collectively reinforced.

Secularisation and Re-enchantment

Campbell (2002) frames the relationship between secularisation and the cultic milieu through two competing logics: while growing pluralism and declining religious authority may increase the accessibility of cultic beliefs, a rationalised, science-oriented society may instead marginalise them.

Early sociological interpretations often followed a linear secularisation narrative. Truzzi's (1972: 29) analysis of the American occult revival, for instance, characterises it as a "mass version of occultism" functioning as a form of "pop religion". He suggests that, for many participants, engagement with the occult is characterised by playfulness rather than deep seriousness. Individuals might perform ritual acts—such as drawing a pentagram to summon a demon—precisely because they do not believe in the literal consequences of such actions. Truzzi concludes with a normative prognosis: as long as the mass engagement with the occult remains playful, it may function as a cultural purging of residual fears and myths, paving the way for a more rational and scientific worldview. This interpretation situates the occult revival within a simplified narrative of secularisation. However, Zaretsky and Leone articulate more nuanced insights. They argue that unorthodox groups, including Satanism and witchcraft, "are neither moribund nor concerned with the death of God," since these formations contribute to "a reaffirmed religious zeal founded on

[10] In particular its religion clauses stating that "Congress shall make no law respecting an establishment of religion, or prohibiting the free exercise thereof".

personalized theologies made to fit the needs of an ever-expanding and diversified following" (1974: xvii). The novelty of alternative spirituality, they suggest, lies less in its substantive content or in the political and economic foundations of American society than in the broad attention it has received through new communication media.

Later scholarship adds more aspects to this discussion by emphasising processes of re-enchantment and the integration of alternative spiritualities into mainstream culture. Partridge (2004) interprets the proliferation of alternative spiritualities since the 1960s not simply as a by-product of secularisation, but as indicative of re-enchantment. As these ideas become "de-exoticised" and culturally embedded, they come to function as plausibility structures (2004: 53), especially within educated, middle-class contexts in Western societies. Extending this line of analysis, Granholm (2012, 2017) examines the connections between rock and heavy metal scenes and the circulation of occult symbolism, magical practices, and left-hand path traditions.

In conclusion, the cultic milieu perspective offers a valuable account of fluidity, boundary-crossing, and the circulation of heterogeneous religious elements. However, its analytical use is limited when applied to a movement such as TST, whose organisational strategies and shared practices exceed the modes of religiosity Campbell describes.

1.5 Satanism as Tension and Alignment

Informed by my focus on alignment and tension in the assembling of TST, this section situates existing scholarship in which such dynamics have been central to the study of Satanism. Petersen (2016: 442) highlights relationships of contestation or "the push and pull within the satanic milieu and beyond", arguing that the "multiplicity in the satanic milieu is one of tension: internal conflict between satanic groups fighting for authoritative definitions of Satanism; external tension with the popular misunderstanding of Satanism as criminal devil worship; and measured tension in their oppositional stance to institutional religion, conventional mores, and social sacred cows". The following sections expand on these dimensions by examining how such tensions are articulated in the socio-cultural positioning of Satanic movements, in external antagonism (including sociological perspectives on NRMs), and in processes of internal contestation and fragmentation.

1.5.1 Socio-Cultural Positioning

The positioning of Satanic groups *vis-à-vis* wider society and similar movements is a recurring theme in earlier studies. I begin by reviewing scholarship on TST and then turn to earlier studies of Satanism that foreground this issue.

TST as a Site of Socio-Cultural Tension and Alignment

Scholarship on TST has consistently emphasised its positioning as an actor engaged in social change. In *The Invention of Satanism* (2015), Dyrendal, Lewis and Petersen analyse TST's emergence in the public eye—for instance its early initiative to donate a Baphomet statue to be placed alongside a Ten Commandments monument on Capitol grounds in Oklahoma City—as a strategic engagement with American culture wars. While the group's use of humour, media manoeuvres, and creatively designed rituals may, for some, raise questions about its religious sincerity (and thus render it controversial), the authors argue that TST's ethical code aligns closely with humanism and culturally legitimate religious forms. In a similar vein, Hedenborg White and Gregorius (2019) position TST's emergence as part of a politically engaged branch of occulture. They situate this development in the context of contemporary American socio-political trends, particularly in response to the mobilisation of the American Religious Right (Gregorius and Hedenborg White 2023).

Laycock (2020) takes this line of argument further by analysing TST not as a variant of self-religion but as a politically and socially engaged religious movement that operates within legal and civic arenas. Drawing on Stephen Prothero's notion of a culture wars cycle, and in parallel to Introvigne's (2016) pendulum theory, Laycock suggests that TST represents a moment in which the political left is 'striking back'. He further stresses that ideas about morality and proper religion at the heart of this culture war are closely intertwined with normative preconceptions about national identity.

Continuing this line of inquiry, Colin (2021) analyses TST through the prism of a social movement, arguing that the perceived threat by Christian fundamentalism is, along with the idea of community, one of the main motivations that led many to join TST. In his survey, 46% of the respondents indicated that rejection or fear of the rise of the evangelical right was one of the main reasons for their engagement with TST. Colin situates the emergence of TST within three interlinked contexts: the rise of subcultures that construct identity by drawing on diverse traditions while resisting religious and political institutions; ongoing internal debates within American secularism, including tensions over strategy, aesthetics, inclusivity, and social justice; and the stagnation of the CoS. In later work, Colin (2025) introduces 'political Satanism' as an additional category to Petersen's ideal types of Satanism—rationalist, esoteric, and reactive. TST's break with LaVey's conservatism and its identification with the liberal Romantic Satanic tradition is thus conceptualised as the culmination of the process of 'esotericised secularism' (as described by Petersen), now transformed into a politicised variant.

Dickman (2025: 67) characterises TST not only as a religious organisation but also as "a human rights group", particularly in its engagement with reproductive rights litigation. She analyses a series of legal cases—The Satanic

Temple v. Parson (2018), Doe v. Parson (2020), and The Satanic Temple v. Texas (2021)—in which TST invokes the Religious Freedom Restoration Act to argue for members' religious right to abortion. In doing so, TST rearticulates feminist struggles for reproductive rights within a framework of religious liberty, grounding its claims in its tenet on bodily autonomy. Dickman further argues that the introduction of TST's Satanic Abortion Ritual (a symbolic affirmation accompanying the decision to terminate a pregnancy) serves also a strategic function, reinforcing TST's legal position by substantiating abortion as a protected religious practice.

When considering alignment with broader societal norms, existing research challenges the assumption embedded in Campbell's notion of the cultic milieu—that fringe beliefs are the defining feature of such movements. This emphasis on deviance does not adequately capture the complexity of TST's cultural positioning. As Cragun's (2025) study of TST's Seven Tenets suggests, the movement's core values align closely with widely shared moral frameworks rather than representing radical or unconventional principles. Drawing on a large convenience sample of primarily American adults, the study finds broad agreement with the Tenets, particularly those emphasising autonomy, compassion, and fallibility, while principles related to science and justice receive somewhat lower levels of endorsement. Although both religious and non-religious respondents express general support, the non-religious in the sample score higher on items related to science, freedom, and nobility of thought. Unlike LaVeyan Satanism, TST's Tenets are not strongly associated with hedonism. Cragun suggests that this alignment with dominant moral values may have contributed to TST's rapid growth and broader appeal.

The Socio-Cultural Positioning of Other Satanic Groups

As these studies demonstrate, tension (and alignment)—expressed through political contestation or responses to dominant cultural norms—has been central analytical motifs in scholarship on TST. Yet this focus is not unique to research on TST. Earlier studies of Satanism have likewise framed the phenomenon through the lens of tension with (or within) mainstream society, often conceptualised in terms of deviance, stigma, cultural conflict or crisis.

One of the earliest scholarly explorations of organised Satanism to frame devotion to the occult in terms of social tension is Moody's (1974) ethnographic study of the CoS. He explains participation, and the willingness to risk social sanction, in pragmatic terms: ritual practices within CoS are perceived as effective in fulfilling desires unmet by society. While CoS members came from diverse social backgrounds, Moody suggests they shared a form of deviance relative to locally defined norms, resulting in experiences of rejection, fear, and anxiety. Although he does not explicitly invoke the concept of stigma, his analysis resonates with a Goffmanian framework. Moody's explanation is rooted in a largely psychological account of religious engagement, which constructs a reductive causal chain from personal dissatisfaction to

involvement in occult practices. Rituals are interpreted in therapeutic terms: as forms of desensitisation or resocialisation, serving needs marginalised by mainstream society. Melton (2003: 936) argues that the Black Mass in the CoS "is meant to be not simply a blasphemous pageant against the Catholic Church, but a purging ritual, making full use of psychodrama to rid individuals of the influence of any sacred cow". This interpretation highlights that while the ritual symbolically rejects dominant religious norms, its purpose is framed as therapeutic rather than purely oppositional. By shifting the analytical focus from individual-level explanations to broader social conditions, Eister (1974) instead foregrounds systemic change. He interprets cults as responses to broader cultural crises and disruptions of orientational institutions: when established frameworks of meaning are unsettled, some individuals seek alternative forms of organisation and support.

Moving from these explanatory frameworks of causation to the level of organisational dynamics and legitimation, Alfred (1976) highlights the CoS's emphasis on respectability. He characterises LaVey's moral code as grounded in discipline, decorum, and law-and-order values, and (drawing on Weber and Goffman) interprets his charisma as a transformation of stigma into prestige through ritual, philosophy, and media visibility. Alfred identifies tensions between indulgence and discipline, and between secrecy and publicity, but argues that these are ultimately resolved through alignment with dominant Western Protestant values such as work ethic, individual responsibility, and capitalism. He thus characterises the CoS as a 'manipulationist sect' (after Bryan Wilson), offering alternative means to conventional societal ends rather than a fully oppositional value system.

Petersen (2013) conceptualises Satanism's registers of transgression, such as blasphemy, violence and obscenity, and political extremism. These registers range from playful provocation to serious religious engagement and target cultural norms about sexuality, the body, religion, and politics, channelling self-work through ritual, performance, and art. Blasphemy, Petersen argues, functions in two distinct ways: as an aesthetic or identity marker, and as a tool aimed at liberating individuals from religious dogma and morality. In the latter sense, blasphemy is only meaningful in the context of constructive objectives, he concludes.

An implicit tension also underpins historical explorations of Satanism and its precursors. To structure the multiple threads of early and modern Satanic history, van Luijk (2016) employs the concepts of 'attribution' versus 'identification' or 'appropriation' (drawing on a theoretical framework created by Wolfgang Lipp). Attribution refers to fictional claims of Black Masses or Satanic worship, often rooted in accusations of reversed morality and conspiratorial thinking. Until the twentieth century, he concludes, the history of Satanism is largely a chain of stigmatising attributions. The 'Romantic Reversal'—the rehabilitation of Satan by post-Enlightenment poets—is contextualised within broader movements towards democratisation, liberalisation, and

emancipation following the French Revolution, alongside secularisation understood as the weakening of Christianity's cultural dominance and the rise of alternative religious options (van Luijk 2016: 393). Identification or appropriation, van Luijk argues, characterises contemporary religious Satanism, particularly LaVeyan Satanism from the 1960s onwards. Van Luijk interprets the identification mode as an ideological reaction against Western Christian heritage, intersecting with earlier traditions of attribution and rehabilitation. Modern Satanism thus emerges as a deliberate adoption of the Satanic stigma, embracing provocation and moral transgression while maintaining social respectability in line with its cultural context.

Introvigne (2002) proposes a cyclical model of the relations between Satanist groups and anti-Satanist discourse in the host society. The process unfolds in three stages, which I refer to for clarity as emergence, anti-Satanist mobilisation, and resurgence. In the emergence phase, a new Satanic current develops within an existing occult subculture and gradually gains negative visibility in wider society. During the mobilisation phase, dominant religious and cultural institutions reject and criminalise the movement, either downplaying its significance or exaggerating its negative influence through conspiratorial narratives. In the final phase, anti-Satanist claims become increasingly extreme and lose credibility, prompting Satanists to retreat and reorganise within the occult subculture, eventually re-emerging to initiate a new cycle. This model assumes a strong causal logic: moral panics surrounding Satanism function as the primary driving force behind the formation and visibility of Satanic movements. While this logic resonates with the tension-oriented theoretical rationale of the present study, my approach is less causality-driven.

Scholars have also explored the political and ideological orientations of various Satanic currents, revealing significant ideological diversity. From a historical perspective, Faxneld (2013: 553) demonstrates how nineteenth-century leftist and anarchist thinkers—including Godwin, Proudhon, and Bakunin—employed Satan as "a symbol of freedom and rebellion against unjust authority". In a similar vein, Faxneld (2017) explores feminist appropriations of Satanic symbolism as a strategy of resistance. Van Luijk (2016) argues that Romantic Satanists tended towards left-wing positions, whereas LaVeyan Satanism aligned with right-wing, anti-egalitarian, and social Darwinist ideas. Truzzi (1972: 28) similarly characterises the CoS's orientation as "extreme Machiavellianism and cynical realism toward the nature of man", drawing on philosophical currents ranging from "the Superman views of Friedrich Nietzsche" to "the Objectivist ideals of Ayn Rand".

Beyond LaVeyan Satanism, some marginal groups have embraced extremist ideologies. The Order of Nine Angles, for instance, has adopted neo-Nazi and neo-fascist positions (see Senholt 2013, who analyses intersections between Satanism and far-right extremism). Dyrendal (2009) argues that Norwegian black metal Satanism deliberately transgressed the cultural norms of its secularised, social-democratic host society by targeting the liberal left. As

he observes, "[a]gainst the liberal left public—and perhaps equally important, the radical left-wing politics of the Norwegian punk scene—they adopted both the images and the rhetoric of the far right" (39). Other studies highlight contrasting tendencies. Granholm (2009b) notes connections between left-hand path movements and animal rights activism, suggesting that Satanic currents are not uniformly aligned with reactionary politics.

1.5.2 External Antagonism

Tensions may arise not only from Satanists' deliberate positioning in relation to socio-cultural norms and political discourses, but also from stigmatising public perceptions of alternative spiritualities. A useful starting point is Barker's (2004) understanding of external antagonism as a defining feature of NRMs. First-generation groups in particular, she argues, are frequently met with "ignorance, suspicion, fear, and hostility" (96). These attitudes may extend beyond discursive marginalisation to concrete forms of discrimination. Over time, however, such tensions may diminish as movements become more integrated into their social environments.

The relevance of external antagonism for understanding TST is demonstrated in Escamilla's (2023) analysis of media representations. Investigating representations of TST in American national and local news media, Escamilla demonstrates that media coverage frequently employs discursive strategies that construct TST as the Other, often through sensationalist framing designed to enhance newsworthiness. A recurring conceptual metaphor is that of 'battle', positioning TST in opposition to government institutions or Christian actors. These patterns are relevant to the present study's focus on alignment and tension with wider society because they suggest that adversarial framings amplify stigma and shape public perception of TST as a controversial actor.

Barker (2004) further argues that NRMs often develop a dichotomous worldview, reinforcing boundaries between insiders and outsiders. Her description of this dichotomy can seem somewhat incongruous when applied to Satanist groups, where the framing of 'godly' versus 'satanic' may have opposite connotations:

> A related tendency one finds in many NRMs (even in some of those that promote holism) is a dichotomous worldview in which beliefs are seen as true or false; people as good or bad; actions as right or wrong—with all three (beliefs, people and actions) being defined as godly or satanic. An individual's identity is defined primarily according to whether s/he is or is not a member of the NRM, with any other role or status being of secondary importance. The sharp division between 'them' and 'us' is not easily permeated, and to cross the boundary can be seen as both treason and heresy—not only a betrayal of God, the leader and one's friends, but also a dangerous and possibly satanic act that can result in severe and terrible repercussions. (Barker 2004: 95)

Another point that deserves attention is the characteristics of the membership in NRMs. Barker notes that these groups consist primarily of first-generation converts and connects this with two other important aspects: a high level of enthusiasm, voluntary engagement and commitment, but also greater vulnerability of membership commitment. Barker sees this fragility of engagement as related to external pressures, as members' beliefs and practices are subject to challenge from the surrounding society.

Insights into the membership profile of Satanist groups further contextualise these perspectives. Introvigne (2002) identifies a shift in the social composition of Satanic communities, contrasting 'classic' Satanism with newer formations. He describes earlier groups, primarily LaVeyan Satanism, as composed of "middle-class urbanites in their forties and fifties", with well-educated leaders familiar with Western esotericism (194), who dressed conventionally outside ritual contexts. In contrast, the groups in Italy and France from the 1990s that he studied were led by individuals in their thirties and consisted largely of teenagers, with little knowledge of traditional occultism and a stronger orientation towards music and popular culture. This generational contrast is echoed in Dyrendal's (2009: 51) observations on the black metal scene among Scandinavian and American Satanists, noting that "the younger Satanists usually have a better grasp of and more interest in popular culture than in Satanist ideology". Although these observations suggest a cultural shift—from esoterically informed adult Satanists toward youth subcultures where aesthetic and musical affiliations often outweigh doctrinal concerns—it remains difficult to determine whether these contrasts signify sociological transformation or simply divergent expressions shaped by cultural context.

1.5.3 Internal Tensions and Fragmentation

Existing research adds more nuance to Campbell's perception of mutual tolerance within the cultic milieu and shows that contemporary Satanism is not uniformly open or harmonious. Lewis (2003) documents online disputes between the CoS and newer Satanist groups and analyses these tensions as part of legitimation strategies. Similarly, Petersen (2011: 13) characterises the Satanic milieu as "a contested space in which actors present themselves as true or genuine and others as false or 'pseudo'-Satanic". Such contestations foreground the role of boundary work in identity construction.

The antagonism between CoS and TST, two of the most visible actors in contemporary Satanism, illustrates this dynamic vividly. Gregorius and Hedenborg White (2023) emphasise these tensions in their analysis of Lucien Greaves's 2017 text "Church of Satan vs. The Satanic Temple", which they interpret as a deliberate construction of CoS as a negative Other, functioning as a key element in TST's identity formation as a socially engaged movement. Contrary to remaining silent, CoS has actively criticised TST and its attempt

to intermingle Satanism with politics or social activism. Laycock (2024: 7) further highlights these tensions:

> The CoS regards TST essentially as plagiarism of its movement and has suggested that Satanists should be above politics instead of trying to force Satanism into the public square. The Satanic Temple, in turn, accuses the CoS of doing nothing aside from posting on social media.

Tensions, however, are not confined to relations between different groups but are also evident within individual organisations. Holt (2022) shows how conflict within CoS arises from LaVey's positions on socio-political topics, the current CoS administration's largely neutral stance, and contemporary members' individual interpretations of LaVeyan literature, as well as their own (dis)-engagement with political questions. There appears to be broad consensus on personal freedoms, positive attitudes towards sexuality, and secularism, given their perceived role in challenging the privileged position of Christian morality in society. At the same time, other forms of privilege-conscious critique, such as discourses on race or gender, reflect the wider societal polarisation of these topics and result in a diversity of individual positions.

Internal tensions and disagreements can lead to fragmentation, and early research on Satanism demonstrates that such fragmentation was present from the first serious organisational endeavours. Melton (2003: 936–939) identifies CoS as the most prominent organisation in the 1960s and 1970s but notes that numerous other groups emerged alongside it or split off from it, including the Temple of Set (1975) and the Church of Satanic Brotherhood. Later, leadership disputes and ideological differences following LaVey's death in 1997 gave rise to new formations such as the First Church of Satan and Karla LaVey's First Satanic Church. Other groups ranged from neo-pagan hybrids to short-lived organisations like Ordo Templi Satanas. This trend of fragmentation was further accelerated by the rise of online networks in the late 1990s.

To account for the conditions under which such fragmentation occurs, Finke and Scheitle (2009) provide a useful theoretical framework grounded in organisational and religious economy theory. While macro-level factors—such as state regulation and religious market conditions—shape the broader environment, of greater relevance to the present study are the internal, meso-level dynamics that render religious groups susceptible to schism. As the authors argue, religious organisations are not unified entities but heterogeneous networks of actors connected through varying social ties. Organisational structure plays a key role in shaping how resources—such as authority, finances, and symbolic capital—are distributed across these networks. More decentralised forms tend to strengthen horizontal ties among local units while weakening connections to central leadership. In such contexts, internal tensions are more likely to culminate in rapid schisms, as central authorities have limited capacity to prevent these. Additional factors, such as organisational

expansion and the charisma of individual leaders, further increase the likelihood of division. Professionalisation is particularly significant: a more professionalised clergy tends to be more loyal to the interests and goals of the larger organisation than to their local congregation, promoting conformity rather than rebellion.

These organisational patterns are a useful backdrop for understanding fragmentation within TST. Laycock (2020) discusses the internal divisions that emerged around 2018, when several local branches (including TST-UK and TST-Los Angeles) broke away after disagreements with the central leadership. These conflicts involved accusations concerning Greaves's alleged links to the alt-right, as well as disputes over the movement's public image and strategic direction. The departure of Jex Blackmore, former spokesperson and leader of TST-Detroit, further illustrates these tensions: her controversial ritual performance, documented in *Hail Satan?,* was deemed by the leadership to conflict with TST's preferred activist style. At the time, TST lacked a formal ministerial structure. Drawing on Finke and Scheitle, rather than viewing these departures as exceptional, Laycock suggests that organisational fragility made schism more likely in the absence of stable institutional frameworks.

A comparative perspective offered by Pizza (2009: 260), based on contemporary Pagan movements, further nuances this interpretation by conceptualising schism not as organisational failure but as a potential catalyst for growth and the reconfiguration of the Pagan community. This perspective reframes fragmentation as a process of revitalisation, allowing diversity while enabling alliances when shared legal or activist goals arise.

1.6 The US Social Landscape

The United States is where TST was first established and where it remains most widespread, at least in terms of affiliation with local congregations. A quick glance at TST's official homepage confirms that the clear majority of listed congregations are in the US. This concentration underscores the importance of situating TST within this cultural, political, and religious landscape. The following sub-section offers an overview of survey-based research on recent attitudes among the American population and on demographic patterns. These trends offer a backdrop for understanding the positions and experiences of TST participants. Thus, I include primarily variables that can be related to those explored in the survey I conducted with TST participants.

The overview begins with attitudes toward religion in public life and Christian nationalism, moves through the broader socio-political climate—including views on social issues and cultural change, social trust, QAnon and emotional responses to local and national conditions—and concludes with demographic patterns. While most of these parameters relate to results presented in Chapter 4 and Research Question 1 (*How does TST assemble in relation to*

wider society?), others provide context for later chapters. For example, social trust is discussed in Chapter 6 in relation to in-group cohesion and is connected to Research Question 3 (*How does TST assemble through internal dynamics and institutionalisation?*). Attitudes toward QAnon appear in Chapter 5 in connection with stigma and stigma management strategies, which relate to Research Question 2 (*How does TST assemble through participants' negotiations of Satanic practice and stigma?*).

1.6.1 Religion in Public Life and Christian nationalism

Religious socialisation remains a dominant feature of American life. About 81% of US adults were raised in a Christian tradition, including Protestant (46%), Catholic (30%), Latter-day Saint/Mormon (2%), and smaller shares identifying as Orthodox Christian, Jehovah's Witnesses, or other Christian (around 1% each) (Pew RLS-III 2023–2024). Non-Christian religious backgrounds are relatively rare: Jewish (2%); Muslim, Buddhist, and Hindu (1% each). In contrast, 13% report being raised religiously unaffiliated, most of whom chose 'nothing in particular' (11%), while atheist and agnostic account for 1% each.

Recent surveys underscore a steady growth of the religiously unaffiliated among Americans. According to the 2023 PRRI Census of American Religion, the share of religiously unaffiliated individuals—often referred to as the 'nones'—has grown from 21% in 2013 to 27% in 2023. Similarly, Pew's RLS-III (2023–2024) indicates that 29% of US adults are religiously unaffiliated, including approximately 5% atheists, 6% agnostics, and 19% who describe themselves as "nothing in particular".

A strong majority of American adults support the separation of church and state. According to Pew (ATP-107 2022), 73% agree that "religion should be kept separate from government policies", while 25% believe that "government policies should support religious values and beliefs" (1% did not respond). However, public opinion on the political influence of churches and religious organisations is divided. About 42% feel that these institutions have "too much influence in politics" (Pew ATP-114 2022), while 22% believe churches and religious organisations do not have enough influence in politics, and 35% consider the influence to be about right (1% no answer).

There seems to be a strong consensus that Supreme Court justices should not bring their own religious views to bear upon major case decisions: 83% of US adults believe justices "should not do this", while 15% think they "should" (2% did not respond) (Pew ATP-114 2022). Yet, perceptions of the extent to which justices have turned to their religious beliefs in recent decisions reveal more complexity. When asked, "In their recent decisions, how much do you think Supreme Court justices have relied on their religious beliefs?" 44% respond "too much", 13% "too little", and 40% consider the level "about right", (4% no answer).

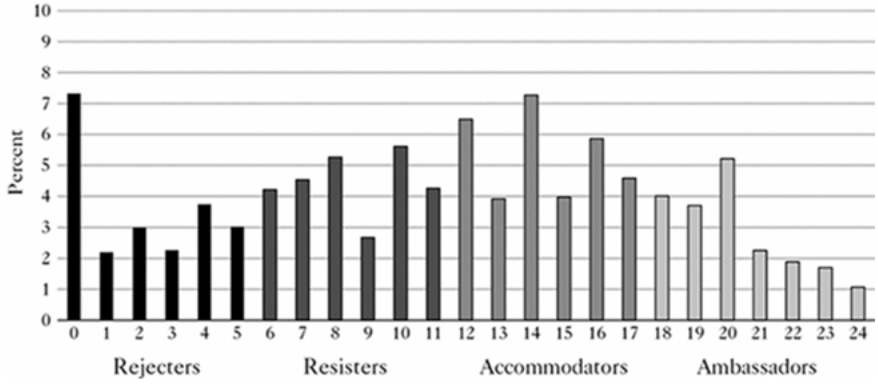
There is also tension in attitudes toward the separation of religion and public education, and opinion on school prayer rulings is almost evenly divided. When asked whether they approve or disapprove of the US Supreme Court's decision prohibiting state or local government from requiring the reading of the Lord's Prayer or Bible verses in public schools, 52% of respondents to whom the question applied approved, while 49% disapproved (Davern et al. 2024).

Just over half (52%) of Americans believe that "the fact that the U.S. population is made up of people of many different religions, as well as people who are not religious" strengthens American society (Pew RLS-III 2023–2024); 18% think it weakens society, while 29% say it doesn't make much difference (1% no answer). Furthermore, 68% believe "it is possible to be moral and have good values without believing in God", while 30% agree that "it is necessary to believe in God in order to be moral and have good values" (2% no answer).

Recent studies reveal a complex relationship between religion and national identity. About 60% of Americans believe the founders intended the US to be a Christian nation, while 37% disagree (3% no answer) (Pew ATP-114 2022). However, when asked whether the US should be a Christian nation, opinions shift: 45% say yes, 51% say no (3% no answer). Similarly, Pew's RLS-III (2023–2024) shows near parity on whether the federal government should declare the US a Christian nation: 47% favour (21% strongly favour, 25% favour), 50% oppose (24% oppose, 26% strongly oppose; 4% no answer).

These patterns intersect with broader ideological currents surrounding the notion of Christian nationalism. Whitehead and Perry (2020) conceptualise American attitudes toward Christian nationalism through four analytical categories. These categories reflect a spectrum of positions within the broader population: Ambassadors fully endorse and promote Christian nationalism; Accommodators are generally supportive but with some reservations; Resisters express scepticism and discomfort; and Rejecters repudiate the idea. Based on a 24-point Christian nationalism scale derived from the 2017 Baylor Religion Survey, Whitehead and Perry estimate that Ambassadors comprise approximately 20% of Americans, Accommodators 32%, Resisters 27%, and Rejecters 22%. This distribution highlights a diverse attitudinal landscape where the group that supports the notion of Christian nationalism to some or great extent constitutes a slight majority (52%). Whitehead and Perry suggest that a majority of Americans hold moderate views, neither strongly opposing nor fully supporting Christian nationalism. Interestingly, within the group of Rejecters, Whitehead and Perry (2020: 25) identify a segment—just over 7% of the American population—that dismisses Christian nationalist ideology as strongly as possible, answering 'strongly disagree' on all statements associated with Christian nationalism and scoring zero on the scale. This segment is represented by the first bar on the left in figure 1.

Figure 1. Distribution of Americans on Christian Nationalism Scale. Source: 2017 Baylor Religion Survey, Whitehead and Perry (2020: 9).



Other survey data provide insight into public awareness and evaluation of the concept of Christian nationalism itself (Pew ATP-114 2022). About 45% have heard at least a little about Christian nationalism (5% a great deal; 9% quite a bit; 17% some; 14% a little), while a small majority (54%) say they have heard nothing at all (1% no answer). Among those who knew at least a little about Christian nationalism, 13% hold a favourable view (4% very favourable; 9% somewhat favourable), while 52% express an unfavourable view (11% somewhat unfavourable; 42% very unfavourable); an additional 18% are neutral and 18% say they don't know.

1.6.2 Values, National Mood and Demographics

American public opinion across moral and socio-political domains presents a complex picture. Debates about reproductive rights are central to contemporary moral discourse. In 2022 the US experienced a dramatic shift in abortion policies, primarily due to the Supreme Court's decision to overturn Roe v. Wade and Planned Parenthood v. Casey in the Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization case. This ruling ended federal constitutional protection for abortion rights and allowed individual states to regulate abortion (Ottley et al. 2023).

Notably, a majority of Americans support legal access to abortion: 64% believe abortion should be legal in all or most cases, while 35% say it should be illegal in all or most cases (Pew RLS-III 2023–2024). In terms of child-rearing, support for corporal punishment illustrates the persistence of more traditional moral norms. According to the 2022 GSS (Davern et al. 2024), 56% of respondents to whom the question applied agree (19% strongly agree; 38% agree) that it is sometimes necessary to discipline a child with "a good, hard spanking", while 44% disagree (27% disagree; 17% strongly disagree).

Resource allocation preferences reveal consensus around certain social welfare concerns. Many Americans judge national spending "too little" to

assist the poor (73%) or to address drug addiction (70%) (Davern et al. 2024). Yet opinions are more divided on racial equity and science funding. On "improving the conditions of Blacks", 56% say national spending is "too little", 31% "about right", and 14% "too much"; on scientific research, 43% judge spending "too little", 47% "about right", and 11% "too much".

Views on misinformation and conspiracy theories are another relevant variable. Americans' awareness of QAnon and their evaluations of its impact on the country were measured in 2020—a year marked by the COVID-19 pandemic and a polarised presidential election. Almost half of US adults had heard at least a little about QAnon (9% a lot; 38% a little), while 53% had heard nothing at all (Pew ATP-73 2020). Among those familiar with QAnon, views were predominantly negative (74% overall: 57% very bad, 17% somewhat bad), while positive evaluations were far less common (20% overall: 16% somewhat good; 4% very good; 6% no answer). Furthermore, social trust appears to have declined. In 2021, 32% of US adults agreed that "most people can be trusted", while 66% said "you can't be too careful in dealing with people" (2% no answer) (Pew ATP-91 2021). Compared with 2016, trust is lower (43% → 32%) and caution is greater (56% → 66%).

Public satisfaction with national and local conditions reveals striking contrasts. In 2022, only 24% of Americans report being satisfied with "the way things are going in this country today", while 75% express dissatisfaction (Pew ATP-107 2022). Satisfaction with one's local community is considerably higher: 65% satisfied versus 34% dissatisfied. Emotional responses to the state of the country are divided: 56% report feeling fearful (43% not fearful), 51% hopeful (48% not hopeful), and 49% angry (49% not angry). Notably, most Americans do not feel proud of their country (76%), while only 22% express pride when thinking about its current state.

In terms of gender, the overwhelming majority of US adults continue to identify within the binary categories of 'man' and 'woman', with only a very small proportion reporting nonbinary or alternative gender identities. When asked, "Do you describe yourself as a man, a woman, or in some other way?" 46% identify as a man, 51% as a woman, and 2% describe their gender in some other way (1% no answer) (Pew RLS-III, 2023–2024).

Class identity reflects a predominantly middle- and working-class society. In the 2022 GSS, US adults were asked to classify their social class by choosing one of four categories: lower class (11%), working class (42%), middle class (43%), or upper class (5%) (Davern et al. 2024). Patterns of urban upbringing further illustrate the social environment. A large majority of US adults (85%) grew up in an urban environment (Davern et al. 2024). This includes those who reported living in a small city or town (32%), a medium-sized city (18%), a large city (18%), or a suburb near a large city (17%) at age 16. In contrast, only 15% reported a rural upbringing, either "on a farm" (5%) or "in open country but not a farm" (9%).

Educational attainment is another dimension captured in these surveys. About 64% report having at least some higher education, whether through some college study (30%), a college degree (19%), or postgraduate study (15%) (Pew RLS-III 2023–2024). However, education levels vary significantly by religious affiliation. According to PRRI (2023), the groups with the highest share of adults reporting at least some higher education are Hindus (85%), Jews (84%), followed by Unitarian Universalists (78%). The religiously unaffiliated rank at 64%, aligning with the national average. At the other end of the spectrum, Jehovah's Witnesses report the lowest level of higher education (32%).

1.6.3 Contemporary Satanism in the US

While the preceding sections have outlined broader patterns in the US social landscape, the following section narrows the focus to survey-based research on Satanism. Existing studies suggest that contemporary Satanism is predominantly US-based, concentrated in early- to mid-adulthood, and characterised by relatively high levels of gender and sexual diversity.

Geographical distribution

Colin's (2021) survey of TST members and allies suggests that most participants were from the US, with additional respondents from Canada and the UK. Similarly, Sprankle and colleagues (2020) conducted a survey among self-identified Satanists, with 53% affiliated with TST. They found that 77% of the survey participants resided in the US, 5% in Canada, and smaller percentages across other countries. Holt's (2022) survey of CoS members suggests an even higher US concentration (86%), with smaller proportions in Canada, Australia, and Europe. Lewis's global surveys (conducted 2000–2001, 2009, 2011, prior to the founding of TST) consistently suggest a predominance of American-based Satanists, with his most recent data indicating 55% from the US, followed by 6% from Denmark, 4% from Canada, and 3% each from Finland and Australia (Dyrendal et al. 2015).

Age

Colin's (2021) survey of TST indicates that approximately 41% are aged 25-34, followed by 32% aged 35–44 and 14% aged 45–54, with smaller proportions aged 18–24 (10%) and 55 and above (23%). A comparable concentration in early- to mid-adulthood is also evident in studies of other Satanic organisations, as Holt's (2022) survey of CoS suggests that the largest age group is 35–44 (37%), followed by 25–34 (33%) and 45–54 (21%). Similarly, Sprankle et al. (2020) report an average age of 31.21 years (SD = 9.90), ranging from 18 to 75. Lewis's longitudinal data indicate that the average age rose from the mid-twenties in 2000–2001 to the late twenties in later surveys, suggesting a trend toward slightly older demographics over time (Lewis 2001, 2010a). These results challenge popular stereotypes of Satanists as 'angry teenagers', demonstrating that most are adults who maintain affiliation into their late twenties or beyond (Dyrendal et al. 2015).

Gender and Sexuality

Gender and sexual orientation of the membership point to other notable trends. Colin's (2021) survey of TST found a female prevalence (47% female, 40% male, 12% non-binary or other). Similarly, Sprankle et al. (2020) report 49% women, 32% men, and 12% identifying as transgender, queer, non-binary, or agender. The gender distribution among CoS members appears markedly different, with approximately 75% identifying as male, 22% as female, and around 3% as non-binary (including queer and transgender) (Holt 2022). Sexual orientation data also indicate diversity, with variation across groups: Colin (2021) found approximately 55% identifying within the LGBTQ+ spectrum and 44% heterosexual respondents, while Sprankle et al. (2020) report 41% identifying outside the heterosexual norm (including bisexual, pansexual, gay, lesbian, asexual, or demisexual). Holt's (2022) data on the CoS indicate a markedly different distribution: approximately 75% of respondents identify as heterosexual (including heteroflexible and related self-descriptions), while around 25% identify within the LGBTQ+ spectrum.

2. Theoretical Framework

There is a need for a short reflection that offers guidance on how to approach the structure and coherence of the theoretical framework, as well as its application in the empirical parts of the thesis. While the format of a manuscript necessitates a sequential presentation, the conceptual orientation of this work—grounded in assemblage thinking and alignment/tension theory—calls for a different kind of reading. The theoretical framework is not structured as a progressive argument from general to specific, nor does it aim to establish a hierarchy of concepts. Instead, it should be imagined as a multidimensional constellation of sensitising concepts that shift in proximity and bonding depending on the readers' vantage point as they move through the following chapters. Coherence emerges through these movements and relations rather than in any imagined static order.

Central to this orientation is a relational ontology informed by assemblage thinking. Becoming within an assemblage is conceived as an open-ended linking of heterogeneous elements in which structure and improvisation co-exist (Gherardi 2016: 687). This understanding informs the present study's approach to religion as assemblage, in which dimensions of practice converge to foster cohesion and belonging or generate tensions and disruption. My approach is consonant with Tremlett's understanding of religious formation as a process of assembling. Tremlett (2013) proposes reconsidering so-called invented religions as new nodes of assembly or forms of association. He argues that "the new religiosities are significant to the extent that they constitute agencies for linking, articulating and connecting people, things, ideas and places (both virtual and physical) together in new ways" (473).

From this perspective, the study engages critically with some dominant sociological narratives concerning contemporary religion and spirituality. Building on the critique of Campbell's conceptualisation of the cultic milieu, it also questions theories of individualisation that portray modern individuals as increasingly constructing identities and belief systems in a reflexive and autonomous manner, largely detached from traditional institutions (Houtman et al. 2011). While such perspectives have drawn attention to important transformations, they often overlook the social processes through which individualism itself is constructed, transmitted, and enacted. As Houtman and colleagues 2011: 22–23) observe "[e]ven though individuals now relentlessly aim to act out their originality, uniqueness, and personal authenticity, and

almost obsessively insist on remaining true to themselves, they paradoxically do so in social environments that expect and demand them to do precisely that". Particularly important for the present study is their critique of the assumptions that alternative spirituality consists primarily of isolated individual bricolage, that it is socially insignificant because its beliefs are diffuse and difficult to transmit, and that it lacks relevance or presence in the public sphere.

Assemblage thinking provides an alternative way of approaching these questions of individualisation and religious formation. By attending to the interplay between micro, meso, and macro levels, this study's theoretical orientation seeks to reveal how even seemingly autonomous individual practices are embedded in shared cultural scripts and collectively constructed regimes. This perspective is particularly useful for understanding how TST forms as a distinguishable configuration situated between order and disorder, and how individuals' practices and self-understandings emerge through relational, collectively patterned dynamics rather than outside them.

Given that the research design of this study is informed by a theoretical framework, I do not follow to the letter the imperative that all preconceived ideas must be set aside (Swedberg 2014: 30). Nevertheless, the design allows space for preconceptions drawn from social theory to be critically examined and for new conceptualisations to emerge through engagement with the empirical material. This abductive approach oscillates between theoretical sensitisation and empirical engagement, allowing concepts to be refined through iterative interpretation rather than imposed deductively or derived inductively. Thus, the role of the chosen theories is not to build a definitive conceptual framework but to help attune attention; this means that "concepts provide initial ideas of what to look for, and these ideas will be refined as research proceeds" (Blaikie 2010: 110).

2.1 Alignment and Tension

Building on the discussion of previous research, the theoretical foundation of this study conceptualises religious movements as assemblages that take form through the concurrent forces of alignment and tension. The following section therefore focuses on alignment and tension as constitutive dynamics. This conceptual orientation draws on Simmel's early sociological thought and engages with Bromley and Melton's alignment-and-tension model to analyse how TST negotiates coherence, legitimacy, and boundary making.

Simmel's work *Soziologie* (2024) offers a foundational ontological perspective on social formations, emphasising that social entities are not sustained by harmony alone, but by the interplay of sympathy, indifference, and

aversion—relations that vary in intensity and duration.[11] While indifference plays a comparatively minor role, any social formation requires sentiments of favour and disfavour to take shape. Just as the individual does not achieve personal unity through complete harmony of values and behavioural patterns, but through the ongoing presence of tension and contradiction, so too does every social entity carry within it divergent and convergent forces. As Simmel (2024: 248–249) writes, a group that is purely harmonious and centripetal would be empirically unreal and devoid of a genuine vitality. Crucially, Simmel argues that within the social, antagonism is not a form of dissociation but a mode of engagement. Thus, tension or antagonism is conceptualised as a constitutive force that can have integrative effects.

Simmel's insight into the relationship between external and internal tension is particularly relevant for understanding religious minorities. He suggests that external conflict intensifies internal processes, either fragmenting or homogenising the group. In peaceful conditions—defined by the absence of strong tensions with an external social order—the commonly occurring antagonistic elements within a group may coexist in an unresolved state, avoiding direct confrontation. However, in times of external conflict, these internal divergences are drawn together under a unifying impulse, prompting either complete reconciliation or total repulsion (Simmel 2024: 311–314). Moreover, Simmel contends that minority groups under pressure or persecution, including religious groups, often resist accommodation or toleration from their opponents, as such gestures risk weakening internal cohesion, thus undermining the capacity to sustain their struggle for existence.

With Simmel's account as a starting point, I now turn to the work of Bromley and Melton, who have theorised the constitution of religious groups in terms of alignment and tension with the dominant social order. Their relational approach attempts to overcome the limitations of dichotomous concepts such as church-sect or denomination-cult and is an extension of Benton Johnson's tension approach (Bromley and Melton 2012; Bromley 2016). Alignment with the surrounding society is considered in terms of social and cultural cohesion. The socio-cultural alignment of a religious group with the host society may be

[11] In the fragments of the work of pre-Socratic philosopher Empedocles (1995: 166–167), we find a cosmological articulation of similar dynamics: *love* and *strife* function as fundamental motive forces that bring all things into being or dissolution by causing the elements to unite or separate. A more contemporary theoretical contribution that situates *affinity* and *estrangement* as socially productive sentiments is offered by Lincoln (2015). In this model, affinity ("all feelings of likeness, common belonging, mutual attachment, and solidarity") and estrangement ("feelings of distance, separation, otherness, and alienation") are understood as forms of sentiment mobilisation that, together with ideology, constitute what discourse is (Lincoln 2015: 8). These sentiments play a central role in the negotiation of social boundaries. In contrast to my framework, Lincoln (2015: 2) employs a broader ontological understanding of discourse, one that encompasses not only language but also "spectacle, gesture, costume, edifice, icon, musical performance, and the like". Petersen (2009) draws on Lincoln's affinity and estrangement to analyse boundaries between authentic and pseudo-Satanism, resonating in part with my approach.

low, high, or somewhere in between. The nature of the alignment may evolve and its degree may change over time. According to the model, a *dominant* tradition group is characterised by a high degree of socio-cultural alignment with the surrounding social order. Such groups are understood as constitutive of the specific host society and are seen as legitimate actors on the socio-cultural scene. A *sectarian* tradition group challenges the dominant religious tradition in a given society and claims to be its legitimate and authentic representative; it may also attempt to subvert aspects of the surrounding socio-cultural order. An *alternative* tradition group, on the contrary, does not claim to be the legitimate version of a tradition that is dominant in the particular context—rather, it seeks to position itself as the legitimate representative of another tradition. In socio-cultural terms, this type of religious formation may vary in terms of conformity, but its conformity is never extremely low. In cases where the level of socio-cultural alignment is very low, Bromley and Melton use the concept of *emergent* tradition groups. The organisational styles, practices or value systems of such movements may be at odds with what is accepted as legitimate forms of religion in the host society.

Most relevant to the current study are the categories of alternative and emergent tradition groups. If we consider organised Satanic groups to be NRMs that do not belong to an established tradition, then TST falls into the category of an emergent tradition, and we would expect very low levels of alignment with the surrounding society. However, looking at the movement from an emic perspective, TST can be seen as an alternative tradition movement. Through its use of Satan as a rebellious symbol, the group positions itself in opposition to Christianity as the dominant religious tradition in its host society. At the same time, it claims affiliation with another lineage—namely the literary Satanism of the Romantic period—and positions itself as an alternative to CoS which functions as an influential tradition within modern religious Satanism. As this project is not concerned with finding the most appropriate category for TST, the purpose of Bromley and Melton's model is to explore what kinds of alignment and tension position TST in relation to its host society, shape its formation as a religious movement and translate into individual practice and identity negotiation.

As Zeller (2021) demonstrates through four global case studies of NRMs, the alignment model does not lend itself to generalised predictions concerning how such groups engage with their host societies. Rather, analysing alignment strategies necessitates attending to the specific context of each NRM and the broader social environments in which it operates. Central aspects include organisational structure, degree of hierarchy, and the role of the group's ideology.

By synthesising these perspectives, the model proposed in this study views tension and alignment not as opposites, but as interdependent forces that shape the emergence, stabilisation, and transformation of a religious entity. Especially in minority or contested religious formations such as TST, the interplay

of identity-defining fields of tension and alignment is central to understanding how TST comes together, persists, evolves, or dissolves.

Bromley and Melton (2012) propose an extensive list of indicators that can be used to analyse the social and cultural alignment of a religious group with its host society, focusing on the group's relationship with state and non-state institutions, the social status of its members, the organisational form, the public and self-identity of the group, the nature of beliefs and rituals, cultural practices, etc. The challenge with this comprehensive system of indicators is how to methodologically address alignment and tension that constitute TST in a feasible way. How this challenge has been met is the subject of section 2.5.

To further develop the model by Bromley and Melton, the study examines not only alignment and tension as relations between TST and the surrounding society but also the conditions and factors that constitute alignment and tension within the movement and at the level of individual practice. In addition, the study advances the theoretical framework by introducing the notion of *dealignment* as a distinct but related analytical category. In this thesis, tension is understood as a structural or situational outcome that is not necessarily sought after. It arises when actors within TST—either as individuals or as a community—are positioned in ways that generate friction. Such friction may occur in relation to individual identity and practice, at a more aggregated level in TST, or between TST and its host society. Although tension emerges from relational and deliberate positioning, the tension itself is often unintentional or not an end in itself. In this framework, it is considered a by-product of difference on aspects that are identity-defining for individual Satanists or for TST as an organisation. In contrast, dealignment is conceptualised as an intentional strategy; it is a deliberate effort to disengage from, resist, or redefine alignment with norms, groups, traditions, or identity categories. Analytically, when alignment is taken as the primary form of deliberate positioning within a relational field, tension in other respects is approached as its by-product. Conversely, when dealignment is foregrounded as the central mode of positioning, it is understood as grounded in, and enabled by, alignment in other respects.

2.2 Religion as Assemblage

Having introduced alignment and tension as a sensitising perspective for studying religion, I now turn to assemblage theory in order to anchor this approach within an ontological and methodological framework. Assemblage theory sees the complexity of the social world in terms of relationality, interdependence and fluidity.[12] It invites conceptualising alignment and tension as constitutive of social formations rather than as the outcome of their positioning alone; as forces that are in play at multiple levels, stabilising and transforming.

[12] Deleuze and Guattari's original concept of assemblage in French is *agencement*.

Assemblage theory differs from ontological assumptions that treat social formations as coherent structures. Instead, it conceptualises the social as composed of heterogeneous elements—human and non-human, material and semiotic[13]—held together in provisional configurations. Central in assemblage thinking are not the intrinsic properties of the elements in the assemblage, but the relations that bind them together for a time. Social reality, from this perspective, is not fixed, but characterised by contingency, multiplicity, and relational becoming. This ontology is articulated through the notion of the rhizome. In contrast to models of structure, which presuppose hierarchy, linear causality, and clear origins, the rhizome is open, connectable, and without a single centre. It is "a model that is perpetually in construction or collapsing", a process that continuously breaks off and starts again (Deleuze and Guattari 2013: 21).

Adopting this rhizomatic ontology raises a central question concerning the location of agency within assemblages and offers a critique of individualisation theories. As Deleuze and Guattari argue, "there are no individual statements, only statement-producing machinic assemblages" (2013: 41). What appears as individual expression is always generated within collective configurations that enable and constrain what can be said and done. Such expression becomes subjectified "only to the extent that an impersonal collective assemblage requires it and determines it to be so" (93). Agency is distributed across relations between actors, material arrangements, and the ordering regimes that condition and connect. This distributed conception of agency allows for an analysis attentive to both creative improvisation and patterned constraint.

Assemblages are characterised by constant stabilisation and transformation (Deleuze and Guattari 2013: 95). Deleuze and Guattari describe them as having both territorialised sides, which stabilise relations, and "cutting edges of deterritorialization", which carry the assemblage elsewhere (103). Territorialisation refers not to spatial enclosure, but to processes of temporal anchoring and sedimentation through which configurations become recognisable and consistent. Through establishing refrains or regimes of signs that function as signatures of the assemblage, boundaries are created that distinguish inside from outside, belonging from non-belonging, authentic from non-authentic (366–68).

Deterritorialisation, by contrast, designates movements that disrupt established patterns and open ways toward new connections or new assemblages. Unfolding through "lines of flight", deterritorialisation does not imply pure rupture (Deleuze and Guattari 2013: 330, 587). Rather, even as it departs from

[13] Assemblages are composed of interdependent relations between material and semiotic flows. Deleuze and Guattari (2013: 21) distinguish between machinic assemblages of desire, which encompass bodies, materialities, and their mutual interactions, and collective assemblages of enunciation, which refer to socially ordering regimes of signs. These regimes exceed language narrowly conceived and are styles that orient action and meaning. Crucially, these are not two independent assemblages but layers of becoming in the same formation.

an existing configuration, it retains a relation to what it seeks to escape. Deleuze and Guattari illustrate this through the relation between 'orthodoxy' and 'heresy', where alternative formations break away while continuing to orient themselves toward a centre of legitimacy.[14] What unites the diverse deterritorialisations of an assemblage is that while they transgress the orthodoxy, they continue to relate to the core of the former tradition, through attractions and repulsions. Similarly, deterritorialisation within TST can be seen in instances of creative, experimental or subversive practice that exceed, rework, or escape the regimes that normally structure and delimit TST's assemblage. These lines of flight can result in novel or schismatic group formations.

To grasp what drives the stabilising and destabilising movements of assemblages, Deleuze and Guattari foreground the concept of desire. They conceptualise desire as the force that couples flows and objects, one that "causes the current to flow, itself flows in turn, and breaks the flows" (2009: 5). As they later formulate it, "becoming is the process of desire" (2013: 318). Desire thus provides the motor through which assemblages are continuously assembled and reassembled: it is the underlying force through which territorialisation and deterritorialisation unfold.[15]The emphasis on desire as a defining feature of assemblage theory motivates the need to account for it within the analytical model. In this thesis I engage the concept of desire not as discussed in the broader continental-philosophical tradition, nor as a purely internal mental state of the individual. Instead, I conceptualise desire as an assembling force manifested through alignment and dealignment that shape territorialisation and deterritorialisation.

The rhizomatic ontology of assemblage thinking carries specific methodological implications. By directing analytical attention away from origins, teleological development, or stable structures and toward the provisional coherence of social formations, Deleuze and Guattari (2013) suggest analytical sensibility attuned to the plateau, the intermezzo, or the milieu. Emphasis is thus on intensities in the middle rather than beginnings or endings. Consequently, the task of analysis is not to reconstruct a complete genealogy, but to trace how heterogeneous elements hold together for a time while remaining subject to centrifugal forces (M. Müller 2015: 32).

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[14] Deleuze and Guattari (2013: 146) exemplify this with Christianity and its emergence through lines of flight that depart from Judaism to invent a new assemblage, which is itself subsequently cut across by deterritorialisation—from eradicated heterodoxies such as the Bogumils to major ruptures such as the Reformation.

[15] According to Buchanan (2021: 56), the centrality of desire distinguishes assemblage from related concepts such as system, which tend to privilege structure, function, or equilibrium. A similar point is made by Müller and Schurr (2016) in their discussion of assemblage theory's distinctiveness in relation to actor-network theory. While both approaches share a relational understanding of action—emphasising the interplay between heterogeneous elements and the emergence of social formations—assemblage thinking, they argue, is marked by its explicit attention to desire as force that bring socio-material relations into being (Müller and Schurr 2016: 218). Desire is not understood as lack (as in Lacanian psychoanalysis), but as a productive force that assembles relations by selecting, connecting, and transforming.

Rhizomatics emphasises bottom-up analysis, attending to the micropolitical, or what Deleuze and Guattari (2013: 25) characterise as "POP ANALYSIS", suggesting an attentiveness to the lived practices and intensities that form and reform an assemblage. Empirically, this involves sensitivity to what drives stabilisation and disruption and the practices through which assemblages are enacted and contested in everyday life.

The way Deleuze and Guattari write about assemblage resonates with discourse theory's concern with meaning production and the decentring of the subject. However, despite these affinities, within Deleuze and Guattari's rhizomatic ontology the discursive itself is also decentered. This stands in contrast to the discourse theory developed by Laclau and Mouffe (1985: 93), where the distinction between discourse, social practice, and materiality becomes difficult to sustain. For this reason, I relocate discourse from a primary structuring principle to one among several ordering regimes conditioning the becoming in an assemblage. Discourses are thus understood as embedded within assemblages. Although discourse does not exhaust what an assemblage is, I nonetheless treat articulations as empirical entry points—traces through which emotions, spatial arrangements, and socio-material relations become analytically observable in this study. In other words, I access the movements in the assemblage through such discursive traces, while avoiding any ontological reduction of the assemblage to the discursive dimension alone.

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Another methodological implication—foregrounded by Tremlett (2021: 39)—is that religious formations can be analytically approached as assemblages shaped by processes of diffusion. These include *inter-religious diffusion*, through which ideas and practices from different religious traditions are combined, and *secular-religious diffusion*, whereby elements associated with both religious and secular domains become entangled within an assemblage. Regarding the distinction between what counts as religious and what is deemed secular, it is tempting to rely on clear-cut definitions that promise to dispel ambiguity. Yet, as Arnal and McCutcheon (2012) argue, such definitions rest upon a socially authorised and politically regulated binary that renders the categories mutually constitutive rather than intrinsically distinct. Their meanings are therefore contingent, historically sedimented, and contextually negotiated rather than inherent properties of the phenomena they purport to describe.

Methodologically this implies that depending on a stable set of criteria that separates the religious from the secular is not desirable. This orientation resonates with assemblage theory's emphasis on becoming as a process that cannot be reduced to predetermined categories. As Deleuze and Guattari put it, "becoming produces nothing other than itself […]. What is real is the becoming itself, the block of becoming, not the supposedly fixed terms through which

that which becomes passes" (2013: 277–278). From this perspective, the task of analysis is not to determine sociologically whether a phenomenon is religious or secular as such, but to trace how this opposition is produced, negotiated, or contested in practice—by whom, for what purposes, and with what effects.[16] This approach is consistent with Beckford's (2003: 2–3) social-constructionist perspective, which calls for abandoning the view of religion as "a relatively well-defined object", focusing instead on the social processes through which phenomena come to be classified as religious, as well as how such classifications are extended, challenged, or transformed over time.[17]

In the assembling of the religious and the secular as broad classificatory categories, as well as in the emergence of a specific religious formation or a particular practice within it, Tremlett (2021: 39) identifies two different kinds of processes that correspond to territorialisation and deterritorialisation: "combination-articulation by which different things arrive in each other's orbit to become an assemblage" and "disintegration-separation wherein those orbits are disturbed and the elements are pulled apart, perhaps to decompose altogether or to fall into the orbit of something else".

Foregrounding relational becoming, Deleuze and Guattari describe assemblages as "complexes of lines" (2013: 587). Extending this emphasis, I propose understanding territorialisation and deterritorialisation dynamics through the metaphor of spirals rather than lines. Unlike a straight line, the spiral captures movement characterised by both repetition and variation: it curves around a centre while moving closer to or further away from it. Spirals of territorialisation are processes of stabilisation in which shared orientations—such as value alignment, emotional and aesthetic regimes, and discourses—persist and generate coherence, while still allowing for improvisation and the ongoing reworking of the assemblage. Spirals of deterritorialisation involve a breaking with established patterns within these social regimes of ordering. They open the assemblage increasingly to forms of improvisation that move away from a unifying centre and, at times, towards the formation of new assemblages, while still retaining a relation to what they diverge from. Alignment and tension, understood as manifestations of desire, set these spirals into motion and sustain the interplay between stabilisation and transformation.

[16] My approach is also informed by Lövheim and Lied (2018: 66, 72), who conceptualise religion as "a contested and mediatized social phenomenon", shaped through the "interplay between previously established, institutionalized forms of religion and challenges to the meaning and legitimacy of these forms that increased mediatization brings, in the form of contestation and negotiation among a larger spectrum of actors".

[17] Legal practice and case law constitute important sites in which such negotiations take place. even though an analysis of TST's framing in the legal domain is not the focus of this study.

2.3 Dimensions of Practice Within the Assemblage

To capture the complexity of TST as a religious assemblage, the study approaches religion as a situated social practice (Ammerman 2020) shaped by alignment and tension. It traces the workings of alignment and tension within the assemblage by focusing on the constitutive entanglement of four dimensions of practice: values, emotions, aesthetics, and discourses.[18] The relational logic central to assemblage theory informs my understanding of these dimensions not as discrete or isolated, but as interwoven and mutually conditioning. Each dimension only becomes intelligible in and through its relations to the others. Accordingly, a focus on one dimension, such as aesthetics, reveals its embeddedness in everyday life and ritual practice, its emotional charge, its discursive articulation, and its relation to shared values. Together, these dimensions are implicated in spirals of territorialisation and deterritorialisation that produce and challenge the temporal intra-consistency and boundaries in the assemblage.

The dimension of *value alignment* corresponds to the morality dimension in Ammerman's approach to lived religious practice (2021: 29), defined as "assumptions and judgements about what is right and wrong, worthy or not". This study focuses on the moral orientations as articulated in TST's foundational Seven Tenets. Rather than treating the Tenets as a fixed doctrinal system, stable or unambiguous, the analysis foregrounds their role as a lived and performative dimension of religious practice. This includes attending to how shared values are interpreted, negotiated, and enacted both individually and collectively: how participants align their personal experiences and moral frameworks with the movement's collective ethos, and how these shared orientations are embodied in everyday practices, activism, and community

[18] The concept of 'lived religion' directs attention towards religion as it is practised in everyday life. McGuire (2008) uses the term to distinguish the religious beliefs and practices of ordinary people from the narratives of official spokespersons and from organisational or doctrinal frameworks. She proposes that scholars attend to the individual level and analyse religions-as-practised—that is, "an ever-changing, multifaceted, often messy—even contradictory—amalgam of beliefs and practices that are not necessarily those religious institutions consider important" (McGuire 2008: 5). At the same time, she underscores the socially and temporally embedded nature of lived religion, emphasising that individual religious practice is shaped by shared cultural repertoires. Similarly, Ammerman (2021: 8–17) argues that a lived-religion lens enables scholars to approach religious belief and practice as "dynamic and creative", formed by personal agency and extending beyond official doctrine. This perspective foregrounds the ways in which religion is enacted not only in explicitly sacred settings but also in the mundane contexts of everyday life—without presuming such practices to be inauthentic, insincere, or unrepresentative of a 'true' tradition. Ammerman also draws attention to the legal and cultural norms that condition lived religion. While this thesis is informed by the lived-religion perspective, and particularly by Ammerman's (2021) model of religious practice, I do not adopt all of her proposed analytical dimensions (embodiment, materiality, morality, emotions, aesthetics, narratives, and spirituality). Instead, I use a related set of dimensions that are not intended to be exhaustive of religious practice, but rather to capture forms of alignment through which TST assembles.

interactions. This dimension is inseparable from emotions, discourses and aesthetics, through which value alignment gains traction.

Another central dimension of religious practice explored in this study is aesthetics. Given the study's social-constructivist approach, aesthetic experiences are not understood as merely private or individual, but as collectively co-constructed and interrelated with other dimensions of practice. This perspective reflects the view that aesthetics is "not so much a matter of individual taste, choices or values, but a matter of social and collective transformations that have a steady and powerful impact on the individual" (Vihalem 2018: 2). I approach aesthetics through the concept of *aesthetic regimes* (pluralis), using it as an analytical lens to examine their role in TST's assembling processes, in the interplay between tension and alignment.

The notion of the aesthetic regime (singularis) originates in the work of Jacques Rancière, who conceptualises aesthetics as deeply intertwined with the political realm (Yepes 2014). For Rancière, the aesthetic regime structures the distribution of the sensible—that is, it organises "bodies, voices, and capacities at work within a given community" and shapes what can be perceived, expressed, and rendered meaningful (Tanke 2011: 72). While Rancière develops the concept primarily in relation to art, subsequent scholarship has extended it to encompass other forms of everyday experience.

Building on this theoretical lineage, the present study employs a more situated and operational definition of aesthetic regimes. Thus, aesthetic regimes refer to structured modes of expression, sensation, and perception that emerge within relational social contexts. They are constructed through socio-cultural practices such as visual art and iconography, ritual design, dress codes, music, performance etc. A regime thus forms a recognisable style or pattern, marked by a minimal set of shared features that are continuously enacted in variation. Through this ongoing repetition and variation in social contexts, the regime is both stabilised and subtly transformed.

Importantly, aesthetic regimes cannot be analytically separated from other dimensions of practice. They do not merely concern questions of beauty or taste, but mobilise and organise a complex nexus of emotions, values, and discourses. Mosurinjohn (2024: 229), for instance, conceptualises the "affective-aesthetic modes" in TST's early public interventions and ritual practices such as Unbaptisms, emphasising a relatively coherent repertoire "drawing from occult, metal, goth, and BDSM scenes", primarily articulated in public performances and media presence. While such sites can be understood as key moments in the production of aesthetic regimes, the present study shifts attention to how these regimes are reflected upon, experienced, and negotiated by participants in their everyday engagements with the movement. Related to alignment and tension, aesthetic regimes may function as cohesive frameworks that enable shared experience and belonging, while also serving as mechanisms for dissensus that disrupt social homogeneity.

In parallel, the study approaches emotions as socially patterned and relationally constituted rather than private or purely subjective states. Emotions are understood as forces exceeding the individual that play a central role in processes of alignment and tension through which the assemblage is stabilised and contested. This perspective is informed by an assemblage-thinking approach to practice that foregrounds the role of affect in structuring social space. It highlights the "ephemeral elements – such as feelings, aesthetics, atmospheres, intensities, and moods – which have the capacity to hold together the elements of practice" (Gherardi 2023: 5).

To analyse these dynamics, the study draws on the notion of *emotional regimes* introduced by Reddy (2001), who conceptualises emotions as shaped by power relations and institutional structures. Emotional regimes stabilise social formations by prescribing which emotions are legitimate, how they should be expressed, and in which contexts. Building on this, Riis and Woodhead (2010) emphasise that emotional regimes operate across multiple social scales—from intimate family settings to religious communities and transnational movements—and are closely entangled with power. As they note, those who express the "correct" emotions in appropriate ways receive both explicit and implicit recognition (Riis and Woodhead 2010: 49). In this sense, emotional regimes play a key role in shaping belonging and legitimacy.

At the same time, emotions cannot be understood in isolation from the other dimensions of practice. As Ahmed (2004: 119) argues, "emotions do things, and they align individuals with communities—or bodily space with social space—through the very intensity of their attachments". Emotions thus intersect with aesthetic regimes, value alignment, and discourses, contributing to the ongoing processes of alignment and tension through which the assemblage is held together or destabilised.

The final dimension of practice that informs my approach to religion, as assemblage shaped by alignment and tension, is the discursive. Although I employ *discourse* as an analytical category, my approach does not adhere to a formal discourse analysis protocol, such as Critical Discourse Analysis (Fairclough 2003).[19] Instead, it is informed by a broad understanding of discourse: "a particular way of talking about and understanding the world (or an aspect of the world)" (Jørgensen and Phillips 2002: 1). At the same time, I recognise that discourse is not merely descriptive, but constitutive of power relations that shape what can be said, by whom, and with what effects (Foucault 2002). As Taira (2016: 126) argues, discourse is made of "statements that operate repeatedly together in forming relatively stable—but changing and changeable—meaning systems that are most effective when entangled in institutions".

[19] My understanding of discourse also aligns with Fairclough's (2013: 220) definition of discourse as semiotic ways of construing the world from particular social positions, as well as with his emphasis on the dialectical relations between semiotic and non-semiotic dimensions (such as practices, institutions, and power relations).

Discourses thus both enable and constrain how actors act, how they experience and express emotions, and how they make moral and aesthetic assessments. In this sense, the dimensions of practice are not clearly delineated, but intersecting and mutually constitutive.

In this assemblage framework, I do not consider ritual a separate dimension of religious practice but rather a space where the other central dimensions converge. Drawing on Grimes's (1992) view of ritual as fluid, creative, and contextually constructed, I understand ritual as a site of both improvisation and stabilisation—shaped by territorialisation and deterritorialisation. It is where discourses are embodied, where aesthetics and emotion are activated, and where moral orientations are enacted, situated between individual interpretation and shared doctrine and tradition.

Through these dimensions the study will analyse religion as a relational becoming, where moral, discursive, emotional and aesthetic dimensions converge to foster cohesion and belonging within the assemblage or create disruptions. In my integrated model, value alignment, discourses, aesthetic regimes and emotional regimes are conceptualised as *regimes of social ordering* within the assemblage.

2.4 Stigma

In line with this study's conceptual sensitivity to desire and its manifestation through alignment and dealignment, the theoretical framework includes stigma and stigma management as integral aspects of TST's assemblage. Goffman (1986: 3) defines stigma as an attribute that renders a person "different from others in the category of persons available for him to be, and of a less desirable kind—in the extreme, a person who is quite thoroughly bad, or dangerous, or weak". Stigma has a discrediting effect, he argues: "we believe the person with a stigma is not quite human. On this assumption we exercise varieties of discrimination, through which we effectively, if often unthinkingly, reduce his life chances" (5). Crucially, the stigmatising effect does not stem from the attribute itself, but from the interplay between individuals' identities, social categories, and their enactment within specific social contexts. Therefore, Goffman emphasises that stigma is a relational phenomenon, emerging through interpersonal interactions shaped by normative expectations—stereotypes about what individuals in a given category are presumed to be like.

While Goffman acknowledges the role of the historical and normative context in which stigma operates, his dramaturgical approach centres on the micro-level of social encounters. Building on Goffman's work, Link and Phelan (2001) expand the theoretical scope by conceptualising stigma as a multi-level process within power-laden contexts. They emphasise that the normative expectations underpinning stigmatisation are structured by unequal access to social, economic, and political power. More recent developments in stigma

theory further embed individual and interpersonal dimensions within broader social structures (Hatzenbuehler 2016; Scambler 2018; Tyler and Slater 2018). Structural stigma is defined as "societal-level conditions, cultural norms, and institutional policies that constrain the opportunities, resources, and wellbeing of the stigmatized" (Hatzenbuehler and Link 2014, quoted in Hatzenbuehler 2016: 743).

Stigma has a significant affective dimension. In order to connect stigma to this dimension, I will draw on the concept of *anticipated stigma*, described by Bos and colleagues (2013: 3) as "the anticipation of stigmatization on the part of the person with a stigmatized condition". Goffman describes stigmatised individuals as self-conscious, other-conscious, and situation-conscious, constantly calculating their performance in social interactions. This condition often entails discomfort or anxiety. He distinguishes between discredited and discreditable identities, depending on whether the stigmatising attribute is publicly known or concealable (Goffman 1986: 4–5). In the case of discreditable identities, navigating 'outness' becomes a continuous negotiation: "to display or not to display, to tell or not to tell, to lie or not to lie, and in each case, to whom, how, when and where" (Goffman 1986: 42). This negotiation constitutes *information control*, defined as "the management of undisclosed discrediting information about self" (41–42), of which *concealment* and *disclosure* are two modes. Goffman argues that most individuals who can pass as 'normal' try to do so. Voluntary disclosure is framed as the final step in a stigmatised person's "moral career", representing maturity and "a state of grace" (Goffman 1986: 102). The codes of information control are socially constructed through in-group alignment, and while there may be variation, Goffman notes a general consensus within a given group of stigmatised people (109–111). The ability or willingness to adhere to these codes is often tied to notions of authenticity, he argues. Goffman introduces the idea of *disclosure etiquette*: socially established norms that guide when, how, and to whom disclosure should occur. These norms are shaped both by practices within the stigmatised group and by mainstream expectations: "The individual is told that if he adopts the right line (which line depending on who is talking), he will be an adult with dignity and self-respect" (123). This is particularly relevant in contexts such as TST, where stigma management strategies, such as the use of satanyms or selective disclosure, are collectively constructed and negotiated.

Another key strategy is seeking out sympathetic others. Goffman (1986: 20) writes:

> The first set of sympathetic others is of course those who share his stigma. Knowing from their own experience what it is like to have this particular stigma, some of them can provide the individual with instruction in the tricks of the trade and with a circle of lament to which he can withdraw for moral support and for the comfort of feeling at home, at ease, accepted as a person.

However, sympathetic others are not limited to those who share the stigmatised identity ('the own'); they may also include individuals who, while not directly affected, recognize and affirm the experiences of the stigmatised ('the wise').

Goffman views group formation among stigmatised individuals as "exemplary objects of study as social movements" (22). Such groups often coalesce into small social units with varying degrees of organisation, and develop a shared 'ideology' encompassing their complaints, aspirations, politics, and personal testimonies. These groups seek to make their ideology public and often inhabit "a literarily-defined world", educating themselves through books, magazines, films, and meetings, and cultivating "an intellectually worked-up version of their point of view" (25).

The relationship of the stigmatised individual to the group may take the form of identification/affiliation, disidentification/disaffiliation, or ambivalence, where the individual "can neither embrace his group nor let it go" (108). Within the analytical framework of this study, these relational positions are conceptualised as distinct configurations of alignment: identification reflects alignment, disidentification signals dealignment, and ambivalence captures a state in which these orientations remain unresolved.

An aspect of this identity negotiation are what Goffman terms stigma symbols—signs that routinely convey information about the stigmatised attribute (43). These can be used strategically in information control. One approach involves openly displaying the stigma symbol as a form of disclosure. The use of a disidentifier: "a sign that tends—in fact or hope—to break up an otherwise coherent picture but […] in a positive direction desired by the actor" is another form of stigma management (44). Depending on the community, stigma symbols may even be reinterpreted as prestige symbols.

This study builds on theoretical frameworks that conceptualise stigma beyond the individual level. In line with Thomas and colleagues (2025), who caution against rigid divisions between structural and micro-social analyses, it adopts an integrative approach. Stigma and its management are understood not as private experiences, but as socially embedded phenomena shaped through interactions within TST as an assemblage and broader social structures.

T. Müller (2020) warns against a narrow interpretation of Goffman's concept of stigma as solely concerning collectively marginalised individuals who share a stigmatised trait and are disempowered by it. While this study assumes that both individual participants and TST as a community tend to be subjected to stigma based on their religious affiliation, it explores how stigma experiences and management strategies vary among actors and reflect their agency. By examining these variations, the study aims to avoid essentialising the stigmatised identity as victimhood.

2.5 Analytical Levels

This section connects the theoretical framework developed above to the empirical analysis by outlining the analytical levels through which the study approaches its material. The relational ontology central to assemblage theory has guided the formulation of research questions, which address interactions across three levels: the micro-level of individual practice, the meso-level of organisational cohesion and disruption, and the macro-level of positioning in relation to broader society. The analytical distinction between micro, meso, and macro levels is employed here not as a claim about discrete social strata, but as a heuristic for organising the empirical analysis. The assemblage dynamics—the interplay of value alignment, discourses, emotional and aesthetic regimes—cut across these levels and take on different forms depending on scale.

In a deductive research design, Bromley and Melton's typology of religious movements might be translated into testable hypotheses—for example, by positing a causal relationship between a group's alignment with wider society and its position in relation to dominant religious traditions. Drawing on Simmel's insights into the interplay between internal and external conflict, such an approach would assume that alignment or antagonism toward the host society activates internal dynamics, producing either increased solidarity or fragmentation. The present study, however, is qualitative and abductive. Its theoretical framework is not used to derive causal propositions to be verified in a positivist sense, but to sensitise the analysis to how relations of alignment, tension, and dealignment are enacted and experienced across different levels of practice. It provides a conceptual grid that assists the selection of strategic research material, i.e., "the empirical material that exhibits the phenomena to be explained or interpreted to such an advantage and in such accessible form that it enables the fruitful investigation of previously stubborn problems and the discovery of new problems for further inquiry" (Merton quoted in Swedberg 2014: 40).

Research Questions and Levels of Analysis

The order of the empirical chapters addressing these analytical levels reflects the assemblage perspective's focus on relational becoming. Beginning at the macro level, moving to the micro level, and concluding with the meso level, this structure foregrounds the study's emphasis on alignment and tension as constitutive dynamics shaping processes of assembling at intersecting levels. The focus on community-building and institutionalisation in the final empirical chapter therefore serves to illuminate how positioning in relation to broader socio-political environments and negotiations within individual practice converge in the ongoing assembling of TST as a religious movement.

At the **macro level**, the study examines the ways in which TST takes shape in relation to the broader social context—primarily the US and, to some extent, Canada—addressing the research question: *How does The Satanic Temple assemble in relation to wider society?* The following empirical areas have been selected to capture these dynamics:

Demographic Composition
This area explores who engages with TST, using indicators such as geographical distribution, age, religious background, gender and sexuality, rural versus urban upbringing, educational attainment, and social class.[20]

Perceived Socio-Political Wrongs
This area identifies key issues around which the movement assembles as a critical religious and social practice. Indicators include satisfaction with national and local conditions, emotional responses to the state of the country, and stances on Christian nationalism and abortion access.

Visions of a Good Society
This area assesses participants' normative views on societal issues, focusing on their positioning regarding the separation of church and state and religious pluralism.

Strategies and Alliances for Change
The focus here is on how TST seeks to enact social change, examined through indicators such as participants' engagement with TST's campaigns, strategic approaches to activism, and cooperation with other public actors.

At the **micro level**, the study elaborates on the research question: *How does The Satanic Temple assemble through participants' negotiations of Satanic practice and stigma?* Empirical focus is placed on:

[20] Race or ethnicity was not included as a survey variable for both methodological and ethical reasons. As my theoretical framework does not engage specifically with race in relation to religious commitment, and as TST's activism does not foreground race as a distinct axis of mobilisation, the inclusion of an additional category of sensitive personal data (beyond religion, gender and sexuality) was difficult to justify in the ethical review application. Nevertheless, questions concerning race within TST's activism are addressed in Section 4.4.2. Previous research has characterised Satanists as predominantly white (Dyrendal et. al. 2015: 136–137). Drawing on interviews with chapter heads from TST–Los Angeles and TST–Chicago, Laycock (2020: 78–79) notes several reasons why at least TST's leadership appears to be mostly white: the organisation's general discouragement of proselytisation; the strong embeddedness of Christianity within many BIPOC communities; the limited appeal of black metal and goth aesthetics among some racialised groups; and the higher social costs faced by racialised individuals whose affiliation with a Satanic movement becomes public.

Negotiation of Satanic Practice
This area examines how participants—regular members and ordained ministers—navigate alignment and tension in their approaches to Satanism. Indicators include how they accommodate or challenge various cultural and religious repertoires through inter-religious diffusion and secular-religious diffusion. Diffusion as alignment is operationalised as the intentional incorporation and translation of elements from other traditions or domains—understood as Significant Others (Hammer 2003)—into Satanic practice in ways that resonate with TST's foundational principles. Diffusion as dealignment refers to distancing from or rejecting religious or cultural forms perceived as incompatible with TST's ethos.

Experiences and Management of Stigma
This area investigates how participants experience and respond to stigma associated with Satanism. Indicators include: awareness and attitudes toward conspiracy theories such as Satanic Ritual Abuse and QAnon; anticipated stigma; management of structural stigma at individual and community levels; everyday experiences of stigma; practices of stigma disclosure and other forms of information control; perceived unequal treatment by identity aspect (gender, sexuality, race or ethnicity, socio-political views, religion, and lifestyle).

At the **meso level**, the study explores how alignment and tension unfold within the religious movement itself, addressing the research question: *How does The Satanic Temple assemble through internal dynamics and institutionalisation?* These dynamics are explored through the following empirical areas:

Coming Together and Cohesion Within
This area investigates how individuals engage with and experience community within TST. Indicators include forms and levels of involvement, pathways into the movement, spatial conditions of gatherings, and negotiations of public visibility. It also examines participants' sense of belonging and identification with TST, focusing on the role of value alignment, social trust, and the influence of aesthetic and emotional regimes in fostering cohesion or tension.

Negotiations of Institutionalisation
This area assesses how TST navigates organisational structure and adaptability. Indicators include satisfaction with TST, internal policies and governance practices at both central and local levels, and negotiations around activist goals, approaches and their boundaries.

3. Methodology

Working within a social-constructivist paradigm, I recognise that the outcomes of research are shaped by the theoretical frameworks employed, the methodological decisions made, and the disciplinary contexts in which they are situated. As Lincoln and Guba (2017) remind us, a social-constructivist inquiry rests on the assumption that the meaning of any social entity is not pre-given but can be constructed through a multiplicity of concepts and their associated variables, which are themselves defined by the researcher. From this perspective, knowledge production is understood as a process of sense-making; it is generated through the data, in the production of which both researcher and research participants are actively involved.

Research is thus not treated as a neutral instrument of discovery, but a set of practices that actively contribute to the shaping of social realities. As Law and Urry (2004: 393) argue, empirical inquiries do not merely describe the world but "make differences", "enact realities", and contribute to bringing into being that which they also study. Adopting a constructivist perspective therefore entails an ongoing reflexivity concerning how research is done, and how it may reinforce or challenge existing social and institutional arrangements.

Within this epistemological framing, the methodological focus of this study follows the shift articulated by Hjelm (2024: 57), "from trying to present a more or less accurate description of the world to trying to figure out what people accomplish (and hope to accomplish) by constructing a particular version of the world". This orientation positions the study within an interpretative tradition (Morse 2022), reflected in the study's ethnographic approach. Rather than aiming primarily at description or causal explanation, the analysis seeks to understand the processes through which meaning is produced, negotiated, and stabilised in practice. This is pursued through the abstraction and synthesis of empirical material, and through engaging results in dialogue with concepts and theories. In line with this interpretative orientation, the choice of methods is directly informed by the overarching research question and its subquestions, which address the assembling of TST through alignment and tension across different analytical levels: its positioning in relation to wider society, its internal dynamics, and the practices of individual participants.

Contemporary Satanism develops in a milieu consisting of decentralised, often virtual networks inspired by popular culture, where individuals can choose from a rich array of narratives and practices and combine them in

meaning-making processes (Petersen and Dyrendal 2012). The assemblage perspective provides methodological sensitivity to religion and media as interconnected social phenomena. As TST is assembled through practices that take place in both physical and virtual environments, the boundaries between online and offline are blurred. In contrast to earlier approaches to digital religion which tended to conceptualise online practice as separate from religion in the 'real world', the present study departs from the understanding that digital media does exist in "a self-enclosed cybernian apartness" and should therefore be considered as "continuous and embedded in other social spaces" (Miller and Slater 2000: 5 quoted in Tsuria et al 2017: 76). Thus, I locate the study within analytical approaches that seek to elucidate how individuals engage with religion in both online and offline realms, and how religious identity and community take shape in everyday negotiations between these social spaces (Campbell and Sheldon 2021, Lövheim and Lundmark 2021).

Against this background, digital material serves as a key entry point, where (de)alignment and tension are negotiated. In total, empirical material was generated through four complementary methods:

1. a selection of relevant digital material published on TST platforms;
2. an online survey distributed to participants in TST;
3. semi-structured interviews with participants in TST; and
4. participant observation in the US.

Figure 2. Overview of the empirical material included in the study.

Data	Time	Description	Format
Digital material: Minister Mondays	2022 (Accessed 2022)	12 episodes (~30 minutes each)	Researcher's notes & transcripts
Digital material: TST Services	June 2021 – March 2024 (Collected in spring 2024)	~220 recorded online services (~40–60 min)	Transcripts
Survey	Spring 2024 – Autumn 2024	136 responses	SPSS dataset
Interviews	Spring 2024 – Autumn 2024	11 interviews Zoom: 90–120 minutes email: written responses	Transcripts
Observation	October 2024	TST HQ in Salem 2 public tours 1 private gathering	Researcher's notes

The digital material, consisting of pre-existing data and spanning the longest time period, provided an initial orientation to the field and informed both the survey and the interview guide. The survey and interviews, conducted concurrently in 2024, together offer insight into participants' perspectives. Observation, undertaken after establishing contact with local congregation representatives during recruitment, adds contextual and interactional depth. Rather than assigning each method to a specific analytical level, all datasets are drawn upon across the three levels of analysis, to attend to complexity within an interpretative framework. As the most limited dataset, observations function primarily as a complementary source, enriching and situating the other materials.

The use of several data sources is not intended to enable direct comparison between predefined groups (e.g., by level of engagement, age, gender, or location), nor to identify a singular point of convergence across perspectives. Instead, my approach is guided by the principle of 'crystallisation' rather than 'triangulation' (Varpio et al. 2017: 45). Crystallisation emphasises the value of examining a phenomenon from multiple angles and through different lenses, producing a complex and layered account that foregrounds interpretative depth. In this way, the use of multiple data sources supports the study's aim to examine TST through an assemblage-informed perspective.

The aim, research questions and corresponding analytical levels have guided the design of the survey, the development of the interview guide, the selection of relevant digital material, and the scope of participant observation. The following sections describe in detail how I implemented each method and the types of research material that were produced.

3.1 Digital Material

TST produces a wide range of digital content that is available across its online platforms, both with and without subscription access and negotiated entry. Given the volume and heterogeneity of this material, it was necessary to make deliberate choices regarding what forms of digital content were most relevant to the aims of this study and what lay outside its scope. The central methodological challenge was the selection of analytically meaningful (given the theoretical approach) and ethically appropriate material from an extensive digital archive. Content produced in closed or restricted online groups was excluded.

The first part of the digital material consists of Minister Mondays, a series of recorded online discussions between ordained ministers of Satan from 2022. Minister Mondays were released on TheSatanicTemple.tv (TSTTV) and consist of 12 episodes of ca 30 minutes each. The content published on this platform changes over time, and the series Minister Mondays is no longer available. As it was not possible to manually download the material (TSTTV is a paid platform and the content is protected), the analysis is based on notes and manual transcriptions of the content. The idea behind the series Minister

Mondays is, according to one of the participants, "to document our history as it is unfolding" (Minister Mondays, 14 June 2022). In each episode, an ordained minister of Satan interviews a colleague about their vocation, focusing on the rituals they have performed or plan to perform in the future.[21]

Through the process of familiarisation with TST's online output, I identified the movement's digital religious services (TST services) as another salient example of the ongoing negotiation and formalisation of its practices. Introduced in 2021 following a major organisational restructuring, these services provide insight into how processes of homogenisation and standardisation emerge within the movement, while still allowing space for distinctiveness and personal adaptation in individual practice.[22] During the period of material selection, TST services were held twice a week, on Tuesdays and Sundays. The live-streamed versions were hosted on TSTTV, the movement's online subscription-based media platform and were announced as Temple Tuesday Service and Temple Weekend Service. Recorded versions were published in an archive at services.satanicministry.com and were accessible without subscription at the time of data collection in spring 2024. There were approximately 220 services digitally available for the period June 2021–March 2024, each 40–60 minutes in length. The services follow an established structure. Each online meeting is led by an ordained minister of Satan, or in some cases two ministers. The minister opens the service by reciting the Satanic Invocation and giving a brief introduction to the theme of the service, followed by a discussion between the minister and a panel.[23]

The services were manually downloaded as video or podcast files by the researcher. Although more time-consuming than using advanced web scraping software tools, manually extracting the data was the preferred method because aggressive web crawling can increase the load on website servers, negatively impacting other users. The manually extracted data was then automatically transcribed with Whisper, following the protocols described in 3.3. The quality of the transcription is high, as Whisper has a relatively low error rate for language recognition in English.[24] Having transformed speech to text, the most feasible analytic strategy for the data set was to focus solely on the linguistic features and ignore other audible or visual dimensions of the material.

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[21] One episode is a departure from this structure as it is about the arson attack on the TST headquarters in summer 2022.

[22] According to one interviewee, in some congregations the tradition of holding services or discussions about TST's religious values and practice began before the Religious Services were introduced as a common TST practice (Interview with K2).

[23] Following a pause during the 2024 schism, TST resumed the production of religious services in a revised format. Rebranded as Hellmouth Religious Services and hosted on TSTTV, some episodes of the services begin with a Litany of Enlightenment rather than the Satanic Invocation used in the earlier format.

[24] Despite the high quality of the automatic transcription, I always double-checked when a sentence or word sounded strange in context. For example, names of campaigns or celebrations could sometimes be misinterpreted by Whisper: "Menstruatin' with Satan" appeared as "Men Strengthen with Satan", and the holiday "Lupercalia" was misspelled as "Lubricalia".

The religious services and Minister Mondays are important research data because they function as laboratories in which participants in TST interpret and enact different dimensions of religious practice. This is in accordance with the aim to examine TST's assembling between alignment and tension, paying attention to stabilising or fragmentating dynamics, and how this is reflected in practice across digital and physical social spaces. Discussions on a variety of topics, including Satanic practices such as rituals and celebrations, tend to draw on the shared values as stated in the Seven Tenets of the movement and how participants interpret and enact them in practice. In this sense, the services and Minister Mondays serve as implicit forms of governance and membership formation. They are digital spaces that transcend the boundaries of local congregations, where the diversity of personal interpretations of what Satanism is are negotiated in mediated and moderated social interactions.

3.2 Survey

Although surveys are more commonly used within positivist research designs, this method can be adapted to gather data without making assumptions about external generalisability. The aim of the current survey is in line with the social-constructivist approach of the study, as the questionnaire is not intended to be quantitative or purely descriptive, but to highlight patterns and shared meanings that emerge within TST. The design of the questionnaire reflects this interpretative focus: questions are context-sensitive and attempt to capture participants' experiences, values, and attitudes in relation to their socio-political and cultural embeddedness. Further, many items include an option that allows participants to elaborate, describing in a nuanced and unique way how they construct meaning, understand their religious identity and interpret their experiences.

The use of survey data in this study serves to capture a range of perspectives within TST, enabling the identification of shared patterns as well as variation across a broader group of participants (Maxwell 2022). Accordingly, the survey includes participants occupying central and highly invested roles—such as engaged members and congregation leaders—as well as individuals representing a broader diversity of involvement. This allows for a nuanced account that attends both to commonalities and to internal variation.

From this perspective, the value of the survey lies in its contribution to interpretative insight, rather than in its representativeness of the entire TST population. It should therefore be noted that the results are not statistically representative of all individuals involved in TST. It was not possible to construct a sampling frame for probability-based techniques such as simple random or stratified sampling, as neither the exact size of the population nor its demographic composition is known.

Participation in the survey relied on a form of self-selection. As Andrews and colleagues (2003) demonstrate in their discussion of online survey methodology, such self-selection is a defining feature of research involving specialised or hard-to-reach populations, where participation is contingent upon participants' identification with the topic. At the same time, self-selection is not entirely unstructured, but is shaped by how the study defines and addresses its intended participants.

Participants were recruited on the basis of their involvement with TST. At the beginning of the survey, potential participants were presented with information specifying that they were being invited to take part because they are involved with the movement—for example, as members of a local congregation, participants in its campaigns, or individuals identifying themselves as friends or affiliates of the movement.[25] This framing served as a self-selection criterion, ensuring that respondents had relevant experience of the phenomenon under study. Prior to participation, individuals were provided with information about the study and asked to give informed consent by clicking "I agree", indicating their voluntary participation. The survey consists of 60 items and takes approximately 20 minutes to complete. It is structured in the following thematic sections:

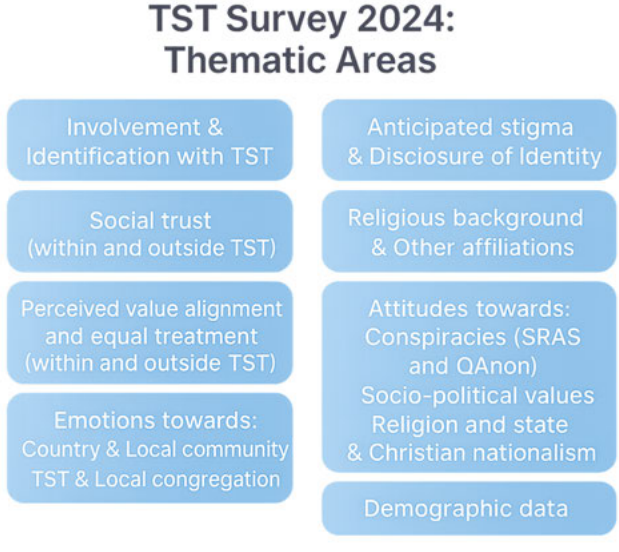


Figure 3. Thematic areas covered by The Satanic Temple Survey 2024.

In designing the survey, items were selected based on how well they addressed the research questions, informed by insights from previous research and by their relevance to attitudes toward issues central to TST's campaigns and the

[25] See Appendix I for the information provided to participants in the survey and the full questionnaire.

experiences of its members. To this end, I drew on existing surveys on values in the US, including those conducted by the Pew, PRRI, and GSS. In addition, I constructed a number of survey items specifically to explore the experiences, perspectives, and practices of actors involved with TST within the chosen theoretical framework.

A test version of the survey was conducted in autumn 2023. During the pilot, feedback from TST participants was received on the wording of the question: "How much do you agree or disagree with the following statements? TST represents my views on what religion is" (Likert scale with four response options). The statement in the question was subsequently reworded to make it more specific: "TST represents my views on religion as non-theistic". Comments from the survey results show that some respondents still find the question difficult or confusing.

The survey was launched on 12 February 2024 and remained open until 31 October 2024. The distribution of the survey was public, accessible via a link sent to local TST congregations via their email contacts, asking them to share the survey with their congregation. Attempts to contact TST centrally with information about the survey received no response. The possibility of using paid social media advertising to promote the survey was explored. In order to reach a very narrow and specific population such as TST, the advertising agency used by Uppsala University suggested posting the announcement on TikTok, but this was ethically problematic, as TikTok is a commercial platform that collects extensive user data, and recruiting through advertisements there could result in sensitive data—such as affiliation with a stigmatised movement—becoming traceable by third parties. Such exposure could compromise participants' anonymity and safety. On 25 April 2024, information about the ongoing research project and recruitment for the survey and interviews was again sent to local congregations by email, with a request to share the survey on their internal communication channels. The second notice was sent on 4 June and the final notice on 12 September 2024.

The survey received 136 responses.[26] The results are contextualised within previous survey research on TST (Colin 2021) and other Satanic communities (Holt 2022; Lewis 2001, 2010a; Dyrendal et al. 2015; Sprankle et al. 2020). This provides guiding questions into existing trends within contemporary Satanism. Given that the overwhelming majority of the respondents in the present survey report residing in the US, results are also contextualised in relation to existing studies on the American religious landscape (see 1.6). The aim is to contribute to understanding how TST's membership reflects or diverges from broader societal patterns across key dimensions, in this study conceptualised as empirical indicators of macro-level alignment or tension.

[26] The number of responses varies only modestly across most survey items, with the majority receiving between 130 and 136 responses.

Survey Challenges

It is important to address methodological issues concerning the sampling process, the distribution methods, and the limitations inherent in the data. Figure 4 provides a summary of outcomes from both prior surveys and the present study that explore the demographics and social characteristics of individuals who engage with Satanism. These studies, conducted over several years by various researchers, utilise non-random sampling and different recruitment methods, which may have influenced their data. From a sociological perspective, although not strictly representative, explorative surveys still reveal notable patterns and shed light on a religious environment that is challenging to capture in statistical terms and remains underexplored within the sociology of religion. Comparing the most frequently represented categories across key dimensions such as community affiliation and demographic characteristics offers insights into shared traits and variations within the Satanic communities.

As Sprankle et al. (2020: 154) note, "it may be impossible to obtain a random and representative sample of a decentralized, stigmatized religious group". Estimating the number of members involved in Satanic communities is challenging due to the varying categories of involvement. According to Foertsch's (2022: 992) personal communication with TST co-founder Jarry, TST had 500,416 "registered" members in 2021, defined by Jarry as "a member who has gone to our website, read our tenets, entered their name and email address, and clicked a box averring that they believe in our tenets". Additionally, researchers have noted that the decentralised and often anonymous nature of Satanist groups makes it difficult to reach a sufficiently diverse sample. This results in studies that provide only partial or fragmented insights into the demographics and characteristics of these communities. Holt (2022: 77) argues in a similar vein that "[n]umbers of self-identifying Satanists are difficult to measure, especially as the Satanic milieu is diffused, existing in ephemeral individual identities and loosely formed groups on top of official groups that may or may not keep reliable records that they release publicly".

Figure 4. Overview of survey-based studies on Satanism.

Researcher	Year	Sampling	Recruitment Method	N
James R. Lewis	2000-2001	non-random; self-identified Satanists	e-mail contacts from Satanist websites; posts on participants' websites	140
	2009	non-random; self-identified Satanists	e-mail contacts from Satanist websites; posts on participants' websites	>260
	2011	non-random; self-identified Satanists	e-mail contacts from Satanist websites; posts on participants' websites	>400
Cimminnee Holt	2016-2017	non-random, Church of Satan	verified e-mail contacts of Church of Satan members	97
Eric Sprankle et al	2019	non-random; self-identified Satanists	social media (Twitter & Instagram)	1272
Mathieu Colin	2020	non-random; The Satanic Temple	social media (Facebook)	327
Zhivka Koleva	2024	non-random; The Satanic Temple	e-mail contacts of TST congregations	136

The limited response rate of the current study should therefore be interpreted in the context of previous research efforts, which have also struggled to obtain representative samples from Satanist groups. Scholars investigating these communities report recruitment challenges. Holt (2011) documented cases where CoS actively discouraged its members from participating in Lewis's surveys because they targeted not only CoS members but all self-identified Satanists, including theists; in some instances, concerns were raised by CoS that few academic inquiries are serious. At the organisational level, CoS's refusal to collaborate with researchers seems to be a lasting policy, as seen in Foertsch's (2022: 986) experience where the organisation's sole response to inquiries was: "We have no interest in participating". Even groups like TST, which engage strategically with public discourse, maintain strict oversight. Zwissler (2023: 170) notes that her fieldwork required "several months for national governance to approve the group's request to work with me", a process reflecting both caution and the need to control narratives.

Members of Satanic communities can be sceptical about academic inquiries due to historical patterns of misrepresentation. As Holt (2011: 39) observes, studies of NRMs like Satanic groups are often complicated by "inconsistencies, contradictions, schisms [...] and inflammatory accusations from journalists, ex-members, anti-cult groups, and various critics". Media discourse contributes to these challenges. As mentioned in 1.5.2, American news media tends to present TST in a sensationalist manner, or using discursive strategies associated with othering (Escamilla 2023). Furthermore, mistrust and organisational gatekeeping are reflective of broader patterns observed in marginalised communities, where stigma and fears of exposure can act as barriers to participation in academic studies.

Along with recruitment challenges, another obstacle in sociological inquiries on Satanism is the lack of standardised survey instruments. This inconsistency in methodologies makes it difficult to compare results across different studies (Finke and Bader 2017: 4). Variations in questionnaire items, their phrasing, data collection techniques, and analytical frameworks complicate efforts to draw cohesive conclusions about the social patterns within Satanic communities and track evidence of change.

3.3 Interviews

The interview process started in spring 2024 and was finished in autumn that year. Recruitment relied on contacts with TST's local communities. Information about the research project was sent to the local congregations by email, asking them to spread the word to their congregants. Prior to participation, potential participants were again provided with information about the study

and the terms of involvement. Informed consent was obtained through a written consent form distributed via email.[27]

Research participants were given the option of being interviewed via Zoom, with their camera turned off, or via email. Harvey and colleagues (2024) argue for the use of a range of online interviewing formats when working with hard-to-reach or hidden populations. Individuals may be reluctant to participate if there is a risk of exposure and options such as camera-off interviews or text-based communication can therefore facilitate participation. Zoom-based interviewing enhances accessibility by removing geographical and logistical barriers and enables participants to engage from familiar and comfortable environments, which may facilitate more open interaction on sensitive topics (Gray et al. 2020). At the same time, different online formats involve methodological trade-offs. Text-based interviews may result in a lower volume of data compared to spoken interaction, as responses tend to be shorter and less spontaneous (Harvey et al. 2024). This was also reflected in my email interviews, which, while providing thoughtful responses, generally produced less extensive material than the Zoom format, which typically lasted between 90 minutes and two hours.

Overall, the interviews were semi-structured (Galletta 2012), guided by a thematic interview guide (informed by research questions and theoretical framework) but allowing flexibility in the order and depth of questions. While the guide provided a framework for reflection, the sequence of questions was adapted to follow the natural flow of each conversation. Topics that were not of particular interest to the participant or were considered too sensitive were not explored in detail. This approach was primarily applicable to the Zoom interviews, which was the preferred mode of participation for most interviewees. For the email interviews, I applied a semi-structured approach adapted to an asynchronous format. While this mode of interviewing lacked the immediacy of conversational interaction, it was guided by the same thematic framework as the Zoom interviews. Participants were informed that they could respond selectively to the questions they found most relevant and omit others. After receiving their responses, I followed up with additional questions to clarify specific points or invite further elaboration.

Eleven interviews were successfully completed. The interview data was transcribed manually by the researcher and automatically through a service provided by Uppsala University.[28] Following Forbat and Henderson's (2005) discussion on sharing transcripts with interview participants, I refrained from

[27] See Appendix II for the interview participant information sheet, the consent form, and the interview guide.

[28] The automatic transcription was carried out using Whisper, with the assistance of application expert Jayant Jadav at UPPMAX, Uppsala University, in accordance with protocols for sensitive personal information, ensuring that no data was transmitted to external servers. This processing was supported by resources provided by the National Academic Infrastructure for Supercomputing in Sweden (NAISS).

returning transcripts as a member-checking strategy (despite its frequent endorsement within qualitative approaches such as that of Lincoln and Guba 1985). This decision reflects the social-constructivist position: transcripts document context-dependent meanings and inviting participants to revise them might introduce new interpretations rather than validating the original interaction. In addition, asking study participants to review extensive transcripts may place an unnecessary burden on them. It may also generate discomfort, including feelings of embarrassment or concern about appearing inarticulate.

As figure 5 shows, the majority of interviewees were highly involved TST participants, such as ordained ministers of Satan and people volunteering in leadership and organisational positions. This is probably a consequence of the recruitment technique, which focuses on local communities. A person who wants to join such a community has to show commitment and go through a vetting process. Therefore, local communities tend to consist of actors who are highly involved in the movement.

Figure 5. Overview of conducted interviews.

KeyID	Form of engagement with TST	Location of congregation	Interview form
K1	congregation member, volunteering at congregation level	Canada	Zoom
K2	Minister of Satan, congregation co-head	Canada	Zoom
K3	Minister of Satan, congregation co-head	US, midwest	e-mail
K4	congregation member	US, midwest	e-mail
K5	Minister of Satan, congregation co-head	Canada	Zoom
K6	Minister of Satan, member of the congregation leadership	US, midwest	Zoom
K7	member of the congregation leadership	US, southwest	Zoom
K8	Minister of Satan, congregation co-head	US, northeast	e-mail
K9	congregation member, pursuing ordination as a Minister of Satan	US, midwest	Zoom
K10	Minister of Satan, member of the congregation leadership	US, west	Zoom
K11	Minister of Satan, congregation member	US, west	Zoom

3.4 Observations

This section presents methodological considerations relating to the participant observations I conducted with TST. Rather than approximating an ideal of prolonged immersion or 'going native', I used episodic participant observation as a strategic and supplementary method, structured in accordance with the study's aim (Svendby 2025). Even time-limited participation can enrich the research data, particularly in contexts where materiality and embodied practice are central to meaning-making. My episodic approach included observations at TST's headquarters in Salem and participant observations at events organised by members of TST that took place in New England in October 2024. This period was strategically chosen because it falls during the month of Halloween, a holiday on TST's annual calendar. During this month, local congregations typically organise face-to-face activities and gatherings to celebrate the occasion. The events observed were two tours in Salem led by a minister of Satan and member of TST, and a Halloween celebration by a local congregation that included performing of a Destruction ritual.

Contact with the local congregation in New England was made primarily through email and social media. The first contact was initiated in April 2024 when the gatekeeper of this community, a minister of Satan and co-leader of the congregation, agreed to share information about the study with their community and then participated in an interview for the project. In June 2024, I sent an email to announce the plan to visit the Salem headquarters and some of the nearby congregations in the autumn. I asked if there were any scheduled events or regular activities in their congregation during October that I could attend as a researcher. My contact shared they usually have a Halloween party for the congregation and later I received an invitation to a gathering on 19 October. The minister explained that the congregation usually holds private sessions in someone's home. This time they had tossed around the idea of doing the celebration elsewhere, asking if I had a preference. Ethically and methodologically, any deliberate intervention in the course of events is something I wanted to avoid as much as possible; therefore, I did not express personal preference, assuring my contact that any events or meetings they planned around the time of my visit would be of interest to my research.

Throughout our correspondence, I considered various strategies for minimising changes in group dynamics and the way participants interacted with each other in light of my presence at their event. When my gatekeeper wrote that they were planning a Destruction ritual at the Halloween gathering and that congregants had voted that I was welcome to attend, I asked whether the congregation would feel more comfortable if I participated in the ritual or observed only. This decision was left to me, but methodologically, the boundaries between participation and non-participation are blurred (Seim 2024). Rather than adopting an observant participation approach—seeking to enact the role of co-congregant to minimize distance—I chose to attend the ritual

without actively participating, refraining from destroying an object of personal symbolic value. As a non-member of the community under study, engaging in the ritual in this way could have been perceived as disingenuous, suggesting either a performance of belonging or an obscuring of my role as a researcher. Therefore, I participated without making an individual contribution to the destruction ritual. At the same time, I tried to be part of the group and, like other participants, I repeated the words of the minister as they set the tone for the ritual and delved into its symbolic meaning. This positioning enabled me to maintain an analytical orientation directed outward—to the practices and interactions of the congregants—rather than inward, to my own embodied experience.

My presence as a researcher may have influenced the interactional dynamics of the gathering. As this was the only event of this kind that I observed, I am not in a position to assess how such interactions would typically unfold. In an effort to remain low key and minimise my influence on the atmosphere, I refrained from actively shaping the social dynamics. For example, I did not attempt to recruit additional interview participants during the evening, and when I was asked about my music preferences and invited to suggest additions to the playlist, I chose not to do so. While this approach supported a more observational stance, it may also have contributed to positioning me as a somewhat reserved or less engaged guest.

The other events I observed were explicitly public in nature: two Satanic Salem walking tours, on 17 and 31 October 2024. Unlike the private congregation event I attended, these tours were open to all members of the public, with tickets available through an online booking platform. The Satanic Salem walking tour is publicly promoted as a tourist attraction, described on the Facebook page of The Satanic Temple of Salem as "a historic walking tour of Salem, free of supernatural or superstitious influences", and advertised on other online platforms for broad accessibility. To ensure transparency and address ethical considerations, I disclosed my role as a researcher in the comment section of my booking. The Satanic Salem Walking Tour was recommended by TST's headquarters, aka Salem Art Gallery, when I asked for information about planned community events I could attend. The strong association between the tour and TST was clear in the fact that the tour was announced on TripAdvisor as "Salem history from The Satanic Temple's Salem Art Gallery". A special Halloween version of the tour ended in the front yard of Salem Art Gallery (TST's headquarters), with a witch ritual performed by the guide in which participants in the tour could join and were given small symbolic gifts. The tour usually begins at Salem's Old Town Hall, a bustling public square surrounded by cafés and souvenir shops, where several other tourist tours also gather, emphasising its integration into the town's public and commercial life.

3.5 Data Analysis

Survey results were processed in SPSS and through the reporting functions of Artologik's Survey&Report, using descriptive statistical methods. The transcribed interviews, selected digital material, and notes from participant observations were analysed with thematic analysis. The survey formed one component of a dialogic qualitative research design in which all four types of material were interpreted in relation to one another.

My experience conducting this study reflects other researchers' observations that qualitative inquiry is characterised by an iterative overlap between data collection, analysis, theorising and writing; even though thematic analysis is often described as a sequence of discrete steps, in practice it involves a continuous and recursive movement across these phases of knowledge production (Nowell et al. 2017). In line with my overall social-constructivist interpretative framework, in the thematic analysis I sustained conceptual engagement throughout the research process to avoid producing merely descriptive themes or staying tied to a pre-established theoretical framework (Braun and Clarke 2019, 2022). In this approach themes are considered as 'generated' through interpretative work rather than simply 'found' within the dataset. Thus, I actively engaged with the material as an interpretative participant, allowing theoretical sensitivity, prior knowledge, and analytical decisions to shape the development of themes. Consistent with this view, coding is an open-ended and iterative process, as further work with the material may always generate new insights. Following Varpio and collegues' (2017) critique of saturation as an absolute criterion, I do not treat it as a measure of completeness, but instead rely on the development of sufficient analytical depth and coherence in the themes. Qualitative rigour is defined internally, by conceptualising and systematically integrating diverse forms of empirical material into a coherent analytical account (Morse 2022: 376). Emphasis is on the capacity of the analysis to address the research questions.

With these principles in mind, the following section breaks down the analysis process into a series of steps. TST services, as the largest dataset and most comprehensive part of the digital material, were approached in three stages: (1) familiarisation, aimed at gaining an overall understanding and guiding the selection of relevant episodes; (2) selection of relevant episodes in relation to the research questions and theoretical perspectives; and (3) deductive coding, informed by the analytical levels described in Section 2.5. During the familiarisation stage I sought to establish an overview of the topics discussed in TST services. To facilitate this process, I organised information about each episode in an Excel spreadsheet, including the original headings, tags, and short descriptions provided on the webpage where the services were published. Where such information was lacking or minimal, I skimmed the episode and added a brief description or a set of keywords myself. This initial

work remained close to the original framing of the material rather than being guided by my analytical concepts, and resulted in a rough thematic overview.[29]

As the interviews progressed and the theoretical framework was further refined, I made a preliminary selection of service episodes and imported their transcripts into NVivo for coding. I then proceeded with deductively oriented thematic analysis of the selected services, guided by prior research and the conceptual framework. Applying thematic analysis deductively "involves using preexisting theory as a lens through which to interpret the data", rather than "'testing' a preexisting theoretical framework or hypothesis" (Braun and Clarke 2022: 8). Accordingly, during this stage the focus was on identifying patterns that specifically illustrate tensions and alignments within TST and between TST and society at large, as well as how these dynamics manifest in participants' reflections on their Satanic practice and everyday experiences. For instance, one of the broader themes identified in the familiarisation step—how TST participants relate their Satanic values and practices to other religious and cultural traditions—was considered important and therefore explored in greater depth.

As the broader analytical process unfolded through engagement with other parts of the material and outlining the empirical chapters, I occasionally returned to the services and added further episodes that appeared relevant in light of refined concepts and analytical levels. These were subsequently incorporated into NVivo for closer analysis, reflecting the iterative character of the research process. For instance, service episodes initially classified under Satanic Philosophy and Ethics in the thematic overview often included discussions of emotional responses. These segments were therefore coded as Emotions, and selected instances were subsequently conceptualised, in accordance with the theoretical framework, as articulations of emotional regimes.

The smaller subset of the digital material, Minister Mondays, was coded first inductively, during manual transcription and note-taking, and later deductively, in accordance with the theoretical framework, after importing into NVivo. While this material was easier to grasp in its entirety, the iterative and organic nature of coding still required several adjustments. For example, a discussion in an episode that was initially coded as "stigma and safety" was later re-categorised as "stigma management", following closer analysis and refinement of themes.

Interview transcripts and observation notes were also imported and coded in NVivo, employing mostly deductive strategies, with codes informed by theory and analytical levels. This theoretical orientation meant that I avoided word-by-word or line-by-line coding. Instead, I proceeded to conceptualise larger segments of data, such as paragraphs. My analytical lenses were already established, albeit undergoing refinement. At this stage, the process also

[29] See Appendix III for the thematic overview of TST services and the codes assigned to the three analytical levels.

became increasingly abductive. For instance, during this process I conceptualised dealignment as a distinctive strategy related to alignment and tension. Several central themes appeared to be deeply entangled, reflecting the relational logic of assemblage theory, though this complexity posed challenges for structuring the analysis. For example, within the theme Collective Practice, intersections emerged with shared values, aesthetic and emotional regimes in participants' reflections on rituals, celebrations, and everyday life. To make sense of these connections, I often stepped outside NVivo to create mind-maps and diagrams, that allowed me to visualise and rethink concepts and relationships.

The integration of survey responses, interviews, digital content, and observations followed the analytical levels. This process involved moving themes across analytical levels and examining points of convergence between levels. For example, survey responses concerning experiences of stigma and stigma-management strategies were read alongside interview articulations and digital discussions from TST services and Minister Mondays to explore how individual reflections resonate with, or diverge from, collective discourses within TST, thereby helping to determine the appropriate analytical level. As I interpreted how themes and their interrelations should be located at the macro, meso, and micro levels of inquiry, I had also begun drafting the empirical chapters. Writing thus became integral to the analysis, prompting repeated reconsiderations of the appropriate analytical level for specific themes and refining of concepts.

3.6 Positionality and Ethical Considerations

Researcher Positionality

Adopting a social-constructivist perspective entails critical reflection on the historical, structural, and theoretical frameworks of my own discipline. This position informs my approach to the category 'religion' (as discussed in 1.3). In line with Taira's (2013b) discursive approach, I treat religion not as a stable analytic object but as a socially constructed category whose boundaries are continually produced and disputed. McCutcheon has critiqued essentialist discourses of religion (2021: 8), arguing that academic definitions often "de-emphasize difference, history, and socio-political context in favour of abstract essences and homogeneity" (1997: 20), while projecting local understandings as universal truths (2024: 2). McCutcheon urges scholars to recognise that the study of religion is neither value-free nor objective but shaped by socio-political and institutional contexts and carries tangible consequences. As he explains,

> [o]nce entrenched in a society's various governing institutions (e.g., schools, courts, legal documents, economic systems, etc.), the category "religion," when defined in specific ways and by certain social actors—and always in concert with a host of organizations and social actors—creates the impression that specific aspects of society are uniquely different and therefore deserving of special treatment, providing a basis for authorizing all sorts of practical claims about the world, whether politically liberal or conservative, whether critical of or in favor of so-called religion. (McCutcheon 2024: 7)

In a similar vein, Alvesson and Kärreman (2011: 6) reflect, that "human interests and cultural, gendered and political ideals can put their imprint on methodological ideals as well as on research practices and results," which makes it "very difficult to see science as a pure activity—neutral and objective in relation to the reproduction or challenging of social ideologies, institutions and interests".

However, I argue that acknowledging the influence of human interests, cultural norms, and political ideals on research does not weaken science—it makes it more reflexive. My own values and assumptions indeed play a role. As Mills (2000: 177) reminds us, "there is no way in which any social scientist can avoid assuming choices of value and implying them in his work as a whole". My personal normative position, rooted in the concept of agonistic democracy (Mouffe 2005; 2013; 2020), has informed both the choice of research subject and the design of this study. Agonistic democracy, with its emphasis on pluralism, contestation, the effective dimension of collective identity formation, and resistance to hegemonic closure, resonates with the values that underpin my interest in TST as a case of negotiated identity and counter-hegemonic activism.

As an outsider to the community—not part of any Satanic community nor the North American context (born in Communist Bulgaria and now a naturalised Swede)—I entered the field aware of my positionality. In addition, I do not share several of the aesthetic and cultural reference points that are common within the community. For instance, I have never played Dungeons & Dragons, do not enjoy horror films and do not own a single black T-shirt with a metal band logo. My only brush with heavy metal was an Iron Maiden cassette in my early teens, which I once defended in an argument with a classmate who claimed metal was not music because "you cannot dance to it". This distance initially raised concerns about access and rapport, but it also shaped the form that interactions took during interviews and observations. On several occasions, I had to ask clarifying follow-up questions, which likely prompted interviewees to elaborate more extensively on certain themes. At the same time, this distance may have led me to overlook particular threads of relevance.

Most interviews were saturated with rich and elaborated reflections, and during my visit to a local congregation's Halloween celebration, I was met with hospitality and care. These experiences left me with a sense that I received more than I gave in these interactions. During the interviews and

observations my role was primarily that of an intensive listener, trying to demonstrate both curiosity and respect for my interviewees but not contributing so much to the dialogue with comments or emotional responses, but rather structure and follow-up questions.

Researcher Reflexivity in Conditions of Internal Fragmentation

Conducting empirical inquiry on a stigmatised religious community raises ethical and methodological challenges, especially when the group is undergoing internal churn. During the research project, TST experienced significant tensions, which seemed to culminate in 2024, resulting in schisms and organisational restructuring. My understanding of these internal processes and tensions was necessarily mediated by my research participants and other community members who chose to name, frame, and explain these developments to me.

This organisational instability directly shaped the research process. Initially, I planned to conduct participant observations and meet potential interviewees at the movement's annual SatanCon (following the two preceding conventions held in 2023 and 2022).[30] However, the emerging practice of organising annual conventions appeared to cease, removing a key anticipated fieldwork site. Recruiting research participants also became more challenging during this period. An interviewee suggested that the ongoing organisational turmoil might be affecting my ability to access participants:

> One person was let go, and more resigned from their positions in support. I don't know if or how it might impact your research, but people who were once enthused disappear. […] It wouldn't be TST without the annual schisms.

While I was able to gather some insider perspectives from research participants, the central leadership's views were not included in the analysis. Some leadership perspectives were available through public-facing materials, such as podcasts in which co-founder Lucien Greaves articulated his interpretation, but these were not incorporated into the study, as expanding the datasets to include further materials would have required reframing the scope of the whole study. Analytically, this also raised difficult questions about what it means to be critical when studying internal conflict. The purpose of this research is not to reveal a singular 'truth' about the causes of tension. Rather, my aim has been to include as many perspectives as possible to better understand how tension was experienced, interpreted, and negotiated by different actors. Ethically, digging deeper into conflict risks amplifying existing divisions or contributing to further fragmentation within a vulnerable community.

At the beginning of the study, local congregations with which I had established contact were invited to share what research themes they considered

[30] The first SatanCon was held in 11–13 February 2022 in Scottsdale, Arizona and the second in April 28–30, 2023 in Boston, Massachusetts.

relevant, and these suggestions were taken into account when designing the study, particularly the survey and the interview guide. Proposed themes incorporated in some form into the research design included: the modern-day Satanic Panic; erosion of church–state separation; 'coming out' as a Satanist; the LGBTQ+ culture war; how radical or non-radical TST may be; religious joy as opposed to religious shame; and the need to make the organisation better rather than engaging in frequent mini-schisms.

Respondents have not been given the opportunity to review drafts or preliminary interpretations of the data because the study design did not include participant validation. However, the results will be communicated in a transparent and accessible manner once the thesis is completed. A link to the published thesis will be provided to study participants through the same email communication channels used for recruitment.

Negotiating Consent in Community Settings

This research project has been approved by the Swedish Ethical Review Board (registration number 2023-06082-01). The ethical guidelines informing the study are grounded in a commitment to research participants' individual autonomy and integrity (Görman 2023). However, in practice—particularly in research involving small communities and stigmatised groups—establishing rapport and negotiating consent is both an individual matter and a collective and relational process (Healey 2020). As I learnt, this process often unfolds in complex and unpredictable ways. When distributing information about the study to local congregations, one TST community contacted the project manager to request clarification regarding survey questions on political orientation and sexuality and their relevance to the research. Clarification was provided, but representatives of this local congregation ultimately decided not to share the survey link with their members, explaining that the group was in the midst of voting on whether to remain affiliated with TST.

These experiences emphasise the importance of recognising consent as a community-embedded and context-sensitive process, shaped by in-group relationships, trust, and shared concerns. Ethical engagement therefore requires attentiveness not only to individual integrity but also to gatekeeping mechanisms within the community. This is notably salient when external tensions, such as societal polarisation during an election year, coincide with internal turmoil within the movement. Such vulnerability may make community members more sceptical of being misrepresented as objects of research.

Navigating these issues methodologically has been challenging. Disagreement within a community regarding participation may place pressure on members and intensify internal tension. Moreover, because TST congregations are relatively small and tightly networked, repeated requests for participation can create a risk of research fatigue: when the same individuals are approached multiple times, they may feel overexposed or pressured to engage. To mitigate

this, I chose not to persist when initial invitations were declined, prioritising respect for boundaries.

Regulating Interviewees' Performance of Identity

The interview format, conducted via Zoom, introduced specific conditions for how research participants could perform their identity. In terms of anonymity, I often exercised greater caution than some participants, in line with my responsibility as a researcher. As outlined in the participant information sheet, which everyone was asked to review before giving consent, interviews were conducted with participants' cameras switched off, while my own camera remained on. In some cases, I had to persuade interviewees that reducing risks of identification was essential. Nevertheless, one interviewee explicitly requested to keep their camera on as a deliberate visibility statement, signalling openness, trust, and perhaps also affirming their belonging to TST within the research context. For most interviews, however, cameras remained off, which inevitably reduced the visual dimension of interaction. Without facial expressions, body language, or visual cues, participants' self-presentation was limited to voice, tone, and verbal articulation. This format limited certain aspects of identity performance. For example, some interviewees spoke about material objects associated with their Satanic identity and practice but were unable to show them, relying instead on verbal descriptions. I acknowledge that this removed an opportunity for participants to display aspects of their everyday Satanism they valued and were proud of.

The absence of visual exposure may have enabled greater openness, allowing participants to speak more freely without fear of recognition or unwanted visibility. The camera-off format can support a more reflective and less self-conscious mode of participation. As Marlowe and Allen (2023: 489) note, the presence of the 'self in the mirror' in video-mediated communication may heighten awareness of being observed and introduce an additional layer of self-monitoring. By removing this visual dimension, participants may experience less performative pressure and engage more directly with the content of their responses. However, the lack of visual cues also introduced specific ethical challenges. It did limit my ability to sense the dynamics of the interaction, complicating the interpretation of silence. Online interviewing requires distinguishing between different types of silence, such as technical interruptions, emotional responses, and reflective pauses (Marlowe and Allen 2023). In practice, I addressed this ambiguity by explicitly checking in with participants, for example, by asking whether everything was functioning properly or whether they would like to pause.

To reduce the risk of identification, I have chosen to omit background details about the interviewees—such as age-group, gender, and local community—from the thesis. For the same reason, I decided not to present interviewees under their Satanyms. These pseudonyms can function as highly recognisable markers, particularly within local congregations and other TST

contexts, where members could easily identify one another. Given the internal tensions during the period of data collection, this poses a substantial risk of compromising confidentiality. Although Satanyms are imbued with creativity and rich symbolic meaning, which I deeply appreciate, my priority has been to safeguard participant safety and anonymity.

Risks and Benefits

During this study, careful attention was paid to minimising risks for participants and to avoiding harm, including the potential for stigma or misrepresentation. The study prioritised confidentiality, voluntary participation, and respectful representation throughout. To the best of my knowledge, participation involved minimal direct risk.

For the survey, the risk of identification was minimised through the use of a web-based tool that did not collect identifying information such as IP addresses or login data. Responses were processed in aggregated form, meaning that individual participants could not be linked to specific answers. Similarly, the interview component posed limited risk but involved a degree of emotional engagement, as participants were invited to reflect on personal experiences and beliefs. While no sensitive topics were imposed, some questions could evoke discomfort. In addition, although measures were taken to anonymise interview material and observations, a residual risk of identification could not be entirely excluded, particularly in smaller or closely connected communities. To mitigate this risk, identifying details were removed or generalised in the presentation of the data.

Overall, the study sought to capture a range of perspectives in order to provide a broader and more nuanced account of a stigmatised religious group. In this respect, the potential benefits of the research extended beyond the production of academic knowledge. Participation also enabled individuals to represent their perspectives in their own terms and to reflect on issues of importance to them. This reflexive dimension was evident in participants' follow-up communications. One interviewee noted in an email after the Zoom conversation: "It was actually really helpful to centre my thoughts and think about some topics more". Another expressed a similarly positive experience, despite my initial concern that the interview might have been emotionally overwhelming. Writing the day after, in response to a follow-up message, they remarked: "It honestly was a great conversation. I have a tendency toward being very open with my experiences, so I was fairly comfortable. […] Thank you so much for talking with me and asking interesting questions [smile]".

4. The Satanic Temple and Wider Society

> I am very uncomfortable with the direction in which my country is heading. (TST survey 2024)

This chapter addresses the first research question: *How does The Satanic Temple assemble in relation to wider society?* Accordingly, the analysis focuses on the ways in which TST takes shape in relation to its broader social context, mainly USA and to a lesser extent Canada.

At this level, the analysis centres on four empirical areas through which the group's positioning in relation to the wider society can be understood: demographic composition, perceived socio-economic wrongs, visions of a good society, and strategies and alliances for change. The analysis presented in this and the subsequent empirical chapters draws on and thematically integrates all primary datasets of the study: survey and interview material, as well as digital data and observational fieldnotes.

4.1 Demographic Composition

This section focuses on the demographic composition of participants in TST based on a non-probability sample (see 3.2) and analyses characteristics that may contribute to social patterning within the movement. The following demographic indicators are considered: geographical distribution, age, religious background, gender and sexuality, rural versus urban upbringing, educational attainment, and social class of individuals who engage with TST.

The *geographical distribution* of the sample indicates that a substantial majority (92%, n = 135) reside in various regions across the US. Among these, the Northeast region accounts for the largest share, comprising 38% of the US participants. Approximately one-fifth of US respondents are located in the Midwest (20%), followed by the South (18%) and West (16%) regions. A smaller percentage (8%) reside outside the US. This group is distributed across three countries: most of them live in Canada, while a few others reside in the UK or the Netherlands.

The pattern of respondents being predominantly located in the US, as observed in the current survey, is consistent with insights from previous surveys on TST and other Satanic communities (see 1.6.3). Regarding the concentration of respondents in the Northeast of the US, cultural, symbolic and

organisational factors may contribute to understanding this pattern. Notably, the historical roots of the organisation lie in this region. It was in Harvard that the movement's founders, Greaves and Jarry, first established contact, and they have maintained strong ties to the Boston area (Laycock 2020). One of TST's earliest public interventions, a controversial Black Mass, was planned to take place on the campus of Harvard University (Laycock 2021: 47). Although the event was moved off-campus due to public backlash, it attracted significant media attention, which might have contributed to the group's visibility in the region. Moreover, TST has its official headquarters in Salem, Massachusetts. The Salem Art Gallery, as the headquarters are known, is both a symbolic and practical hub for the organisation. It serves as a community space and an artistic hub, attracting both members and tourists, and further embedding the organisation in the local cultural fabric.

Turning to *age* composition, the survey results suggest a predominantly adult respondent group. The average age of respondents is 41.76 years (SD=8.90, n = 135), with ages ranging from 23 to 67 years. The largest age group is 38–48 (41%), followed by 27–37 (31%) and 49–59 (24%), with smaller proportions aged 18–26 (2%) and 60 and above (1%).[31]

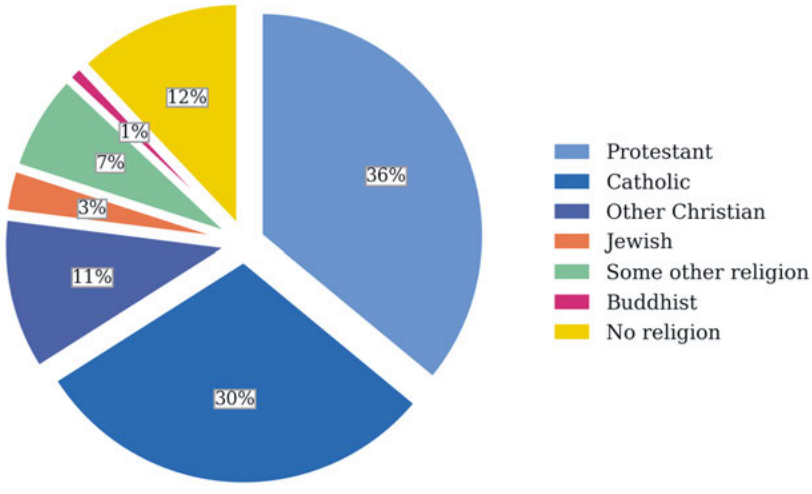
In terms of *gender*, the data indicate an equilibrium between female and male respondents, with 40% of 136 respondents identifying as women and 40% as men, while 19% identify as gender-diverse (including non-binary and other gender identities). Regarding *sexual orientation*, the data suggest that 49% are heterosexual, 32% gay, lesbian or bisexual and 19% identify as other. In other words, 51% of the 136 respondents, or approximately one in two individuals, fall within the LGBTQ+ spectrum.

An interviewee confirms this picture and further reflects on the presence of other marginalised identities within their community, including in leadership:

> I'd say TST is more LGBT than the surrounding population. We tend to be more 'queer' and there are a lot of women and trans people in leadership. […] And even the couple of men that have been in our leadership in [local congregation] have all been disabled or have had mental health issues as well. We tend to be pretty marginalized in our leadership, […] It's the same makeup as our congregants themselves so we're of the same identities as our congregants and people that are coming to us. (Interview with K5)

[31] For ethical reasons, the survey was limited to participants aged 18 and over.

Figure 6. Religious upbringing.
Source: The Satanic Temple Survey 2024.



Breakdown by *religious background* shows a clear prevalence of Christian heritage (about 77%) among respondents (see Figure 6).[32] Within these Christian backgrounds, Protestant (36%) and Catholic (30%) are the largest groups. Within 'other Christian', survey participants report diverse religious backgrounds, including Orthodox Christianity, Mormonism, Unitarianism, Pentecostalism, the Church of England. Additional descriptions of religious backgrounds in the comments suggest a variety of Christian socialisations:

> Non-denominational Christian. Both non/light practicing from parents.
>
> A pyramidology based Christian apocalypse prediction cult.
>
> Born again Christian.
>
> Was Christian now open spiritual.

The unaffiliated ('no religion') group represents a notable segment of the respondents (12%). In the category 'other religion', several survey participants report Pagan backgrounds; a few identify with the Native American Church or Unitarian Universalism. Some respondents describe a mixed environment:

> Atheist, Jewish and Pagan.

[32] The pattern of Christian upbringing reflects earlier survey results on Satanists prior to TST's establishment (Dyrendal et al. 2015: 156).

> A mixture of everything; my family was very encouraging of me exploring different religions.

Looking at respondents' *education levels*, it is worth noting that a high proportion (90%, n = 136) report at least some higher education or a college or an advanced degree.[33] In terms of socio-economic status, two additional variables add interesting facets to the group's composition: *place of living at the age of 16* and *self-identified social class*. A considerable part of respondents (85%, n = 136) report an urban background: about 43% lived in small cities at the age of 16, while a similar proportion (42%) grew up in medium-sized or large cities, or their suburbs. A smaller percentage (15%) report a rural upbringing, either on a farm or in the open countryside.

Living in a large city or suburb might be associated with higher socioeconomic resources, while living in rural areas might indicate different economic conditions (Clark et al. 2022). Somewhat surprisingly, the data suggest a relatively low perceived socioeconomic status among the respondents, despite relatively high levels of reported educational attainment. Only 38% of the respondents (n = 135) identify as middle class and just 3% as upper class, while the majority (59%) identify as either working class (41%) or lower class (18%). This apparent disconnect between education levels and socioeconomic self-identification may be connected to respondents' emotions regarding the condition of their country, their perspectives on social issues, and their motivations for engaging in activism—topics to which we now turn.

4.2 Discontent as Tension

This section focuses on how participants in TST perceive socio-political wrongs in their country of residence. Given that most survey respondents and interviewees are based in the US or Canada, the discussion on perceived wrongs, and the emotions associated with them, will dwell mostly on how these participants experience the current state of these countries.

4.2.1 An Emotional Regime of Discontent

Attitudes to the socio-political climate identified across different data sets suggest a shared sense of unease. For example, one interviewee remarks:

> The current status of political discourse in the United States is worrying. And if I were watching it from outside, I would be very concerned. (Interview with K9)

[33] This includes 27% of respondents with some college education, 40% with a college degree, and 23% with an advanced degree.

This trend is reflected in the survey, notably in reported emotional responses to the country and the local communities in which respondents reside. A large majority (95%, n = 135) are dissatisfied with the state of their country, which suggests widespread discontent with national issues, policies, and/or the overall socio-political climate. Satisfaction levels are more balanced when it comes to local community of residence: while 57% (n = 135) are still dissatisfied, a notable 43% express satisfaction. Respondents who report satisfaction with the place in which they live, tend to attribute it to a "progressive community" or the open-mindedness of the people in this area.

This pattern of discontent recurs in other emotional orientations reported in the survey. Respondents overwhelmingly express negative sentiments when contemplating their country's current condition. About 93% (n = 134) report feeling anger and 88% (n = 133) express fear. Additionally, 92% (n = 132) indicate they do not feel a sense of pride in their nation. Despite this, more than one in three (36%, n = 132) still report experiencing hope. In the comments, several respondents describe a complex mixture of emotions:

> I do try to remain hopeful, but I'm beyond scared and angry about what's happening when it comes to the regression of our values as a country.
>
> I am fearful but always have hope.
>
> Mixed emotions. Because Trump predominantly clogs up the media with his whining and lies. I have hope that Biden will turn things around but fearful that Trump will weasel his way back to the WH.
>
> Sometimes things happen that make me hopeful, and I would say more disappointed than angry.
>
> Hopeful, but consistently disappointed. I love this country like the parent of a child addicted. Unconditionally, but with the understanding that they're probably going to make a lot more mistakes and get hurt a lot before they get better.

Hope can be connected to belief in change and the possibility of another future; it can thus nurture engagement in activism and provide the energy to persist. This emotional complexity is illustrated by an interviewee based in the US, who describes how involvement with TST fosters empowerment:

> [I]t gives me optimism for once, you know, because being an American citizen is not a great experience a lot of the time. It's not something that you can often feel a lot of pride in, depending on your view of the world. But being a Satanist, I feel like I have more agency over the future, that I can help make things not suck. So, I do like that. (Interview with K10)

A closer examination of the social wrongs identified as sources of this discontent across different datasets (survey, interviews, and digital material)

suggests that these issues are both complex and interconnected. At the most general level, this discontent can be characterised as an experience of a 'major crisis'. Negative sentiments are associated with issues like wealth disparity and economic crisis, as exemplified in the following survey comments: "the economy is collapsing"; "the various systems in this country favor the ultra-rich and leave everyone else behind"; "there is so much wealth in this country, but so few people have economic security"; "my family can barely afford food". This pattern of major crisis is further exemplified in respondents' descriptions of housing crises, and problems in the health care and education systems. Both US residents and Canadians are concerned about the erosion of welfare: "We have a lot of issues with housing affordability and housing instability, and people not being able to afford food because of how expensive everything is" (Interview with K5). Notably, some of these issues are addressed in TST's work for social change. In particular, the Satanic Good Works campaign facilitates locally organised efforts to gather and distribute essential material support (hygiene items, clothing, and food) to shelters and other charitable organisations (The Satanic Temple n.d.d).[34]

A further layer of discontent is found in articulations of socio-political regression. Voices from the survey express deep concern about trends they describe as a threat for society:

> The USA is in a scary place with the increasing rise in nationalism, threat of fascism […]
>
> We are living a dystopian nightmare under a corrupt fascist regime […]
>
> Even as a cishet[35] white male who might not suffer under it, the lurch toward fascism and rabid intolerance makes me very scared for the future of my friends, family, fellow Satanists, and my child.

In addition, respondents voice frustration with the crisis in partisan politics in the US—an issue that became especially pronounced in public debates during the election year 2024. "I cannot believe that the two-party system is truly sinking our entire ship", a survey respondent comments.

Several voices reflect on socio-political regression as a phenomenon that is not confined to North America, but as a part of a broader global trend. For

[34] Another aspect of the identified pattern of a major crisis concerns global challenges such as climate change. Although climate change is not a core focus of TST's campaigns and is less significant for the movement's social engagement than other issues explored later in this chapter, this issue still appears in the data. For instance, one of the US interviewees includes their country's "not dealing with climate change" in their list of societal problems (Interview with K10). References to climate change appear in nine TST services, most notably in the service" Sustainable Satan" (23 January 2024).

[35] Cishet refers to someone who is both cisgender—having a gender identity that matches the sex they were assigned at birth—and heterosexual. That is, someone who fits the dominant norms of gender and sexual orientation.

instance, one US-based interviewee expresses concern when contemplating both the political future of their country and the situation in Europe, as 2024 saw numerous state and regional elections across the old continent:

> I'm really following the news for Europe and everything else, the elections this year are just terrifying. The right wing has really, really upped their game here in the United States. Trump is just absolutely out of control. (Interview with K11)

This concern about global socio-political trends is also shared by a Canadian interviewee. Their long-standing attention to the rise of right-wing movements (dating back to the 1990s, well before the emergence of TST) indicates a sustained engagement with socio-political issues both domestically and internationally. The following quote illustrates how ideological concern and socio-political interpretation are closely intertwined with emotional responses; political developments are not only observed and evaluated, but also felt:

> There were punks fighting skin-heads on the streets of Ottawa. I have a friend of mine who actually became a CSIS [Canadian Security and Intelligence Service] informant because her boyfriend got involved in organizing these right-wing gangs in Ottawa and she got tapped by CSIS to become an informant. That was scary, serious shit! (Interview with K2)

For another Canadian Satanist, growing social division in the North American context is articulated as a worrying trend, and the presence of TST in the public realm as a necessary counterbalance to certain political and cultural currents. The comparison between the US and Canada suggests that the interviewee perceives varying degrees of social tension and different ways in which these antagonisms manifest in each country:

> Canada less so, more so in probably the United States, but [in] the recent years there's been a lot of social division on political lines and along certain cultural lines—religious divisions I think are a component of that. And I think that the voice that TST has in that kind of cultural milieus is an important factor in increasing the range of voices that are on the stage in terms of social life in both the United States and Canada. Canada, I think, is under less stress. I mean, there has [sic] been a number of social upheaval events in recent years in the US that are more extreme, more dangerous, more violent than things in Canada. But we have corresponding events in Canada that are disturbing, maybe not to the same degree. (Interview with K1)

This account situates TST within a broader landscape of escalating socio-political polarisation. The congregant observes a loss of "a common cultural identity". Their involvement with TST is framed as a part of the trend towards radically opposing positions:

> For example, I'm going to the extreme of… The Satanic Temple is an extreme wing of a cultural movement. How extreme—we recently had tea together—but I mean, as far as the range of social interests they're pursuing, each as individual and to some degree as a collective. (Interview with K1)

Words such as "scary" and "disturbing" highlight the emotional dimension embedded in these evaluations of socio-political issues. Survey respondents add more facets to this discourse on socio-political regression, articulating frustration with what they see as an erosion of civil rights in various areas.[36] Specifically, racism, the decline of LGBTQ+ rights and women's reproductive rights are mentioned:

> […] reactionist movement against any type of civil rights gains (for non-white people and LGBTQ+ people) […]

> […] losing women's rights to abortion […]

> I have an [sic] uterus. So, to this country, I'm less than a person.

Some respondents even express safety concerns:

> I can't even live openly as a non-Christian anti-Trumper without fear of being harmed here in the southern US.

> I'm trans in America, there's a reason I'm armed.

Seen through the theoretical model guiding this study, the emotional responses identified in the material are interpreted as situated within a socially structured field of relations. When individuals reflect on or name their emotions, they do so in ways that are shaped and rendered intelligible by emotional regimes operative within the assemblage(s) they inhabit. In this sense, emotional regimes provide the conditions in which particular emotions can be recognised, articulated, and amplified, while others might remain marginal or muted. Importantly, conceptualising these emotional expressions in terms of emotional regimes does not imply a questioning of individual agency or sincerity, nor does it suggest the presence of explicit collective pressures to feel or express emotions in particular ways.

The patterns discussed here are embedded within an emotional regime of discontent, functioning as a socially available interpretative vocabulary through which to make sense of perceived social problems, injustices, and threats. These articulations of discontent illuminate how socio-political tensions are emotionally negotiated within TST—but they do not exhaust the range of emotions that shape the movement as an affective social space. The

[36] Some of these issues will be examined more closely in this chapter and in Chapters 5 and 6 in relation to solidarity for diversity, stigma and stigma management strategies.

regime of discontent is oriented toward large-scale socio-political developments. Against this backdrop, the following section turns to an issue that occupies a particularly central position in these emotionally charged articulations of crisis, threat, and injustice: Christian nationalism.

4.2.2 Discontent With Christian Nationalism

An analysis of the empirical material points to a significant concern over the entanglement of religion and state, particularly in the socio-political context of the US. Christian nationalism is identified as a key threat. Concerns about its influence are prevalent in the survey, with statements such as "Christian nationalist movement tries to move us closer to a theocracy" and "the religious right is slowly taking away our freedoms". A US-based interviewee reflects why this intersection is problematic for democratic society:

> And that alignment—the willingness to alter politics in accordance with faith, but also alter religion in according with politics—is something that I find very worrying. […] If between the two of us, we have a disagreement on a matter of politics, and we're both approaching that from a political perspective, then we can have that disagreement and be friends at the end of the day. We can rationally disagree, or we can reasonably disagree on whether a particular political stance is the best one. But where one of us believes that a particular religion, a particular political stance is a matter of faith and the decree of an omniscient and omnipotent God, there is no conversation. (Interview with K9)

In the survey, awareness of the concept Christian nationalism is high, with 96% (n = 136) indicating familiarity with the term (78% report hearing or reading 'a lot' about it, and 18% have heard or read 'a little'; only 4% state they have heard or read 'nothing at all'). Among respondents who are at least somewhat familiar with Christian nationalism (n = 131), attitudes are overwhelmingly negative: 98% hold a very unfavourable view, and the remaining 2% view it somewhat unfavourably (no respondents hold a neutral or positive position). To gain a more nuanced understanding, several items assessed attitudes to statements commonly associated with this ideology (see 1.6.1). These results underscore a consistent and emphatic opposition to Christian nationalist ideology. For instance, respondents were asked "Do you think the founders of America originally intended for the US to be a Christian nation?" An overwhelming majority (98%, n = 135) answered no (2% responded yes). A few comments that might suggest possible agreement with the idea—or at least ambivalence—are simultaneously downplaying its relevance to contemporary American society. For example, comments such as "Doesn't matter. Things are different now" or "And who cares if they did... they aren't here" reflect a view that the issue shouldn't be important today. Notably, voices that strongly reject the notion of the US's foundation as a Christian nation emphasise that

this is a matter of historical knowledge rather than an opinion, thereby aligning with rationalist rhetorical apologetics:[37]

> It is documented that several were not Christians.
>
> Any serious student of history can see from primary source materials that it was in no way intended to have any preferences toward any one religion.
>
> If we look at and consider ACTUAL history, America was founded to get away from religious prosecution.
>
> Just read the constitution and/or biographies of leaders of that day.
>
> Read the literature!

Attitudes to other statements associated with Christian nationalism suggest again a remarkable consensus among the respondents. For the statement "Being Christian is an important part of being truly American", all 136 respondents select 'completely disagree', indicating unanimous opposition to the notion that a Christian identity defines national belonging. The statement "The US government should declare America a Christian nation" is also overwhelmingly rejected (99% completely disagree, 1% mostly disagree). The claim that "If the US moves away from Christian values, we will not have a country" is met with the same level of disapproval (99% completely disagree, and 1% mostly disagree). Similarly, responses to the statement "US laws should be based on Christian values" indicate near-total resistance (96% completely disagree, 3% mostly disagree). In the comments, Christian nationalism is frequently articulated as a danger and threat, suggesting that this discourse is sustained by a distinct emotional regime of discontent marked by heightened intensity:

> I believe it could be extremely dangerous for those in our country who do not practice Christianity but practice a different religion. It could turn out to be a witch hunt.
>
> All of these things are terrifying to me, especially knowing there's people actively working to make these things a reality.
>
> Christian nationalism is an existential threat.
>
> Christian nationalists are a scary lot.
>
> They are extremists and, in many cases, domestic terrorists.

[37] More on the deliberate alignment with scientific discourse in 5.1.2.

> It's the worst thing to happen to this country.
>
> It is one of our largest national security threats that we are currently facing.

Some statements link Christian nationalism with fascism, framing them as closely related. For example: "Christian nationalism is just a guise for nationalism. It's Germany 1930s all over again" and "When fascism comes to America, it will be wrapped in the flag and carrying a cross". Notably, articulations that seem to reject not only Christian nationalism but object to Christian morality per se, coexist with more accommodating views:

> Christian values are ruining the possibility for peace & for the planet to support life. Christian values are actually threatening the survival of our species.
>
> Many great people have been Christians, but then so have many morally corrupt persons, so a belief in God did not make them better.
>
> There are some Christian values I think we should have, like forgiveness and dedication to the poor. But it's not because they are Christian values.

Another articulation of the discontent with Christian Nationalism is the reflection of a member in TST, based in the Midwest region of the US. The interviewee strongly rejects the broad normalisation of trends such as othering and dehumanising of minority groups, which they attribute to the influence of right-wing politics. Notably, their discontent with the socio-political climate is translated into activist mobilisation:

> It's kind of an obvious big orange answer there, isn't there [sic]? I mean, the rise of the alt-right, the Christian nationalism, Trump, and all of that—that type of stuff has definitely fuelled the fire. Especially when you have these individuals getting out there and saying the quiet part loud again, saying that, "Oh, these people coming over the border, they're less than human". Then the others that are having that internal thought go, "Oh, it's okay to say that now, good". And it's like, "No, no, no"… We're not going back to this! We have tried so hard to move [away] from this and I don't want to slide back to it. And that's one of the things that we have to fight against—that backslide into this authoritarian Christian nationalism that we're seeing now. (Interview with K6)

Lived experience and historical consciousness shape some TST members' perceptions of current political and religious entanglements. An interviewee with a background in the South of the US situates the present-day integration of religion and politics within a long continuum of historical events. They acknowledge that Christian communities have contributed to both the advancement of civil rights and their opposition. Tracing current socio-political challenges back to the era of the American Civil War, the Reconstruction period, the Jim Crow laws, and the Civil Rights Movement, the interviewee

emphasises the violent backlash that accompanied demands for racial justice. The interviewee shares how their family witnessed firsthand some of the most aggressive resistance to the civil rights efforts. They also reflect on the enduring legacy of segregation, describing its tangible impact on their early education:

> I very much grew up in in the after effects of that. […] My father was a sophomore at the University of Mississippi in 1962. So, there was a big riot.[38] There was a lot of violence. The military was called in. And the military essentially had maintained a presence at the University of Mississippi for about a year in order to maintain civil order. After that, I will say a positive word about my father. He was not one of the people rioting. […] When I was in elementary school, I went to a private school because the public school in the area where I grew up, which was integrated, essentially received no money from or very little funding from the government. And all of the white kids went to a private school. And that was just kind of the normal practice. And a lot of that comes from kind of an early evangelical movement that started in the 1960s and 1970s and carried forward. (Interview with K9)

Historical contextualisation of the current socio-political challenges appears also in another US-based member's interpretation of the present condition: "we're still feeling the echoes of the civil rights movement from the '60s because we didn't resolve everything" (Interview with K10). Such historical anchoring is likewise evident in the digital material, for instance in references to the American civil rights movement in a TST service addressing Black, Indigenous and People of Colour (BIPOC) issues ("Militancy in Oppressed Communities", 28 March 2023).

For a community as engaged in social change as TST, the discursive strategy of anchoring the perceived social wrongs in a broader historical context of social change can serve multiple purposes. It signals an understanding that the collective struggle for social transformation is continuous and requires structural change, rather than a quick fix. Thus, the historical references could nurture resilience and strengthen the sense of purpose and belonging to a cause. At the same time, by positioning the current struggle within a long and heroic legacy of resistance, TST as a community can gain legitimacy for their own cause. Understanding their own community as part of a tradition of resistance that encompasses many different oppressed groups contributes to the discourse on solidarity for diversity, which will be discussed further in 4.4.2.

[38] The race riot at the University of Mississippi took place from 30 September to 1 October 1962, when segregationist rioters attempted to block James Meredith, the first African American student, from enrolling at the university.

4.2.3 Discontent With Abortion Access

A significant aspect of dissatisfaction with the current socio-political climate relates to abortion rights. This is reflected in the survey and suggests a strong consensus among the respondents. The results indicate clear and unanimous support for the legal right to abortion (91% stating that access to safe abortion should be 'legal in all cases' and 9% that it should be 'legal in most cases').[39] In the digital material, particularly the religious services, the limitation of abortion access in the US is, alongside the integration of religion and politics, one of the most frequently discussed themes in relation to social wrongs. The word 'abortion' occurs 282 times in 46 of the services and reproductive rights are a central theme in at least seven services from 2021 to spring 2024, with the most frequent discussions occurring in 2022. Increased emphasis on abortion rights in the services in 2022 can be attributed to the community's heightened sensitivity to changes in the socio-political climate. In 2022 the Supreme Court's ruling ended federal constitutional protection for abortion rights. A US-based interviewee reports deciding to join the organisation in response to these legislative changes:

> It was whatever day Roe v. Wade got overturned in the US. That day is when I joined. (Interview with K10)

In a service dedicated to the issue ("By My Will, It is Done!", 13 February 2024), several voices describe how their abortion experiences led them to TST. This again indicates a connection between perceived social wrongs and engagement with TST. In another service, the new legislation on abortion in the US is articulated as a problem with global implications:

> The Supreme Court opinion in the United States may seem remote for some, but I know that in Central Europe, the arguments and talking points which underpin the larger religious stance get recycled and show up in the mouths of politicians. ("Bodily Autonomy vs The World", 7 May 2022)

Discontent with abortion access is deeply entangled with the discourse on religion and state separation. In relation to TST's campaign Religious Reproductive Rights, a participant in a service raises a critical tension—while TST promotes the separation of religion and state, they find themselves invoking religious arguments to defend bodily autonomy: "Our religious rights are the only thing we have left to fight with", the panellist decries ("Bestial Bodies & Reproductive Rights", 5 October 2021).

The discourse on reproductive rights is dominated by articulations of abortion as an expression of bodily autonomy, a core value within the community.

[39] Previous survey data indicate that support for the legality of abortion has been widespread among Satanists; in Satan Survey Three conducted by Lewis in 2011, 88% of respondents stated that "people should have unrestricted access to abortion" (Dyrendal et al. 2015: 174-175).

It is articulated in Tenet 3 and established as part of TST's fundamental principles and beliefs: "One's body is inviolable, subject to one's own will alone" (The Satanic Temple n.d.a). Thus, engagement with the discourse on abortion reinforces the centrality of bodily autonomy and indicates a strong connection between shared moral orientations and attitudes to socio-political issues. Several survey respondents emphasise this perspective:

> Bodily autonomy is a fundamental right and one of the Seven Tenets.
>
> One's body is inviolable subject to one's own will alone.
>
> Bodily autonomy is a Satanic belief I fully support.
>
> If someone wants or NEEDS an abortion, they should be allowed to get one. It's their body.
>
> People should have absolute control in decision making when it comes to their bodies.
>
> At the end of the day, a person shouldn't be forced to give birth without their consent, 100%.
>
> Get your religious views off our bodies.

Similarly, in TST services, articulations of the discourse on abortion repeatedly highlight the connection between TST's fundamental values and the current condition of reproductive health-care. It is emphasised that "access to safe, legal, local and affordable reproductive health care is just one aspect of the right to essential life-saving medical services which support our right to bodily autonomy" ("Bodily Autonomy…", 7 May 2022). The undermining of reproductive rights in the US is condemned as a "violation of our religious practice" ("Bestial Bodies…", 5 October 2021). The service "Vasectomies and Reproductive Rights" (14 June 2022) frames vasectomy as both a practical and ethical response to the erosion of abortion rights, particularly in the US, and as a solution that enhances reproductive autonomy. In a similar vein, the discussion in a service dedicated to bodily autonomy (Another View on Tenet III, 15 October 2022) explicitly links reproductive rights, such as access to abortion or sterilisation, to the fundamental principle of personal sovereignty.

In survey comments, abortion is articulated within an ethical-medical discourse and situated in relation to TST's broader engagement with the authority of science. Respondents reflect on the complex issues of viability (e.g., "I mean I don't support abortion in the 39th week") or engage with debates on personhood as an intricate part of this discourse. Notably, there is also a feminist-informed reference to the role of scientific research and education in relation to women's health: "More extensive research into female reproductive

parts is needed as well, we only recently started studying that, you can tell because there hasn't [sic] been pictures inside scientific books until 1990s to 2000s". This illustrates a commitment to the rhetoric of reason and science on issues central to TST's positioning as an actor for social change.

As the previous analysis of discontent suggests (4.2.2), attitudes towards abortion access are likewise discursively situated within a broader historical context of injustice. In several services, abortion is framed as part of a broader struggle against oppressive social and religious norms. Such framings also emphasise the importance of education and awareness. In one such instance, the attack on abortion is described as a modern-day witch hunt: "A new form of Malleus Maleficarum[40] has taken the form of model legislation, intended to identify the witches who dare maintain control of their bodies" ("Bestial Bodies…", 5 October 2021). The historical and ongoing influence of religion—particularly the Catholic Church—is foregrounded as shaping abortion laws and societal attitudes towards reproductive rights globally. Service participants emphasise also the importance of addressing abortion access from a diversity perspective, especially for women and marginalised communities. Present-day restrictions are discursively linked to earlier dehumanising practices, such as forced sterilisation of people of colour and those with mental illness, as well as unethical clinical trials on vulnerable groups. Within this framing, the normalisation of abortion access is understood as particularly challenging in certain BIPOC communities. Similarly, another service links reproductive rights to the oppression of minority groups, with reference to the historical and contemporary challenges faced by Indigenous Australians in colonial and postcolonial contexts ("Womb for Improvement", 8 January 2022).

A further thematic strand is the emotional dimension of abortion discourse. In the service "Roe v Wade and US Theocracy" (3 May 2022), for instance, the emotional processing of the Supreme Court decision becomes the focal point. Participants share strong negative sentiments, using language such as "overwhelmed", "heartbroken," "very, very scared", "mad", "anger", "rage", and "I feel like I've been assaulted". These articulations extend into embodied registers ("I'm fighting back tears", "tightness in my chest"). At the same time, emotions are negotiated in relation to alignment with TST's values. This is reflected in the articulation of a moral dilemma arising from feelings such as hatred towards a patriarchal system of governance:

> I don't want to feel like that because I don't want to return the same bigotry I'm met with. But at the same time, I'm kind of struggling between compassion and where's the line drawn. ("Roe v Wade…", 3 May 2022)

[40] Heinrich Kramer and Jacob Sprenger, *Malleus Maleficarum* (*The Hammer of Witches*, 1487)—an influential demonological treatise that shaped the prosecution of witchcraft in early modern Europe (Weinreich 2022).

This inner tension arises from the contention that both the right to bodily autonomy (Tenet 3) and the principle of compassion (Tenet 1) are fundamental part of their shared values. TST is articulated as a "safe community" where people can express feelings and where all emotional reactions are valid. The deeply emotionally felt crisis is transformed into a community-building force and a point of orientation for activist engagement: "So we need to work together […] we have to come together and move forward" ("Roe v Wade…", 3 May 2022).

Similarly, abortion access is articulated in interviews as a matter of both political and emotional significance. Engagement with the issue is not limited to TST members who identify as women; rather, it seems to resonate across gender identities, as illustrated in the following reflection:

> From an emotional perspective, the support for reproductive rights is extraordinarily important to me. Both because my wife is not able to have children due to a health issue—carrying a child would very likely present a potentially fatal health complication for her—and […], my mother died in childbirth. (Interview with K9)

This account underscores how lived experiences can shape members' attitudes on this central issue, reinforcing the emotional dimension of reproductive rights advocacy within TST. It is important to note that discussions surrounding abortion in the material often take place in a space of profound vulnerability. In some instances, participants in the services share deeply personal experiences related to reproductive health, including stories of assault, loss, and other traumatic events. These discussions also aim to break the silence and stigma surrounding abortion, with participants offering stigma management advice, such as: "Be careful who you open up to, because there's a lot of people that prey on the vulnerability you have about that experience" ("By My Will…" 13 February 2024). The management of abortion-related stigma thus constitutes a site in which the emotional dimension intersects with processes of value alignment. This intersection likely contributes to in-group cohesion (a theme that will be explored in Chapter 6.)

4.3 Visions of a Good Society

The previous section examined discontent as intersection of discourse, emotion, and value alignment. Frustration and grievance, reflecting tensions with dominant socio-political trends in the host society, constitute sites in which in-group cohesion within TST appears to be reinforced. The present section shifts the analytical focus to aspirations for a different future. Here, the collective desire for socio-political transformation is analysed as a key factor in

the assembling of TST as a socially engaged religious movement embedded within a specific social context.

4.3.1 Separation of Church and State

In section 4.2.2, the analysis centred on the discourse of Christian nationalism as a perceived social wrong, indicating tension with the American host society. The present section shifts focus to an alternative normative vision, in which the separation of church and state is foregrounded as a key element of TST participants' construction of a desirable social order.

The survey results indicate a strong consensus among respondents (98% completely agree and 2% mostly agree, n = 136) in favour of keeping religion separate from government policies. While there is some variation regarding whether government policies should support religious values, the majority (n = 135) either completely (63%) or mostly (24%) disagree with such support. Comments add nuance to how respondents reflect on the line between religion and politics. The following articulations emphasise that while religious freedom must be protected, religion should not influence the development or implementation of public policy:

> Policy should protect the right to religion while keeping it out of governance and policymaking entirely.

> I do think that the government should allow for its citizens to have various values and beliefs that cause no harm to others, and freedom of religion should be enshrined in law/government; but other than ensuring that religion doesn't cause harm to others and ensuring that people aren't attacked for having different beliefs: government and religion need to be separate.

> Religion should not dictate the law, except for that everyone should be free to choose their own religion free from fear and harm.

> Religious values and beliefs should never inform government policies. But government ought to affirm the rights of people to practice their religious values and beliefs.

An additional aspect of this shared position is concern about the overreach of religious institutions in shaping public policy and governance. In a survey item examining perceptions of the current relationship between religion and government, all respondents (n = 136) indicate that churches and religious organisations have too much influence in politics. These attitudes appear to be linked to experiences as a minority religious group advocating for religious freedom and equal treatment, as reflected in the following comments:

> In a perfect society, TST would not have to engage with our legal system at all, but we have to because a certain other religion is consistently using our political system to trample on our rights as people and as Satanists.

> [M]inority religious organizations, churches, and similar groups tend to have far less influence in politics, while dominant groups have far too much—often at the expense of access and safety for minority communities.

In constructing their visions of a desirable society, TST members navigate between what they seek to achieve and the means available to them, when arguing from the position of a religious community. As also discussed in 4.2.3, this tension becomes particularly pronounced when members seek to uphold a principle of church–state separation while simultaneously finding themselves compelled to argue for their rights in explicitly religious terms. One interviewee articulates this as a challenge: how balance their dedication to TST and the political realities that increasingly demand the attention of their religious community. Although the interviewee sees their primary focus in the theological and philosophical exploration of Satanism, they describe how political developments intrude upon what they want to preserve as a distinct religious space:

> The rise of Christian nationalism affects my ability to practice my religion. So, I've got into this situation where I'd like them to be separate but they can't be in some ways. When I'm leading a discussion, when I'm leading a service, I'm interested in the theology and the philosophy. But at the same time, I also have to go: "Hey guys, the Premier of Ontario came out this week and outright said, 'I'm going to start appointing judges who think like I think, and one of the things that we think in our party is that abortion shouldn't be legal'". So, we are looking at the beginning of the politicisation of the Canadian judicial system. This is a problem! (Interview with K2)

The principle of church-state separation is discussed in TST services. Some services are specifically dedicated to exploring how the relationship between religious and state institutions is shaped in countries outside the US, such as Canada or various European nations ("Church, State, and Plurality", 6 November 2021; "The Many States of Church and State", 19 February 2022; "How Secular is Germany", 10 June 2023). Below, a service panellist from Sweden argues for greater attention to the entanglement of religion and state in contexts outside the US:

> We can complain a lot about how Christianity affects government in America, and it is very fair. It is a huge issue there, but at least people are talking about it. I think in Europe, the problem is that nobody is really talking about it, because people just take it for granted, because it's always been like that. But when you start peeling it off, it's like, well, this is not okay, because if you replace Christianity and Christian baptism, and Christian marriage, and Christian burials with any other religion, people would say, "Hey, I don't want to be

> married in a mosque, I don't want to have a Buddhist temple being able to extract money". ("The Many States of Church and State", 19 February 2022)

As is often the case in TST's services, participants tell personal stories to ground their positions on socio-political topics. Below, a minister of Satan shares their perspective on secular governance, shaped by early socialisation and lived experience of interfaith relationships. Rather than rejecting religion wholesale, the minister advocates a clear boundary between religious belief and legislative authority and emphasises that no tradition—including TST—should escape scrutiny when it comes to religious influence in governance:

> I was raised in a house of atheism and agnosticism, so I learned from the start that morals and justice are not based on religious doctrines. I have a very close loved one who has been a huge part of my life since I was about five years old and is now a fourth- or fifth-generation Baptist minister. Him and his family are the epitome of what good Christianity can be and what Christian love looks like. It is because of them that even as a steadfast atheist, my entire life I've been open to people of faith. I do not have love for everything that is Christian, Muslim, Jewish, or any other religion. This may seem controversial, but this also stands true for Satanism and TST specifically. No religion is perfect, including our own, and that's one key reason why religion should stay out of government and laws. ("Church, State, and Plurality", 6 November 2021)

A central aspect of the discourse on the separation of church and state concerns the religious neutrality of the US Supreme Court—especially in light of rulings on abortion access and public education (areas central to TST's activism). To explore respondents' views on judicial decision-making, the survey asked, "Thinking about the Supreme Court, do you think justices should or should not bring their own religious views into how they decide major cases?". All respondents (n = 136) answered that justices should not do this. Similarly, when asked, "In their recent decisions, how much do you think Supreme Court justices have relied on their religious beliefs?", all respondents (n = 134) chose "too much". Thus, there is a strong consensus on keeping religious influence out of the Supreme court. Comments further illustrate this view:

> Judges are supposed to be impartial and operate off of the law and the past legal precedence. It's a conflict of interest if they use their religious views to affect the decisions.

> Justice should have no outside influence upon it. No partiality. It should be fair and balanced.

> Religion should not be a part of this. Women are DYING because of the idiots in the Supreme Court who thought they could play God.

Survey respondents were asked about a landmark Supreme Court decision, that "no state or local government may require the reading of the Lord's Prayer

or Bible verses in public schools". A clear majority (96%, n = 135) approve of the ruling (4% disapprove). Again, this suggests value alignment—a broader commitment to upholding separation of church and state, particularly in public education. Respondents emphasise secularist principles and religious freedom or want to see better guarantees, such as prohibition:

> Public schools should be secular.
>
> Christianity should have no place in our schools. It's perfectly fine if a student or teacher wants to make a small prayer for themselves during school, but reading the Bible and trying to force Christianity on the kids is beyond immoral.
>
> Instead of not being able to require it, they should not be able to permit it.
>
> Disapprove in the sense that it should be mandated that it is not allowed, due to the attendees having different religious views. As stated above, it [state or local government] may not 'require' so it leaves a lot open for interpretation.

In an interview, a minister of Satan describes how TST responds to this institutional entanglement in the context of public education:

> I believe Florida passed a law to allow untrained chaplains into public schools. You know, keeping in mind [that] our public schools are secular, there's no [religion] in our public schools, but essentially a chaplain would be a religious position that they would have. And the assumption, of course, is that that person would be a Christian chaplain and would provide Christian religious support. And so, TST has put forward chaplains that can go into that same space. Similarly, there are after school programs that are Christian-focused, and TST has the After School Satan program that is very much, again, kind of in that same space and pushing back against that essentialisation or assumption of Christianity within all of the public spaces for the United States. (Interview with K6)

Secular education, as a cornerstone of church-state separation, is directly linked to TST's activism and to the discourse on religious pluralism. The framing of the campaigns suggests that TST asserts equal access under pluralistic principles. Through a strategy of counter-presence, TST leverages the same legal and institutional frameworks that enable Christian access to public spaces—to challenge religious privilege and assert its own equal rights. This approach defends secularism as a principle and frames religious pluralism as a key axis for socio-political engagement, a discourse to which we now turn.

4.3.2 Religious Pluralism as a Contested Terrain

This section considers the discourse on religious pluralism as a vision for a good society. In "Satanic Utopia" (4 June 2022), a TST service framed as a

philosophical thought experiment, participants are invited to imagine a society in which Satanism is the official religion—partly in response to contemporary issues such as school shootings and abortion laws in the US. Structured as a debate, the discussion contrasts arguments for and against TST as a dominant religious group. The minister opens as follows:

> Welcome to Satan Island, a fictional island inhabited by Satanists and like-minded folks and governed by the Seven Tenets where everyone can be who they want to be. No-one is persecuted for their beliefs or their sexual orientation. People treat each other with respect and compassion, and assholes, bigots and fanatics can stay out. There will be a big goat farm and a 10-meter-high Baphomet sculpture—that is 32 feet and 9.7 inches for you, American folks. How does that sound? ("Satanic Utopia", 4 June 2022)

While the imagined Satan Island is presented as a space of freedom, respect, and non-discrimination, the discussion problematises whether such a separatist vision would foster pluralism or lead to isolation, and whether it aligns with TST's core values. Panellists emphasise the importance of articulating distinctiveness without claims to superiority, as well as the need to engage with and improve existing society, rather than withdraw from it.

Religious pluralism is negotiated in several TST services. In "Church, State, and Plurality" (6 November 2021), the minister balances the critique of religion with an affirmation of pluralistic values. In the introduction, they explicitly challenge the stereotype that Satanists are inherently anti-religious:

> I want to discuss the idea that Satanists hate all religions. […] a big draw for me was the fight for plurality. I'm a huge fan of that aspect. I […] show love to many religious people. I'd like to think we're opposed to aspects of religions—not the religion as a whole or all of the followers. ("Church, State, and Plurality", 6 November 2021)

In other services, panellists reflect on navigating interfaith contexts, engaging with others as Satanists and upholding pluralism without reproducing the very behaviours they critique in other religions. The general tone supports public expressions of belief, provided they are not coercive or dogmatic. For instance, in "Passion vs Proselytism" (17 September 2023), this theme is linked to broader issues such as freedom of speech and expression, as well as to the distinction between sharing one's beliefs and imposing them on others. Panellists who were formerly Mormons, evangelical Christians or Jehovah's Witnesses recount experiences of proselytising and reflect on how these shaped their spiritual journeys, ultimately leading them to Satanism. One minister defines proselytising in a broader sense as "the act of attempting to convert people to your religious or, these days, also political beliefs". Across the discussion, emphasis is on the importance of consent and respect for autonomy in interreligious encounters. One participant explains: "If I want to share

something that I'm passionate about, I tell you [that in] one sentence. I'll ask you, are you OK with me sharing this part of me?" Participants also situate the value of pluralism within a historical frame, linking it to critiques of colonialism and Western supremacy, and their enduring harmful effects on Indigenous populations.

Similarly, the discussion in "Satanic Apologists" (10 October 2023) foregrounds religious pluralism and its limitations: "We can't even just coexist yet. And I think that's a really damn good starting point". Reflections also extend to the public expression of belief through religious symbols: "I personally feel like little things such as necklaces, shirts, and other public displays of belief are anybody's right, just like they're ours". At the same time, attentiveness to pluralism is framed as requiring sensitivity to the emotional impact of religious language, particularly where it may evoke fear or trauma: "I don't need you projecting your fear of hell onto me". While pluralism is consistently articulated as a core value, participants acknowledge the practical difficulties of enacting it, wondering whether it can be fully realised in practice.

As with other discourses examined in this study, articulations concerning religious pluralism have an emotional dimension. This reflects a broader pattern, where engagement with socio-political change is not limited to abstract values but also embodied. As the following interviewee suggests, the idea of a dominant religious ideology shaping public policy evokes both a sense of injustice and a profound emotional reaction:

> The biggest issue for me is ensuring that capacity for religious pluralism. I am horrified by the thought of one religious group being shown preference in the public sphere, particularly regarding what laws get created. (Interview with K4)

The emotional intensity attached to the discourse on religious pluralism underscores its centrality but does not imply consensus. Survey results suggest a wider range of positions. When asked about their views on "the fact that a society is made up of people of many different religions, as well as people who are not religious", 75% of survey respondents (n = 134) feel that it strengthens society, 10% state that it weakens society and 14% that it makes little difference. Religious pluralism as a positive force in society is a recurring theme in the comments, emphasising diversity, mutual respect, and the enrichment that the coexistence of differing worldviews can offer:

> Diversity is important for a strong, healthy society.

> Society should thrive with people of all kinds. Our acceptance [of] and kindness to those of a different creed or sect should be a strength.

> If we were all the same it would be so boring. We don't have to believe the same thing to be a productive happy community.

> Diversity has the potential to strengthen society and in other contexts, has proven itself.
>
> People are diverse, period. Strength and prosperity come in unification.
>
> Different cultures coexisting peacefully is a beautiful thing to see.

However, endorsement of pluralism is not uncritical. The tensions and challenges that can accompany religious diversity are also acknowledged—particularly when accommodation is not reciprocal or when specific religious ideologies seek dominance over others. In this view, pluralism requires constant negotiation and active commitment to tolerance:

> Pluralism is the best way to have a society, but it creates problems that need to constantly be addressed.
>
> Our strength is in our diverse worldviews but if this isn't honored across the board, it will cause harm.
>
> The concern becomes when members of a religion decide that their religion should dictate how everybody should act, and is the only true moral compass.
>
> I think it could strengthen the society if they all accepted each other and got along but until we learn to do that, it can do more damage than good.
>
> Tolerance of other beliefs is necessary for peaceful coexistence.
>
> One person's beliefs should not be enforced on others.
>
> As long as you keep your religion to yourself it's fine. I have no issue with religion itself, it's when religion tries to control others of a different religion or non-religion that it's an issue.
>
> So long as they aren't Nazis or actively threatening to people they see as 'other'.

Some articulations go further, expressing explicit scepticism or even criticism of religion per se—especially theistic and organised forms. This perspective questions the social value of religion, highlighting perceived dangers such as extremism, indoctrination, or resistance to critical reasoning:

> It is a source of conflict and anger that makes it hard for people to get along. It's less about the diversity and more about how people respond to it.
>
> I've lived in a country where there was war between religions, bombs and guns and the like. It didn't make for a better society.

> Theistic religions are harmful to society.
>
> I'd prefer that no-one had theistic beliefs. I know that it's not likely to ever happen so pluralism is better in this case.
>
> I think 'religion' weakens society. 'Religion' is a weakness.
>
> Religious extremism weakens society.
>
> The world has advanced so much that there is no reason we should still have organized religion. We should trust science and reason.
>
> Organized religion demands people believe and obey blindly without any critical thought.
>
> Faith-based thinking, even as a useful fiction, often does more harm than good because unjustified beliefs often get created or become codified into unquestionable beliefs.
>
> The devout religious are prone to proselytizing, indoctrinating, and otherwise controlling and forcing their beliefs on others. They lack respect for autonomy.

Another item that sheds light on how religion's role is understood in respondents' visions of a good society concerns attitudes toward "a decline in the share of people belonging to an organized religion". Here, too, responses indicate a range of perspectives: 56% (n = 136) view this development as "very good for society", while 38% consider it somewhat good and 7% somewhat bad (no respondents select "very bad"). The accompanying comments illustrate this variation—from recognition of religion's social value, to more critical or dismissive positions on specific religious expressions or institutions. A number of participants express a generally positive view of organised religion, particularly regarding its communal and social functions, albeit often with reservations. One respondent points out its unique societal role in America:

> Religion provides very specific needs that the secular society in North America has done nothing to replace. They have little [or] no barrier to entry and provide people [with] access to communities with people from all walks of life. The loss of that is very impactful and partly related to our loneliness epidemic.

Similarly, the following articulations emphasise the importance of religion and spirituality, suggesting that organised religion can be socially beneficial when it does not engage in harm or coercion:

> [S]pirituality is an important foundational pillar for resilience […] everyone should practice it. I don't care if you're involved in an organized religion as long as you aren't being discriminatory (Westbrook Baptist Church) or taking away rights or hiding paedophiles (evangelicals in the US or the Vatican).

> Organized religions can be great for society, but I believe children should be raised secularly and decide whether or not to join a religion once they are an adult and don't have to rely on someone else for necessities.

Another articulation is ambivalent toward organised religion, balancing involvement in a marginalised religion and critique of mainstream Christianity:

> As a member of TST, it may seem paradoxical that I think that a decline in those participating in organized religion is a good thing, but since the majority are of a Christian denomination in Western countries, we're not going anywhere.

A sceptical or critical orientation is also common, highlighting concerns about particular forms of organised religion and their perceived harm:

> I'm not strictly opposed to organised religion, but damn if some of them ain't awful.

> If there was a sudden decline in people joining Evangelical megachurches, great!

To further explore this discourse on religious pluralism, the analysis draws on impressions from observations in Salem, in particular two guided tours led by a minister of Satan. Religious pluralism was prominent throughout. On TripAdvisor, where the tour is advertised, the guide is introduced as "an expert in occultism, witchcraft, and an ordained Satanic minister". Similarly, when the sightseeing group gathered, the guide presented themselves to us as an "interfaith minister", with one foot in Wicca and the other in Satanism. "This is America," the guide remarked, invoking an ideal of religious freedom as the ability to choose and integrate different affiliations. Present-day Salem, both as a cultural destination and as home to TST's headquarters, was framed as a place where religious differences can coexist relatively harmoniously. On the corner of Hawthorne Boulevard and Charter Street, the guide pointed at the Catholic church Immaculate Conception to advance the discourse on religious pluralism. The minister emphasised that members of the local church are genuinely friendly, and expressed appreciation for the church's symbolism and art. One exception was noted—the Ten Commandments monument outside. However, the guide stressed that such a display, when on church grounds, does not pose a concern, clarifying that TST is not anti-religion; rather, TST intervenes when political actions misuse religion, such as siting religious symbols in ways that violate the separation of church and state. TST's responses, such as donating a large Baphomet statue to be placed beside the monument, are efforts to "clear things up", the minister argued.

The notion of religious pluralism is closely tied to the aspiration for broader societal acceptance of TST as a legitimate religious group—recognition

central to its capacity to act as an agent of social change. This aspiration can be understood as a response to concrete tensions, such as the controversy over a Satanic display installed by TST in the Iowa State Capitol in December 2023, which was later destroyed by a Mississippi man and the act prosecuted as a hate crime (Burkitt 2024). Subsequent legislative efforts such as the Senate Bill 1279 titled RESPECT (Reject Escalating Satanism by Preserving Essential Core Traditions) form an important backdrop to interviewees' reflections on recognition. These tensions are explicitly addressed in their framing of religious pluralism as necessary for securing equal access to public space and legal protection:

> I hope that we can get past some of these trials and hardships we're getting into right now. Especially in states like Iowa, where they're trying to […] say that we're not a real religion—and so, we shouldn't have access to the public space. That we can see wider acceptance of us from society. I know that's a lofty goal and will take probably years, longer than I'll be around. […] But that's my first and foremost goal—that we can start doing that, and that this acceptance will then cascade and help us with the rest of everything that we're working on. An understanding of us as an organization can help prevent things like laws against abortion, because people will understand that this is an actual deeply held religious belief, that one's body is their own […]. That forms the foundation, right, that everything else can be built upon. (Interview with K6)

Another interviewee refers to the same policy, viewing the bill as a clear violation of the First Amendment and concerned that, in the long term, it could threaten the visibility and rights of other religious minorities:

> That created a sense of urgency and care for my community, care for rights of everyone, because they put [the] Satanist name on it, but it could be directed at anybody. It could be directed at my Jewish friends or Muslim friends. Lawmakers don't get to do that shit. (Interview with K7)

These accounts suggest that religious pluralism in the context of TST is negotiated through lived encounters with exclusion, contestation, and legal regulation. The discourse on pluralism is thus inseparable from experienced tensions with the host society, and functions as both a normative claim and a strategic framework for civic engagement and social transformation. While this pluralistic stance opens many paths for action, these too are subject to ongoing negotiation. Below, I examine how pluralism and related frameworks are mobilised through campaigns and alliances aiming to create socio-political change.

4.4 Strategies and Alliances for Socio-Political Change

We now turn to the strategies and alliances that shape the assembling of TST as a socially engaged religious movement. The analysis proceeds from

participants' knowledge of and engagement with TST campaigns, to diversity as an approach to socio-political change, and finally to alliances.

4.4.1 Engagement in Campaigns

Survey results indicate variation in respondents' knowledge of TST's campaigns. About 62% (n = 135) report knowing "a lot" about the movement's advocacy, 36% know at least "a little", and only 1% know "nothing at all". In general, respondents consider all the national campaigns initiated by TST important for them to some degree (see figure 7), with the Reproductive Rights initiative particularly significant: about 97% (n = 132) consider it important (of which 88% very important), underlining again the centrality of discourse on abortion access, discussed in section 4.2.3. The campaign combines practical support with legal advocacy to expand abortion access (The Satanic Temple n.d.e, n.d.f). Through its tele-clinics[41] TST provides abortion services and assists members to access care. Central to the campaign is the Religious Abortion Ritual, framing the procedure as an expression of deeply held beliefs in bodily autonomy. The ritual integrates the recitation of Tenets with a personal affirmation and serves to assert religious exemptions under the First Amendment and relevant Religious Freedom Restoration Acts. TST's legal strategy is exemplified by the "Judy Doe" case, which contests waiting periods and mandated counselling as violations of religious freedom. Following the rejection of its claims in Missouri, TST filed an appeal to the US Supreme Court. The campaign received mainstream media attention, including coverage in *Cosmopolitan* (Domb 2023).

Several respondents explicitly link their affiliation with TST to its advocacy in this area. As one notes: "When I read that they sponsor online abortion clinic(s), I immediately became a member". This underscores the campaign's capacity to attract new members through direct action on pressing social issues. Although some express scepticism about its effectiveness, the responses nonetheless affirm the central importance of reproductive autonomy, often perceived as particularly urgent in the current context. These patterns suggest a strong degree of internal alignment around issues connected to the principle of bodily autonomy.

The survey asked respondents to indicate their personal involvement in TST's campaigns (see Figure 8). The results suggest varying participation. Notably, 39% report no direct involvement in any of the campaigns. While this group may align ideologically with TST, it appears passive in relation to national-level activism. Non-engagement may reflect a preference for interacting with TST as a community over active contribution to its national initiatives. It may also be linked to organisational dynamics within TST (see 6.2),

[41] Clinics are given provocative, politically charged names e.g., *Samuel Alito's Mom's Satanic Abortion Clinic* or *The President's Yuge Most Beautiful Tremendous Satanic Abortion Clinic*.

including a perceived disconnect between local and national levels. As one respondent notes: “Congregations are unfortunately usually quite separate from campaigns”.

Figure 7. How important for you are the following TST campaigns?

Source: The Satanic Temple Survey 2024.

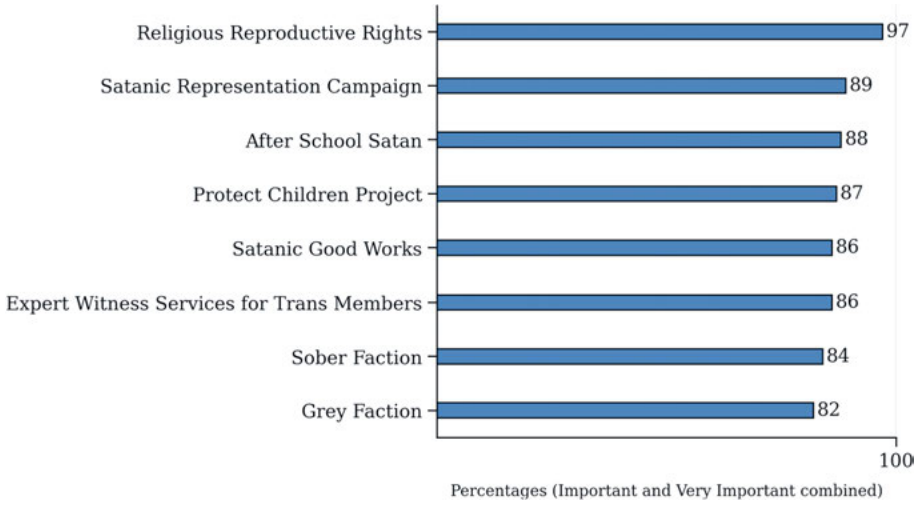
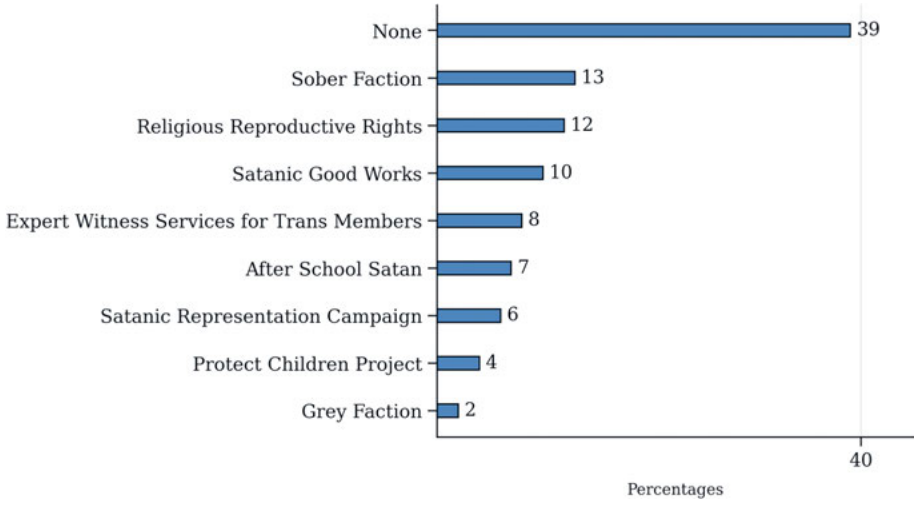


Figure 8. In which of these campaigns are you personally involved?

Source: The Satanic Temple Survey 2024.



Among those engaged in TST's nation-wide initiatives, the Sober Faction campaign garners the highest levels of involvement (13%), followed closely by Religious Reproductive Rights (12%). This points to interest in campaigns centred on personal autonomy and health—issues that resonate with TST's emphasis on bodily sovereignty. Engagement with Sober Faction underscores the campaign's practical value in providing peer support and harm reduction resources for individuals navigating substance use. Interviewees highlight the campaign as a secular alternative to faith-based recovery programmes:

> I think it's important to provide this option given the fact that so many people are court ordered to attend recovery meetings of some sort with the assumption being AA or other 12-step programs, which require superstitious beliefs in a higher power. Sober Faction provides people the opportunity to get and remain sober without all that superstition. (Interview with K4)

> The Sober Faction benefits a large number of people who would otherwise be directed toward Christian-oriented addiction treatment programs. For those who aren't part of that faith, Sober Faction offers a meaningful alternative. A lot of people are getting help through it. (Interview with K1)

However, some comments from the survey point out internal tensions and organisational fragmentation:

> The only reason I consider Sober Faction to be 'not important' is because of a schism between Sober Faction leaders and TST leaders. Sober Faction started a new group while TST focuses less on goals and more about legal rights to the brand.

The Expert Witness Services for Trans Members campaign appears to be a polarising initiative. According to a press release issued by TST, the programme provides expert witness testimony from ordained ministers in legal cases where members' bodily autonomy is challenged, framing such cases as matters of religious freedom. The initiative can be understood as a response to recent socio-political developments in the US, where transgender rights have become an increasingly contested legal and political terrain (Petrin 2026). Comments in the survey, however, reflect a mix of support and concern, alongside limited awareness about the campaign's implementation. One respondent points to gaps in campaign visibility: "I actually didn't know anything about the expert witness one! And it's not on the website". Other responses express scepticism about TST's commitment to the issue, suggesting that internal tensions may undermine confidence in the campaign's sincerity and effectiveness. One articulation frames the initiative as reactive and poorly grounded:

> The Expert Witness Services for Trans Members appears to be a knee-jerk reaction, rolled out after LG [Lucien Greaves] got into a dispute with trans

> members and couldn't manage to show a bit of humility… you know, Tenet 6: 'tenets for thee, but not for me'. While other initiatives are spearheaded by those genuinely fighting for change, everything gets diluted by that classic 'send me your money' vibe you'd expect from a televangelist, not a grassroots movement.

These critiques are situated within a scepticism about TST's national leadership and its strategic priorities, discussed further in Chapter 6.

The Protect Children Campaign challenges school practices that restrict students' bodily autonomy, particularly corporal punishment. Students who are members of TST are encouraged to assert their religious belief in bodily autonomy to exempt themselves from mistreatment (The Satanic Temple n.d.c). The campaign is widely regarded as important by respondents, with 64% (n = 131) rating it "very important" and a further 23% as "important". A related survey item reinforces this, indicating strong opposition to corporal punishment: 96% of respondents disagree (73% completely) with the statement that "it is sometimes necessary to discipline a child with a good, hard spanking".[42] This near-unanimous stance closely mirrors the campaign's core objectives.

The most common forms of campaign involvement among respondents are information-oriented, with 31% indicating that staying informed is their primary mode of engagement, followed by sharing information (22%). Volunteering, which may be regarded as a more active and engaged form of participation, is reported by 16% of respondents, as is financial support (16%). More invested forms of engagement, such as starting local initiatives (5%) or taking on organisational responsibilities (5%), are comparatively rare.

Other ways in which respondents engage with campaigns include asserting their religious rights in everyday settings, for example in defence of bodily autonomy and religious freedom for their children. As one respondent explains: "My son is in school and every year I inform his teachers about our religious rights and that things that would violate his bodily autonomy (restricting bathroom breaks, corporal punishment, etc) would violate his religious rights". Some respondents contribute to national campaigns by facilitating internal community learning: "I am hosting a study group for our 7 Ritual practice".[43] Others describe involvement in local organising and participating in demonstrations. Along with public-facing activism, some members engage in self-directed forms of political monitoring. One minister, for instance, describes attending religious freedom conferences in Canada organised by Evangelical and Catholic groups parallel to the UN's Multi-Faith Week, in order to track religious nationalist movements and identify relevant organisations

[42] This position is in marked contrast to attitudes in the wider US population, where 56% express support for corporal punishment (see 1.6.2).
[43] The Seven Rituals is a central part of Sober Faction's addiction recovery program.

(Interview with K2). These efforts aim both to raise awareness and to support journalists' future investigative work.

At the local level, TST congregations engage in grassroots initiatives that reflect the organisation's broader values. Their work often focuses on community care and social justice and is supported by TST's national campaign Satanic Good Works.[44] For instance, "[w]e do roadside or park clean-ups. We collect and distribute to shelters... menstrual supplies. One that we work on at the moment is packing naloxone kits for a prevention agency in the [city name] area" (Interview with K7). One participant describes a local campaign titled Satanists Against Censorship, aimed at combating book bans by encouraging library engagement: "We're having a campaign where we're working on getting the word out and getting people registered for their local libraries to support the libraries" (Interview with K11). As another interviewee notes, public outreach also plays a role in demystifying the group's mission, "letting the public come and talk to us and ask questions and figure out what we're about" (Interview with K10). Contributions to Menstruatin' with Satan, an initiative that collects menstrual and hygiene products for unhoused individuals, has developed into a recurring effort, as one congregant explains: "We've been doing that for three years now, and we're coming up on our fourth […]. Every year we've collected more than the year previous, and it's been phenomenal" (Interview with K6). TST advocacy for social change often takes shape within a framework of solidarity for diversity—a theme explored in the following section.

4.4.2 Solidarity for Diversity

This section discusses engagement with solidarity for diversity as a strategic approach to socio-political change. It examines how TST participants reflect and respond to the conditions of marginalised groups, such as LGBTQ+ individuals, BIPOC, economically disadvantaged groups and individuals dealing with addiction. Within this framework, LGBTQ+ inclusion constitutes a central axis of solidarity for diversity, both demographically and ideologically. As reflected in the survey data (see 4.1), 19% of respondents identify as gender-diverse and 51% identify somewhere along the LGBTQ+ spectrum. These figures underscore the significance of queer identities within the community and are important to contextualise the relevance of LGBTQ+ issues in TST's advocacy for social justice.

Demographic patterns are mirrored in the respondents' values. For example, survey responses suggest overwhelmingly positive perceptions of same-sex marriage. About 98% (n = 136) believe that legalising same-sex marriage

[44] Some of the initiatives of TST's Satanic Good Work include "Day of Action Blood Drive in May, the Community CleanUp in September, and the Sol Invictus Charity Drive in December" (The Satanic Temple n.d.d).

is "very good for society", while an additional 2% consider it "somewhat good" (no respondents view it as "somewhat bad" or "very bad"). Similarly, there is a strong consensus in favour of "greater social acceptance of people who are transgender": 93% (n = 136) indicate that such acceptance is "very good for society", an additional 6% regard it as "somewhat good" and 1% consider it "somewhat bad" (no respondents rate it as "very bad"). This suggests a positive attitude toward transgender inclusion, with minimal dissent. This support is further echoed in the comments, expressing solidarity with LGBTQ+ individuals and concern for the rights and safety of trans people:

> Everyone having the chance to be free and open to themselves is all that matters. We are all human.

> People deserve to live, love, and be who they are without fear of being harmed for it. If it's not harming or hurting anyone else: live and let live.

One participant expresses discomfort with hormone treatments and surgeries due to concerns about reproductive health, but still emphases support for individuals "being true to themselves".

The prominence of trans issues is further underscored by their inclusion in major TST events. At SatanCon 2023, the second national convention of the young organisation, trans identity and empowerment was a central theme. Devi Dillard-Wright delivered a keynote titled "Reclaiming the Trans Body: A/theistic Strategies for Self-Determination and Empowerment". An interviewee who attended the event described a deeply emotional response to the presentation, which inspired them to create and share a piece of art in tribute:

> I would like to direct your attention to the one presentation I had the most emotional response to. Devi Dillard-Wright […] was talking about her experiences coming out as trans in recent years and the current social conditions of backlash against trans people. It's a very emotional response I had actually. I made up an art work afterwards. […] I was trying to reward her. I shared it with her and I asked her permission to share it. (Interview with K1)

Another interviewee expresses concern about trans rights being under attack not only in the US but also in Canada:

> […] there's [sic] a bunch of provinces that are trying to make it to where children, if they want to go by a nickname in school, have to have parental consent—which would be forcibly outing trans kids to their potentially abusive or transphobic parents […]. This has never been an issue before. I had plenty of friends when I was growing up who went by their middle names or a shortened version of their first name—plenty of Zacharies went by Zach and no-one had to ask their parents' permission for that. But as soon as it's a trans person, it's a whole issue. Or trying to stop trans kids from playing sports, trying to stop trans kids from accessing age-appropriate information, medical care. So that's happening here too. (Interview with K5)

Local congregations and individual members express their solidarity for diversity through participation in Pride events. As one interviewee shares "[m]y partner and I marched in [a city name] during the Pride parade last August" (Interview with K2). Congregations take an active role in such engagement, using Pride as a platform for visibility, outreach, and ritual expression: "We usually get a booth and set up there and we'll have some merch, do Unbaptisms and stuff like that" (Interview with K10).

Beyond LGBTQ+ advocacy, TST broadens its solidarity discourse to include several forms of marginalisation. An interviewee explains:

> I know we have internal alliances, which are basically people from multiple congregations that will connect over a particular identity or topic. We have a Satanists of Color, we have a group of disabled people,[45] group for trans folks […]. (Interview with K5)

The Satanists of Color Coalition (SoCC) exemplifies this commitment through its Resource Guide, a document that offers educational materials, practical tools, and recommended reading to support anti-racist action and community engagement. This focus is also reflected in TST's media and events. SatanCon 2022 featured a session titled "Satanism and the BIPOC Community", led by Citlali Soona, and SatanCon 2023 included "SoCC: Satanism and the BIPOC Experience", a panel led by Soona, and "BIPOC Body Modification in Satanic Culture", a keynote by Enma Yama. TSTTV has also hosted two BIPOC Satanists Conferences (December 2022 and March 2024). These initiatives indicate a growing institutional recognition of BIPOC issues within TST.

In addition, survey results indicate strong support among TST respondents for investment in improving the conditions of BIPOC: 93% (n = 135) believe that too little money is being spent on this issue nationally, 7% feel the current spending is about right and only 1% think too much is being spent. Engagement with BIPOC issues is also reflected in ritual practice. A TST member describes a ritual based on land acknowledgement:

> TST has been giving these sorts of land acknowledgments where we reflect on the people whose land we're on now, because this country is a colonized nation. People were displaced. And so, we try to acknowledge that. Lots of nonprofits and other organizations do this too. And we've embraced it. So, at this land acknowledgment, we had a few participants in addition to the MC of the ritual. She introduced it and spoke about the land where we are and about the tribes who lived here prior. And then each of us who was also participating brought a piece of land from where we're from in a container and dumped it into a common container up on the altar and spoke about the land that we came from and how we came to be there. Some of them were from the [a city name] area and talked about where they grew up there and about the tribes there. I

[45] The group is also referred to as Satanic Disability Alliance.

> spoke about where my family and I grew up. I talked about the tribes in what is now Ohio and New York and what happened throughout the colonization period. Some of the tribes in what is now Ohio were killed off during the Seven Years' War… (Interview with K7)

Another important dimension of solidarity is concern for socioeconomically disadvantaged individuals and those affected by addiction. Survey results reflect this commitment: 93% of respondents (n = 135) believe that too little is spent on assistance for the poor. Similarly, 87% feel that too little is being invested to address drug addiction. These concerns are also reflected in both national and local initiatives. Nationally, TST's Sober Faction campaign addresses addiction through a Satanic lens. Religious services, such as "Denying Temptation: Satanism & Addiction" (6 August 2022) and "A Match Made in Hell" (16 August 2022) which addresses sobriety from the prism of romantic relationships, focus on the issue. A recent contribution to Sober Faction, titled "Neurospicy Satanic & Sober", explores the intersection of neurodivergence and addiction, highlighting the layered vulnerabilities faced by some (The Satanic Temple 2025a). Additionally, the Sober Faction Facebook page promotes Pride-themed merchandise and shares content from the SoCC, reinforcing solidarity across marginalised identities. At the local level, congregations engage in grassroots charity both as part of Satanic Good Works and through informal fundraising to support those in economically disadvantaged positions (Interview with K5). These practices illustrate how solidarity is enacted across both symbolic and pragmatic registers, shaping the assembling of TST at multiple levels.

4.4.3 Alliances for Activism

A central question in understanding TST's activist orientation is with whom its members seek to collaborate and on what socio-political issues. Previous research suggests that TST members are less inclined to align with other Satanic groups due to ideological tensions and mutual distrust (see 1.5.3). At one point, TST even maintained a section on its website explicitly outlining its differences from CoS, portraying the latter in a somewhat dismissive light (The Satanic Temple n.d.g).

To better understand what alliances TST members are more likely to seek, survey items explored engagement in other religious or spiritual communities, in Satanic communities, and in secularist organisations. These items address both past and present affiliations. Responses offer insight into spiritual and activist trajectories that might shape respondents' attitudes towards collaborations on socio-political issues. 12% (n =136) have previously participated in religious or spiritual communities outside of TST, with 8% still involved. Paganism and Wicca are the most frequently mentioned contexts, followed by

Eastern philosophies such as Buddhism and Taoism.[46] In relation to other Satanic communities, 10% (n = 136) report past involvement and another 10% remain currently engaged. The CoS and LaVeyan Satanism are the most frequently cited, followed by a variety of groups like United Aspects of Satan, Church of Rational Satanism, Sect of the Horned God, and the controversial Order of Nine Angles. Interestingly, some respondents describe their engagement with punk or rock bands (such as Twin Temple) as a form of Satanic community involvement. Others report participating in online Satanic spaces, including podcast communities like Black Mass Appeal and Hail Satan Podcast, as well as fora and social platforms such as Reddit, Discord, Facebook groups, and other online collectives.

Involvement in secularist organisations is slightly more prominent in the present: while 13% (n = 133) report prior engagement, approximately 17% state they are currently affiliated. This trend reflects TST's strong alignment with secularist principles, particularly its emphasis on the separation of church and state (see 4.3.1). The most frequently mentioned organisation is the Freedom from Religion Foundation, followed by various atheist, humanist, and freethinker groups at both national and local levels. Some respondents also report involvement in civil rights organisations such as the American Civil Liberties Union and advocacy networks supporting transgender rights.

Interviewees describe working with secularist and humanist organisations that share similar commitments to rational ethics and church–state separation. These partnerships are often framed as mutually beneficial:

> If somebody were to reach out to us and say, "Hey, we need your assistance" or "We want to work with you", I think there is a lot there. The groups that tend to reach out to us and don't mind the association with TST tend to be Humanist organizations, Freedom from Religion, things like that. (Interview with K2)

Ideological proximity is foregrounded as the basis for such cooperation, as articulated in the following accounts:

> The Ethical Humanists align very much with our own philosophies and ideas. We rented a space from them for our Lupercalia ritual. (Interview with K6)

> There's a humanist group in [a state name] we work with. (Interview with K8)

At the same time, such partnerships reveal both alignment and tension. While shared concerns—particularly regarding Christian nationalism—facilitate cooperation, differences in orientation remain. Another interviewee highlights a

[46] This pattern mirrors previous research: when asked which other religions they had explored prior to adopting Satanism, participants in earlier survey research most frequently mentioned Neopaganism (Dyrendal et al. 2015: 178).

perceived distinction in style and impact, noting that secularist organisations "lack the attention-getting gut-punch and aesthetic of Satanism" (Interview with K3). Even within partnerships that appear ideologically compatible, TST members might sometimes find it necessary to clarify the nature and mission of their religious movement. Misunderstandings can arise due to the persistent stigma surrounding Satanism. A minister describes their experience of collaboration with secularist organisations:

> Working with [a state-level secularist organisation], that keeps me connected with all of them, because it's an umbrella secular organization to help other groups network together and be represented in our local government. […] We do keep in touch on plans and on collaborating on projects and events through monthly meetings and stuff. […] [The secularist organisation] is very understanding of what TST is and does. Like the other organizations that we are working with, I haven't heard any reluctance on the basis of Satanism. But individuals may misunderstand and that's fine. (Interview with K7)

Tensions may emerge around differing visions of secularism. As one interviewee reflects, some secularist actors' aspirations for a religion-free public sphere diverge from TST's emphasis on pluralism and equal recognition:

> We got talking to a representative from the [local humanist organisation]. And one of his things is, "I'm so happy you guys are here. It'd be great, you know, we can all stand together in solidarity for to live in a religious free society". And I'm like, "But we're a religion!" Their goals actually don't align as closely with ours as they think. I want a world where we can be pluralistic, we can believe what we want, and don't feel the need to dominate someone who agrees differently. No, I don't want to destroy Christianity. I want to destroy the Christian hegemony. That's a very, very different goal. And I think a lot of people from various humanist societies miss that part. (Interview with K2)

Some congregations advocate interfaith dialogue as part of their engagement for religious pluralism. For instance, TST Arizona has joined a local interfaith network, a move described as "ground-breaking" on TST's homepage (The Satanic Temple 2025b). As one interviewee puts it: "I think that religious plurality is the direction we should be working toward, so I am a big supporter of making connections with other groups" (Interview with K3). However, cooperation is articulated as contingent on value alignment. While dialogue is encouraged, alliances with organisations like the Catholic Church may be avoided due to fundamental moral differences: "I might find points of agreement […] but I'm probably not going to associate myself with them at a political or protest event because there are too many points that I find morally objectionable" (Interview with K9).

TST members also interact with a variety of actors within civil society to advance socio-political goals. These engagements are again guided by

alignment with TST's values. One interviewee describes working with several local groups, including local food banks, shelters and LGBTQ+ supporters:

> I belong to a couple of other groups in the area […] One of the other groups that I work a lot with […] is a group called the Parasol Patrol. They use rainbow umbrellas to block protesters from LGBTQ+ events, you know, people showing up to harass those events. And they utilize big rainbow umbrellas to block them from the people who are attending so they don't have to see them. […] Those social political activities are informed by the values that I hold, which I share with TST. (Interview with K6)

In some of their initiatives, such as the highway clean-ups, congregations cooperate with the state. However, as interviewees describe, local activist efforts require navigating logistical and bureaucratic hurdles:

> We're not accountants […] we don't want to be handling anything more than just extremely small petty donations. (Interview with K5)

> When we do stuff with food banks and stuff like that, we do have to send proposals upwards. So, it's not just like a no, but it is kind of a subject to review situation. (Interview with K10)

TST's positioning in relation to wider society concerns the contexts (religious or secular) in which its members seek to collaborate and their socio-political priorities. As this analysis suggests, while there is tension and boundary-keeping towards other Satanic groups, participants are open to cooperation with other organisations that pursue secularist goals. The value alignment within the group thereby influences which alliances are regarded as appropriate.

4.5 Summary

This chapter has addressed how TST assembles through alignment and tension with its wider social environment. The demographics of participants suggest Christian backgrounds, significant LGBTQ+ representation, and many individuals who identify as socially or economically marginalised despite relatively high educational attainment. These features provide social conditions for common experiences and concerns. Perceived socio-political wrongs articulated across the empirical material suggest a shared experience of living in a period of socio-political crisis. This can be understood as an emotional regime of discontent that shapes the assembling of TST as a socially engaged movement. Christian nationalism, in particular, is construed as a central antagonist. Concerns about the entanglement of religion and politics, restrictions on abortion access, and challenges to minority rights become focal points around which activist orientations align. These tensions with the socio-

political environment are coupled with affirmative visions of a desirable society, such as commitments to secular governance, religious pluralism, and solidarity with diverse groups. While TST's campaigns align with participants ideologically and constitute attempts to enact these visions for social change, the analysis suggests that active participation in national activist initiatives remains relatively limited. Alliances with other organisations and movements are negotiated through questions of value alignment, particularly commitments to secularist principles and support for marginalised communities. Insofar as such collaborations exist, they extend TST's assemblage beyond the movement itself and connect it to other assemblages in wider society.

5. Individual Practice and Stigma Experiences

> I realize myself initially through others: from them I receive words, forms, and tonalities for the formation of my initial idea of myself. (Bakhtin 1987: 138)

This chapter elaborates on the second research question: *How does The Satanic Temple assemble through participants' negotiations of Satanic practice and stigma?* The first part explores how individuals negotiate their Satanic practice between personal adaptation and alignment with shared orientations. While the analysis is situated at the micro level, individual accounts are examined in relation to the collective frameworks that inform them. I also consider ministerial practice as a setting where the individual and collective intersect and analyse blasphemy as a contested aspect of Satanic practice. In the second part I turn to the role of stigma and stigma management, tracing experiences ranging from direct hostility and violence, to the ways in which stigma shapes participants' everyday experiences through anticipated and lived stigma. In this context, I also analyse a variety of stigma-management strategies, including reflexive engagement with stigma through counter-discourses, forms of information control and practices of community care.

5.1 Individual Practice

Personal approaches to Satanic practice offer a compelling lens through which to explore the interplay between micro, meso and macro levels of assembling. Individual Satanic practice emerges not as an isolated expression of personal agency, but as a relational process shaped by ongoing engagements with communal frameworks and broader cultural contexts. This section examines how Satanic practice is negotiated through strategies of alignment and dealignment that unfold across different domains of religious life, including rituals, celebrations, and everyday interactions. The discussion progresses from the individual practitioner's relationship with TST's shared values, to the co-production of practice in communal contexts, and finally to the negotiation of external religious and cultural Others.

5.1.1 Practice Aligned With Shared Values

Although TST emphasises individual autonomy and encourages participants to develop practices that reflect their own needs and experiences, such personalisation is structured through alignment with the movement's shared values, articulated in the Seven Tenets. These function as orienting frameworks that guide the interpretation, development, and enactment of individual Satanic practice. Participants create their own expressions of Satanism while remaining connected to the broader TST community. The centrality of the Tenets is evident in how they are enacted both in explicitly religious contexts, such as rituals and celebrations, and in everyday life. An interviewee illustrates this, reflecting on how compassion (Tenet 1) is ever-present in their ordinary social exchange, becoming a lived expression of their Satanic identity:

> Being a Satanist is a fundamental aspect of my identity. […] In terms of my Satanism, I am […] 100% Satanist, 100% of the time. Being a Satanist guides my every daily interaction. […] Trying to remember to be compassionate and understanding in my interactions. I'm not perfect at it, but I do my best to understand that other people are going through their own stuff. Trying to be compassionate to other people, even people I disagree with, is work I try to do. (Interview with K4)

For some, the Tenets become the focus of specific individualised practices:

> For a while, I was spending a couple of afternoons a week just going out in the desert and meditating and reading, with some of the reading being just reading through the Tenets to myself, just to kind of recentre. (Interview with K7)

Individual practices may vary considerably in form, but their legitimacy is often grounded in alignment with the foundational values. This flexibility is reflected in participants' descriptions of the wide range of practices and resources that can be incorporated into Satanism. As one interviewee remarks:

> I find most people have their own version of Satanism. It's very open to individual interpretations. We have people who do Chaos Magic, people who do just daily meditations that are more Buddhist-leaning. It works very well with other belief systems. I think we even have someone who used to be in the Ordination Council and still had iconography of Jesus on a Satanic altar. […] And even then, people were like, "Yeah, no, I guess that makes sense, he's a rebel too, kind of in his own way". That's fine. So, I find there's no real tension […] as long as you're not straight up believing in theistic deities where you're like, "I believe Hecate or Artemis are literally real". Then people are like, "Oh, what?" (Interview with K5)

This space for creativity and personalisation is not without limits. Literal belief in gods tends to provoke resistance, given TST's self-understanding as a non-theistic religion. Personalisation of practice is structured by a shared

ontological orientation that privileges metaphorical or symbolic engagement with a variety of religious and cultural traditions over belief in the supernatural. These boundaries are closely connected to TST's emphasis on science and reason, embedded in Tenet 5, which states that "[b]eliefs should conform to one's best scientific understanding of the world", while Tenet 1 frames compassion as a principle to be exercised "in accordance with reason". This framing of scientific rationality corresponds to the public image that TST seeks to project. As TST's official website explains,

> The Satanic Temple believes that religion can, and should, be divorced from superstition. As such, we do not promote a belief in a personal Satan. To embrace the name Satan is to embrace rational inquiry removed from supernaturalism and archaic tradition-based superstitions. Satanists should actively work to hone critical thinking and exercise reasonable agnosticism in all things. Our beliefs must be malleable to the best current scientific understandings of the material world—never the reverse. (The Satanic Temple n.d.b).

Reliance on rationalist 'rhetorical apologetics' (Lewis 2010b) as a source of authority is therefore not merely an individual preference but an institutionalised value that structures understandings of legitimate Satanic practice. Notably, this orientation is reflected in positive attitudes to scientific research in the survey results. About 85% (n = 136) indicate that too little is spent on scientific research—patterns consistent with high levels of education (see 4.1).

The organisational agenda of dealigning from superstition is reflected in the ways participants design and interpret their individual practices. For instance, when explaining how Tarot can be incorporated into one's individual Satanic practice, a minister insists that "[t]here's nothing supernatural or superstitious about this. Those cards are just a tool for helping me to contemplate the Tenets" ("Personal Satanic Rituals", 8 February 2022). Their description outlines the structure and function of a Satanic Tarot ritual, dedicated to reflection and internalisation of TST's shared foundational values:

> I start by lighting a candle and some incense. And next, I recite my Tenet of the day while I shuffle my Tarot deck. This, I have found, is a great way to commit the tenets to memory. Then I spread the cards out on the table, face down, and select one card at random. Now, I have a journal that I keep and I record the Tenet of the day in my journal, along with the name of the card that was selected. I record all the details I can about the background of the card in my journal: symbols I see, colours, etc. And then I record the foreground of the card: actions that may be happening, people, which way they're facing, what are they doing, any additional symbols. All of that is a primer for the most important part of the ritual, which is when I begin to contemplate how the card reflects the nature of the Tenet and how the Tenet reflects the nature of the card. I then write down my thoughts and feelings, so that I can go back to them at any later time. Finally, when that's all done, I take a few breaths and I have a little phrase I like to say into the world. I take a refreshed and enlightened

> mind. It is done. Hail Satan! And then I extinguish the candle and incense, and I get on with my day. ("Personal Satanic Rituals", 8 February 2022)

Dealignment from superstition also serves as a boundary-marker that individual practitioners use when negotiating the relationship to their own religious heritage. An interviewee involved in the design and performance of rituals, sees their elaborate aesthetics as a continuation of what they used to appreciate as a former Catholic; while emphasising aesthetic alignment with the suggestive richness of Catholic ritual, the congregant makes an explicit dissociation from any supernatural aspects:

> One of the things I always enjoyed and still do to this day from Catholicism was the pageantry. There's something about Mass that puts you in a headspace—even if it isn't supernatural—to do introspection. And there's something about the pageantry that kind of sets that up for me. (Interview with K6)

In some cases, there seems to be a tension between alignment with notions of rationalism and practitioners' full immersion in ritual as a distinct, meaningful experience. This tension likely prompts participants in TST to continually legitimise the role of ritual and emphasise its significance. Some frame their engagement with ritual as a source of community and affirmation of their activist commitments, as articulated by an interviewee:

> I think that there is a sense of connection that's formed as a result of that practice. Connection to the community. And to the larger cause. I don't believe in the literal existence of any supernatural power. But I think that there is a connection to community or connection to a set of beliefs that can be emphasized in that space. (Interview with K9)

Here again, clear dealignment from supernatural belief mirrors the broader pattern of boundary maintenance in TST, where ritual is embraced as a secular, affective, and communal practice. However, for other participants, particularly those with atheistic backgrounds, engaging in ritual in general can feel unnatural or self-conscious. This tension is evident in how an interviewee reflects on their struggle with the ritualistic aspects of their practice, as both congregant and officiant:

> It's something I'm working on, because I think it deals with growing up as an atheist. Religion and ritual, and things like that were always for other people […] not something I engaged in. A lot of people have talked about missing that aspect—having the religious community and the shared rituals and stuff like that. So, they just dove right in to it, "Oh, cool, Satanism has these too!" But I guess I've got some mental barriers up that I have to get through before enjoying them. In other contexts, like sitting around and playing Dungeons and Dragons, for instance, has the same kind of thing: you have that magic circle between you and the outside world where social norms are lifted up and you can wear a cloak and you can get way too emotionally invested in what number

> a piece of plastic lands on, right? But I can't get my head in that point for a ritual, doing the same kind of thing, standing there in a robe and saying a whole bunch of magic-sounding stuff. […] So, I think it's just something about the word ritual itself that's holding my brain back. (Interview with K10)

This account illustrates how emotional experiences and aesthetic preferences with regard to individual Satanic practice intersect with early socialisation and broader cultural discourses on religion and ritual. Notably, this minister's personal challenge with the ritual side of Satanism is intertwined with their own and the community's expectations of emotional responses. The reluctance to officiate a ritual as a minister is linked to a concern for the experience of other ritual participants: "I feel like it wouldn't feel genuine to the other person, if I'm not understanding it yet, if I'm not feeling it" (Interview with K10). The minister's expectations about such emotional response are shaped by a collective discourse: "I've heard from other ministers that it [officiating a ritual] helps a lot, seeing how much it's affecting someone else emotionally […] showing the importance of it and everything" (Interview with K10). While not universal among TST participants, rituals within the community are often reflected upon as deeply felt emotional events. This regime cultivates a communal space where emotional intensity is valued, guiding how participants approach, interpret, and internalise ritual practice. Such dynamics illustrate how personal engagement with Satanic practice is negotiated in relation to the community. Individual understandings and expectations of what a ritual means and how it could or should feel are in a dialogical relationship with regimes co-constructed and enacted in communal contexts.

The organisational commitment to dealignment from theism and superstition is also evident in how participants negotiate their engagement with Pagan or Indigenous traditions. Such traditions are often incorporated into Satanic practice, but only after being translated into a 'secular' framework compatible with TST's commitment to reason and scientific naturalism. To achieve this, elements drawn from these Significant Others are typically not framed as theological commitments but reinterpreted as cultural artefacts or ancestral echoes. This mode of alignment enables practitioners to remain true to TST's foundational principles while engaging with other religious and cultural repertoires. In the service "Secular Witchcraft" (21 December 2021), folk magic and Pagan traditions are framed as "cultural history" upon which Satanists can draw. In negotiating the incorporation of such traditions, some participants also emphasise the ethical imperative to avoid cultural appropriation. Such concerns are expressed in the service "Halloween Practices and Traditions" (30 October 2021), where a minister argues that All Saints Day represents a Christian appropriation of Pagan traditions such as Samhain. In contrast, Satanic engagement with these traditions is framed as a recognition of "our immigrated ancestors" and a sincere veneration of marginalised groups:

> We owe it to the Celtic and Irish immigrants who first came to North America, bringing their traditions with them, for without their efforts we would not enjoy Halloween as we do today. It is important to always bring honour to the original founding traditions of holidays. It is in the spirit of the marginalized that we rally together to keep these practices and traditions alive […]. Shining light into the dark corners of all that has been hidden through time, we find pieces of ourselves in many of the old practices, bringing them back into our lives, so we can give new life to what we once thought was dead, even within ourselves. ("Halloween Practices and Traditions", 30 October 2021)

By presenting these elements as matters of culture and heritage rather than religion, Satanic practitioners translate 'religious' elements into 'secular' in order to integrate them in TST's non-supernatural framework. At the same time, the inclusion of a Samhain ritual in a Satanic celebration of Halloween may, according to another minister, reveal "a much deeper and ancient meaning" and preserve "the feeling of sacredness and solemnity inherent in the holiday" ("Strength and Renewal in Samhain", 19 October 2021). Translation within these alignment dynamics therefore operates between inter-religious and religious-secular diffusion, aimed at navigating personal religiosity, while sustaining commitment to TST:

> I see in the ancient Celtic celebration a way for Satanists to have a transcendent experience without belief in the supernatural, hopefully deepening their feeling of being religious in a non-theistic context. We can adapt and utilize the imagery, symbolism, and archetypical deities associated with Samhain. ("Strength and Renewal in Samhain", 19 October 2021)

Alignment with external traditions is negotiated within TST's established doctrinal boundaries. Translating religion into culture or heritage constitutes a recalibration of identity-defining fields of tension. Individuals negotiate forms of belonging, maintaining affinity with (actual or imagined) familial and cultural histories without compromising their shared TST values. This dynamic may be particularly relevant for individuals for whom religious belonging to TST is entangled with complex layers of ethnical and religious backgrounds. By translating religious elements into secular, TST participants soften certain boundaries, making space for layered belonging in the assembling of their individual practice. In contrast to heritage work in Indigenous contexts, where community members' connections to land and locality are central (Liinason 2025), the incorporation of Pagan or Indigenous lore into Satanic practice seems to follow a different logic—rooted in imagined genealogy and symbolic coherence rather than direct territorial or ancestral continuity. This corresponds to Tafjord's (2018) discussion of "romantic modes of indigenising": members of NRMs inspired by what they perceive as ancient or original traditions engage in discourses and practices, where they

> recycle old and invent new ideas about golden but oppressed and almost forgotten local religious pasts, about grand religious ancestors or rare noble Others who can serve as exemplary guides to (post)modern seekers, and about nature worship and nature religion that can be revived or imported. (2018: 307)

Thus, processes of alignment and dealignment highlights the complex interplay between inter-religious and secular-religious diffusion, problematising the notion of religion as a dynamic and messy assemblage.

5.1.2 Co-Production of Practice in Communal Contexts

While TST's Tenets provide shared values and boundaries for individual practice, they do not prescribe a fixed repertoire of rituals, traditions, or cultural expressions. As a relatively young religious movement, TST lacks many of the established conventions, ritual forms, and inherited traditions that characterise older religious communities. Consequently, the development of Satanic practice becomes both an individual and collective project in which participants actively negotiate what Satanism may or should look like. As a minister explains, the construction of Satanic culture involves conscious reflection on which traditions, symbols, and practices should be adopted, modified or rejected:

> TST specifically is so new that we're sort of developing our own culture. […] If we want to make Sol Invictus traditions, we have to be like, "Okay, we want to keep some of the stuff from Christmas that we like. Is there anything we don't like that we need to absolutely get rid of? What parts of society as it is do we like? And what parts do we want to reject? […] In our Tenets, justice is a necessary pursuit, but okay, what vision of justice are we pursuing? What does that look like? […] Or what do we want our music to sound like at holidays? Or what traditions do we want to build? What does our art look like? What symbols are important to us?" (Interview with K5)

The diversity of sources and influences drawn upon in this process underscores the experimental character of Satanic practice. Participants describe exploration and adaptation as advantages of belonging to a new religious movement whose traditions remain under development. As a minister remarks in a service, "what's great about Satanic ritual is that it's ours and we make it our own" ("Personal Satanic Rituals", 8 February 2022). An interviewee similarly observes:

> It's kind of cool because there's not, you know, centuries of history that build a ritual in The Satanic Temple. So, we have the ability to do as we please and build it for our purposes—which is really fun. (Interview with K6)

Individual religious practice emerges through participation in collective processes of assembling. Participants develop practices drawing upon communal

improvisation with templates. Individual and collective dimensions of practice are therefore mutually constitutive. One of the primary sites where this dynamic becomes visible is TST's religious services. Since their introduction, the services have functioned as fora where participants discuss, develop, and enact Satanic practice. One of the clearest signs of formalisation within this format is the consistent opening of each service with a Satanic invocation written by Greaves:

> Let us stand now, unbowed and unfettered by arcane doctrines borne of fearful minds in darkened times. Let us embrace the Luciferian impulse to eat of the Tree of Knowledge and dissipate our blissful and comforting delusions of old. Let us demand that individuals be judged for their concrete actions, not their fealty to arbitrary social norms and illusory categorizations. Let us reason our solutions with agnosticism in all things, holding fast only to that which is demonstrably true. Let us stand firm against any and all arbitrary authority that threatens the personal sovereignty of One or All. That which will not bend must break, and that which can be destroyed by truth should never be spared its demise. It is Done. Hail Satan!

The repeated use of the invocation provides a recognisable structure and alignment with shared values that link the otherwise diverse topics discussed in the services. While the text is typically recited in its standard form, ministers sometimes introduce subtle personal variations. For instance, some conclude the invocation with additions such as "Hail Lilith", "Hail me", or "Hail" followed by their Satanic pseudonym after the original "Hail Satan". Another example of how such modifications personalise the ritual while remaining within the shared template is the service "Mindfully Satanic" (29 November 2022). Here, the minister changes the invocation's opening line from the exhortation to a first-person declaration: "I will stand now, unbowed and unfettered by arcane doctrines born of fearful minds in darkened times". This shift from collective to individual voice is a performative articulation of personal agency anchored in TST's fundamental values. Another example of personal adaptation of the service template is the episode "Secular Witchcraft" (21 December 2021), where the minister recites a Wiccan Winter Solstice invocation following the standard Satanic invocation:

> O absent sun, the earth grows cold as we wait. Our vigil fire is but a small spark compared to your brilliance. Our bones grow cold awaiting your warmth. Patiently we await your return in the eastern sky. Impatiently we await the first shard of light piercing the eastern dawn, the first sign of life's renewal. Come to us, O sun! For now, we wait.

Beyond being individual personalisation, these modified service templates illustrate performative alignment with other religious traditions, as participants explore possible connections between Satanism and Significant Others without abandoning the values that define TST. Another element in the services

emerging between personalisation and formalisation is the practice of land acknowledgements. In some services, ministers begin by recognising the Indigenous peoples associated with the lands on which they live. While the practice of land acknowledgements reflects a general commitment to ethical awareness and cultural respect, the content of these statements is personalised and varies according to the minister's geographical and cultural context.

These examples illustrate how TST services foster both formalisation and experimentation and provide a space for individual and shared religious expressions. The consistent use of the Satanic invocation signals a move toward ritual standardisation, while the individual adaptations and integrations of other traditions reflect an openness to personalisation and innovation. The digital format of the services may play a particularly important role in enabling these dynamics. Radde-Antweiler (in Helland and Kienzl 2022: 47) argues that the online world creates fertile ground for the development of patchwork rituals; these rituals are shaped or reshaped by blending elements from different traditions, adapted to new contexts, and facilitated through digital platforms—a perspective resonating with Tremlett's (2021) understanding of combination-articulation processes in assemblage formation. Similarly, Lewis (2010a) highlights the importance of the internet for Satanists (and Pagans) in fostering a sense of community and providing access to a wide range of resources from which they can construct personalised forms of religious practice.

The interplay between individual and collective practice extends beyond TST's online services into local congregational settings, where ritual forms are adopted to meet the needs of community participants. Some congregations have introduced initiation rituals as a way of marking transitions in individuals' relationships to the group. A minister explains:

> We have tiers of membership. You become a provisional member where we're still kind of feeling things out and making sure you're a good fit. And then you become an initiated member. So, we try to have a ceremony just to honour the people who have gotten initiated. (Interview with K10)

Initiation rituals serve an important social function, enacting an individual participant's incorporation in the community and producing that community by creating occasions through which shared values are affirmed.

Describing a ritual created for their congregation, another minister reflects on the balance between structure and individual creativity:

> Mine was more like a guided visualisation. […] the symbolism I used was a wild plant versus a garden. You have wild plants, you have tended gardens, and you should be able to grow and tend your garden the way that you want to. And if that means breaking free and growing wild too, that's fine. And [I] had people, if they had either a plant in their home or a picture of one, just to use as aid with that visualization. Other than that, it was just me reading loose-

> form poetry that I wrote for people to visualise on. That was basically it. But then we have things like… Black Masses are rare, but they're also a little bit more structured. Or Unbaptisms—they tend to have a little bit more of a structure, but there's still freedom there too. (Interview with K5)

Ritual formalisation coexists with an ongoing commitment to free individual expression. Discussions surrounding the Black Mass, one of Satanism's distinctive rituals, illustrate how individual practice is collectively negotiated. In the service "To Voisin, With Love" (11 January 2022), ministers and panellists discuss differing attitudes to the ritual's structure and relation to a Satanic lineage. One perspective advocates for a set of minimal characteristics for a ritual to be recognised as a Black Mass:

> Some people argue that for it to be a Black Mass, it needs to be what was conceptualized by Anton LaVey […] which was a complete blasphemous version of the Catholic Mass. Using naked altars and putting Eucharist inside bodily cavities and using various bodily fluids—really just taking this mass created by Catholics that is seen as a very sincere, deeply important ritual for the Catholics and just bastardizing it to every extent possible in the name of Satan. ("To Voisin, With Love", 11 January 2022)

Other participants articulate a more flexible approach, arguing that the defining feature of the Black Mass is not adherence to a specific script, aesthetic, or ritual sequence, but its capacity to express Satanic values and identity. One panellist explicitly distances themselves from the traditional LaVeyan model:

> LaVeyan Black Masses, it's too coded for me. It's the one true way and there's no other way. It's too centred on the male power and all that. So, I'm eager to just reject that, even if I would take some elements. ("To Voisin, With Love", 11 January 2022)

Rather than accepting inherited ritual forms as authoritative, this position expresses a feminist critique. The flexible approach to Black Mass design is framed as an egalitarian alternative to LaVeyan Satanism. The discussion illustrates how ritual functions as a site of both alignment and dealignment: participants negotiate their relationship to earlier Satanic traditions, engaging with questions of authenticity, continuity, and innovation.

Similar dynamics are evident in the interpretation and celebration of Satanic holidays. Practices associated with TST holidays, such as Sol Invictus, Lupercalia, and Hexennacht, provide a particularly rich context for exploring alignment in the construction of individual forms of Satanism in relation to communal frameworks. These celebrations are sites where notions of Satanic identity are negotiated, reflecting the ongoing recalibration of what is considered 'authentic Satanism' within TST. Sources of inspiration can range from Satanic texts like *The Devil's Tome: A Book of Modern Satanic Ritual* by Shiva Honey (Interview with K10; "Personal Satanic Rituals", 8 February

2022) to neopagan literature such as *Llewellyn's Sabbat Essentials Collection* ("Secular Witchcraft", 21 December 2021). Participants can draw from a diverse array of traditions and contexts, incorporating elements from ancient Roman rites, local pre-Christian customs, and even the symbolic structures of modern gaming worlds. In a TST service dedicated to the theme "Celebrating Sol Invictus" (4 December 2021), a minister's interpretation of the meaning behind the holiday reflects an alignment with a pre-Christian Roman tradition. In the service introduction, the minister explicitly anchors the symbolism of the holiday in TST's Tenets:

> As Satanists, a part of the Satanic Temple, on December 25, we celebrate being unconquered by superstition and being consistent in the pursuit and sharing of knowledge. As such, it aligns with our Luciferian impulse and our fifth tenet. […] The 25th of December is a day in the later Roman Empire when people celebrated the winter solstice and the birthday of the sun god. […] According to some historians, Christmas was set to December 25th because it was the day of the festival of Sol Invictus. This idea became popular, especially in the 18th and 19th centuries. Some argued that Christianity assimilated the religion of Sol Invictus, and that Jesus himself was Sol Invictus. ("Celebrating Sol Invictus", 4 December 2021)

This framing can be interpreted as a strategic dealignment from Christianity through the reclamation of a culturally significant date and the attribution of alternative symbolic meanings. The interplay between alignment with ancient Roman traditions and dealignment from Christian heritage positions Satanic practice between resistance and imagined continuity. Although the reinterpretation seeks to distance the assemblage from Christian frameworks, Christianity remains the reference point around which this movement turns, illustrating how spirals of deterritorialisation curve around a centre while also moving away from it.

While the minister's interpretation of Sol Invictus articulates a collective framework for understanding the holiday, other contributions in the service represent more personalised approaches. A panellist shares their personal way of celebrating Sol Invictus, integrating elements from local Swedish traditions. References to pre-Christian Pagan heritage are framed positively, legitimising their incorporation into one's Satanic practice. Notably, this approach is also influenced by contemporary gaming culture:

> There's this really, really old tradition in Sweden called 'the year walk' that goes back hundreds of years, where you basically fast and you stay up. And then, in the middle of the night, you go on a walk and you're not supposed to meet anyone or greet anyone, or talk to anyone. […] And the things you see during this walk are supposed to tell you about the coming year—like predictions for the coming year. You might see…because you are hungry and you're tired…you might hallucinate. It's really, really interesting. I'm fascinated by this tradition! There's actually […] a game where you can experience the year

> walk. […] You learn about the different beings and creatures you might encounter on this year walk and what it might mean. I would like to incorporate the spirit of this tradition into a ritual: an introspective ritual for the year—like, what do I want to accomplish, what do I feel I want to do, or my goals and aspirations for the coming year. ("Celebrating Sol Invictus", 4 December 2021)

This example illustrates how individual celebratory practices emerge through alignment with collectively constructed templates and personally significant symbolic repertoires. The participant expresses interest in local folklore in a communal setting in which references to pre-Christian traditions have already been legitimised as meaningful components of Satanic practice. Their approach to personal celebratory practice combines perceptions of ancient religious frameworks with contemporary gaming culture, reflecting assembling dynamics shaped by inter-religious and secular-religious diffusion.

A further example demonstrates how the assembling of individual practice involves experimentation with ritual as combination-articulation. A service panellist explains how their Satanic practice draws on a rich constellation of sources including the circular dances of a Catalonian tradition and the deconstructive philosophy of Jacques Derrida ("Personal Satanic Rituals", 8 February 2022). Their embodied engagement with material culture is inspired by African-Brazilian traditions. The participant recounts sourcing items from local shops in Brazil, where the in-person interactions with shopkeepers become part of how they craft and reflect on their practice:

> I feel very blessed because in Brazil, you know, we have many little shops with religious articles. Every neighbourhood has one with the skull on the door. It's very, very appropriate. But every time the lady there starts laughing because of what I'm asking for—because she probably knows by heart every African Brazilian ritual, how many black and red candles do they use… So, when I ask for five or three, she starts laughing, like, "What's this person trying to do?" ("Personal Satanic Rituals", 8 February 2022)

As in the preceding examples, the participant's ritual practice is assembled through alignment with heterogeneous religious and cultural Others. This creative construction of Satanism is made intelligible through collective discourses that authorise experimentation and provide conceptual frameworks within which diverse practices can be recognised as Satanic. More than just personal expressions, individual practices are produced through engagement with collective TST frameworks, while simultaneously contributing to the ongoing reshaping of those frameworks. The reciprocal nature of this relationship is evident in discussions surrounding the celebration of Lupercalia. While the holiday has been associated with positive sexual expression, participants have also negotiated how it should be celebrated in ways that accommodate diverse participants. As one interviewee explains:

> One Lupercalia, […] there was a thing going around on Twitter. People were sending really sexy selfies, which was fun. But then a lot of the asexuals in the community were like, "Hey, that felt like really—obviously celebrate yourselves—but it felt weird that the only things for Lupercalia were super sex-based, which meant that we felt really excluded". So, the next Lupercalia, we had an entire educational panel on what asexuality was and wasn't and how to be inclusive […] where sexuality is not something to be ashamed of. But also, when you're celebrating your sexuality that you're not making it compulsive to people—that 'yes' is celebrated and so is 'no', and that is the choice that matters. (Interview with K5)

This account illustrates how collective norms themselves are renegotiated in response to individual experiences and identities. As the analysis in this section demonstrates, Satanic practice is assembled through continuous interactions between individual practitioners and communal frameworks.

5.1.3 Negotiating Religion and Religious Others

The ways in which participants in TST conceptualise and enact their Satanism illustrates how processes of alignment, tension, and dealignment operate in relation to Significant Others beyond the community.

Alignment With 'Religion'

One dimension where these assembling dynamics become visible is in the weaving of a terminological 'coat'—the vocabulary through which participants articulate their Satanic practice. The negotiation of terms such as 'minister', 'congregation', and even 'religion' reveals how participants position their Satanism within, against, or beyond other religious contexts, especially those shaped by Christianity. More than a semantic issue, this negotiation is characterised by value-laden and identity-defining tensions. In the series Minister Mondays, TST ministers discuss the Christian undertone of key concepts they use, and the role these play in their personal journeys as Satanists. The selective use of religious terminology is framed as a process of resistance, reinterpretation, and reappropriation. Ministers' reflections point to a conceptual recalibration, aimed at dealignment from Christian connotations:

> It's weird. I think I still have Christian indoctrination in my head with words like 'minister' and 'congregation'. It's really difficult to separate that from Christianity […] It's a lot of work. I have to remember that there are dictionary definitions to these words and Christians did not invent them. So, it's been really good for my personal growth to accept these words. The biggest word for me to even accept is the word 'religion'. […] Why can't we take ownerships of these words too? They belong to everybody; they don't belong to just Christians. So, it's definitely a part of reclamation of not just myself—it's reclaiming languages that someone claims to be their words and it's just not true. (Minister Mondays, 10 October 2022)

The reclaiming of this religious language is associated with emotional confusion and cognitive labour. This tricky negotiation goes hand-in-hand with mobilising dealignment from what is labelled as superstition and indoctrination:

> I believe religion can be divorced from superstition but it took me a really long time to just feel comfortable with that and […] use words like 'minister', 'congregation', even when we talk about 'services', like Temple Tuesdays. There was a lot of unlearning from previous religious indoctrination. (Minister Mondays, 10 October 2022)

Religious terminology thus becomes a medium through which alignment and dealignment are enacted. The negotiation of 'religion' extends to questions of practice. A participant in a TST service ("What Are Satanic Services Anyways?", 22 October 2023), who values the open, interactive, and pluralistic nature of these online gatherings, contrasts them with what they describe as authoritarian Catholic pedagogy that shaped their expectations. Their account exemplifies dealignment from the hierarchical and didactic structure of Catholic services. The participant's Christian background is also evident in the figurative language used to describe their first experience of a TST service: their participation as a panel member then felt "almost like a Baptism of fire". Here again, the use of a Christian-coded metaphor implicitly reinforces the role of Christianity as a point of reference, even in accounts structured around departure from it. Instances of dealignment from Christianity as a Significant Other coexist with expressions of implicit alignment. In the same service, the minister leading the discussion explains the original idea and the development of TST's newly established tradition of holding religious services, notably, elaborating on the difference between "religious formation" and "religious services" as understood in Christian contexts:

> [I]n some Christian communities, they make a distinction between services on the one hand and what they call religious formation. Religious formation, as I understand it, is Bible studying or whatever the equivalent is in whatever religion. You know, Sunday school, it's a place where new people go to learn about a religion in a fun and engaging way. […] Now, we've never had Sunday school. What would we even call it, Bible study? We wouldn't call it that. We haven't had that religious formation, but a lot of our early services functioned as a kind of introductory, you know, Satanism 101. ("What Are Satanic Services Anyways?", 22 October 2023)

The minister seems to use the comparison to explain the logic behind evolving TST practices in a way that other community members can understand. The ethos of selective appropriation and reinterpretation of religious forms is evident in their emphasis on the importance of having "for lack of a better term, Sunday school for Satanists". Similarly, reflecting on their initial expectations of TST services, another participant in this episode shares how prior experiences in different religious contexts have shaped their understanding of what

Satanic services should be. They acknowledge how a culturally specific form of Mormon worship represented the ideal structure and experience of community they would later seek to find. In this sense, their attraction to certain aspects of Mormon practice can be seen as a form of implicit alignment:

> [W]hen I was younger, we went to the Mormon Church and those services—I don't know how it is with Mormonism in America, but at very least in the UK or the specific one we went to in Edinburgh—they did open with someone talking for about 15-20 minutes about Mormonism. But then it opened up and felt more communal, felt more like a community discussion as well. And people were more talking about their lives. […] And it felt more community based than what I was used to. And then, losing my religion through lots of self-study of other religions and then finding the Temple of Seth and finding Thelema and stuff, I wanted them to be very much this. ("What Are Satanic Services Anyways?", 22 October 2023)

By adopting familiar formats such as 'services', TST members engage in a form of inter-religious diffusion—translating established religious forms to serve doctrinal and communal purposes in a new context, while dealigning from the theological assumptions associated with them. In this sense, participants do not simply abandon previous religious influences when joining TST; rather, selected elements are carried forward and reassembled within the new Satanic context. These assembling dynamics also reflect broader challenges within NRMs, which often navigate legal and institutional frameworks designed around traditional, institutionalised religions (see 1.4.3). In TST's context, familiar religious language and forms may serve pragmatic purposes: facilitating recognition, legitimacy, and access to rights or protections. The interplay between strategic alignment and dealignment is thus a site of complex negotiation, where individuals assemble their Satanism in relation to personal preferences, internal community norms and external regulatory pressures.

Alignment in Ministerial Practice

The discussion now turns to the role of ministers as mediators between TST and people outside the organisation. Weddings and other memorable ceremonies are ritual contexts where ministers often must accommodate diverse religious backgrounds while remaining aligned with TST's values. Their work therefore provides a particularly useful perspective on how alignment and dealignment are negotiated in practice.

The organisational rationale for maintaining boundaries against the supernatural becomes particularly clear in TST's ministerial guidelines, where nontheism is explicitly defined as a prerequisite for becoming a minister. In the FAQ section of TST's official homepage, the following question is addressed:

> I am a theistic Satanist. Can I still become ordained by The Satanic Temple?
>
> No. The Satanic Temple is a nontheistic Satanic organization, a matter that follows naturally from the fifth tenet. Having a personal commitment to theistic Satanism makes you unable to represent the values and deeply-held beliefs of The Satanic Temple in the way that we require of our ordained membership.
>
> We encourage you to seek out a rigorous ordination program with an organization that represents your values and beliefs. (The Satanic Temple n.d.b)

Although ministers are granted considerable freedom in designing rituals, this flexibility operates within clearly defined organisational boundaries. In a Minister Mondays episode (31 October 2022), a minister identifies two principal strategies through which they negotiate relationships with other traditions: accommodation and inversion. Accommodation is framed as a gesture of reconciliation and inclusivity, particularly when officiating rituals, where elements from other traditions may be integrated to honour the backgrounds of participants. Ministers sometimes refer to this type of ritual as a "cross-over", highlighting combination-articulation dynamics. Ceremonies are held both for members and for people who do not belong to TST, yet know the Seven Tenets and follow or sympathise with the movement's campaigns. Ministers express openness to such inclusivity, as one officiant puts it: "It doesn't really matter as long as you do something that is meaningful to you" (Minister Mondays, 22 August 2022). Wedding ceremonies are one of the ritual contexts where non-members who feel aligned with TST's values seek ritual expression that reflects their convictions while remaining discreet. As one minister explains:

> We've had a lot of requests from all over, from people asking for a minister of Satan to officiate at their wedding without it being overtly Satanic, just because they want a more secular kind of setting or because they can't be entirely out with their families. It gives them that inner little validation of "Oh, it's a Satanic wedding, no-one really knows it's a Satanic wedding, but we do!" (Minister Mondays, 28 November 2022).

This reflection illustrates how ritual design becomes a site of negotiating alignment with TST, navigating between personal conviction and varying degrees of 'outness'. Ministers mediate between participants' alignment with TST and the practical challenges associated with managing a stigmatised identity. Trust-building is important, and in the context of memorable ceremonies, has a lot to do with feeling the right kind of "vibe" or "energy", as a minister argues:

> They don't vibe with any of the ministers they have around that are non-theistic or theistic. Sometimes you have a friend who is a minister from a Christian church and they just do a secular wedding—and it works. […] It's really what feels good, what you want and what you can achieve with what you have

> around you. We have hundreds of ministers. There is one for you! (Minister Mondays, 22 August 2022).

The sense of emotional harmony between ministers and ritual participants appears particularly important in contexts where a toned-down performance of Satanic identity is desirable, or where participants seek a sense of belonging without overt identification. In some cases, ministers adapt ritual language and symbolism to accommodate family members who may hold views that collide with TST's ethos. This can involve coded ritual design, where Satanic values are expressed in a subtle or symbolic way, as a minister recounts:

> I talked about them being free thinkers and not being bogged down […]. There was one part where I said "We should be goats, not sheep!" (Minister Mondays, 22 August 2022).

Similarly, the wedding vows for this ceremony, "Do you promise to live a life without shame and without regret and to live deliciously and in your own way?", express Satanic principles in a less overt manner. The phrase "live deliciously" is part of the community's internal discourse, drawing on the Devil's invitation in the horror film *The Witch* (2015): "Wouldst thou like to live deliciously?" This intertextual reference to popular culture allows for the expression of Satanic values in a coded, less provocative way. As another example of this strategic adaptation, the minister recounts using the phrase "Blessed it be!" instead of the customary "Hail Satan!"

A similar dynamic emerges in another wedding ceremony. A minister associated with TST's SoCC recounts officiating a Satanic wedding for an interracial couple (Minister Mondays, 28 November 2022). In this case, the bride was Catholic, leading the minister to incorporate elements of that tradition: "In Catholicism, you have three readings, so what we came up with were three quotes, three meaningful things". However, the ceremony developed as a form of secular-religious diffusion, where the Catholic tradition with three statements was mixed with elements from popular culture reconfigured to fit TST's ritual repertoire. The couple chose to read the so-called "corpse bride vows", written by another minister, adding a further symbolic and aesthetic layer to the ritual with intertextual reference to another occultural source, Burton's animated fantasy *Corpse Bride* (2005). As in other cases discussed in Minister Mondays, the Satanic character of the ceremony was intentionally kept "very discreet" out of respect for Christian family members. This example highlights the creativity of alignment dynamics, in which a rich variety of sources are drawn from to navigate different identities and belongings. In several cases, popular occulture, in Partridge's understanding (2004), functions as a cultural reservoir of ideas and aesthetic sensibilities for the construction of a Satanic ritual repertoire. As Partridge argues, occultural content is often not subculture but *cultura popularis*, saturated with elements that transgress

'the secular'. In the context of TST's ministerial practice, popular occulture becomes a resource for secular-religious diffusion, enabling a form of ritual camouflage that maintains ideological integrity while facilitating modified visibility and broader social inclusion.

Ministers may also officiate the wedding ceremony in a secular way, or perform a Satanic wedding ritual separately, in the absence of sensitive relatives. As one minister explains: "It was the right time, you know, grandmother wasn't there and people that were going to be offended" (Minister Mondays, 22 August 2022). The design of the ritual can then include "a lot of Satan talk" and a rich array of Satanic symbolic elements for connecting the married couple. Similarly, another minister recalls officiating at a wedding ceremony that had a secular, rather than a Satanic tone:

> It wasn't a 'Satanic' wedding but it was secular, in that we didn't invoke God or Jesus or any of that bullshit. We just focused on the couple, their commitment and their journey going forward in this very important time. (Minister Mondays, 26 September 2022)

Ministers also describe how attitudes of family members and friends towards Satanism can change during the planning and performing of a ceremony:

> The funny thing is that at first some of them were like "Ugh, I don't want to do a Satan thing!". But then they were like "Oh, I don't want to mess it up! How do I do this?" [Laughter] "No, you can't mess it up, you can't mess it up!" (Minister Mondays, 22 August 2022)

These accounts illustrate how ministers modulate the visibility of ritual participants' identification with TST, negotiating both broader social tensions surrounding Satanism and participants' individual anticipations of stigma. Their approaches to ritual design and performance are thus closely connected to information control as a stigma management strategy (see 5.2.2). Ministerial negotiation of practice may also involve the officiant's own religious heritage. A minister with a Catholic upbringing explains how they draw on Catholic aesthetics, reconfiguring them through symbolic inversion:

> I really like taking the pomp and circumstance of a typical wedding and turning them on their head and making them that way to just be fully Satanic. (Minister Mondays, 16 April 2022)

For this minister, ritual design becomes a "cathartic" emotional experience, through which a former religious tradition can be symbolically renegotiated.

Alignment with and dealignment from Significant Others is negotiated not only in wedding ceremonies but across a broad spectrum of ministerial practices. One example is the intersection of Satanic and Pagan ritual spaces. A minister recalls performing a Satanic Unbaptism at a Pagan Pride festival.

Drawing on prior experience with the CoS and non-congregational Satanic communities, the minister wanted to create a ritual script that was accessible to both members and non-members of the community:

> We didn't want to seem overtly spooky and crazy […]. We just wanted to make it easier for non-Satanists as well as Satanists to understand what we were doing. (Minister Mondays, 14 November 2022)

This reflects both a strategic inclusivity and an implicit form of stigma management (see 5.2.2), where the ritual is designed to counteract stereotypical perceptions of Satanism as threatening. Other aspects of ministerial practice are characterised by dealignment from dominant religious traditions, particularly Christianity. A minister who has written a Black Mass script recounts growing up in an environment marked by superstition and fear of Satan:

> Even though that Christianity and that Abrahamic religion wasn't in my household, it was all around me all the time, especially in high school. […] And it was just… it was nuts! (Minister Mondays, 31 October 2022)

The minister's reflection on their Black Mass underscores how dealignment in ritual design can serve as a form of symbolic resistance. Such resistance is also evident in TST participants' attitudes toward blasphemy, which can function both as a mode of alignment with Satanic values and as dealignment from a negative Significant Other—a theme to which we turn next.

Blasphemy as Ritualisation of Dealignment

Blasphemy in the context of TST is officially framed as a manifestation of the individual's autonomy and dissent from oppressive religious norms:

> We do not believe in symbolic 'evil.' We acknowledge blasphemy is a legitimate expression of personal independence from counter-productive traditional norms. (The Satanic Temple n.d.b).

This organisational stance positions blasphemy as a tool for dealigning from dominant religious frameworks, particularly Christianity. In the service "The Unholy Holy (and vice versa)" (8 June 2021), a minister reflects on the cultural and theological heritage associated with the concept of holiness, particularly in American Christianity. The minister critiques holiness discourses rooted in Wesleyan theology, arguing that they create moral hierarchies and social exclusion. This critique likely resonates with TST participants who have grown up in such Christian environments and seek dealignment from those frameworks. As the minister puts it:

> With all of this baggage, it is no surprise, to me anyway, that plenty of Satanists and plenty of atheists, more generally, hear the word 'holy' and think, 'Fuck that'. ("The Unholy Holy and vice versa", 8 June 2021)

Individual engagement with blasphemy is explored in the service "Me & Blasphemy: A Complex Relationship" (6 July 2021), where a minister openly reflects on their ambivalent relationship with Satanic blasphemy. While traditional blasphemous symbols, such as the inverted cross or the number 666, may resonate with those from Christian backgrounds, the minister argues that such symbols may hold little significance for practitioners from other religious or secular contexts. Consequently, they propose a broader understanding of blasphemy framing it not primarily as inversion of specific religious symbols, but as living authentically in defiance of imposed norms:

> […] blasphemy can also mean simply refusing to abide by the social conventions imposed by religious power majorities. It can involve reading forbidden literature or holding forbidden thoughts […] for example, I'm LGBTQ, you can blaspheme just by living your authentic self unapologetically. That's a powerful form of blasphemy. ("Me & Blasphemy: A Complex Relationship", 6 July 2021)

Indiscriminate uses of blasphemy are discouraged, especially when they target religious traditions that have not been sources of oppression for the practitioner. The minister draws a distinction between blasphemy directed at dominant religious institutions and that aimed at marginalised groups:

> Blasphemy against a persecuted religious group's faith is not the equivalent of punching up at the majority faith tradition […] Pissing on the god that oppressed you is liberation. Pissing on other people's traditions is something else entirely. ("Me & Blasphemy: A Complex Relationship", 6 July 2021)

This perspective, reflecting a sensitivity to the ethical implications of blasphemy, especially in pluralistic and multicultural contexts, is also articulated in a service held on the "International Blasphemy Day" (25 September 2021). The minister emphasises blasphemous practice as a vital act of resistance and a safeguard for freedom of expression. Yet, they also acknowledge that the boundaries of blasphemy are context-dependent, as shifting configurations of power and marginalisation emerge in relation to ethnicity, immigration, and other socio-political factors.

Among individual practitioners, attitudes toward blasphemy are far from uniform, and their utilisation of blasphemous elements in Satanic practice are shaped by a range of personal preferences. Some Satanists embrace blasphemy for its provocative and artistic qualities. A member of a local congregation recalls being drawn to TST through its early public actions:

> I dug the blasphemy of what they were doing with those early things. That would have been the Pink Mass and the abortion counter-protest—those early actions that were very artful and drew a lot of attention. (Interview with K7)

For this member, blasphemy served as a gateway to Satanic activism, aligning with their values of creative resistance and social critique. For others, rituals with blasphemous undertones such as Unbaptism may carry therapeutic and liberating significance. One interviewee, who grew up in a very conservative Christian-dominated area and later found a home in a local TST community, describes undergoing an Unbaptism ritual as a transformative experience:

> The Unbaptism ritual was an emotional experience… being labelled as neither clean nor unclean was personally very powerful for me. I felt the weight of expectations being released from me. It doesn't matter what labels others attach to me… it's the labels I attach to myself that matter… and the behaviours that I engage in that matter. This was liberating. (Interview with K4)

Another illustrative example of blasphemy framed as therapeutic practice is the service "Satan's BIG Tent Revival" (11 July 2023). According to the minister, the deliberately blasphemous aesthetics—including the use of a crucifix-shaped dildo and a Jesus doll as theatrical props—are intended to facilitate healing from religious trauma and forced indoctrination. The service employs theatrical performance to rework familiar religious forms, making a parody of evangelical revivalism. The minister mimics the emotional intensity and rhetorical style of charismatic preaching while inverting its theological content:

> Praise Satan, tonight you will see and hear mystical feats beyond belief! You will be wowed, you will be awed, you will physically say 'Wow' and 'Awe'. You will praise Satan! Your life will be forever miraculously changed for evil, after you lay eyes on the wondrous wonders you will see here tonight. Praise Satan! Satan has delivered us from the injustices in the world. Satan is the bringer of chaos, good, a free thinker, a true questioner of bullshit. Praise Satan! Satan has taught us to question everything and sit comfortably in the heat of his fucking fire. Praise Satan! Allow me to begin by laying hands on you to bring the devil from the evil lair, propelled from the midst of darkness to cure what ails you. Praise Satan, the devil will deliver us right here tonight from the evil in the world and we will be showered! Just as Satan questioned a false god and came flying from the heavens in a bolt of light, Luke chapter 10 verse 18, he said, "I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven". ("Satan's BIG Tent Revival", 11 July 2023)

This performative inversion reflects a creative and playful engagement with religious tropes, allowing practitioners to reframe familiar rituals and expressive modes in ways that resonate with their own experiences and shared TST values. The tone of the service is not only critical; there are also notes of reconciliation. A panel participant emphasises the importance of seeking common ground and dialogue with Christians, in line with TST's principle of

compassion, while maintaining clear dealignment from what the they identify as negative expressions of Christianity. Satanic empathy is thus discursively engaged as a boundary-marker against hypocrisy or abuse. In contrast to what is described as the false goodness of some Christians, the Satanic approach emerges as a stigma-subverting engagement with difference:

> I love the idea of the good guy wearing a shirt that says evil. It's interesting, right? Because at the same time that Christians are 'the good guys' or whatever, they're the ones hitting us in school with a board. They're the ones with a cricket bat with holes in it so it whistles before it cracks you. […] I think practicing empathy, Satanic empathy, […] is really what sets us apart from that. And […] it really develops some social literacy to keep conversations going. […] Maybe there's hope, there's some common ground. At the end of the day, keeping the conversation going is better than shutting it all down. ("Satan's BIG Tent Revival", 11 July 2023)

These examples suggest that blasphemy is employed as a double-edged tool in ritual and everyday practice—one that simultaneously enacts dealignment from a negative Significant Other and alignment with shared community principles. Given this complexity, blasphemy within TST is not a universally understood practice. Rather, it constitutes a contested symbolic resource through which individual practitioners negotiate their Satanist identity and their relationship to religious traditions, cultural norms, and personal histories. This negotiation, especially as a response to religious trauma, thus intersects with stigma and stigma management strategies—a theme discussed below.

5.2 Satan's Stigma

> There's still such a giant stigma. It's frustrating that people stop thinking at the sight of the name and don't bother to properly look up the organization. (TST Survey 2024)

5.2.1 The Heavy Mark

Structural Stigma

Stigma is deeply embedded in the assembling of TST and is reflected in the lived experiences of its members. Enduring cultural narratives, such as the SRAS and more recent conspiracy movements like QAnon, function as discursive forces that shape public imaginaries surrounding Satanism (Dyrendal 2016; Lewis 2016; O'Brien 2023). These narratives extend beyond mere misinformation; they construct moral regimes that define what is considered deviant, dangerous, or unacceptable. They can be understood as expressions of

structural stigma that condition how Satanism is recognised, interpreted, and reacted to in the broader social environment.

One of the most explicit manifestations of this structural stigma is the hostility directed towards TST and its members, including physical attacks against the organisation's headquarters. 2024 was a period of intensified external hostility toward TST, in which the movement was subjected to two distinct violent attacks. In January, a man was arrested and charged with plotting to bomb the headquarters in Salem (Sylla 2024); and in April, an improvised explosive device was thrown onto the porch of the building, prompting strong mayoral condemnation, heightened local security, and the involvement of the FBI's Joint Terrorism Task Force (NBC Boston 2024). Although the device did not fully detonate and caused minor exterior damage, the attack was explicitly religiously motivated. A six-page handwritten note left at the scene stated, among other things: "Dear Satanist, elohim send me 7 months ago to give you peaceful message to hope you repent. You say no, elohim now send me to smite satan and I happy to obey" (US Attorney's Office, District of Massachusetts 2025).



Figure 9. The Salem Art Gallery, the headquarters of The Satanic Temple, Salem, Massachusetts. Despite its history as a target of attacks, no visible traces of violence remained at the time of the visit in October 2024. (Photograph by the author.)

These attacks were not unprecedented. In June 2022, a man wearing a T-shirt with the word "God" on it set fire to the headquarters, leaving a copy of the US Constitution and a Bible at the scene. He told police that his actions constituted a hate crime and stated that members of TST were "devil worshippers" (AP News 2022). Co-founder Lucien Greaves made a statement in the *Independent* addressing the arson attack:

> Due to the swift response, damage was isolated to the front door and porch, and we are grateful it was not worse. Nonetheless, the occupants who were inside the Temple at the time are understandably shaken. (Greaves, 14 June 2022).

Verbal threats and protests are another significant illustration of how public stigmatisation of TST works. Hostility is often directed at its public representatives. Since the organisation's inception, Greaves has received numerous death threats. Having grown up during the SRAS, he frames the church-driven moral campaigns that shaped the cultural environment of the 1980s and '90s as "a witch-hunt" (Metro Times ES 2014). The persistence of these narratives is reflected in the hostility directed at him, including negative media portrayal: "I've gotten just so many death threats, I'm just sick of it. It's distressing in a way, how the Fox News crowd points to me" (ibid.). Hostility intensified around debates concerning the Baphomet statue—central to TST's challenges to Ten Commandments monuments at two state capitols—where a guest on Don Imus's Fox News programme even suggested that Greaves and others involved in creating the sculpture "should be lined up next to it and shot" (Merlan 2014).

Structural stigma is also reproduced through collective forms of public hostility. When TST held its 10th anniversary SatanCon in Boston 28–30 April 2023, hundreds of demonstrators gathered in Copley Square to protest outside the convention. Protestors carried banners that read "Satan has NO rights!" or "Don't be deceived! Homosexuals, baby killers, idolaters, unbelieving, liars, drunkards, gossips, cowards, thieves, mockers, fornicators: Hellfire awaits" (McColgan 2023). One of the groups that showed up in Boston to protest the Satanic convention was The Patriot Front—a white nationalist group that split off from Vanguard America in the wake of the 2017 Unite the Right rally in Charlottesville, Virginia, that left one person dead and several injured. Wearing their signature khaki pants, baseball caps and white masks, members of the Patriot Front were confronted by counter-protesters in Copley Square, chanting "Nazis, go home". According to Boston police reports, "demonstrators outside SatanCon were peaceful and no-one was arrested". However, a member of TST who attended SatanCon 2023 experienced the atmosphere created by the protesters as dramatic and hostile:

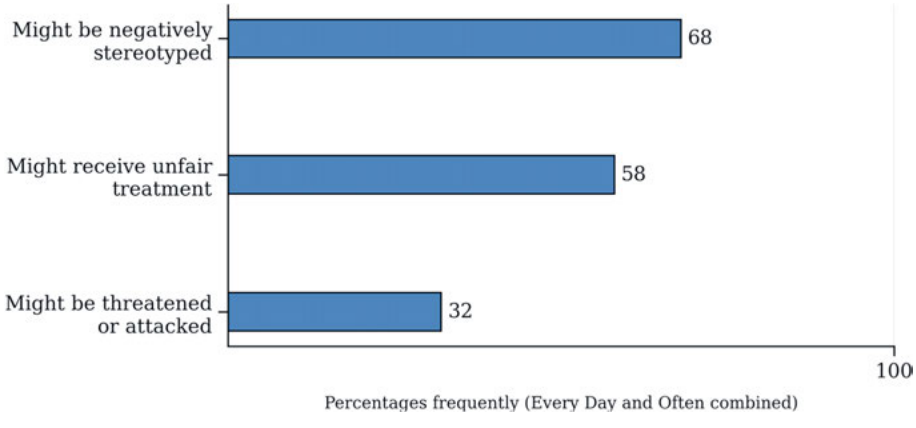
> Another part of the SatanCon was the protesters outside. Some of them seemed almost dangerous, some of them were definitely dangerous, some of them I think are called right-wingers, white supremacists like the Proud Boys or something, that showed up in a group and they were all dressed in the same costumes […] At least one of them was arrested for threatening with a weapon or something. (Interview with K1)

Structural stigma is also expressed through more subtle forms of symbolic discreditation. Greaves is regularly interviewed in national and international media, and journalistic portrayals sometimes rely on imagery that implicitly reproduces stereotypes about Satanism. An article from *The Boston Globe*, for example, describes Greaves in a peculiar way (Quinn 2024). While the overall tone is characterised by curiosity and neutral sentiments towards TST, one quote—strongly focused on the spokesperson's appearance—seems to imply something demonic about him: "He has a striking, almost serpentine face, like his skin might be cold to the touch". Later, reflecting on the disappointingly non-devilish sound of Greaves' real name, the journalist writes: "Greaves has the looks, though, with waxen skin and eyes of different colors, like the devil in *The Master and Margarita*". Some journalists' preoccupation with Greaves' injured eye reveals a lack of sensitivity and risks reinforcing stigmatising framings:

> So, he won't say his real name, or much about his childhood… or why his eye is messed up, beyond saying it's an injury. But, in a symbol of how big his temple has gotten and how much blood the temple has boiled, a few Twitter users think they know why Lucien's eye is off. A prophecy in Islam says the false messiah—the Dajjal—will be blind in his right eye. (Capps 2019)

Figure 10. How often, if ever, do you worry that the following might happen because of your engagement with TST?

Source: The Satanic Temple Survey 2024.



Anticipated Stigma

Among participants in TST, lived experiences of stigma are complex and depend on the specific social context. In addition to awareness of external stigmatising narratives, stigma may also be anticipated in everyday situations (see Figure 10). To explore this dimension, three survey items address how frequently respondents worry about being negatively affected because of their engagement with TST. All 136 respondents answered these items on anticipated stigma. Reflecting on how often they worry that they "might be threatened or attacked", 68% report low levels of concern (including 52% who worry about this rarely and 16% never), while 32% express elevated concern (27% reporting that they worry often, and 5% every day). Regarding the possibility of receiving "unfair treatment", the distribution of responses indicates greater concern: 58% state that they worry about this (of which 45% often and 13% every day) while 42% report lower levels of concern (34% rarely, and 8% never). More subtle forms of stigmatisation seem to constitute the most frequently reported concern. When asked whether they worry that they "might be negatively stereotyped", 68% express frequent concern (47% often and 21% every day), whereas 32% report lower levels of concern (26% rarely and 6% never).

These patterns indicate that, among respondents engaged with TST, anticipated stigmatisation is more prominent in relation to negative stereotyping and unfair treatment than to fears of physical harm. Comments help to understand how specific social environments shape concerns about stigma-driven discrimination. In professional settings, several respondents describe experiences of discrimination or express concern about potential repercussions if their affiliation with TST is known. For example:

> I did face some religious discrimination at my previous workplace because of involvement in TST.

> I already have been [negatively stereotyped] in my place of work, [I] received a very negative reaction from the local town administrator (I'm a town department head).

These individual concerns are often amplified by the socio-political climate on local, state or national level. Respondents living in politically conservative areas describe heightened anxiety. One account presents a politically-conservative environment as openly hostile:

> We live in a very 'red' area… full of people that want anyone who isn't a straight, white, Christian 'put to the sword', for lack of a better phrase.

In contrast, another respondent notes the relative safety of living in a liberal state, but still acknowledges limits to their public activism:

> Illinois currently has a liberal-leaning governor, making it safer than most states… However, if I were initiating other campaigns on the local level, I would not feel safe.

Some respondents experience national discourse in the US as exclusionary and misrepresentative of their religion, suggesting that structural stigma influences who is entitled to religious recognition. During interviews, I asked TST members to reflect on how Satanism is portrayed in popular culture and public discourse. Several voices expressed fatigue and disheartenment at portrayals perceived as reductive and sensationalist, contributing to persistent structural stigma:

> It's often portrayed as something dark and sinister, which is frustrating, to say the least. I know it's public fear-mongering. (Interview with K8)

> I am weary of Satanism being portrayed as evil, or short-sighted shock-value rebellion. I have explained Satanism to so many people that it's hard to keep patience with the exercise. (Interview with K3)

Especially in Christian-dominated contexts, the social cost of being a Satanist is experienced as a continuous struggle against prevailing norms and stigmatising attitudes. One interviewee articulates this tension vividly:

> That's the biggest fight I think we, not just as TST, but as Satanists as a whole have—this fight to say, "You don't get to tell us how we live our life". If I choose not to believe in God, if I choose to believe that we can be compassionate, empathetic, and just without some moral code [enforced] by this non-existent being, what should you care? As long as I'm not breaking the law, as long as I'm not invading in your privacy […] what do you care what I do? For me, that's the basic, simple, social thing that we're shooting for—just let me be me! Don't tell me I have to be a Christian. (Interview with K11)

For some, the experience of stigma-driven religious harassment predates their involvement with TST. One participant recounts the consequences of simply not being Christian during their youth:

> When I was little, the social consequences of being out, not even as a Satanist, just as not Christian, were pretty high. The last two years […] in high school, I didn't have any friends because I faced such relentless religious bullying, where people were doing prayer circles outside my locker, putting Bible class brochures in my locker, following me around and praying at me. I also had people praying at me and telling me I was going to burn in hell when I was in middle school. I know, it sounds ridiculous. (Interview with K5)

Lived Stigma

Another aspect that relates to experiences of stigma concerns how TST participants perceive treatment in relation to identity markers such as gender,

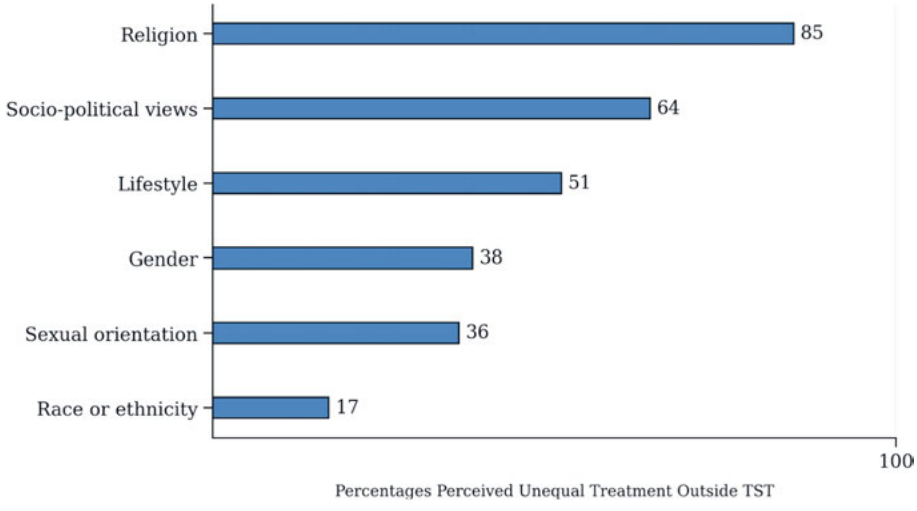
sexuality, race or ethnicity, socio-political views, religion, and lifestyle. The survey results provide insight into these experiences, both in contexts within TST and in wider society. Within TST, reported experiences of unequal treatment are minimal. Across different identity markers, agreement that respondents receive equal treatment is nearly unanimous.[47] In terms of religion (other than TST), half of respondents mark the question as not applicable, likely reflecting the absence of a religious affiliation apart from TST. Among those for whom the item applies (n = 67), 93% agree that they receive equal treatment, while 7% disagree. One respondent feels that "[t]here is a strong anti-religion in TST". Another reflects on their experiences in TST contexts, in relation to gender, race and lifestyle:

> There are individuals that have exhibited some implicit gender bias, however, this is far less common in this community, in my personal experience, than in the larger community. I will say, as one of few non-white members of my congregation, I have never felt discriminated against, but I definitely don't always feel seen, or rather I feel that there are parts of my experience as a human that many congregation members can't relate to. In my experience, this community is far more affirming of lifestyles that some people consider 'alternatives' as part of the normal fabric of humanity. The congregation members I have interacted with, in general, have been more willing to learn [about] and less afraid of people who are different from them. They have also been more cognizant of people who may have trauma, neurodivergencies, or other reasons that they may experience the world differently than other people compared to many of the other spaces I've been in.

[47] Agreement (combining completely agree and mostly agree): gender, 100% (n = 131); sexual orientation, 100% (n = 131); lifestyle, 99% (n = 131); race or ethnicity, 98% (n = 130); and socio-political views, 98% (n = 132). Applicable responses only.

Figure 11. Perceived unequal treatment outside TST by identity aspect. Percentages of respondents selecting Mostly disagree or Completely disagree to the item "Thinking generally about your experiences outside the TST community, how much do you agree with the following statement: I feel that I receive equal treatment in relation to my …" Not applicable responses excluded.

Source: The Satanic Temple Survey 2024.



By contrast, reflecting on their experiences outside TST (see Figure 11), respondents to whom the question applies most frequently report unequal treatment in relation to their religion, including affiliation with TST (n = 124; 85%) and socio-political views (n = 135; 64%):

> I have to be cautious about how I present my political beliefs unless I'm prepared to argue with someone; I've been told outright that someone wanted to run me over with their truck. If I am in public expressing my religion, I get active verbal outbursts from strangers and people I interact with going about errands.

> I've never experienced prejudice due to my involvement with TST, but that's because I keep it under wraps.

In relation to lifestyle[48] (n = 130), 51% report unequal treatment. Reflecting on their gender (n = 134) and sexual orientation (n = 130), 38% and 36% respectively report they feel that they do not receive equal treatment. In terms of race or ethnicity, experiences appear comparatively more positive, yet 17%

[48] 'Lifestyle' was not defined in the survey and was therefore subject to respondents' individual interpretations. Comments indicate that some respondents associate it with disability or mental health-related issues.

(n = 130) still report unequal treatment. In the comments several reflections address the notion of white privilege, for example:

> I am, by 'normal' social standards, a complete weirdo, but I'm white so I do get that privilege.

Observations at a local congregation in New England gave insight into the complex interplay between Satanist identity, stigma and parenting practice. As a host of an online parenting group for Satanists, a member of the local community to whom I spoke expressed a liberal approach to child education that emphasises personal freedom and religious tolerance. Her parenting philosophy rejects physical punishment and embraces liberal gender expression, aligning with progressive child-rearing practices and the shared values of TST. However, her parenting experience reveals the persistent stigma associated with Satanism, partly because it intersects with atheism. Despite efforts to maintain an open and inclusive household, she shared that her family faces social repercussions. Some parents have restricted their children's interactions with her daughter, allowing her to visit their homes but not reciprocating. This selective social exclusion, the mother feels, stems from her known atheist conviction. Interestingly, this congregant navigates a delicate balance between openness about her Satanic identity, evident in her visible Baphomet tattoo, and a non-proselytising approach. This extends to her daughter's religious education, where she promotes religious tolerance and freedom of choice. The child's participation in both Episcopalian services with her grandmother and Satanic gatherings with her parents demonstrates a commitment to religious pluralism, highlighting the ongoing challenges Satanists face in reconciling their religious identity with social expectations, particularly in the context of parenting.

Personal stories of TST participants reveal how rural settings in the US can intensify experiences of stigma. Accounts, shared in a service titled "Bucolic Satanism" (21 March 2023), illustrate how Satanists navigate social hostility, scrutiny, and intersectional marginalisation. They describe developing personal strategies to manage and reframe their stigmatised identities. A service participant recounts the cultural shock of moving to a rural county and the personal dilemma between staying at an ideal job or relocating to a more populated, liberal, and diverse area:

> I went to school in St. Louis, [which I] somehow finished by the grace of Satan. And I was offered a great opportunity at one of the nation's best facilities for my line of work for my internship, which was located in a small rural town of a population of maybe 10,000 or so residents. Definitely more corn and cows than residents in my county. […] I was torn between working in one of the top forensic facilities in the nation or doing what I'd always dreamed of, fleeing to the coast, getting out of Missouri and to a major liberal city in a blue state. I wanted to live a life of youthful chaos, going to shows, clubs, [and enjoying a]

> nightlife of people, diversity. I found such great freedom and anonymity in large major cities. (“Bucolic Satanism”, 21 March 2023)

This longing for urban anonymity contrasts sharply with the hypervisibility they experienced at the rural setting. The minister describes being subjected to stigma and ridicule due to their goth style and visible Satanic symbols:

> The staring from locals, bad attitudes, the old cliché “Wasn’t Halloween months ago?” Harassment, especially from creepy older white men. I still remember vividly the panic attack that I had after being followed and threatened by a large man just because the clothes I was wearing had some spooky and maybe Satanic imagery on it. Yelling sexual obscenities to me as he followed me to my car when I was grocery shopping alone. (“Bucolic Satanism”, 21 March 2023)

Here, stigma is not only religious but also gendered, producing a layered experience of vulnerability. The minister’s response to such encounters reflects a form of stigma management through withdrawal and reinterpretation of community. In a sermon-like reflection, they articulate a strategy of a privatised utopia as a self-help plan, stressing their own agency:

> This was my choice to stay in a rural town where me being outed as a Satanist will probably cost me my job and maybe even my life on a bad day. I can either fight the outcomes of that choice or I can make the best of it. If I can’t have my diverse neighbourhood, well, then give me no neighbours at all. If I can’t have a community garden or vegan cafe, give me my own farm full of homegrown, real, farm-to-table vegetables. If I can’t have a dog park and likeminded friends, give me my own dogs, along with cats, pet spiders, snakes, pigs that you saw, goats. Let the cows be my neighbours. Let the deer who rot behind my house be my friends. Let the coyotes be my neighbourhood entertainment. (“Bucolic Satanism”, 21 March 2023)

Socio-economic security as a reason for “ending up in the corn” and the emphasis on personal agency are recurrent themes in several testimonies—likewise the experiences of challenges when trying to adapt socially to the rural context. One participant recounts being perceived as an outsider not specifically due to Satanism, but simply as a newcomer:

> There was one cop. […] He thought I was a Russian spy. They pulled me over the first time I went to drive into my house. They pulled me over in the parking lot of my house in the driveway. And he was like, “What are you doing here?” And I’m like, “I live here”. And the only ID I had was a passport. And he was like, “Why do you have a passport?” [I replied] “I don’t know, I travel”. And he seriously thought I was a Russian spy for a while. And he asked me that outright. (“Bucolic Satanism”, 21 March 2023)

Another service participant located in the American South reveals how multiple marginalised identities—queerness, neurodivergence, and religious identity—compound the experience of stigma:

> I grew up not realizing I was queer and not realizing I was autistic. And both of those things were hard as shit to deal with out here, in the fucking woods of East Texas. ("Bucolic Satanism", 21 March 2023)

These accounts encapsulate the intersectional nature of stigma. They also point to the temporal dimension of stigma management, as individuals often undergo delayed processing of their experiences due to the oppressive social environment. Faced with life as Satanists in hostile social contexts, participants in the service describe a range of stigma management strategies. Some develop "a thick skin" to cope with everyday challenges or adopt tactical approaches to stigma exposure. The desire to create a supportive community is strong; for some, becoming Satanist has helped deconstruct harmful social norms and embrace the positive aspects of rural life. Others choose not to be openly Satanic in order to stay safe. The service discussion highlights the importance of self-care, community engagement for progressive causes, and finding allies with similar values—even if they are not Satanists. These individual experiences resonate within the broader TST community. The inclusion of "Hellbillies: Visible Satanism in Rural America" as a theme during the second SatanCon in 2023 reflects a collective effort to articulate and confront the challenges faced by rural Satanists. The following section explores additional strategies used by TST participants, both individually and as a community, to address hostile attitudes.

5.2.2 Stigma Management

Reflexive Engagement With Stigma

Among TST participants, awareness of stigmatising narratives appears to foster a reflexive engagement with structural stigma. Through media engagement and public events, TST's leadership works to demystify its beliefs, aiming to promote understanding and acceptance. At the organisational level, TST actively confronts structural stigma through curated reading lists that serve both educational and ideological purposes. On the group's official website, the recommended reading under the History of Satanism section includes academic and popular literature that critically examines the SRAS phenomenon. By foregrounding these works, TST educates its members and the public about the socio-historical construction of stigma surrounding Satanism and reclaims narrative agency. This strategy aligns with its broader activist ethos, exposing the mechanisms of moral panic and engaging in institutional stigma management through counter-discourse dedicated to reason. I refer to this strategy as stigma subversion through the strategic deployment of scientific legitimacy.

Part of the community's effort to counteract structural stigma is performative, for example through the recitation of TST's invocation, which includes the exhortation: "Let us demand that individuals be judged for their concrete actions, not their fealty to arbitrary social norms and illusory categorizations". As a performative rejection of dominant classificatory schemes that position Satanists as deviant, this exhortation is used both in communal settings, such as the service openings, and in broader public fora where it also serves TST's activism for religious pluralism. A notable example occurred in July 2016 when David Suhor, co-founder of TST West Florida, delivered the invocation before the Pensacola City Council (Pensacola City Council Invocation n.d.). His appearance was met with vocal protest from audience members while the council president's response "We cannot!" signalled alignment with the protestors' disapproval, illustrating the persistence of structural stigma in a state-sanctioned public forum. By singing the Satanic invocation in the musical guise of Malotte's 1935 composition for the Lord's Prayer, Suhor challenged established assumptions about which religious voices could legitimately occupy civic space. In Rancière's terms, this performative aesthetic engagement with structural stigma unsettles the structured distribution of the sensible, or the habitual way of being.

To examine how engagement with structural stigma is reflected among individuals in TST, the present study assessed awareness of and attitudes towards SRAS and QAnon. Results from the survey suggest that awareness of SRAS is relatively high, with 62% of respondents reporting they have heard or read a lot about it, 27% a little, and 11% nothing at all (n = 136). Awareness of QAnon is also widespread, with 50% having heard a lot, 46% a little, and only 4% nothing at all (n = 136). When asked about their attitudes, respondents to whom the questions applied express overwhelmingly negative views toward both phenomena. SRAS is considered a very bad thing for the country by 92%, and a somewhat bad thing by 8% (n = 119). Similarly, QAnon is viewed as very bad by 95%, and somewhat bad by 4% (n = 128).

Survey respondents emphasise that SRAS was based on misinformation, pseudoscience, and propaganda, thus engaging in stigma subversion. There is consensus that the alleged abuse was fabricated, as one respondent notes: "I don't think the thing actually existed. But the scare is bad". A recurring theme is the trauma and injustice inflicted upon innocent individuals:

> The results of the SRA scare involved traumatising innocent people, incarcerating innocent people, empowering people with harmful personal agendas, empowering law enforcement with tactics that would inordinately target innocent people, and creating an environment of paranoia around innocent activities that still ripple through our culture.

Several comments highlight how fear was weaponised to serve socio-political agendas, particularly Christian-dominant narratives, thus implying that SRAS

and QAnon function to perpetuate structural stigma. As one respondent notes, "[e]veryone thinks we eat babies and think the devil is real and we worship him like they do their gods". Reflecting on the effects of these stigma theories is not solely a cognitive process; it seems to be intertwined with emotional responses. Some express frustration that SRAS continues to affect society and perceptions of TST. One respondent warns: "We haven't come clean from that so it still *concerns* me". Another notes the resurgence of similar moral panics, stating: "It's *frightening* to see these unfounded fears rising again" (italics are mine). Some assert that the foundational principals of TST are antithetical to the behaviours alleged during the panic, calling the association a "travesty that demands reparations". Respondents draw direct parallels between the SRAS and QAnon. While distinct in historical context, respondents perceive both phenomena as manifestations of moral panic, misinformation, and socio-political manipulation, tangibly harming individuals and society. QAnon is described as "stupid and dangerous", "cultlike" and "nuts", promoting reliance on pseudoscience and propaganda, such as COVID denialism and anti-mask rhetoric. Both SRAS and QAnon are seen as tools of right-wing authoritarianism. As reflexive engagement with structural stigma, such views signal a desire to reclaim moral legitimacy and distance the group from historical falsehoods, constituting a strategy of stigma subversion through counter-discourse.

One interviewee implies that the structural stigmatisation of Satanism and sex work operate through similar conspiratorial logics. Both are framed as morally deviant and socially dangerous, often through fabricated claims of secret networks and ritual abuse:

> There're a lot of conspiracy theories that overlap both Satanism and sex work, like secret cabals are sex trafficking people for Satan or whatever. It's ridiculous. But it's, unfortunately, common enough that it does impact law. The original anti-trafficking law in the US used to be called the White Slave Traffic Act and was based on a whole conspiracy about men of colour trafficking white women and girls out of ice cream parlours, which if you change ice cream to pizza, it's just Pizzagate. It's almost identical. You know, the QAnon Pizzagate stuff is very much tied in with Satanic Panic. There's like a lot of overlap there. (Interview with K5)

Awareness of stigma linked to conspiratorial ideas surrounding Satanism can be present even among individuals who, due to their gender, race, and sexual orientation, rarely experience stigmatisation, as a survey comment implies:

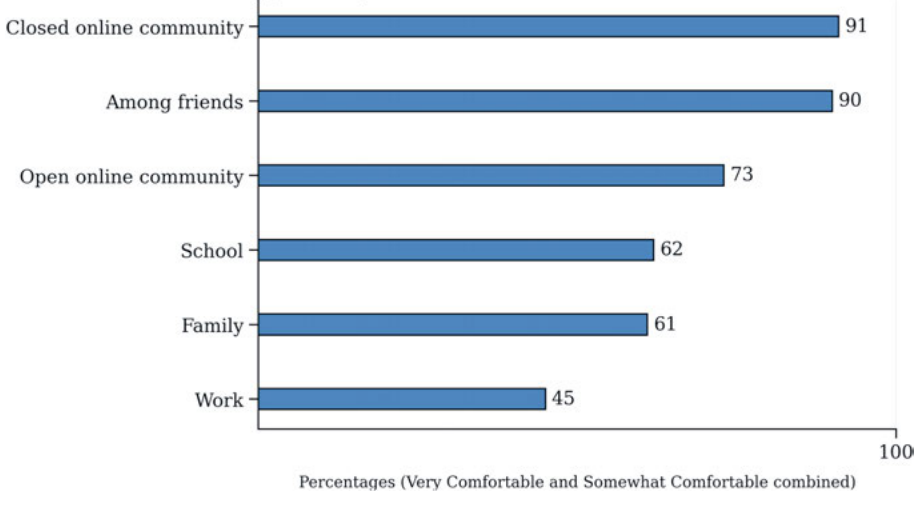
> I'm a 6'3" cis-het white dude, so discrimination is pretty rare for me. I do have a neighbour who believes in Satanic ritual abuse, and I am aware of extremist organizations in my city and nationally that do not like us.

Information Control

Anticipated stigma can shape how individuals navigate their social environments, influencing decisions around disclosure. A central strategy for managing anticipated stigma among respondents is information control through selective disclosure of their Satanic identity. The survey asked respondents how comfortable they are to 'come out' as Satanists in different settings. The results offer insight into the social boundaries and spaces that structure identity expression. In closed online communities, comfort at being out as a Satanist is highest: among respondents for whom the item is relevant (n = 132), 91% report feeling comfortable (70% very; 21% somewhat comfortable), and 10% uncomfortable (2% very; 8% somewhat). Among friends, comfort is similarly high: about 90% report being comfortable (67% very; 22% somewhat), and 10% uncomfortable (2% very; 8% somewhat) (n = 134). In open online communities, 73% report feeling comfortable (37% very; 36% somewhat) and 27% uncomfortable (9% very; 18% somewhat) (n = 131). In school settings, 62% report feeling comfortable (45% very; 17% somewhat) and 38% uncomfortable (27% very; 11% somewhat) (n = 66). Within family settings, 61% report feeling comfortable (45% very; 16% somewhat) and 39% uncomfortable (19% very; 20% somewhat) (n =132). Notably, at work, discomfort outweighs comfort: 45% report feeling comfortable (22% very; 23% somewhat), and 55% uncomfortable (36% very; 19% somewhat) (n = 119).

Figure 12. How comfortable do you feel or would you feel to 'come out' as a Satanist in the following contexts? Only applicable responses.

Source: The Satanic Temple Survey 2024.



These results suggest that friendships and closed digital spaces are perceived as the safest relational environments for identity expression. Open online contexts seem to invite a slightly more cautious approach, though comfort is still high. While these insights support Possamai's suggestion that online environments can facilitate experimentation with religious identities by reducing the effects of stigma (see 1.4.1), they also indicate that it is important to distinguish between different kinds of online spaces. Moreover, the decision to be 'out' as a Satanist is rarely binary, as the survey comments reveal. Instead, it unfolds across a spectrum of visibility choices, shaped by perceived risks in each social context.[49] Some respondents embrace full visibility: one states, "I'm 100% out as a Satanist and have been since my teens", and another affirms, "I am openly a Satanist in all of these contexts". Such accounts suggest a confident and unapologetic stance—the state of grace, in Goffman's words, where discreditable identity is seamlessly integrated into everyday life. Some use their social privilege in terms of race and gender to be more publicly visible and thus resist structural stigma. As a service participant declares:

> Part of the reason why I do my as much as I can to be out and as a Satanist in my local community is because I am a six-foot-three white dude. I'm going to wield that privilege like a club. ("Canadian Satanism", 28 January 2024)

On the other end of the 'outness spectrum' are accounts that challenge the idea of visibility as a meaningful or appropriate goal. The disclosure etiquette these individuals articulate does not frame religious identity per se as something to be publicly asserted, but rather as something that belongs to specific, contextually relevant domains. For example, one respondent writes: "[To] come out in my opinion is being loud and proud about something—I do not think religion takes place in being loud and proud". Another echoes this: "As a general rule, I don't find it necessary or appropriate for people to share their religion unless it is relevant to something they are actively involved in or will impact them in some way". Others express a dialogue-based disclosure etiquette: "I welcome the opportunity to discuss," and "I don't see a need in 'coming out' as a Satanist, but I don't shy away from it if asked". Several respondents describe concealing their affiliation with TST to avoid negative consequences:

> I am not open about my religious views to everyone because of the highly likelihood that I could be stereotyped negatively, treated unfairly, and potentially threatened physically or financially… I currently use a pseudonym when interacting online and in person as a Satanist.

[49] In response to the question "How open are you about your affiliation?", Holt's (2022) results indicate varied disclosure practices among CoS members, with a general tendency towards caution. Approximately 68% report being very private, disclosing only to close contacts, or sharing their affiliation selectively, while around 32% describe themselves as more openly affiliated, including 4% who identify as public spokespersons of CoS. This suggests that disclosure is context-dependent, with affiliation often kept private in professional settings.

Another respondent notes the limits of disclosure in everyday life: "We are not open about being members of TST in our day-to-day lives, except to a few people or in very few circumstances". For some, the tension between public and private identity is shaped by their role within the organisation:

> I straddle the line between public and private Satanist, due to my role within the organization. I am honestly surprised that I haven't had a major incident yet as a result of my public involvement.

Familial settings present more ambivalent conditions for disclosure. The fear of negative reactions from close relatives is a recurring theme: "I am not 'out' because I know how one family member would react". Disclosure decisions are often guided by a desire to preserve relational harmony. One respondent shares how they control information about their Satanic identity in different relationships:

> A few of my relatives know of my involvement in TST, and have no issue with it, but my parents don't know. I asked a couple of softball questions about their views on Satanism and received a moderately negative response of a somewhat religious kind, which I found odd as neither of them had expressed any recent interest in religion at the time that I'd asked, so I left it at that. As for friends, it depends on the friends. I'm very comfortable with discussing it with some, but not with others.

This account illustrates a disclosure etiquette that is situation-sensitive and adaptive, shaped by considerations about close relationship ties and emotional safety. Another respondent reflects on the emotional calculations involved:

> Some religious family and family friends would react very negatively and I value amicable relationships with them more than my need to express all aspects of my identity to them.

As already mentioned, professional settings stand out as the only contexts where discomfort outweighs comfort. Several respondents share how they engage in strategic information control at work. One takes a straightforward approach: "Most people who know me, including co-workers, know I am a Satanist". Another respondent expresses an acute sense of vulnerability: "I know for almost certain that I'd be unfairly & illegally fired if my workplace found out I was involved in TST, despite my high performance & ratings & completely safe & sterling character". A public-school teacher takes a more complex approach to their visibility: "Many of my colleagues are aware of my involvement in TST and Satanism, but if the greater community of parents and students were to find out, it would likely be disastrous to my career". Considerations about employment can also influence the negotiation of identity disclosure in other settings beyond work:

> I'm using a pseudonym in those closed or open online spaces. I don't want someone's terrible assumptions about my religious beliefs to affect my ability to stay employed.

> I already have been [negatively stereotyped] in my place of work, received a very negative reaction from the local town administrator (I'm a town department head). I do worry about if I should be as public as to have my religion on my social media as TST like I currently do, or if I should remove it.

These accounts suggest that selective disclosure functions as a protective mechanism, allowing individuals to navigate social environments and minimise exposure to stigma. Respondents express varying degrees of identification with TST and its cause. For some, strong identification leads to open defiance of stigma: "I want to be the rebel… I will always be who I am no matter what people think or do, and I won't hide it". Others align with the values of TST but choose not to adopt the label Satanist due to its stigmatic associations: "I understand the reasons for the name, but personally don't want to be stigmatized as a 'Satanist'. I do align with all the tenets, but do not identify with the label of Satanist, so I remain an ally".

These variations in disclosure and identification reflect a spectrum of stigma management strategies, shaped by personal, relational, and contextual factors. In response to persistent structural stigma, some members adopt strategies that reframe Satanism as a positively oriented worldview, rather than one defined by opposition or reaction. A minister reflects on this approach:

> My Satanism is not dependent on other people's perception of me. I get concerned when we are being actively demonized. […] But from a day-to-day thing, my concern isn't how Satanism is portrayed. It's how those outside of the hegemonic values are portrayed. That includes me. But very rarely do I think about how people think about Satanism. I am very proud that there are people that will stand up and defend us. And I know that people are going to not understand us and demonize us at the same time. I'm not worried about that. Because my Satanism is built around positive Satanic values. I have specific values I uphold. Being in opposition to others doesn't bother me. So, I don't really care what they think. (Interview with K2)

Within TST, stigma management is not merely an individual undertaking but a socially constructed and collectively negotiated process. Disclosure etiquette is negotiated in relation to both the risks of being publicly identified as a Satanist and the political potential of visibility. Strategies such as adopting 'satanyms' in physical and online spaces are developed and refined through community dialogue in the services. In an episode devoted to Satanic pseudonyms, a minister links the adoption of alternative names to growing concerns about digital visibility and privacy ("What's in a Name? Satanic Pseudonyms", 4 July 2023). A service participant explains that the decision to use a satanym

is motivated not only by concerns for their own safety but also by a desire to protect loved ones from possible negative consequences:

> For me, it's […] to kind of ensure safety and privacy—not only of myself, but of my family and those around me, because I don't want that attachment to have to become an issue for my parents or my sister, or my children, or anybody else that I know. […] it's also an issue of like keeping […] separation between different worlds […]. I have a professional world and then I also live in the fetish world. […] I do have friends on my regular non-Satan social media who are […] Christians and what I would consider like the good Christians. […] just because we do have the right to offend other people doesn't mean that we should.[50] So, I try to keep that […] social media a little more vanilla. ("What's in a Name? Satanic Pseudonyms", 4 July 2023)

The discussion also complicates the idea of pseudonymity as concealment of one's 'true' identity. Several participants describe their satanyms as enabling forms of self-expression that feel more authentic than those associated with their legal names:

> [A]nytime I come home from somewhere that I've been with my congregation or my friends who call me [satanym] […] and I have to go back to not being [satanym] feels more like putting on a mask to me now than it does the other way around. ("What's in a Name? Satanic Pseudonyms", 4 July 2023)

> I totally unmask when I'm [satanym] versus using my government name. […] I only go by my government name when I absolutely have to. […] I feel more comfortable to express myself under my assumed identity of [satanym]. ("What's in a Name? Satanic Pseudonyms", 4 July 2023)

Disclosure decisions, including whether to use a legal name or an alias, are shaped by assessments of anticipated stigma in particular social settings. Maintaining a separation between Satanic and non-Satanic identities is presented as requiring continuous awareness:

> I'm always a little bit cognizant […] there are people here [a city name] who know me by my government name who might frequent the same establishments that we do as TST. So, I'm always, kind of in the back of my head, like keeping my eye out, […] being a little bit careful. If we're in somewhere private, like if we're out doing our initiations or whatever, somewhere where we're not going to be in public, then I can be a lot more myself. ("What's in a Name? Satanic Pseudonyms", 4 July 2023)

Through collective discussions of satanyms and disclosure, TST participants develop shared understandings of how to navigate stigma while adapting these strategies to specific circumstances. Thus, stigma management becomes a site

[50] This is a reference to the first part of Tenet 4: "The freedoms of others should be respected, including the freedom to offend".

of alignment—between individual and collective concerns, strategies, and notions of authenticity. TST also addresses the challenges of stigma through practices of community care.

Community Care

The profound effects of stigma at both organisational and personal levels prompt ongoing efforts to manage and resist stigmatisation through community care. In response to the arson attack on the headquarters in Salem in June 2022, TST members and ministers engaged in collective emotional processing in an episode of Minister Mondays (14 July 2022). This conversation reveals the complex emotional impact of stigma on the community. Participants express a range of emotions, including anger, sadness, and frustration, but also gratitude. One minister notes, "gratefulness that this could have been so much worse […] we could have lost the building, we could have lost human life". The discussion highlights the harm caused by the attack; beyond the physical and financial costs, one minister points out the "emotional damage" experienced by the community. Another minister's emotional account underscores the personal toll of such stigma-driven violence:

> I've cried a couple of times about it when I got home because, you know, we should be celebrating that moment and celebrating that we had such a successful Pride event and that we have all of these things, that we were watching this amazing programme and doing all this incredible stuff, and instead I'm [cleaning up] broken glass. [Crying] It's hard. I guess I'm not OK and that's OK. (Minister Mondays, 14 July 2022)

Anger is expressed at the suggestion by a conspiracy theorist that TST set the fire itself to gain money and attention. A minister who wasn't near the headquarters at the time of the arson attack shares feeling powerless at being unable to help. The conversation also reveals how the community grapples with broader societal attitudes. The arson attack is related to mass shootings and other violent events in the US. Fear is expressed that people in America have become indifferent, while others express concern that the emotional impact will be deeper and stronger after the initial shock and might demotivate the community. In response to the arsonist's use of Bible pages and the US Constitution in the attack, one minister emphasises, "this guy doesn't speak on behalf of all Christians and he doesn't speak on behalf of people who believe in the constitution". There is also gratitude for the support of Salem as a local host society. This emotional Minister Mondays episode serves as a form of community care, allowing members to process trauma collectively and reinforce their solidarity.

Community care also includes practical efforts to reduce members' exposure to stigma-related risks. A service devoted to "Security and Cyber Defense" (25 July 2023) provides advice on security measures, adapted to one's

level of public visibility within the movement and personal circumstances. Participants discuss strategies such as creating a satanym, managing digital footprints, practicing situational awareness, obtaining first-aid training and where necessary, varying daily routines to reduce risks. Large community gatherings such as SatanCon are described as situations requiring precautionary measures, captured in the advice to "go chameleon incognito":

> A big Satanic event draws a lot of eyes. They have protesters, there are people outside of the front doors and one of the ways in which to keep yourself safe is perhaps wear […] clothing over the top of your Satanic clothing just to get your ass in through the door and to remain incognito […]. Then once you get there, throw the trench coat away and flash your true self. ("Security and Cyber Defense", 25 July 2023)

The discussion is informed by members' experiences of the consequences of public disclosure. One service participant shares having been involuntarily outed by someone they trusted, resulting in legal action restricting contact with their child. By providing a forum for exchanging experiences, the service episode constitutes a practical form of community care aimed at helping members navigate potential risks associated with a stigmatised Satanic identity. Such initiatives are consistent with TST's broader support infrastructure. For example, Thee Satanic Advice Hotline provides members with opportunities to seek help and advice from fellow Satanists. TST also has its own security group, Cerberus Satanic Security Services, which conducts online threat monitoring and assists campaign and congregation leaders in planning safe events.

The relationship between stigma and Satanic identity constitutes an important dimension of TST's assemblage. As the analysis suggests, stigma management is both an individual undertaking and a collective process, contributing to the formation of communal bonds and a sense of cohesion. How these and other alignment dynamics shape the movement's communal and organisational life is the focus of the following chapter.

5.3 Summary

The analysis in this chapter suggests that personal Satanic practice is negotiated through interrelated processes of alignment and dealignment that connect individual creativity with shared values, organisational norms, and broader cultural repertoires. Practices in which individuals engage become sites where they selectively incorporate and reinterpret elements from diverse religious and cultural sources while maintaining boundaries against expressions perceived as incompatible with TST's ethos. A rationalist discourse grounded in TST's normative framework functions as a source of legitimacy and a mechanism of boundary maintenance *vis-à-vis* Significant Others. Ministerial

practice constitutes a site where alignment dynamics reflect calibrations between personal commitments, collectively shaped roles, and pragmatic considerations. Blasphemy illustrates the complexity of negotiating Satanic practice in relation to religious traditions, cultural norms, and personal histories in ways that serve different needs and purposes.

Stigma constitutes an important condition under which TST assembles, shaping how Satanic identities are negotiated. Participants respond to tensions arising from structural, anticipated and lived stigma through a variety of strategies, including reflexive engagement with stigmatising narratives, information control, and community care. These strategies suggest that individual responses are intertwined with collective frameworks and resources, strengthening communal bonds and alignment. TST assembles through ongoing dynamics of alignment and tension embedded in participants' negotiations of Satanic practice and stigma.

6. Internal Dynamics and Institutionalisation

> TST is not here to deconstruct Christianity. It's here to construct Satanism. Those are two different things. (Interview with K2)

This chapter addresses the third research question: *How does The Satanic Temple assemble through internal dynamics and institutionalisation?* Building on the preceding analyses of TST's assembling in relation to broader socio-political contexts and through participants' negotiations of Satanic practice and stigma, the chapter shifts attention to the meso level, where alignment and tension shape the movement's communal and organisational life. Two empirical areas structure the analysis. The first examines forms of engagement, patterns of in-group alignment, emotional and aesthetic regimes and their relation to shared values. It further considers the enactment of community through rituals, celebrations and gatherings, including the role of spatial conditions in shaping communal practice. The second empirical area examines how TST navigates institutionalisation and organisational governance, and how the boundaries of activism are negotiated.

6.1 "I Came for the Activism and I Stayed for the Community"

6.1.1 Forms of Participation

TST assembles as a religious movement through diverse modes of engagement. This section examines how members participate in the movement, and how their involvement spans different contexts. Attention is paid to the pathways through which members discover TST, to the duration of their affiliation, and to their interactions with the community.

Responses to the survey item "How did you learn about TST?" (n = 136) suggest that mediated channels play a central role. Digital media appears to be the most common gateway, including social media platforms (26%), news websites or apps (20%), TST's website (12%), documentaries (10%) and podcasts (5%). Traditional media such as television and radio (2% each) appear less influential. Personal connections—friends (9%), family or partner (4%), and co-workers (1%)— also contribute to first encounters. Comments further illustrate this. One respondent notes that "a fellow member of the New York

City Sceptics" introduced them to TST, which can be linked to members' experiences with secularist organisations (see 4.4.3). Another writes, "looking for secular recovery programs, I found Sober Faction, which led me to TST", suggesting that TST's campaigns can function as points of entry. Some respondents also mention discovering TST through community events, indicating that TST's in-person activities contribute to outreach and visibility. An interviewee illustrates how both mediated exposure and interest in specific campaigns may shape an individual's pathway into the movement:

> I first learned about TST when I saw the *Hail Satan?* movie on Netflix a few years ago. I immediately fell in love with the idea of the organization, but didn't pursue joining. Eventually, a few years ago, I was on a sober journey. I didn't like all of the God[-related] aspects of AA and other sobriety programs and learned about TST Sober Faction. So, I joined that. […] It was at that time that I found out about my local congregation and applied to join […] (Interview with K4)

To gain insight into the duration of respondents' involvement, the survey asked: "How long have you been involved with TST?" Relatively recent involvement is common, with 52% (n = 136) reporting engagement for up to three years. Another 35% have participated for four to six years, and 12% for seven or more. Although the data do not prompt any conclusions about causality, it is plausible that increased media visibility and socio-political developments in the US have provided favourable conditions for membership growth in recent years. Two key events stand out in this regard. Firstly, the release of Penny Lane's documentary *Hail Satan?* in 2019 contributed to public awareness of the organisation. Based on survey and interview data, Colin (2021: 306–308) argues that the documentary functioned both as a recruitment tool and as a means of strengthening commitment. Secondly, the US Supreme Court's 2022 decision to overturn Roe v. Wade marked a major rollback of abortion rights, an issue central to TST's activism. Abortion access occupies a prominent place in TST participants' perceptions of social injustice (see 4.2.3), and TST's activism on this issue is considered highly important (see 4.4.1). This convergence of media exposure and political activism might have contributed to an influx of new members.

The nature of participants' engagement with TST varies. Responding to the item "What describes best your involvement with TST?", 44% (n = 136) identify as a "registered member", 4% as a "probationary member", 11% as an "ally but not a member", and 10% as "other". Additional 18% indicate that they serve as a minister, and 13% report holding an "organizational and/or representative role". Comments indicate that respondents may combine multiple roles at various organisational levels:

> Minister & Congregation Head.
>
> Minister, Regional Committee Member, Leadership Council and more.
>
> I have multiple roles. I am a minister and I work for the global organization's Ordination Council. I also answer academic and some media queries.

Interviewees too describe engaging in a range of functions, including serving on committees, leading congregation meetings, helping to organise events for the local community, undertaking one-on-one ministerial work, and providing support or directing congregants to appropriate resources. This pattern of engagement reflects the reality of being a relatively new religious organisation with limited resources. Sustaining its structure and community depends heavily on the voluntary engagement of dedicated members.

Patterns of interaction reflect the organisational structure of TST. When asked, "What is the main way you get involved with TST?", about 41% (n = 136) of respondents report engaging primarily at the local level. An additional 33% indicate that their main engagement occurs at the state level. For 12% involvement with TST happens mainly at the national level, possibly through national campaigns, leadership roles, or digital platforms that connect members across the country. The following reflection suggests that local congregations play a central role in members' involvement and sense of belonging:

> I feel a sense of belonging in my congregation, not through overall [to] TST. I signed up for overall TST first and got my card and certificate… but that was it. No sense of community. When I joined my congregation, that's where I found I fit in and could connect with other people. […] I am solely involved with my local congregation. I don't do anything outside of the local, except for travelling to events from other congregations… which I do with members from my congregation. (Interview with K4)

The most common level of interaction is likely to take place within members' congregational affiliation. In the "Join" section of TST's homepage, three main forms of engagement are presented. One may register on the website to receive email updates or contribute to campaigns through donations. A more active form of involvement directs individuals to a local congregation. According to the contact information available, congregations in the US and Canada typically span an entire state or province (e.g., TST Nebraska, TST Alberta), or in some cases, two adjacent states (e.g., TST New Hampshire and Vermont). There are, however, a few exceptions in which more than one congregation exists within the same state (such as in Texas). Outside North America, congregations are fewer in number and are typically structured either as one congregation per country (e.g., Finland or Germany) or as transnational configurations (TST BeNeLux).

Affiliation with local congregations is thus important for understanding how TST assembles as a religious community. Most survey respondents (91%, n = 133) indicate belonging to a TST congregation, while 9% report no congregational affiliation. This distribution likely reflects the survey's recruitment strategy, which relied on contact with congregations (see 3.2). Eight congregations are represented in the sample, each accounting for at least 5% of respondents, and together these account for approximately 61% of the total. One of these congregations is located in Canada, with the remaining seven spread across the US. About 26% report belonging to congregations in the Northeast region of the US, in line with previously discussed demographic data indicating concentration of TST participants in the Northeast (see 4.1).

Survey results indicate differences between how frequently participants in TST engage online compared to in person.[51] Online interaction is more prevalent, with 64% (n = 134) reporting daily interaction and a further 23% engaging weekly in digital spaces (4% report that they never or almost never interact with TST online). Comments suggest that respondents connect through multiple digital platforms, where they participate in both synchronous and asynchronous communication with community fellows, joining regularly scheduled events as well as spontaneous interactions:

> I try to go to the online TST movie nights that Lucien hosts every Wednesday but have been busy lately.
>
> I have a group of fellow TST members that I meet with almost daily to watch movies and interact with them online on social media.
>
> I attend online meetings with TST's Sober Faction a couple times a week. Online meetings with [local congregation] are every other week.
>
> [...] a monthly online meeting within the congregation, plus near daily interactions with our congregation Discord and Minister Slack.

In-person interaction with TST occurs to varying degrees: 42% (n = 132) report engaging weekly and 7% do so daily. An additional 13% engage monthly and 1% yearly, whereas 21% indicate that they never or almost never interact within TST in person.[52] Local availability and practical obstacles appear to limit participation for some respondents. Health-related issues can also prevent physical attendance, as noted in the following comments:

[51] Item wording*: How often do you interact with TST? – In person; Online*. Response options*: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, Yearly, Never or almost never.*

[52] By comparison, Lewis's Satan Survey 2011–2012 asked *How often do you communicate with other Satanists?* Among those selecting the in-person option, 10% reported daily interaction, 12% weekly, 14% monthly, 13% yearly, and 51% never (Dyrendal et al 2015: 150).

> Due to severe illness, it is not possible to meet in person: I would if I could.
>
> In-person participation reduced during COVID and as result of disability-related mobility issues.

Several respondents describe how logistic barriers such as geographic distance constrain their in-person engagement:

> I try to attend in-person events as much as possible but they're often out of range for me.
>
> I do not know of any fellow TST members locally in my area (to my knowledge, most of my congregation is halfway across my state and not within reasonable driving distance for my family's circumstances).
>
> I live in the United Kingdom and TST Maine is my nearest English-speaking congregation.

Interviewees also report that geographic dispersion poses a significant challenge for congregational community life. With members spread across vast distances, maintaining a sense of togetherness and facilitating regular interaction becomes difficult. Some congregations adopt a hybrid approach, offering regular digital meetings alongside occasional in-person gatherings:

> We don't have as much physical contact as we would like, because we're spread so far throughout the state. (Interview with K11)
>
> For our members that live the furthest away from each other it's a 24-hour drive. […] So, trying to do anything is really, really hard. And that geographic dispersion causes problems. […] A lot of stuff has to be done online. You have to have a large virtual space, which we do—our monthly meetings are online. People can come in from all over, but a lot of people don't want to hang out in Zoom meetings for fun. And I don't blame them. (Interview with K2)
>
> We're primarily online just because it is such a big state. […] But we try to have social meetups as much as we can. And just meeting somewhere to help—pick up trash at a beach, things like that. (Interview with K10)

This pattern also resonates with experiences outside the US. Being a Satanist across the Atlantic often entails a degree of geographical or social isolation from fellow members, as participants in a service describe ("The Satanic Temple in Europe", 18 February 2024); for these members, TST provides a digital network of like-minded individuals:

> Being a lone Satanist is a norm […]. But the opportunity to have a community I can connect with and learn from […] was exactly what I was looking for.

6.1.2 Patterns of Alignment

Building on the analysis of participation patterns, this section examines social trust and perceived value alignment within and beyond TST as factors shaping experiences of cohesion. It also considers related aspects, including emotional responses to TST's socio-political positioning and levels of tolerance for moral ambiguity.

Responding to the survey item: "Most people in the TST community can be trusted", 96% (n = 135) agree (33% completely and 63% mostly agree) and 4% disagree. Comments suggest that social trust is experienced most strongly in relation to the local congregations. In this context, members are more likely to be vetted and to actively engage in interactions with others. TST congregations appear to foster deeper relational bonds and a sense of solidarity, as one respondent notes:

> In regard to [local congregation], we have a pretty amazing connection with each other. There have been many instances where we help each other out whether it be emotionally, physically, or financially. There have also been numerous occasions where members have mentioned feeling more like family.

Respondents emphasise a distinction between trust within congregational contexts and trust in TST more broadly:

> The TST community I'm referring to are the members of local congregations. There is no vetting process for joining the national organization, but the local congregations have a stricter vetting process for joining.

> There is a dramatic difference between people that are national members and people that are registered members with a congregation in both knowledge and involvement. Some national members signed up as a joke or to be a troll, thinking that TST is just "spicy atheist".

> We have similar values at our core, and we make the efforts we do based on that shared set of values. I'd feel comfortable letting most TST members into my home and among my family. […] Most of the people I interact with in the community have been through some measure of vetting, so my sample of TST is among the more active and connected members.

In comparison, when asked to reflect on people outside TST, patterns of social trust among respondents appear more ambivalent. Responding to the statement, "Most people outside the TST community can be trusted", 42% (n = 133) express agreement (all of whom mostly agree, with no respondents completely agreeing), while 58% express disagreement (47% mostly disagree and 11% completely disagree). This suggests, that while TST is experienced as a space of social cohesion and relational safety, there is reluctance to extend trust beyond the boundaries of the community.

A related aspect of in-group cohesion is the perceived value alignment in and outside TST. Survey respondents were asked to evaluate the statement: "Thinking about people within the TST community, they probably share many of my values and goals". The results indicate a very high level of perceived value alignment, with 98% (n = 136) expressing agreement (49% completely agreeing and 49% mostly agreeing) and 2% disagreeing. Perceived value alignment with those outside TST is lower. Responding to the statement "They may feel differently than I do about TST, but they probably share many of my other values and goals", 63% (n = 134) report agreement (7% completely and 56% mostly), while 37% disagree (33% mostly and 4% completely).[53]

To further understand in-group alignment, the survey considered how closely individuals' views align with TST's public stance on religion and secularism—an issue central to the community's visions of a good society (see 4.3.1). In response to the statement "TST represents my views on what role religion should play in the public sphere", 100% (n = 136) express agreement (80% completely and 20% mostly). Similarly, 100% report agreement (87% completely and 13% mostly) with "TST represents my views on whether law and policy decisions should be based on secular or religious grounds". These patterns point to a shared identification with the organisation's public position. Taken together with the high levels of trust in fellow members—particularly those in local congregations—this suggests a cohesive social environment that strengthens alignment within. Notably, despite strong in-group cohesion and value alignment, respondents exhibit a high tolerance for moral ambiguity. Approximately 90% agree that "most things in society are too complicated to be clearly divided into good and evil". Conversely, about 86% reject the statement that "most things in society can be pretty clearly divided between good and evil".

The survey also explored emotional responses to TST's socio-political positioning. Responses to the prompt "Thinking about TST's position on socio-political issues that matter to you, would you say you feel…" signal a markedly different emotional configuration compared to sentiments about the broader national context (see 4.2.1). Here, hope (92%, n = 133) and pride (89%, n = 131) dominate, while fear (11%, n = 132) and anger (12%, n = 131) are marginal. Comments nuance this picture, suggesting that emotions with respect to TST's role as a socially engaged actor can be complex and in some cases challenged by ambivalence and critique. For instance, some respondents articulate strong positive sentiments, framing TST as a driver of change:

> Members of the TST, theistic and non-theistic, are truly dedicated to the sort of socio-political progress that this country desperately needs to be worthy of the global community's respect again.

[53] Several respondents found the phrasing "people outside the TST community" too broad or vague, and preferred a more specific definition. This ambiguity may have influenced responses.

However, other articulations signal caution:

> I'm not fearful or angry, but pride and hope are not things I'm ready to assign. I have concerns about how some things are handled, and only time can show me whether or not we are headed in the right direction.

Reservations or scepticism are related to leadership and their capacity to make change happen, as in:[54]

> TST and executive ministry may not always be right, but their heads and hearts are in the right place and trying to make a positive change and protect people that need it.

> I have come to feel TST is a lot of smoke and mirrors with little impact. Reproductive rights are going backwards.

As this analysis seeks to demonstrate, interrelated factors such as social trust, perceived value alignment, and emotional responses produce cohesion, territorialising the assemblage. To further explore the role of the emotional dimension in shaping the spirit of the community, the following section turns to two emotional regimes.

6.1.3 Coming Home and Satanic Joy

TST members often describe their engagement with TST as akin to 'coming home'—a powerful emotional experience that marks a shift from isolation or marginalisation to a sense of belonging. In such articulations, this feeling is often framed in contrast to previous encounters with other religious or social environments, where they experienced themselves as outsiders or temporary guests. The following interviewee account suggests that TST offers not just a platform for activism, but a space for feeling connected with others:

> When I got involved with The Satanic Temple—I think it was after the second in-person meeting we did—I mentioned to my partner, "This feels like coming home". (Interview with K2)

This brief but poignant statement illustrates how some members reflect on their place within TST through an emotionally charged language. The metaphor of 'home' signals comfort, safety, recognition, and a sense of being understood. Similarly, another interviewee reflects on the contrast between being a guest and feeling at home, underscoring the difference between superficial contact and belonging:

[54] See Section 6.2.1 for a more detailed discussion of different perspectives on leadership.

> I saw there was a group meeting in [a city name]. I'm like, "Oh, well, they have a coffee hour sort of near my house—I might as well just go and see what these people are like". Because I'd never had religious community before, even other Wiccans. I was like, "They really don't like the Satan thing that I'm doing". And I never felt like in community, even in religious settings where I felt welcome. It felt like being a welcomed guest in someone's house. But when I went to that coffee hour and I met people from [a local congregation of TST], it was the most like 'at home' I'd ever felt with strangers before. I immediately felt, "Oh, these are my people!", I immediately felt comfortable with each other on a level I'd never experienced before. (Interview with K5)

Such emotionally charged articulations of belonging are often linked to a shared cultural and ideological foundation. Some members frame TST's core values as resonating with their long-standing personal convictions, even prior to formal involvement with the movement:

> When TST came into existence, I found that it spoke a language that described how I was already living my life. For example, I was a vegetarian for a very long time and then switched to being vegan several years ago. When people asked why I was vegetarian or vegan, I would always say something about how it was part of my religion. At that time, I didn't have any religion, so it was partially a tongue-in-cheek answer, but also felt true as well. When I learned about TST and how the first tenet is about striving to have compassion and empathy for all living creatures in accordance with reason, then I was like "Yeah! Being vegan actually is part of my religion!" (Interview with K4)

> Once I saw the tenets, I was like, "Boom, that's my belief system, that fits my belief system!" And then I became a minister. I just love TST and it's only going away because either I die or they die. (Interview with K11)

Beyond reflecting individual experiences, these accounts can be understood as discursive traces of a collectively cultivated emotional regime. As a socially embedded framework, the emotional regime of feeling 'at home' shapes how members interpret and express their experiences. Importantly, 'coming home' and value alignment (such as the shared commitment to principles articulated in the Tenets) emerge in a dialectical relation. Their interplay serves as a basis for collective identity, contributes to the cultivation of belonging and fosters cohesion that in turn stabilises the assemblage.

'Coming home' is not limited to experiencing alignment on an abstract level—it can also be about forming and sustaining relationships. The following describes how interpersonal connections in some local congregations involve mutual attentiveness and ongoing engagement in one another's lives:

> I am 100% immersed in my TST community, and I wouldn't have it any other way. Pretty much all of my social interactions outside of work and family are with people from TST. […] People know things about my life, and when I see them next time, they will ask how that thing is going that I've been working on. I feel a sense of belonging by knowing these things about other people as

> well and asking them for updates on the things they've been working on. (Interview with K4)

For some members, TST provides a social space where deep connections, bonding, and even romantic relationships flourish, reinforced through value alignment:

> The community aspect is the most important part of TST for me. I feel very close to TST as a member of the community. My local congregation is where I've met a large percentage of my friends and I value our interactions immensely. I've travelled around the nation for different TST events, and always know that even if I don't know anyone, they are going to be good, fun people who share my views. Everywhere I go within TST has been a welcoming, inspirational, safe, and completely enjoyable experience. I met my girlfriend through TST! I have spoken with individuals in TST congregations from other countries, but to a limited degree. (Interview with K3)

This sense of community and belonging can also be experienced as interactions grounded on collective creativity, where relationships are sustained in shared practices. One member describes how their local congregation functions as a platform for positive transformation and collaboration, alleviating individual struggle and prior alienation:

> For a guy like me, before I found TST I was really quite isolated and very unhappy for the most of my life. But now I've found people that have a similar cultural experience like me, a similar kind of self-expression and that means I'm interested in doing more collective work together. So instead of each of us individually, on our own private struggles, isolated out in the wilderness of a society we don't really feel a part of, now we are finding each other together, having conversations and discussions, doing art projects and just generally engaging with self-expression in a forum which is more accepting to who we are. (Interview with K1)

The dialectical relationship between the emotional regime of 'coming home' and value alignment can translate into tangible support. As an interviewee describes, the sense of exceptional trust and being cared for is grounded in the expectation that others will act in accordance with shared principles:

> I'm trying to think of a good word for it. Like, if I needed something, I know that someone would come, right? Even knowing that I live on an island, I know that someone would come. One time we were having issues with our water, and [a person from] my congregation had asked in a way where, I could tell she was going to drive over here if I couldn't get it fixed myself. And that's not always something you get out of every community. It's a very special kind of bond. And just knowing that there are shared values and shared emphasis on compassion and empathy—it's just different. It's a relief! (Interview with K10)

TST is framed as an inclusive social space in which a wide range of identities and experiences are accommodated. This emphasis on inclusivity is central to how belonging is discursively produced. Members locate themselves within a community that legitimises forms of difference that may be stigmatised elsewhere. A minister, speaking during a service, reflects on how the shared values enable the coexistence of diverse identities:

> Our community embraces Black, Indigenous and People of Color. We embrace members of the LGBTQ+ community, members of the kink community, people who are neurodiverse, be they neurodivergent or neurotypical. So many people with so many different backgrounds and experiences! Some might conclude that it is our tenets, the guiding principles of our religion, which explain how our community can be so diverse, yet cohesive. ("Satanic Community", 16 October 2021)

A shared moral framework can enable members to interpret their diverse experiences through a common lens. This dynamic can also be understood as facilitating the management of stigmatised identities, insofar as it reduces the anticipatory burden of rejection and creates conditions in which members can present aspects of themselves that might otherwise be marginalised (see also 5.1). One interviewee contextualises their engagement with TST in relation to prior experiences of marginalisation linked to their identity:

> I've always been different. I've always been somewhat rebellious and adversarial. Being a queer person raised in a religious environment, I questioned the religious culture of my upbringing. (Interview with K4)

Similarly, another interviewee emphasises how shared values create a social environment in which vulnerability, imperfection, and personal choices can be shared without fear of rejection:

> I think part of it was just having a group of people that had these shared foundational values and not just basic stuff. Because I've had arguments with other left-wing progressive people before. But just having a series of written values of compassion, and empathy, and reason, and forgiveness… Not just "Oh, you have to forgive someone" but "No, you make a mistake—you have to do work to make up for what mistakes you've made". All of that, being codified and knowing that everyone shares that perspective together, gave us at least a foundation of "Okay, I can make mistakes in front of these people because they will allow me to make mistakes, they will allow me to make up for it". If I make a mistake, and then do my best to rectify any harm, they've already agreed in advance—that's beliefs [sic] we have in common. Or, if I say, "Oh, I don't believe in this thing for whatever scientific reason", we've already established that science is a basis. Or if I'm like, "Okay, I want to get gender affirming surgery", we've all already agreed that it's my body—I can do what I want with it. […] It's one thing to know that we share those values and another thing to actually experience having a conversation under it and be like, "Oh, okay, they're admitting mistakes and I'm admitting mistakes and this is fine". Not

> feeling like, "Okay, these are some strangers, I have to figure out if they're going to dislike some fundamental part of me". (Interview with K5)

Importantly, articulations of 'coming home' can also be found in TST's mediated formats, such as the religious services and the series Minister Mondays. These digital settings contribute to the formation and circulation of the emotional regime, as illustrated by a minister of Satan: "When I went [to TST's headquarters] for the first time, I thought, okay, this is home, this is where I belong" (Minister Mondays, 12 December 2022). A service participant draws on the same emotional language: "I hate that cheesiness of saying, oh, it felt like a homecoming, but it definitely felt like I was arriving at a destination where I would be welcomed" ("Global Perspectives of Satanism", 13 November 2021). These recurring comments in digital communal settings suggest that 'coming home' is both socially reinforced and mediated, contributing to the stabilisation of the emotional regime across local and translocal spaces.

Emotional regimes that emerge within TST play a vital role in how members navigate challenges and sustain motivation for community engagement and work for social change. Emotions such as anger, sadness, and hope can be shared and amplified in communal settings, as a minister suggests:

> I've definitely had moments where we felt angry together or really sad together, or when I've made art of my own, feeling really, it's expressing my sadness, or melancholy, or sometimes hope. There's no point in rebelling if you don't have hope. Why fight a system if you don't think you can—where's the point? So, a lot of times I feel hopeful—especially with other people in TST and making stuff together. […] It's definitely nice having people that can be like "Okay, now together we actually can make a difference". (Interview with K5)

In this complex web of emotions, another affirming emotional regime deserves attention—one that is emically framed as 'Satanic joy'. Like 'coming home', 'Satanic joy' can be understood as a deliberately cultivated emotional regime that plays a central role in how members construct Satanism in positive terms. It affirms identity, strengthens commitment and in-group social ties, and serves as a resource for navigating stigma and sustaining engagement. A recurring pattern in articulations of Satanic joy is the contrast between affirmation and opposition. Rather than defining Satanism through negation—what it is *not*—members emphasise what it is for them personally. For instance, service participants describe Satanism as an emotionally fulfilling alternative to atheism, precisely because it allows for an affirmative articulation of identity:

> There's more joy in saying who I stand with rather than who I stand against. Both of those statements feel different in the body because one is an affirmation and the other one implies some sort of negative conflict.

> Why Satan over atheism, for instance? It's because we want to define ourselves by what we are, not by what we are not.
>
> ("In Times of Difficulty, Remembering Your Satanic Joy", 19 March 2024)

Satanic joy as a cultivated emotional regime is further articulated as a resource for creative expression, and as a way to bring positive emotion into community-care. For a service participant, Satanic joy is not only individually experienced but also circulates between members through shared practices:

> Creative expression is something that we see a lot of in this community. […] By living our Satanic joy, by being creative, by putting our own kind of internal joy to work like that […] it really does have an effect on other people's ability to cultivate their own, I think. ("In Times of Difficulty, Remembering Your Satanic Joy", 19 March 2024)

Satanic joy also emerges at the intersection of emotional resonance, value alignment, and a sense of purpose. In another articulation, it is linked to the symbolic repertoire of Satanic figures and narratives, which are reinterpreted as sources of empowerment:

> So, when we think about the rebels in these stories, Satan, Eve, and beyond biblical texts to even Lilith and Prometheus, etc., we have representatives of autonomy, curiosity, self-empowerment, compassion. I know all of these things bring me joy. For me, it's the continued struggle for justice for what I know in my heart is right that brings me joy. It is asking questions to learn more, to gain a better understanding of not only myself, but others, the world, that brings me joy and gives my life meaning and purpose. It's showing compassion for all beings within reason, doing what is in my power to support others, to aid the community in positive ways, that brings me joy. All of these things are satanic as fuck. Accepting others' beliefs, other expressions of being without bounds is joyous, is Satanic. ("Satanic Joy", 19 April 2022)

These accounts demonstrate how Satanic joy, like 'coming home', is anchored in shared values such as autonomy, curiosity, and compassion. This underscores the assemblage's relational dynamics that connect the emotional and the moral dimensions of religious practice. These dimensions reinforce one another, creating conditions for in-group cohesion and identification with TST. As one service participant reflects:

> The aspect of Satanic joy is really important because for me, it has so much to do with my community, the community of Satanists that I've become connected to. It really helps me to […] get in touch with my truly authentic self because the things that are important to me are embedded in the tenets. ("Satanic Joy", 19 April 2022)

Here, the experience of joy and authenticity is not framed as purely individual, but as relationally enabled. The relational aspect of Satanic joy is, however, not confined to TST as a social space. It also extends into encounters with non-Satanists, where joy can be communicated across difference. The same participant describes the pleasure of initiating exchanges where they openly discuss Satanic values with people outside their community:

> I have my little card in my pocket and I'm always like, "So what do you think of this stuff?" […] The surprise on their face, like, "Wow, I had no idea, that's actually really cool". […] It gives me the opportunity to really share with them the joy that I have found in the freedom of being able to be myself. ("Satanic Joy", 19 April 2022)

Such positive emotional approaches enable members to reclaim narratives about Satanism. By articulating their values in ways that invite curiosity and foster connection—rather than fear or rejection—they contribute to the formation of affirmative Satanic discourses. The act of sharing one's beliefs becomes a moment of empowerment. Similarly, for some members, Satanic joy is tied to processes of personal transformation, particularly the re-signification of marginalised or stigmatised identities:

> I was always, ironically enough, the scapegoat, the other. And now I find myself in a community that doesn't see that as a failing. They see it as a strength. And that is so powerful and validating for me as a person. I have been in recovery for 13 years. And a major source of joy for me comes from my recovery. […] I was struggling to try and fit in to the social gender norms, anything that society had placed upon me. […] not only allowing myself to live freely, but being encouraged by my community has helped me and helped my mental state and my happiness just immensely. ("Satanic Joy", 19 April 2022)

Moreover, Satanic joy is mobilised as a strategy for sustaining alignment in the face of internal tensions. During the service "In Times of Difficulty, Remembering Your Satanic Joy" (19 March 2024) a minister addresses the "sense of negativity" circulating within the group, encouraging members to focus on gratitude and the positive aspects of communal life. In such articulations, the emotional regime of Satanic joy serves as a strategy to counteract fragmentation.

Importantly, in some cases the sense of alignment and emotional comfort within TST is contrasted with experiences with different forms of Christianity and in relation to other forms of Satanism, particularly the CoS.[55] The

[55] This distancing from LaVeyan Satanism can be contextualised in relation to patterns discussed in section 4.4.3: one in ten respondents report past involvement with other Satanic communities, and another one in ten remain currently engaged—with the CoS and LaVeyan Satanism being the most frequently mentioned affiliations.

following interview excerpts illustrate how prior encounters with CoS are framed as misaligned with interviewees' values, dispositions and experiences:

> I read the Satanic Bible as a teenager, but that was like, "Okay, Satanism seems cool"— I just never really identified with it […]. So, this is really the first time that I would say I've actually been a part of it. (Interview with K10)

> I looked into religions and the ones that I found that spoke to me were Satanism and Wicca. I ended up not going with Satanism at the time because it was very Church of Satan sort of vibes. And as much as I liked the freedom stuff, the very masculine, aggressive, "If someone offends you, destroy them" or whatever—that seemed too much for a bullied 14-year-old. I was like, "No, that's too much!" (Interview with K5)

> My initial interactions with Satanism go back more than 20 years, dealing with the LaVeyans. And I had a very, very negative view of Satanists based on how LaVeyans act. […] I had a very strong dislike for the Church of Satan. (Interview with K2)

In these accounts, CoS is constructed as a negative Other against which participants position their own alignment with TST. Such articulations can be seen as discursive resources that reinforce identification, stabilise commitments, and further consolidate the sense of 'coming home' and Satanic joy.

6.1.4 Goth or Not? Aesthetic Regimes

Religious life within TST is not only value-driven and emotionally saturated, but also aesthetically oriented. Aesthetic practices can be seen as additional mechanisms for fostering in-group alignment, insofar as they enable the embodied experience of shared values, emotions, and identities. These practices—ranging from visual art and iconography to ritual setting, dress code, and musical and other sensory preferences—are integral to the community's assemblage, helping to articulate a distinct Satanic identity.

The centrality of the aesthetic dimension is underscored by its prominence across both mediated community settings, leadership and member engagement. In TST services, for instance, aesthetics is a recurring theme, that appears in relation to core areas of practice. The aesthetic dimension is explored in discussions of the historical development of Satanic symbols, myths, and iconography ("Mythical Creatures of Satanism", 8 August 2023); in reflections on the motto 'living deliciously' and the way in which the Satanic emphasis on pleasure and indulgence influences members' dietary choices, ritual practices, and celebrations ("Responsible Hedonism", 14 February 2023); as well as in engagements with visual and material culture, including jewellery and occult objects, used both in rituals and for personal expression ("Occult Clutter", 4 February 2023). In this respect, popular culture constitutes an important site of engagement with aesthetics. Service participants identify

Satanic values and symbolism in horror, gaming, and music genres (e.g., "Satanism and Horror Movies", 25 February 2023; "The Devil's Hymns", 28 February 2023) or discuss ethical questions around consuming art by problematic creators, negotiating commitment to shared values and aesthetic enjoyment ("Schrodinger's Author", 24 September 2023). Importantly, both Greaves and Jarry have been engaged in music projects, with Jarry also having background as a filmmaker. Moreover, TST's headquarters functions as an art gallery, where rituals are occasionally held—a strategic choice in the assembling of the community that reinforces the integration of aesthetics.

Given this rich and varied engagement with aesthetics, it becomes pertinent to consider whether TST cultivates distinctive aesthetic regimes that shape Satanic identity and in-group cohesion. Members engage in aesthetic expression through personal or communal creative projects, including visual art, jewellery-making, and performance. In some respects, their aesthetic preferences are influenced by shared cultural conditioning. As Christian backgrounds are common (see 4.1), members' engagement with Satanic aesthetics can be articulated as a response to, or inversion of, the religious iconography to which they have been exposed. An interviewee elaborates:

> We have a shared cultural history of being familiar with some of the stuff that is in the Bible or some of the imagery that surrounds religion. People who go towards Satanism tend to be people who identified more with the darker side of things, you know, like "Hey this picture of the devil is very interesting, I want to look at that. I'm not so interested in looking at the angel picture, I want to see the devil picture." Maybe it's an emotional or culturally oriented response to the iconography which then finds expression? (Interview with K1)

Not surprisingly, central to TST's aesthetic dimension is the figure of Satan or Lucifer, whose character provides a symbolic through-thread:

> The imagery of Satan and Lucifer are [sic] themselves rebellious as they illustrate rebellion [away] from the status quo. The imagery gives me chills and embodied experience of my religion. (Interview with K4)

Engagement with aesthetics is not merely decorative but evokes emotional responses and reinforces the moral dimension of religious practice. Members engage with different aspects of the Satan notion that allow a wide spectrum of artistic interpretations, from dark and gothic to delicate and contemplative:

> You might get art that's more like King of Hell sort of rebel where it's really dark and aggressive. Or you might get really pretty stuff based on Snake in the Garden and Garden of Eden. […] You can pull out these different threads that give you different perspectives on things. I do feel a lot of it is gothic in a way, even if it's not dark necessarily—that it has that 'finding beauty in darkness', and finding beauty in the neglected things or the ostracized things, or things that society doesn't necessarily see as beautiful. Like dying roses or snakes.

> Lots of people are scared of snakes but we consider them beautiful. I feel that sort of tone—of trying to have a different perspective on things and finding value in those things that normally aren't seen as valuable—is an undercurrent I see a lot. (Interview with K5)

A recognisable gothic aesthetic points to a shared orientation that resonates across different individual expressions. However, it coexists with a wide range of personal styles and preferences, as illustrated in the following accounts:

> Sometimes there is a certain kind of fascination, I guess, that you find in the same thing where people keep spiders and snakes as pets. There's a fascination in that sort of transgressive art where you're breaking the rules of beauty and art by finding beauty in things that would not be conventionally considered beautiful. […] My tendency is towards things that people would recognize as art and find in a museum as opposed to, you know, necessarily some of the darker stuff. But at the same time, I love horror movies. I grew up watching horror movies. […] I don't associate horror movies with bad things. I associate horror movies with watching horror movies with my dad and the two of us enjoying something together. (Interview with K9)

> I'm generally not a fan of a lot of the industrial type of music that is favoured by many TST members. I do appreciate the performances, rituals, events, and so on. I like the suggested readings (e.g., Revolt of the Angels). (Interview with K4)

The interwoven nature of aesthetic and religious experience is further reflected in how members describe their engagement with music and visual culture. In the following account, the coexistence of seemingly contrasting aesthetic forms—dark and cute, fierce and gentle—can be seen as co-present aesthetic regimes within TST. These regimes appear to be anchored in shared symbolic foundations, such as the duality embodied by Baphomet:

> About the same time that I started getting more into TST and Satanism, I was just getting into heavy metal and black metal […] those kinds of concerts, it can feel like a religious experience as well. And there is a lot of overlap in musical tastes and aesthetics between extreme metal and Satanists. Not 100%. There're lots of people who don't listen to metal. There're lots of people who don't wear black T-shirts. There's a variety in Satanism. But black metal and extreme metal—they have been embracing the imagery of Satan, of being an outsider […] for a long time. So, I can see the parallels. I can see the catharsis of embracing that outsider status that is put on one by being a metalhead or being a Satanist. Like the blasphemy of black metal and the blasphemy of Satanism. There are a lot of parallels, but it definitely does not have to be the case. You would have seen plenty of the cutesy, kawaii-style Baphomets. Oh, I've got a crocheted little Baphomet right beside me! Satanists appreciate the dark aesthetic, but at the same time, we also love cute stuff and the duality of it as well. That's super important. Baphomet is an expression of duality; having cute stuff, and having ugly stuff all at the same time, and being the same character—that's a wonderful aspect of duality as well. (Interview with K7)



Figure 13. Aesthetic regimes I. (A) Baphomet at TST's headquarters. The statue is a prominent symbol in the organisation's legal campaign for religious pluralism. According to artist Mark Porter's statement on TST's website, the sculpture draws on influences from Zoroastrianism, Gnosticism, and Slayer's debut album, symbolising the union of opposites and the interplay of shadow and light (photograph by the author). (B) Announcement of a clean-up initiative in a TST digital newsletter (screenshot). (C) Landing-page image on the TST TV homepage illustrating a playful and whimsical aesthetic characteristic of the movement's digital culture (screenshot).



Figure 14. Aesthetic regimes II. (A) Occult-themed installation at TST's headquarters (photograph by the author) and (B) merchandise of the book *Good Night Baphomet* from TST's online shop (screenshot), exemplifying the co-existence of gothic and cute aesthetics.

Satanic iconography becomes a source of joy and positive identification. Symbols such as Baphomet, the goat head and pentagram, are prominently displayed at TST headquarters in Salem. An interviewee explains how TST members understand these symbols as affirmations of their religious identity:

> That's kind of an organising cultural symbol. A lot of people are going to look at that and recognise it as being the devil—and then feel good about it. You know, I'm sure there are a lot of people in the world that will look at that and say "Uh! That's horrible!" But for us it's not. For us that's positive self-expression. We like it! It's not a matter of putting it up in order to make the Christians unhappy—no, it's to make us happy. It's a positive orientation toward this kind of iconography. (Interview with K1)

Aesthetic regimes within TST extend beyond its formal representation in the public, permeating members' everyday life and domestic spaces. Members often incorporate Satanic symbolism into their homes and personal traditions, creating a sense of continuity between their religious identity and aesthetic environment:

> We have art on our walls that reflects that […] we get a different Christmas ornament every year, my wife and I. So, our Christmas ornament for two years ago was a Baphomet Christmas ornament. We love it. It's fantastic! […] I think that's something you see in a lot of subcultures. […] We have common interests and a lot of us like similar kind of music. Certainly, I do enjoy those things. […] a lot of us who are interested in TST as an organization have an attraction to what would be considered darker art, that is reflected in the kind of media that you see in the community. (Interview with K9)

Engagement with aesthetic expression enables members to connect emotionally and ideologically. Collaborative artistic projects reinforce the sense of community through engagement with aesthetic practices. As one member reflects on a congregation's collective art endeavour:

> They've got some Satanic rosaries that they're making to sell at their merch table […] when they do events. It's a project to work on together, so it's a great community thing. […] We're creating this community, we're creating this narrative of Satanism, this is our space and we're filling it in with all the beautiful things that we like and that we are—and art is one part of it. (Interview with K7)

Another example is the creation of a Tarot deck called "The Raccoon Deck", which involved contributions from co-congregants, including photographs, hand-drawn images, and collages. The name of the deck comes from the card of The Beast, represented by a grinning cartoon-like raccoon (an image kindly shared with me by an interviewee). The choice of the raccoon—a creature often associated with nuisance or trash in North American culture—can be read as exemplifying an aesthetic regime that finds beauty and symbolic value

in what is typically seen as negative or marginal (notably, TST Tennessee has incorporated the racoon into its congregational logo). The art project itself functioned as a form of collective artistic expression and community building, as the interviewee describes:

> We did a collective art project. That was during the COVID lock down. We couldn't get together in person safely so I did this over the internet with other people. And you know, people contributed art pieces and stuff and I made up the thing and then I got a game company to print the cards and mail them to me and I got them distributed. So that's a form of self-expression, like an anarchist art project. People contributed what they wanted, if they wanted, to build this thing together. It was a pretty fun experience to do the project and afterwards we had some physical artefacts we had created as a result and a shared experience to some degree working on this project. (Interview with K1)

The coexistence of dark, cute, and sometimes whimsical aesthetic expressions may be interpreted through Goffman's lens as a continuation of the stigma management strategies discussed previously (see 5.2.2). While darker gothic aesthetics and Satanic iconography can be understood as stigma symbols transformed into prestige symbols in the community, cute and whimsical aesthetic articulations appear to function differently. In Goffman's terms, representations such as crocheted kawaii-style Baphomets and cartoon-like rearticulations of Satan as Trash Panda may operate as disidentifier symbols. Instead of presenting Satanic identity through transgressive or dark aesthetic regimes, this imagery mobilises humour, playfulness, and whimsy. It challenges dominant cultural stereotypes of Satanists, disrupting expectations of menace and evil and inviting alternative readings. The cute and whimsical as aesthetic regimes rearticulate Satanic symbolism in ways that reverse stigma.

Aesthetic regimes also find expression in ritual design, where they function as a key mechanism for facilitating emotional engagement and experiences of community. Ministers play a central role in curating these shared experiences, carefully selecting aesthetic elements that resonate with the ritual's purpose and desired emotional tone. As one minister explains:

> The aesthetics of the ritual have to meet the aesthetics of the purpose. So, for example, we did a Lupercalia ritual earlier this year, which is an ancient Roman festival around the time of Valentine's Day. We pulled on a lot of Roman aesthetics for the Lupercalia ritual. For the Unbaptism, we did a little bit of a Christian ritual. […] we'll pull a lot of Christian aesthetics and kind of invert them or twist them for those, because that is the aesthetic that we're looking to get there. We have an Unfertility ritual—and the 'un' is kind of in little parentheses, like it can be either fertility or unfertility—to affirm individual members' choices and what they make for their family: be that them themselves, them and just their partner, them and some kids, them and their pets, whatever your choices are on your family. So, we pull a lot on images of fertility and unfertility in that: in either planting seeds in a pot that you then take home and one of those pots you can drop into the ground—it'll biodegrade and

> everything—or taking dried flowers and tossing them into a fire, or different aspects of that. It's all about forming that aspect and that aesthetic that can bring you into that headspace. (Interview with K6)

The same interviewee underscores the importance of ritual aesthetics—what they describe as "pageantry"—in facilitating religious practice:

> I think it comes down to that pageantry […] It will put you into that mental headspace to do that introspection, to create a separation between the mundane everyday life and that ritual space[...] You have to bring all the senses into it. Otherwise, you don't create that space. So, you know, scent, and sight, and sound, and touch—all of it combined, creates that space, that separation, if you will. (Interview with K6)

While aesthetic regimes can serve as a medium for emotional resonance and in-group alignment, they can also function as a filter: they mark symbolic boundaries and shape perceptions of inclusion and exclusion. An interviewee reflects on this dual function:

> I mean, I'm a dirtbag, goth and metalhead with a curtain of an inverted pentagram behind me. […] There is a degree of—it's just kind of cool! One of our former members said that it's the first thing that people catch up with Satanism. It isn't the philosophy, it isn't the theology—it's the "Oh, that looks cool!" So, I do think there is a thing about the aesthetic that is important. But I also think the aesthetic can be a barrier as well. […] If you are a pop princess, seeing a bunch of dudes wearing spikes and inverted pentagrams, it kind of sends a message that this isn't for you—that it is exclusive, in a way, or […] that you have to give up too much of yourself to join this. And I don't want to feel that way. […] if you come to see us in person, it definitely feels a lot more welcoming, because we don't fit the stereotype that you see projected forward. But that aesthetic exists for a reason at the same time. Because that is part of the protection. If you can't get past the aesthetic, you're probably not going to fit in anyway. But I do definitely see why people can be like, "I want to like you guys, but you are kind of scary". To embrace the aesthetics, you already have to be open minded. (Interview with K2)

Another interviewee reflects on how certain aesthetic preferences—such as black clothing, occult symbols, and gothic styles—are widely recognised within the community. They also note the diversity of aesthetic expression and the continuity of personal style that often predates formal affiliation with TST. For some members, these preferences are not adopted as part of a transition into Satanism but are long-standing elements of identity that align with the movement's aesthetic regimes:

> Naturally, there're lots of black with red highlights. You know, we do have our typecast thing a bit. But, there're just as many people who look like regular people— for lack of a better word—who don't really have the goth aesthetic and all of that. There're people who are schoolteachers in the community. And

> they look like it. […] I've been into metal my entire life. So, pentagrams and stuff […] don't really hold that transgressive value that they hold for a lot of other people. Like, "Oh, look, there's Baphomet!". I've seen that on 80 album covers. I do wear a lot of black and I have some of that imagery and stuff, but often those are shirts that I've owned since college. So, it's kind of hard for me to draw that line of, where is this my Satanism and where is this just how I am. (Interview with K10)

As I observed during a visit with a group of TST members in New England, such long-standing aesthetic preferences not only shape individual identity but also foster a sense of cohesion within the group. Attending the gathering led me to reflect on how aesthetic regimes operate as implicit yet effective mechanisms of alignment. Several congregants mentioned that they had recently relocated to New England. While the region's liberal socio-political climate and proximity to the Canadian border were cited as practical considerations—especially in light of the upcoming presidential election in 2024—their accounts suggested that proximity to their TST friends was an important factor. Interestingly, in some cases these friendships were initially formed in virtual spaces, with no prior in-person contact before the move. The trust and sense of connection had developed through regular interactions in the chat of *Whimsical Blasphemy*, an online music show hosted by Mercy Maelica and broadcasted live from Salem.[56] One of the congregants told me they visit Salem every other week and often meet up with Mercy Maelica in person.

The group I visited was not only united by their TST affiliation but also by bonds of friendship, as was evident in their relaxed and familiar interactions. When my TST companion and I arrived at the front yard of the hosts, we were greeted warmly—not only by our hosts but also by an imposing, dark-coated dog. The dog's appearance startled me slightly, yet my travel companion and the other guests were unfazed; they already knew the dog by name. As afternoon turned to evening and we gathered in a circle around a fire, the impression of a tightly knit group grew stronger. Conversations flowed easily, touching on both joys and hardships. The core values of TST seemed to provide a foundational ethos, but what stood out was the alignment in aesthetic literacy that enriched their interactions. Shared references, ranging from computer games to music, created a web of intertextuality that was familiar to the congregants. One moment that illustrated this was a discussion about a satanym inspired by a character from a video game. While the game's title was unfamiliar to me, other guests immediately recognised the reference and engaged in a conversation about its symbolic resonance.

[56] *Whimsical Blasphemy* is a multi-genre show, with recent themes played including: The '80s, The'90s, Music to Burn in HELL, Classic Rock, Assorted Electronica, Industrial, Broken Glass, Love You, The Satanic Panic, Just Cover Songs, Hate You, Blood, Isolation, Drive, Your Mom, High, Fuck the System, Old Timey Tunes, Crazy, Just the Ladies, RUN, The Feels, Money, The Darker Place.

Music played a central role in shaping the atmosphere that evening, further aligning the group aesthetically and emotionally. We began with a metal playlist, and the host repeatedly invited guests to suggest alternatives. One attendee requested British indie artists from the 1980s, naming goth rock icon Peter Murphy and the darkly ironic Morrissey. When the music app unexpectedly shifted genres—jumping from metalcore to the 1980s power ballad "I Just Died in Your Arms" by Cutting Crew—people laughed; the algorithm must have latched onto the theme of death, someone said. This moment of shared humour, rooted in recognisable aesthetic references, illustrates subtle ways in which community alignment is produced in lived religion.

6.1.5 Communal Practice

TST values such as compassion, autonomy, and reason are enacted and embodied through emotionally and aesthetically laden practices. While Section 5.1 examined how individual practitioners negotiate and assemble Satanic practice, the focus here is on practice as a primarily collective endeavour, contributing to in-group cohesion. Communal ritual practices constitute tangible expressions of value alignment and illustrate how shared identities are embodied and collectively reinforced. They offer members a social space in which they experience and cultivate unity. As one interviewee explains:

> The role of ritual is for me to connect with myself and other congregants on a human level. I appreciate being connected to other humans who share a worldview that is similar to my own. (Interview with K4)

Experiences shared in ritual contexts become crucial for processing emotions, fostering belonging, and negotiating meaning. An interviewee describes a Destruction ritual held during the pandemic:

> I think a lot of it comes from a love and compassion. […] It's a ritual where you basically write something down or you have an object that represents something that you need to let go of, and then you burn it in a fire to ritualistically let go of it. […] it really depended on the person but it would just be something that could be printed out of a printer on a piece of paper, just a little symbol or something they've written or drawn that could be a two-dimensional representation. And then, they'd say a little bit about what the symbol represented to them and why they were destroying it and ritualistically letting it go together as a group, and some of that was like—I don't know how to describe, I don't think there's a specific word in English—but that emotion you get when you're actually letting go of anger, that really nice, calm catharsis afterwards. We all shared that together. (Interview with K5)

Here, the aesthetic dimension of the collective ritual, manifested in the use of scenography and performative gestures, plays a crucial role in evoking specific emotional states. As another interviewee describes, rituals, in this case

Unbaptism, are intentionally crafted to help people confront and release what some members refer to as 'religious trauma':

> What do you do to help with this religious trauma? You do an Unbaptism. You give these persons, through a ritual thing, a release—the freedom to go, "Oh, that Baptism is not real!", and this [feeling that] "I'm free!" […] We bind your hands, you've got a face mask, and you remove it, and there's all this intricate stuff. And it's all designed to help the person take that trauma and go, "It no longer has a hold over [me]—it's part of me, but I'm free now". It's a very moving experience because it brings a lot to these people. It's tearfulness and joy, relief, pain, and to get to experience that—it's very satisfying. It helps pump me up that I can make someone else feel good, help them mentally. (Interview with K11)

Even practices with a playful or unconventional framing can operate as rituals and foster communal bonding, when they are recognised as meaningful:

> Last year, after a period of internal strife and coming through it, we wound up having a water-gun fight. A bunch of us brought those to the park and that was our way of blowing off steam and building unity back. But it was a religious ritual. We did file it as a ritual. It was a unity ritual. (Interview with K10)

Rituals are often performed in the context of communal celebrations structured by TST's religious calendar. Satanic holidays provide opportunities for congregants to experience and perform a common Satanic identity. A minister recounts designing a Lupercalia ritual for their congregation, centred on bodily autonomy and personal growth. The act of creating and leading a ritual rooted in lived experience illustrates how congregational celebrations can function as social spaces where members embody shared values:

> It was one for Lupercalia last year, which is a holiday we have based around hailing yourself and bodily autonomy, and that sort of stuff. So, I wrote something around that because it was the one-year anniversary of me getting this surgery that I really wanted. It was for gender. I was like, "It's right around the same time, I'm thinking a lot about this issue". So, I just wrote something for people to celebrate their own self-knowledge and autonomy, and growth. (Interview with K5)

Halloween is a central fall observance in TST's calendar, associated with themes of embracing darkness, facing one's fears, and letting go of painful experiences. As I observed during a Halloween celebration held by a New England congregation, the holiday was not enacted as a superficial aesthetic engagement with darkness but was instead framed as a religiously meaningful opportunity to confront and integrate the more difficult of 'shadow' aspects of human existence. The celebration took place on a warm October evening in the garden of a minister's home. Congregants gathered around a fire, following a rich buffet where each had contributed a dish. The culmination of the

gathering was a Destruction ritual. In preparation for the ritual, attendees put on costumes and attributes. Some outfits were explicitly Halloween-inspired—such as an orange prison uniform or the viral break dancer Raygun's Australian Olympic tracksuit. Other attendees manifested their identification with TST and dark aesthetics by wearing purple robes, Satanic T-shirts, black horned masks decorated with colourful rhinestones made by one of the congregants, or a gothic leather and metal collar necklace. Wearing their masks, congregants took group photographs in the semi-darkness around the fire.

As the ritual began, the minister changed the music to a calm and mystical instrumental playlist. They opened the ritual script on their mobile phone and began to recite. At certain points, they invited the participants to repeat after them, which they did in unison. The minister explained that through the Destruction ritual, the practitioner reclaims the power they have projected onto physical objects. "We do not belong to the objects," they said, "the objects belong to us". This was not only an implicit critique of consumerism but also a call to release attachments to items associated with painful experiences. Following the recitation, participants who had brought items to destroy could throw them into the fire. Those without items actively participated by asking questions about the meaning of the objects being destroyed and expressing emotional support. One attendee had no personal items to let go of this evening but offered carpentry tools to aid in the destruction. Meanwhile, participants shared reflections on things they had considered destroying but still could not for various reasons. One ritual participant, who had brought three large canvases to burn, explained that the ceremonial setting helped them let go of conditions that had burdened them. The canvases were allegories of psychological suffering, such as body dysmorphia, anxiety, and depression. The congregant described the ritual destroying of the art work as self-empowering. They emphasised the importance of engaging with the difficult emotions in a material and embodied way, rather than addressing them solely through cognitive means, as in conventional psychotherapeutic contexts.

Ritual design in the context of communal celebrations can be understood as a collectively negotiated crafting of a recognisable TST culture. The desire for in-group alignment in terms of traditions and symbols is expressed as a hope for cultural consolidation with space for personal adaptations, as a minister elaborates:

> I also really hope that TST grows more of more of a culture that we get past the exploration phase into something where we're building traditions that have customization, but I want us to have recognizable, traditional, Sol-Invictus songs. I want to have symbols around certain holidays that we can be like, "Oh man, it's Easter, so bunnies and chocolate". It's like, "Oh man, it's Lupercalia, so milk and wolves". […] I hope we get to a point where we have a really flourishing creative art scene that comes from within TST rather than being inspired from external stuff, that we can be self-sustaining. […] I think we'll get there. It's just going to take time. But I hope I at least get to see it. (Interview with K5)



Figure 15. Interior of The Salem Art Gallery, the headquarters of The Satanic Temple. Salem Art Gallery functions as a space for Satanic practice where TST first established the tradition of services. Members and non-members can book fee-based ceremonies led by ministers of Satan and performed in one of the venue's rooms (Salem Art Gallery n.d.). (A) The installation exhibited by TST in the Iowa State Capitol in winter 2023. (B) *As Above So Below*, an exhibition by the artist KTRON. (C) The La Voisin Room, dedicated to Catherine Monvoisin (c. 1640-1680), a French fortune teller accused of witchcraft. (Photographs by the author.)

The development of distinctive TST traditions is inseparable from the spaces in which they are enacted. Rituals, celebrations, services and informal gatherings are shaped by context dependent spatial conditions that enable community building. Continuity and experimentation in response to spatial affordances are reflected in TST's hybrid organisational form, in which digital and physical modes of engagement are combined and continuously reconfigured. The evolution of the services exemplifies this hybridity. A minister explains how the tradition of holding services began as physical gatherings:

> It started with in-person services in Salem, Massachusetts. They were at our headquarters, […] And on Friday evenings, after the art gallery and the rest of it closed, we would set out chairs in the Milton Hall meeting space for anyone who came by, and we would have a religious service. ("What Are Satanic Services Anyways?", 22 October 2023)

These services were later moved to digital platforms, creating shared social spaces across geographical boundaries and serving as a bridge to in-person interaction when opportunities arise. As an interviewee describes:

> Temple Tuesdays[57] actually started on a different platform […]. Now it's on TSTTV, but before it was at the Satanic Estate […]. It was a website that was laid out like a mansion, and you could go into different rooms. Some of them were meeting rooms, like it would be a Zoom conversation. There was the main room, which is where they held Temple Tuesday, and that was like a one-direction thing with a chat bar along the side. So, the current TSTTV Temple Services is the equivalent of just one of the rooms over at the Satanic Estate. That online community really started developing over there at the Satanic Estate. And then we had SatanCon, and that brought some of us who were conversing online into a physical space together. It's really powerful to start networking congregants together. It really helps connect congregations to the campaigns, congregations to other congregations, all that stuff. (Interview with K7)

The new format of the services exemplifies what Miczek (in Helland and Kienzl 2022: 47) describes as a transformation process in ritual design: the reshaping of existing ritual templates to adapt their content or structure for online facilitation. While such digital infrastructures enable connection, physical gatherings remain central to local congregational life. In the absence of dedicated venues, congregations gather in spatially contingent ways, often relying on private homes:

> We don't have a space that we have, that's our own, like a church that we go to. […] I'm fortunate enough to have a large enough space in my backyard. We've done a lot of rituals in my own backyard. I'm sure my neighbours are like, "What are they doing out there?" […] We get together and play some

[57] TST religious services streamed on Tuesdays.

> board games for recreation. That's a lot of fun because individual members will volunteer to open up their house so that we can all gather in their house to get together and have a good time. (Interview with K6)

Such domestic environments shape the character of interaction. Private settings can foster trust and deepen social ties, while public venues introduce visibility and require negotiation of the group's integrity in relation to broader society. Celebrations such as Lupercalia exemplify how congregations creatively adapt ritual life to available spatial conditions:

> I pulled up one of my club lights set that set the mood, create a more rarefied space, even though it's just my apartment, […] And we had a nice little ritual and then ate a ton of sweets, and just involved in some… just luxury. That was really, really nice! The first Lupercalia was right before the pandemic. Two of our members are musicians. X kind of does some proggy guitar stuff. And Y, at that time did her dungeon synth project. […] We had a concert. We had a bunch of spice milk and figs—foods from ancient Rome, that kind of idea, the foods and stuff to be enjoyed during Lupercalia. We did that and it was a really nice time. (Interview with K2)

Access to public venues is negotiated with care. Congregations balance financial constraints and social perceptions of TST, as the following accounts illustrate:

> People tend to have an opinion on TST. So, sometimes you'll reach out to a place and they'll say no. And sometimes you'll reach out to a place and they'll be, "Oh, we'd love to have you". That's usually how it goes. One of them that I remember, where we held an Initiation, was a left-hand path shop—with all kinds of different Wicca and Greek gods, Norse gods, and all this stuff, crystals… They just had everything. So, they were more than happy to have us come. (Interview with K10)

> Trying to find places to do things is tough in [a city name]. It's very expensive to get spaces. […] We do have to worry about a space that is a venue that is willing to put up with the risks, and that is affordable. Those are two big and important things. (Interview with K2)

The significance of spatial context becomes particularly evident when rituals are performed in public. The following account conveys how a public celebration can both affirm social bonds within the group and involve the navigation of external perceptions:

> We did that for Unveiling Day, which is a summer holiday for us. Absolutely beautiful day! We could not have asked for better weather. It wasn't too hot or we were in the shade where we rented our space. There was a nice breeze and we set everything up. And people were very respectful of the ritual when we were doing it. As I mentioned, I think people thought it was a marriage ceremony because it was a guy and a girl up doing the Unbaptism. [Laughter] So,

> I think they thought it was a wicked marriage, not a Satanic Unbaptism! But people were very, very respectful of it. And then, after everything was done, it was getting dusk, we went to our pub where we do our meetups. Cause it was not that far away. We all went and had some food and some drinks together. And it was really, really nice. I think it meant a lot to the people that did it. (Interview with K2)

This description illustrates how ritual visibility in public space operates as a double-edged affordance: it can enhance alignment and introduce potential for tension. As visibility invites external interpretation, it can lead to possible misrecognition from the public. In this case, the performance of religious practice seems to be misinterpreted, yet respectfully received.

Spatial affordances condition ritual design, shaping what practices are possible to perform and how emotional and aesthetic regimes are enacted and experienced. One minister recounts how their local community celebrated Lupercalia:

> […] for the Lupercalia ritual, we weren't able to have a big fire pit because it was inside. […] In a suburban neighbourhood, you have to be cognizant of those…the possibility of those other eyes. I always say there's no dress code, but I don't live in a nudist colony. At least cover the important bits when you're here. […] If there is something that we would want to do that is more sex positive, we would have to find a private space that we could rent […] Ultimately, the space can dictate that and it can be either a boon or a blessing […]. Like indoors for the Lupercalia, it was very nice to be able to control the ambient light level […]. We don't have to wait for the sun to set or anything else like that if we wanted a moodier appearance. It's always something that we consider when we're coming up with a new ritual. Is this something that we can do in X's backyard or is this something that we need a space for? (Interview with K6)

This suggests that TST at the communal level is assembled through ongoing negotiation between intention, resources, and the affordances of specific settings. Such negotiations also involve a careful consideration of security concerns and social appropriateness in the given contexts. These assembling dynamics can, in turn, be understood in relation to stigma and practices of stigma management, as discussed in Section 5.2.

6.2 Balancing Institutionalisation

6.2.1 Polity Tensions

While the previous section has demonstrated how value alignment, emotional and aesthetic regimes can foster cohesion within TST, the current section turns to internal tensions that can arise as the community navigates institutionalisation. Tensions are identified in how participants negotiate commitment to both

autonomy and collective governance, and how organisational fluidity coexists with dynamics that promote formalisation and stability. The analysis addresses patterns of satisfaction and articulations of fault lines, tension between fluidity and authority, organisational restructuring and congregational governance, the 2024 schism and its aftermath.

Satisfaction and Fault Lines

Satisfaction with both TST and its local congregations offers a lens through which to assess in-group alignment and possible tension points. When asked, "Are you generally satisfied or dissatisfied with the way things are going in your congregation?", 92% of those to whom the question applies (n = 118) express satisfaction, while 8% report dissatisfaction. In the comments, respondents who value their local congregation emphasise the democratic and decentralised structure, which empowers members to initiate and lead activities. They appreciate the shared values, the pro-social charity work, and the sense of belonging among like-minded individuals committed to making a positive impact. However, respondents also note challenges such as geographical dispersion (as discussed in 6.1.1), financial difficulties due to the economic crisis, safety concerns, limited involvement, and reliance on organic recruitment rather than active religious outreach. Another recurring theme is leadership burnout and the trials of managing a congregation as voluntary work. These issues are reflected in the following survey comments:

> Members often struggle to find time to volunteer around jobs and travel, which makes physical events smaller, though we organise them across the region to create opportunities for in-person community. We maintain very active online communication and can rally for larger events. Recognising these difficulties, I feel everyone is doing their best, and we are growing at a sustainable rate. So, I'm satisfied, even if I'm hungry for more.

> People are burnt out across the state. […] While I'd like us to do more, it's complicated.

Satisfaction is framed as a balance between activist ambitions, limited resources, and the voluntary nature of the organisation, as in the following responses:

> It's a monumental fight in front of us and the majority of members are marginalized humans with our own physical, financial and identity-related vulnerabilities. There is always more work than resources.

> As an organization run almost entirely from volunteer efforts, everything we manage to do is a bit of a wonder to me. I respect the work that makes every visible (as well as the background work going into) TST action possible.

More acute tensions occasionally surface in accounts of exclusion or fragmentation. One respondent reports how their local congregation dissolved and formed a new group, describing the situation as an ongoing "schism". Another characterises the congregation they tried to join as exclusive, defining it as "a clique".

Concerning TST as a whole, overall satisfaction is similarly high. When asked, "All in all, are you satisfied or dissatisfied with what TST is and does today?", 93% of respondents (n = 135) report satisfaction, and 7% dissatisfaction. Comments suggest a more complex picture. Several respondents express ambivalence, often distinguishing between their experiences in the local congregation and their views on central leadership. For example:

> I'm trying to work this out. Locally, I'm satisfied—our local congregation is wonderful. The larger structure of the TST—I'm not sure about. I don't trust that things are what they present themselves to be.

> I have been disillusioned by TST, but there are still good people involved in congregations.

Others articulate similar sentiments, expressing trust and pride in their local communities while raising concerns about the central leadership, particularly the Executive Ministry (EM) aka the co-founders Greaves and Jarry:

> Satisfied with local but not with Lucien and EM.

> As a whole, yes. With Executive Ministry, founders Lucien Greaves and Malcolm Jarry, no.

> I definitely have opinions and notes that I would like to change (Lucien's behavior as spokesperson, for example), but I generally am happier working within TST to make change.

> I have been, and continue to be dissatisfied that a branch of our organization is set up without checks or balances, or any way to remove those within (Malcom Jarry and Lucien Greaves) from their positions. I do not think this is a healthy way to run an organization.

Some respondents point to broader structural tensions within TST, a theme reflected in the interviews too. These include internal divisions and a shift toward dealignment with TST, as the following accounts suggest:

> I love my religious community, and I am proud of the work I do for it, but I think a chasm has opened up between various parts of the organization, and I'm not sure if it's going to recover.

> Currently things are happening that have changed my desire to associate with TST.

An interviewee offers an account of the tensions that can arise; they describe a sharp contrast between the supportive atmosphere of local congregations and the toxicity they encounter in broader TST platforms:

> There are honestly very few platforms to interact with the larger TST community. It's kind of a problem we have. And they're often very toxic… The international platforms are difficult to be in most of the time… The only time they're active is when there's fighting, it feels like. But the local community is so much better. It's like night and day. (Interview with K10)

These articulations suggest that satisfaction coexists with critical perspectives on leadership, organisational transparency, and inner antagonism. Emerging dealignment tendencies risk eroding internal coherence. The distinction between local and national levels of satisfaction reinforces previously discussed patterns (see 6.1) suggesting that trust and belonging are most strongly experienced within local congregations.

Tension between Fluidity and Authority

TST's assembling is shaped by continuous negotiation between the desire for coherence and the need for openness. In a service articulation, openness to change is rhetorically mobilised to draw a boundary between TST and other religious traditions; TST is framed as a self-aware and progressive alternative and its ethos of adaptability becomes a marker of authenticity and ideological distinction, as the minister puts it:

> That's one of the cool things about Satanism, right, we can fucking change it! We're a non-theistic religion. We admit that our religion is something that we are creating actively as humans. I mean, all religions are, but we admit it. So, times change. Circumstances change. We can learn. We can update things. ("What Are Satanic Services Anyways?", 22 October 2023)

Similarly, an interviewee reflects on the provisional and exploratory nature of TST, where existing models are subject to critical reflection and reconfiguration:

> I think TST's culture right now is one of experimenting, because we don't have anything solid yet, we're just trying to play with things and figure things out, deconstruct what we already have all been given—and actually sit and think about what culture is. It's a lot! (Interview with K5)

This openness and reflexivity appear to be understood not as threats to religious commitment but as valued aspects of it. In this sense, the self-conscious engagement with the construction and reconstruction of tradition supports Cusack's argument (see 1.4.1) that so-called 'invented' religions adopt a more self-reflective approach to tradition. Participants acknowledge the constructed

nature of their religious practices while nevertheless investing them with meaning, significance, and commitment.

At the same time, sustaining a tradition as consciously open and revisable raises questions about how coherence and collective organisation can be maintained. The pronounced tendency to sustain the assemblage's fluidity has not been unproblematic. The movement has grappled with questions of authority, representation, and autonomy:

> One of the big things about Satanism is rejecting arbitrary authority. The arbitrary rules that exist from top down are often pushed back against hard. (Interview with K6)

> TST can't have leadership, because leadership is bad, right […] It's against arbitrary authority, not all authority. And I think people miss that keyword. (Interview with K10)

A minister's reflection in a service further articulates this tension; the pursuit of radical individualism—often expressed through focus on rebellion, autonomy, and personal growth—is foundational, while being continuously negotiated in relation to a framework that emphasises collective integrity and mutual accountability. As the minister puts it:

> We prefer to think of ourselves as the head-strung and indomitable goat, rather than the subdued and compliant sheep. Many of us often enjoy the employment of such expressions and phrases as, 'Do what thou will' […] or 'Hail thyself', as a means to express our belief that we are each the highest authority over our own lives, meted with the ultimate accountability, all of which is very in tune with the left-hand path focus of becoming your own god, despite the fact that we obviously approach this from a purely non-theistic perspective. […] But if we choose to be a part of a community such as The Satanic Temple, don't we therefore agree to abide by the standards set by that community? […] Any seemingly authoritative measures taken to ensure the integrity of our community cease to be arbitrary, don't they? ("The Individual & The Community", 9 October 2021)

These tensions have not remained merely discursive; they have informed ongoing organisational reconfigurations, as the movement has sought to work out what forms of governance can sustain its commitments to both to autonomy and coordination.

Organisational Restructuring and Congregational Governance

From its early days in 2013 to the more recent arrangements of 2024, TST's organisational model has been strategically reassembled. The 2021 restructuring—referred to as "the transformation"—marks a shift in the organisation's internal governance. This transformation includes the launch of the Ordination program supporting the establishment of a formal Satanic ministry, and the

redefinition of TST's local groups from "chapters" to "congregations". These changes can be understood as efforts to render TST more recognisable in relation to the dominant religious tradition of its host society—Christianity—a strategic movement toward alignment that bears particular relevance for the movement's activist engagements. As part of this restructuring, the Society of Congregations was created to help local communities to manage their own work. These changes were intended to decentralise authority, foster autonomy, while keeping the coherent framework for religious life within TST (Satanic Ministry n. d.). The Ordination Council has since played a central role in shaping and supporting the ministerial community, contributing to what can be understood as a spiral of territorialisation within the movement's assemblage.

These assembling dynamics are reflected in how members frame the changes in the movement's governance. Across two services—held on December 5, 2023, and February 6, 2024—the Ordination Council's dual function is clearly articulated: managing the ordination process and providing ongoing support for ministers. This includes developing educational resources and coordinating services that reflect the diverse ways ministers contribute to the community, for instance, through leading rituals, writing, organising events, or offering philosophical guidance via formats such as podcasts. However, the path to ministry is not without its challenges. Both services address misconceptions about ordination, cautioning against motivations rooted in self-interest or the pursuit of status. The emotional burden is also a recurring theme, with ministers emphasising the importance of setting boundaries to prevent burnout and maintain sustainable engagement. Reflecting on these challenges, one minister notes the rewards of supporting others, while stressing the need to recognise that the role does not entail formal counselling expertise; the same minister also expresses a desire for more practical guidance within the Ordination program:

> Lots of the lessons were interesting, but it was mostly focused on history, the evolution of Satanism and stuff, which is great. I mean, they were fascinating topics, but there wasn't a lot of, "Hey, what does it mean to be a minister, what should you do, how does the organization work?" I would have liked a lot more practical advice than just background information. (Interview with K10)

Another interviewee describes how they experience the shift from a previously centralised, top-down structure to a more decentralised and community driven model of congregational governance:

> There's been a transition over the decade plus of TST, and at the moment the congregations are self-run by a panel of congregation heads. It's representational as far as determining policies for congregations, and we all worked it out ourselves. (Interview with K7)

This decentralised model includes regional governance structures and committees that coordinate congregational activities by formally approving event proposals and new congregations. The layered structure is designed to foster autonomy while maintaining some degree of coordination. In terms of local congregations, the degree of formalisation seems to vary widely. Some congregations hold elections for leadership, while others rely on more informal arrangements:

> I met someone from one congregation who talked about how they have regular elections for who their congregation heads are. In my congregation, it just seems like the heads are the heads. I like them both, so that works for me. I would worry about how that could change if they were unpopular. We also have an executive council, which is voted into place. As I understand it, those positions are pretty much stable for those individuals. I don't know how they would be removed from council. (Interview with K4)

> When it comes to the day-to-day operations of an individual congregation, we are autonomous. We are allowed to make our own rules when it comes to things like that, or how we want to operate, or how we want to meet… as long as we're not breaking the code of conduct from national. Some congregations say, if you have supernatural beliefs, we're not going to have you be a member. Some congregations will accept them as full members. Some congregations strike a balance and create that ally membership. Some may do other things that I'm not even aware of yet. It is up to those individual congregations. (Interview with K6)[58]

Given the absence of a singular, established model of local governance, congregations are assembled through locally tailored arrangements that reflect the specific needs and capacities of individual communities. As a minister explains:

> We break some of our stuff down into guilds, where we have the people that do art and handle our technology. I'm in charge of our education guild. […] There're so many different forums where we talk about this stuff and try to figure out what best practices should be and how to go about things. (Interview with K10)

This variability extends to the question of who gets to belong to a local congregation. Some congregations implement screening processes to ensure alignment with shared values. Interviewees' accounts indicate an ongoing negotiation between openness and gatekeeping:

[58] It should be noted that the degree of insight into local governance varies depending on the form of personal involvement: the first account is provided by a congregation member, whereas the second comes from a minister and member of congregational leadership. In addition, some interviewees did not express an interest in discussing governance issues, or were hesitant to share documents regarding internal policies, as TST maintains non-disclosure practices (Laycock 2020: 72).

> We strain members before they come in. We ask a bunch of questions about why they want to join, what they want to get out of the community, what's their experience with Satanism and things like that. So, it's mostly cultivating a community that's there for the same kinds of reasons, at least. (Interview with K10)

> There's always this push and pull between a dichotomy of acceptance versus gatekeeping to make sure that we're not just accepting everyone, or we are accepting everyone, or do we put rules and more restrictions on who we accept to make sure that they're in line with our views, or do we be more open and allow others who, per se, hold supernatural beliefs to become members. If we do, do we create a separate tier of that membership, whether they're considered allies, but not full members. These are definitely considerations and things any organization, especially any religious organization, needs to confront and come up with solutions for. (Interview with K6)

Leadership backgrounds also shape inclusion policies, particularly around safety and ideological coherence:

> … we're all volunteers that come out of the congregations and most of us have at least some marginalization—it's a little easier to empathize with our congregants and then also just be like, "Hey, this person's randomly spouting hate speech, they don't get to join our congregation". If people are applying through a Facebook group and we see they're following right wing hate pages on their Facebook, it's like, that's probably not a good fit. Because that wouldn't be safe for me, why would I then allow this person access to all of these other people. (Interview with K5)

For some members involved in congregational work, the decentralised model is experienced as a valuable and exploratory process, offering a degree of flexibility that is actively sought (Interview with K7), and potentially contributing to the emergence of more sustainable organisational forms through processes of trial and error (Interview with K6). However, for others, a high degree of autonomy at the congregational level gives rise to challenges. The following account expresses concern about the lack of guidance and consistency across congregations:

> After you get recognized as a congregation, there's very little after that. It's too autonomous, frankly. We had to redo all of our rules last year because of a whole mess. [Our congregation] has been plagued with problems, and we are finally in a good position now. […] So, TST, the committee's big TST, told us, "Hey, you have to redo all of your rules because they're bad", and gave us no guidance. There's no template for bylaws or anything like that. It's 'everyone has to figure it out on their own', which leads to a lot of problems. In our congregation, for instance, our leadership has a term of three years, it just got increased from two when we redid everything. And others—it might be four, six… I guess there are some where it's unlimited. This is a critically important position. And there's not even regulation on that. I'm not even sure that they have to be elected. I think they can be appointed and that some do that. […] So,

> it's really all over the place. Once it's hard to get in. But once you get in, there are almost no rules, it feels like, which is a problem, in my opinion. (Interview with K10)

While the Transformation aimed to make TST's assemblage sustainable through decentralisation, communities abroad have voiced concerns about its uneven implementation and the persistence of US-centric structures. International members experience a lack of administrative support and unclear pathways to official recognition. One service participant expresses frustration with the slow process:

> If the work for giving us official statuses would be faster, it would be nice. At the moment, it feels like our hands are a little bit tied. We can't do everything we want. We can't get as many people as we want because we're not official. We can't market ourselves as an official group. We can't do everything we want to do as charity and fundraising because we're not official. That's something that sometimes feels a little bit frustrating—it feels like the train isn't really moving on. ("Global Perspectives of Satanism", 13 November 2021).

Subsequent articulations indicate that such concerns have not been fully resolved. Canadian members, for example, emphasise the need to "help ourselves" by organising locally, sharing resources, and creating their own initiatives ("Canadian Satanism", 28 January 2024). European members similarly stress the importance of adapting TST's practices to fit local cultural and legal contexts. This includes finding their own strategies also when engaging in work for social change rather than replicating American-style activism ("The Satanic Temple in Europe", 18 February 2024). These accounts suggest that the tension between institutionalisation and fluidity shapes the organisational assembling of TST over time and across both local and translocal contexts. While the restructurings have introduced structures meant to support growth and autonomy on local level, they have not made the community immune to conflicts.

The 2024 Schism and its Aftermath

Internal tensions reached a critical point in 2024 following the cancellation of SatanCon, TST's annual convention. The decision, attributed to limited resources and competing priorities during an election year, sparked widespread frustration—particularly among some members in leadership roles:

> Ministers and congregation leaders started making memes on Facebook, mocking TST, Lucien Greaves, and the idea that this is supposed to be a year of unity […] This sparked a wave of resignations […] and currently, we're 'a cult', we're 'the Gestapo'—there have been so many things flying around. (Interview with K10)

While some interpreted these ministers' reactions as disproportionate or misaligned with TST's values, others viewed them as legitimate expressions of dissent. A critical account frames the subsequent internal disciplinary actions and decisions by the Executive Ministry as authoritarian and ethically troubling:

> Over the course of this summer, things came to a head when one minister made some memes that were basically teasing Lucien. Rather than following the established disciplinary protocols, Lucien defrocked that person of ministry and excommunicated them, all while saying this person "was resigned". You can't "resign" someone else. That's not how that works. In any case, after that, there was a flood of people who did resign. (Interview with K4)

The fallout included collapse of leadership in several congregations, as interviewees share, with some leaders attempting to take their communities and internal documents with them. In response, other congregations have sought to offer refuge and continuity to displaced members. This development exemplifies how alignment and dealignment drive spirals of deterritorialisation and territorialisation, resulting in a fragmented assemblage in which congregations respond to internal tension in divergent ways—some choosing to dissociate from TST entirely, while others remain and seek to consolidate their position. These responses are shaped by differing interpretations of what constitutes legitimate authority and ethical leadership, and reflect the ongoing tension between fluidity and authority. At the same time, both alignment and dealignment can be understood as responses to the centrality of shared values within TST, even as interpretations of what these values entail in practice diverge. While TST's foundational values reject arbitrary authority, this rejection is not universally understood. For some, central leadership's actions are seen as necessary to preserve the integrity of the movement; for others, they represent a violation of its very core principles that make them feel at home. This divergence in interpretation underscores the fragility of the assemblage, where trust in co-fellows is closely tied to perceived value alignment. How internal tensions give rise to lines of flight in practice, propelling spirals of deterritorialisation, is illustrated through a detailed account of congregational rupture and reformation:

> I've been ready to leave TST for quite some time, primarily because of the tyranny that comes from Lucien and Malcolm's plain grossness […] I stayed because I loved my community. When the opportunity came for my community to leave TST, I jumped at the chance. […] During this time one congregation unanimously voted to leave and another one the leadership voted to leave and take their congregation with them. There are others who left last year when Lucien took a selfie with a big transphobe bigot. All of this occurred in the context of Lucien sending some really belittling emails to people in our congregation head. During this time, one of our members called for a vote to dissociate from TST. The large majority of our most active members voted to

> leave and become their own congregation, which we are currently planning. We literally left TST yesterday. (Interview with K4)

Notably, some members who remain loyal to TST during turbulences seem to be reluctant to speak openly about tensions. This silence appears to stem from a desire to protect the integrity of the movement and avoid contributing to further fragmentation. According to a minister, most members prefer to stay focused on community-building:

> It's really just middle management who's upset about this. The membership doesn't really care… But it's a bunch of people who are getting themselves spun up in an echo chamber, more or less, and making it everyone else's problem. (Interview with K10)

Members' reluctance to engage in public critique against Executive Ministry reflects a conscious commitment to the long-term viability of the movement. As another minister explains, those who choose to stay are doing so with a clear understanding of the compromises involved:

> We believe we're not the final authority on what Satanism is. And Satanism is individual. Those of us who are staying after this last big schism, we are making personal sacrifices, because we understand that as an organization, there has to be structure, there's got to be rules. I mean, as much as we hate them, abhor them. […] We need to run as established religion, so we can fight the fight. (Interview with K11)

Tensions and lines of flight coexist with approaches that aim at navigating disagreement in productive ways. An interviewee describes how shared values create a foundation for respectful dialogue:

> Even when we have different perspectives on things from our different backgrounds or whatever, we immediately can see where the other person is coming from and not making it an argument that needs to be won but a discussion where we're sharing. So, I feel just that perspective—that this isn't antagonistic, this is collaborative—immediately made me feel I could put my guard down, I think. Because that's what a home is, it is somewhere where you're supposed to be able to let your guard down and relax and as soon as I felt myself be able to do that I was like, "Oh, I haven't been able to do that almost anywhere before!" (Interview with K5)

Navigating internal turmoil involves going back to the foundational values that bring stability and initiating discussions about different understandings and implementations of these values; as one interviewee notes:

> We have all these metaphysical concepts in our tenants, but we never actually interrogate what we mean by freedom. What do we mean by justice? You

> know, we talk about acting with nobility. What does that actually mean? (Interview with K2)

The same interviewee describes an initiative intended to facilitate such reflection—Minister's Salons. As they explain, the aim of the Salons is to create space for meaningful discussions about what it means to be a TST adherent, particularly in response to a perceived lack of shared beliefs, values, and collective identity. These discussions are intended to contribute to an ongoing process of refining TST's collective self-understanding. The interviewee further notes that the initiative has had a broader ripple effect, inspiring others to establish similar discussion groups within the movement.

This analysis suggests that spirals of territorialisation and deterritorialization unfold simultaneously, shaping the assemblage of TST. The movement's decentralisation and ideological openness provide fertile ground for experimentation and localised adaptation. At the same time, these dynamics may also make it difficult to reach alignment on what constitutes best practice in community governance. A perceived lack of transparency and consensus exposes the community to miscommunication, leadership crises, and fragmentation, particularly when foundational values such as autonomy and anti-authoritarianism are interpreted in conflicting ways. The 2024 schism has rendered these processes especially visible. Moreover, fragmentation has brought into sharper focus the vulnerability of local leadership structures. In TST congregations, where much of the work is volunteer-based, continuity often depends heavily on individual leaders. When key figures, such as congregation heads, step down—whether due to burnout or internal disagreements—the stability of local congregations can be significantly affected. Leadership renewal becomes difficult, and the local communities they've built may struggle to stay afloat.

6.2.2 Negotiating Activism

As discussed in Chapter 4, a defining feature of TST is its self-conception as a socially engaged religious movement. This mission-oriented identity gives rise to a range of activist expressions that, while grounded in shared values, can also reflect differing views on how best to pursue the organisation's goals. Varying perspectives on the scope and nature of TST's involvement in social justice and activism coexist. These differences reveal an ongoing negotiation between the desire to act on deeply held convictions and divergent understandings of the practical limits and boundary maintenance in TST's positioning as both a religion and an agent of social change. Participants continually navigate questions about which causes align with the organisation's mission, what forms of action are appropriate individually or collectively, and how to uphold TST's integrity while engaging in different initiatives.

Engaging for social change through the frame of solidarity for diversity, TST focuses on issues such as addiction, LGBTQ+ rights, the conditions of the BIPOC community, disability, and poverty (see 4.4.2). Activism in these areas is negotiated between personal conviction and organisational strategy. Interviewees note that while individual members are encouraged to pursue causes that resonate with their values and expertise, TST as an institution limits its engagement to areas where it can make a distinct and meaningful impact:

> Anything that interferes with religious expression or religious freedom, or bodily autonomy is something that TST has at least some investment in. But not every issue is something that a religion necessarily has to get involved in. And we obviously can't be partisan either, we can't support specific political groups, but mainly just advocate on issues. (Interview with K5)

While this perspective establishes broad parameters for TST's activist engagement, interviewees also emphasise that decisions about involvement are shaped by concerns regarding the potential consequences for other movements and communities. Reflecting on how to express support when advocating for minority rights, a participant in a TST service states:

> We need to just step back and say, "What can I do for you? How can I help you? What can I do with my voice and my privilege that can help you best?" And sometimes that is just shutting up. ("Law, Justice, and Disobedience", 21 May 2022).

In a similar vein, another participant in this service emphasises that solidarity requires refraining from speaking over affected communities: "So rather than me going, 'Look, this is what they need,' I'm better off just echoing what they already say they need". A similarly cautious approach is expressed in the following interview reflection:

> There're already people operating in this sphere. They already know more than we do about the issues in this sphere. Coming in and saying, "I want to do this" is ignoring their work, their expertise. And there's a very good chance you're going to come in and do a lot of harm really, really fast. (Interview with K2)

Questions of activism are also closely tied to stigma and stigma management. Engagement with diversity issues involves consideration of how beneficial an association with TST may be for marginalised communities, as illustrated by the following reflection:

> If there is something that can be related to religious freedoms and plurality—we're all over that. Also, the LGBT community—Pride is a huge event for congregations every year. […] it can hurt other movements when Satanists show up. That's something that I think people forget. If we show up to a Black

> Lives Matter rally or something, that can make them look very bad. They might not want us there. So, we try to really make sure that we're keeping it mostly to religious topics or the LGBT community. (Interview with K10)

Stigma shapes discussions of public collaboration. While TST may find solidarity with other marginalised groups, its association can sometimes be more harmful than helpful as a result of the stigma attached to TST. One interviewee explains that movements already heavily stigmatised may be more open to collaboration with TST because they share a common experience of being vilified by dominant religious and political forces:

> Once you're already villainized by the hegemony, there is a way to bring you into that coalition to fight against the hegemony. I don't think that exists within a lot of ethnic minority-led movements, because there's a lot of really good Christians who support those causes at the same time, and they're not being villainized in the same way as atheists are or Planned Parenthood or the gay community. You don't see a lot of people calling Black Lives Matters 'heathens' and 'sinners' and 'you're being damned and going to hell'. I think if you were seeing that, it'd be a lot more comfortable with TST coming into that space. […] It's the groups that are already ostracized from that religious perspective, that are the ones willing to work with us because we have that common access of alienation from the hegemonic culture. (Interview with K2)

Stigma is not only a barrier to public collaboration but also a practical concern in behind-the-scenes efforts such as fundraising. Even when other organisations are ideologically aligned with TST or open to its support, the association with Satanism can create reputational risks that are difficult to manage. An interviewee explains how the mere appearance of receiving support from a Satanic group can be weaponised by opponents, potentially undermining the credibility and safety of partner organisations:

> It's really hard to work with other groups just because the stigma against the name Satanism means that even for organizations that are fine working with us, it's difficult for them to take direct donations with the name Satan on them. Because then places that don't like them could attack them. Can you imagine, like Planned Parenthood, the news goes "Oh, Planned Parenthood gets donation from a Satanic organization!"—people would run with that. And so, we have to be really careful about how the stigma against us can impact people that we're working with. […] We don't want our presence to make a situation worse, rather than better. (Interview with K5)

Stigma awareness leads to a cautious approach, articulated as especially important in marginalised communities where Christianity plays a central cultural role:

> If we are talking on the organisational level, I think any cooperation has to be initiated by the other party first. […] we have this thing where they, yes, they want the support of Satanists but if you show up with a big TST flag, that's a

> very polarizing thing. […] the Christian church is very important in Black culture. The Christian church is very important on a lot of Indigenous reserves. […] So, if we show up as TST, we are going to suck a lot of the air out of the room. All of a sudden, the discussion is now going to be "You've got a bunch of Satanists showing up". Now we are the focal point, not what they are trying to do. (Interview with K2)

While TST as an organisation may choose not to participate in certain public actions—especially when its presence is not explicitly welcomed or considered potentially harmful due to stigma—individual members can act on their convictions in a personal capacity. This approach is described in the following reflections:

> There were some people that wanted TST to go out in public and participate along with some other protest groups in America a few years ago and TST asked them if they wanted TST to join and they said no, so TST didn't join them as a formal public face and institution. But then there is nothing stopping the individual members from participating on their own. (Interview with K1)

> I think it's very important for Satanists, just like any religious affiliation, to go "I see a problem and my beliefs inspire me to act". […] So, go and get involved—not as TST but as a Satanist. (Interview with K2)

A congregation member shares how their activism conducted outside of TST's formal structure remains deeply rooted in their religious identity. Their longstanding involvement in anti-war and queer activism is experienced as a spiritual practice—especially in moments of direct confrontation with authority:

> I regularly attend anti-war protests. For more than ten years, I've been attending protests and direct actions towards Palestinian liberation. When I was in grad school, I served on the board for the local queer community centre and managed a $20k grant. […] My own personal activism is not itself affiliated with TST. However, my activism is based on my worldview and what I think is important, including the seven tenets. So, when I was arrested during a direct action, it was a religious event for me in that I was directly confronting an unjust authority. […] When I go to activist events, I do not go as a TST members… no one knows about my TST affiliation other than the other TST people who go with me. So, there is no need to negotiate space, explain TST, etc. (Interview with K4)

Disagreements over the scope of TST's activism have, at times, led to significant internal tension and fragmentation. In the following reflection a minister express concern that attempts to broaden the organisation's focus to include a wide array of political and social issues risk diluting its core religious mission:

> People will come in with their own pet projects and try to make TST do those things. There's a lot of social problems out there that deserve attention. I'm all for social progress and stuff, but this is about Satanism. We can't care about

> every, you know, 'Hey, what's our opinion on Israel and Palestine right now?' We've had problems in the past where people try to take on every issue under the sun and if we say no, then obviously we're racists or we're homophobic or whatever, because 'Why would you be against doing this thing?' It's like, "Well, because it's not what we're doing here. I'll happily go march at this thing with you in a different context, but not in TST". […] We've had two separate schisms in [a local congregation name] where people have left over exactly that kind of thing. (Interview with K10)

Two particularly contentious issues—Palestinian liberation and trans rights—highlight the complexity of these debates. One perspective questions why TST, which has taken bold stances on issues like abortion, remains silent on others that also align with its values:

> WE talk about how we are a religious group, not a political group, we don't take a political stance, but then we open an abortion clinic named after a supreme court justice's mom… which seems political. I am very involved with Palestinian liberation movements… and I can't see TST ever aligning itself with that… even though a lot of the issues we face in the US (with regard to Christianity seeping its way into governance) are very much at play with regard to Israel's military occupation of Palestine.

> I think it's annoying that sometimes TST takes a stand on something and other times not. TST has taken a clear stand on abortion access as it relates to the third tenet. However, TST hasn't done with same with gender affirming care for trans and other gender non-conforming individuals. (Interview with K4)

Another perspective foregrounds caution that public advocacy on trans rights must be approached with care, given the potential for backlash and the risk of harming the very communities TST seeks to support:

> …if we wanted to take the Trans Alliance and make the campaign that was going to advocate for trans healthcare access or whatever, we'd have to be really, really careful about how we phrase anything. Because we don't want to harm non-Satanic trans people with the association of Satanism and transness. (Interview with K5)

There is also a diversity of opinions regarding the most effective style of activism that TST should engage in. Some voices express stronger preference for the adoption of styles such as seeking common ground with a broader platform while others see more value in applying a provocative approach. Examples of provocative activism TST engages in include the use of blasphemy and initiatives like "The Judge Alito's Mom's Abortion Clinic". Supporters of provocative activism styles argue that such tactics are not only attention-grabbing but also effective in mobilising supporters and amplifying the message. As one interviewee puts it:

> I do think being like over the top has value. I'm not getting mad at Samuel Alito's Mom's Abortion Clinic. To me, that's funny. And the idea of alienating potential allies with that name—I don't see that. I just don't. In my experience, the people that don't like that name are people who already didn't like us. […] And there are a lot of people who really like it. We'll donate towards the cause because it is shocking and it sits there. (Interview with K2)

Similarly, another interviewee emphasises the symbolic and strategic function of being deliberately noticeable, someone who can speak uncomfortable truths through satire and spectacle:

> And I want to be very explicit that violence is not acceptable under any circumstances. There is no place for violence in political opposition. That is unacceptable to me. But there is a place for drawing attention to an issue by being noticeable, by being something that stands out. And I think there's absolutely a function. It doesn't do all of the work. But it's a valuable resource to the rest of the people doing the work. Being willing to, frankly, be a little bit ridiculous. It has a value in drawing attention to the issues that are at hand. You have to have the court jester or the fool to be able to poke fun at the king. (Interview with K9)

In some contexts, civil disobedience is framed as a legitimate form of activist action, grounded in TST's Tenet II, "The struggle for justice is an ongoing and necessary pursuit that should prevail over laws and institutions" ("Law, Justice, and Disobedience", 21 May 2022). Reflecting this principle, one service participant frames disobedience as not only justified but also a moral duty for Satanists, "especially when laws are immoral". While some TST participants embrace provocative tactics or nonviolent violation of laws, others express a preference for approaches that reflect TST's core value of compassion:

> I don't think confrontational is the best way to meet eye-to-eye but it has its place when needed. I prefer to exist and love everyone with verve. It's the softer and more compassionate side of Satanism. (Interview with K8).

Some observe a shift in TST's activist style over time, noting a move away from the more provocative and theatrical actions that characterized its early years:

> There is some softening of the edgy actions, like those things that I first mentioned, the Pink Mass, the baby protest, that sort of stuff does not seem as necessary to me. And based on what I see happening, it's not being enacted in those sorts of dramatic fashions anymore. (Interview with K7)

In navigating between these activist styles, there is a line of argument that foregrounds context sensitivity. The value of adopting different strategies in different circumstances to fit specific audiences and goals is articulated in the following reflection:

> I think it's a multi-front battle. Stuff like the current name of the abortion clinic [Samuel Alito's Mom's Satanic Abortion Clinic], it is a jab and that's fun. It's attention drawing and those are important factors to getting attention and making social change. There is a lot of importance to having that kind of approach to things because it gets attention and it draws more allies to your side. When trying to work with similar-minded but maybe more mainstream organizations—like if I were to go and talk to the Unitarian Universalist church about bodily autonomy and all this stuff—if I start with the bodily autonomy and here's what we're working for, that's going to be a different conversation than if I just open with Samuel Alito's Mom's Satanic Abortion Clinic and start talking about that. (Interview with K7)

In a similar vein, another articulation frames bridge-building and shock tactics as situational strategies:

> There are certain times where being cooperative is the best way forward, especially when you're dealing with people, or organisations or groups that are looking to cooperate with you. By all means, cooperate with them. Reaching out into the community and doing good works—like our Menstruatin' with Satan campaign, or doing highway clean-ups. We in [local congregation name] are doing harm reduction kits, working with an organisation that builds harm reduction kits for people who utilise drugs, so they can utilise those safely. Things like that—reaching, cooperating, and leading by example. Showing that people's preconceived notions about us are not what they think they are—that we are not what they think we are. [That] can go miles far and wide and make a large impact. But sometimes you run into people that…I like to say, you can't reason someone out of a position that they haven't reasoned themselves into. And those types of people, the only way to make any sort of impact is that little bit of shock value—to shake their foundations, grab their attention and go, "Hey, wake up, and take a look at this". (Interview with K6)

A related perspective emphasise that the style and scope of activism must be adapted to the specific political, legal, and cultural contexts in which congregations operate:

> Many countries have limits on what a religious organization can do as an activist group. […] You have to understand your own political system. (Interview with K2)

In countries such as Canada, for example, activist efforts take place within a national context that is frequently overshadowed by American political discourse. Within this context-sensitive approach, education and public awareness-raising are viewed as important tools, particularly where misinformation or cultural blind spots obscure the presence of harmful ideologies. This position also recognises the limits of awareness-raising alone:

> I do think specifically in Canada, education is really important just because so many people are unaware of Canadian context. We get so inundated with

> American stuff that a lot of Canadians don't know about right-wing hate groups here. They'll think, extreme racism and white supremacy is an American thing because they'll look at the Proud Boys that are this massive hate group in the US. But they originated in Ottawa. Gavin McInnes, the founder of the Proud Boys is from Ottawa. It's important to get eyes on the things that are happening here so they don't get worse and that we can, once people are aware of it, formulate a plan to fight back. But you can't fight something you don't know is there. And I think learning as much as you can means you can try and form an effective strategy rather than just reacting. You know what your enemy's goals are, you can much better foil them rather than just reacting to the things that they're saying. So, I think education is important, but I do think awareness campaigns at a certain point stop being as useful. (Interview with K5)

6.2.3 Looking Forward

As TST continues to reassemble through tension and alignment, some of its more dedicated participants articulate their aspirations for the future of the organisation. One perspective addresses the development of more effective communication infrastructures. This stems from a frustration over the lack of centralised platforms for sharing information and coordinating activities across the organisation. The perceived deficiency of information is felt particularly in relation to ongoing campaigns, as a minister describes:

> I'm a minister, I'm in congregation leadership […] I can't answer those questions either […] I don't have a way of really getting involved […] What are they doing? What are they working on? What could we contribute to as a congregation? (Interview with K10)

Despite strong commitment to voluntary work and organisational goals, insufficient communication between central and local leadership, together with limited transparency regarding national campaigns, may hinder direct participation, weaken members' sense of involvement in collective projects and intensify internal tensions. In light of the negative sentiments regarding contemporary socio-political conditions (discussed in Section 4.2), engagement in collective action is understood as particularly important for transforming these emotions and, in turn, sustaining long-term involvement; as another minister argues:

> Once people are aware it's like, "Okay now, what do you do", and you have to have some sort of productive thing that they can do to keep them engaged otherwise they're like, "Okay, well, now I'm upset. And I don't want to be upset anymore so I'm just going to tune out of it". So, giving people along with education something that they can do—whether that be advocating for a particular legal change, or speaking up to their elected representatives on issues—giving them something that they can actually do often helps. (Interview with K5)

Another future aspiration concerns the need for deeper philosophical engagement with the movement's core values. Part of this ambition entails moving beyond a primarily reactive dealignment from Christianity and towards greater internal alignment through the cultivation of a positive Satanist identity. This desire for TST's future is reflected in the following statement:

> We have to be able to say, "I am a Satanist, and this is what I believe, this is what I do". […] I think we need to have positive values, and we need to push those positive values forward in a way that does not make us look like we are simply opposing Christianity. I do think opposing the hegemonic Christianity is important. I think it's important to say, "no, you don't get to legislate from a religious viewpoint". […] But I would like to see a more positive sense of this is who we are, and we can identify ourselves outside of needing a foil. […] we are going to be able to identify ourselves as a Satanist because we are a Satanist, not because we are opposed to hegemonic Christianity. (Interview with K2)

A third aspiration extends beyond addressing tensions in the organisation itself and concerns the cultivation of dialogue in wider society through the dissemination of practices and dispositions developed within the movement. As reflected in the following articulation:

> I want to see people grow to the point where they can take the lessons that they've learned and apply those elsewhere as well, to where we can sort of ripple effect the sorts of things we've been learning about having productive disagreements. […] Because I think the world needs more of that. Whether that's through the lens of Satanism or not—I don't think it needs to be Satanic—but I think it would be really nice for people to get a little bit more comfortable with conversations that don't have clear winners. You can just disagree and that's fine. I hope my congregation takes that stuff that we've been doing and takes it out into the world. (Interview with K5)

6.3 Summary

This chapter has addressed how alignment and tension dynamics are reflected in processes of community-building and institutionalisation, shaping the assembling of TST. The analysis suggests that the assemblage functions through diverse forms of engagement. While digital platforms play a central role in facilitating participation, local congregations appear particularly important as sites of belonging, trust, and value alignment. I argue that emotional and aesthetic regimes contribute to stabilising TST as an assemblage. Experiences articulated as "coming home" and "Satanic joy" reinforce social bonds and strengthen identification with the movement, providing positive alternatives to experiences of social marginalisation. Likewise, communal rituals, celebrations and gatherings create opportunities for participants to embody these

regimes of social ordering and cultivate a sense of coherence. At the same time, these communal practices are characterised by ongoing negotiation between formalisation and experimentation, as well as by pragmatical considerations conditioned by access to space.

TST's assemblage is also characterised by internal tensions manifested in ongoing negotiations between autonomy and authority, fluidity and institutionalisation, local self-governance and central coordination. Activism constitutes a site of tension, with differing views regarding its scope, style, and strategic direction. Concerns about stigma further shape how activism is negotiated. The 2024 schism illustrates how tensions within the movement challenge the assemblage's territorialisation, producing both fragmentation and renewed commitment.

7. Conclusion and Discussion

This final chapter returns to the central aim of the study: to understand how TST assembles as a religious movement and as a site of social engagement through the interplay of alignment and tension. While grounded in the specific case of TST, I have also sought to develop an analytical approach applicable beyond Satanism.

The study has demonstrated how approaches attentive to alignment and tension (building on Simmel 2024 and Bromley and Melton 2012), assembling dynamics (Deleuze and Guattari 2013), and practice (Ammerman 2021) can be synthesised into a coherent analytical framework. The operationalisation of assemblage theory through social regimes of ordering corresponding to dimensions of practice has involved considering the interdependencies through which elements of the assemblage hang together. Within this framework, value alignment, emotional regimes, aesthetic regimes, and discourses function as analytical entry points for examining the alignments and tensions through which the assemblage is sustained and transformed. The study demonstrates that these dimensions of practice do not operate independently but in conjunction with one another. By focusing on participants rather than organisational discourse, the analysis has examined how TST is negotiated and sustained in practice. This bottom-up perspective (Deleuze and Guattari 2013) bridges approaches that prioritise either institutional organisation or individual religious experience and instead attends to the relational dynamics through which participants align with, reshape, and at times contest the movement's shared orientations.

The analytical approach adopted in this study has enabled me to answer the overarching research question (*How do dynamics of alignment and tension shape the assemblage of The Satanic Temple?*) in a way that foregrounds the interaction between analytical levels rather than treating them as separate dimensions. In doing so, it makes visible how individual experiences, congregational life, organisational processes, and broader socio-political environments are interconnected.

7.1 From the Cultic Milieu to the Milieu of Assembling

The analytical perspective developed here allows for a revision of influential assumptions within research on alternative religion. Campbell's (2002) shift of the sociological focus from the individual cult—organisationally fragile, short-lived, and empirically elusive—to the more enduring cultic milieu represents an analytically seductive solution to real problems. The rapid emergence and disappearance of such groups complicates conceptualisations of their dynamics or social significance. Campbell's move attempts to bring analytical order to what is empirically chaotic. The milieu is rendered intelligible by a shared mode of relating to knowledge, authority, orthodoxy, and difference. Deviance thus becomes the primary orientation towards the dominant social order; openness and tolerance the orientation to other heterodox positions; syncretism the expected outcome of such openness; and seekership the overarching ethos.

Rather than approaching TST by tracing the familiar patterns of the cultic milieu, this dissertation has examined how the movement assembles through situated processes of alignment and tension negotiated in practice. Following Deleuze and Guattari (2013) and Tremlett (2021), the focus shifts from categorising religious formations according to stable characteristics, towards examining the relations through which heterogeneous elements are combined and held together, or disintegrated and reconfigured. The methodological reorientation from Campbell's cultic milieu to Deleuze and Guattari's notion of milieu as a moment in the midst of assembling directs attention away from openness, syncretism and seekership as characteristics of individualistic alternative religion. The emphasis on individualism is particularly problematic. If we envision the objects of our study as autonomous seekers pursuing individual spiritual trajectories, how is belonging created, as expressed in 'coming home' articulations, even if it is contingent and temporal? As Probyn (1996: 13, 24) argues, belonging cannot be understood as "an isolated and individual affair". It is inherently relational, constituted through socially negotiated limits, boundaries, and forms of recognition. This observation resonates with Houtman et al. (2011) and their critique of reducing alternative spirituality to individual bricolage, as well as Deleuze and Guattari's (2013) argument that what appears to be individual expression is always produced within collective assemblages that shape and condition subjectivity. Moreover, the desire to belong becomes especially productive when it arises from experiences of not fully belonging (Probyn 1996), propelling movements between outside and inside and generating relations among individuals and groups. What requires attention is therefore how dynamics fostering belonging are negotiated in relation to the group and external social contexts.

The study problematises assumptions of openness and unrestricted syncretism by showing how seemingly individual practices are shaped by collective expectations, shared values, organisational structures, and boundary-making

processes. Rather than approaching TST in terms of the apparently free combination of pre-existing elements, I employ alignment and tension to examine how practices are negotiated. While individual participants draw on diverse cultural and religious resources, the analysis demonstrates that practice is negotiated within a social structure. This perspective shifts analytical attention from what is combined to how and under what conditions practices become legitimised, highlighting the role of social regimes in shaping movement coherence. Attention to alignment and tension also makes visible forms of disagreement, contestation, institutionalisation, and fragmentation.

The thesis thus contributes to broader discussions of religious innovation, internal dynamics and institutionalisation in NRM-studies, offering a relational and process-oriented understanding of how NRMs take shape. By examining how members respond to organisational developments and change, it provides an empirically grounded account of the formative phases of a movement and the intensity and volatility that characterise these stages. A central contribution lies in showing how assembling processes operate across analytical levels. Through attention to regimes of social ordering, individual experiences, commitments, and interpretations are understood in relation to participation in collective contexts. Individual and collective processes are situated within broader socio-political environments that condition their operation. This is particularly evident in relation to stigma and stigma management.

7.2 Assembling in Conditions of Stigma

The inclusion of stigma in the assemblage framework has enriched understanding of relational becoming through alignment and tension across the analytical levels. This study goes beyond conceptualisations of stigma primarily as individuals' management of spoiled identity in everyday interactions (Goffman 1986), approaching stigma instead as a multi-level phenomenon operating across interpersonal, organisational, and structural contexts (Link and Phelan 2001; Hatzenbuehler 2016; Scambler 2018; Tyler and Slater 2018). Thus, stigma links different levels of analysis and can be understood as a mechanism through which tensions are transmitted across scales of the assemblage. The study has demonstrated how stigma operates in three mutually constitutive forms—structural, anticipated, and lived. The structural stigma surrounding Satanism constitutes an enduring source of tension between TST and wider society. It provides the broader socio-political context within which participants anticipate negative judgements, while lived experiences of hostility, stereotyping and unequal treatment reinforce expectations of future stigmatisation. Moreover, stigma-driven tensions between TST and wider society are translated into individual and collective responses, including various forms of stigma management. Here, the analysis elaborates upon Bromley and Melton's (2012) concern with socio-cultural alignment, illustrating how tensions

originating in the wider social environment become translated into organisational practices, emotional experiences, and everyday negotiations of identity. Thus, stigma contributes to the production of alignment by generating shared concerns and strategies.

Although the analysis has addressed multiple manifestations of structural stigma, including hostile public reactions and attacks on TST's headquarters, most respondents in the survey do not express concern about being threatened or physically attacked. Anticipated stigma most commonly takes the form of fears of negative stereotyping, particularly in workplaces and in socio-political contexts perceived as conservative. Lived stigma is reported as unequal treatment and social friction in interactions outside TST. Such experiences are most frequently linked to participants' religious affiliation with TST, followed by their socio-political views, which participants often frame as aligned with the movement's core values and activist efforts. The effects of stigma may extend beyond participants themselves, spilling over onto family members. In assemblage terms, stigma functions simultaneously as a territorialising and deterritorialising force (Deleuze and Guattari 2013): shared experiences of marginalisation may strengthen solidarity and collective identification, but may also weaken identification, constrain engagement, and contribute to withdrawal or fragmentation.

The interconnected forms of stigma are closely intertwined with stigma-management practices. Here, information control is important, but the plurality of disclosure approaches within TST suggests that there is no single disclosure etiquette: information-control practices are context-sensitive and adapted to individuals' needs and situations. In particular, participants are least comfortable being openly identified as Satanists in the workplace. Instances of purposeful disclosure suggest a more complex dynamic than that envisioned by Goffman (1986). While such acts resonate with his notion of the 'graceful' integration of a discreditable identity in one's life, they also function as deliberate attempts to challenge structural stigma. This suggests that disclosure is not adequately understood as a matter of an individual 'moral career'. Rather, it operates as a socially negotiated practice, embedded in shared values within the assemblage and shaped by broader socio-cultural contexts. Here, voluntary disclosure becomes less a final stage of personal maturation and more a strategic practice that may serve collective goals. Stigma management also connects levels through the role of ministers as mediators of ritual participants' information control (as discussed in 5.1.3). Ministers modulate ritual design, negotiating both broader stigma-driven tensions surrounding Satanism and participants' anticipation of stigma.

Beyond information control, stigma management is enacted through reflexive engagement at both individual and group levels—especially through counter-discourses that contest stigmatising frames such as conspiracy theories. This corresponds with Goffman's (1986) observation that stigmatised groups often develop ideologies oriented towards social change and invest in

knowledge production. In the case of TST, relatively high reported levels of educational attainment and TST's digital platforms may resource such efforts. The emotional dimension of stigma management is also pronounced, particularly in practices of community care that respond to collective trauma, such as attacks on TST's headquarters. Seeking support within the community, affiliating with fellow members, and participating in campaigns for religious representation can thus be understood as both individual strategies and forms of collective, largely voluntary labour aiming to resist stigma. Through public visibility and Satanic good work initiatives, local congregations engage in narrative redefinition, transforming stigma into a matter of contestation rather than merely a condition to be managed.

Stigma management in TST is also enacted through aesthetic regimes cultivated within the movement. Darker gothic aesthetics and Satanic iconography transform stigma symbols into prestige symbols. Cute, whimsical aesthetic regimes rely on disidentifier symbols—instead of the expected transgression or darkness, they mobilise sweetness, humour and playfulness, disrupting stereotypical expectations of menace and evil and inviting alternative readings of Satanism. Within TST's repertoire of practices, blasphemy functions as an aesthetically and emotionally saturated form of stigma management through which alignment and dealignment are negotiated (see 5.1.3). As proposed in this study, dealignment refers to a strategy of deliberate distancing from norms, traditions, and frameworks perceived as incompatible with a particular assemblage. Blasphemous practices often involve the strategic inversion, parody, or contestation of dominant religious symbols and narratives. Through such ritualised dealignment, participants distance themselves from religious norms and authorities that they perceive as oppressive while simultaneously aligning with alternative values and identities.

Stigma in TST can also extend beyond a Satanist identity itself, encompassing other stigmatised positions that intersect with adherents' religious affiliation. Consistent with Barker's (2004) argument that membership of NRMs reflects distinct demographic segments, and Moody's (1974) observation that individuals drawn to Satanism often diverge from prevailing norms prior to recruitment, the present study suggests a degree of demographic distinctiveness within TST. Most notably, this concerns the high representation of LGBTQ+ identities, in line with earlier studies (Colin 2021; Sprankle et al. 2020). While gender distribution is more balanced in the present study (40% women and 40% men) than in previous surveys, all studies point to a significant presence of non-binary identities. In the present survey, 19% identify as gender-diverse (vs. c. 2% in the general US population). The analysis suggests that adherents perceive TST as an inclusive space in relation to other identity aspects such as lifestyle, gender and sexual orientation. As discussed in 5.2.1, reported experiences of equal treatment in TST are in contrast to more mixed experiences in wider society. This difference indicates that, for some members, TST functions as a refuge from structural stigma—a community

assembled around the discourse on solidarity-for-diversity. Such patterns resonate with Goffman's (1986) argument that stigmatised individuals seek communities of sympathetic others. Belonging to a group that accommodates diversity in gender, sexuality, and other marginalised identities may alleviate stress associated with information control, reinforcing internal cohesion and alignment. Stigma management extending beyond Satanist identity was also evident in discussions around abortion services, where participants support one another while reflecting on their experiences of navigating socio-political and legal contexts in which abortion is contested or condemned. Here, both Satanist identity and collectively reinforced value alignment around bodily autonomy function as resources for managing abortion-related stigma.

While experiences of marginalisation may foster alignment with other stigmatised groups beyond TST and encourage engagement with broader socio-political causes, the stigma attached to Satanism may simultaneously constrain TST participants' ability to engage under the banner of their religion (see 6.2.2). Stigma thus functions both as a source of solidarity and of tension, complicating coalition-building with external actors and enactment of alignment that extends beyond the boundaries of TST's assemblage.

7.3 Emotional Regimes of Belonging

Stigma and stigma management are closely connected to emotional regimes of belonging, such as 'coming home' and 'Satanic joy'. Contemporary Satanist and Pagan narratives often differ from classical conversion accounts (Lewis 2010a; Johnston 2013). Rather than framing their experiences as a spiritual awakening or rebirth into a new self, practitioners tend to emphasise self-continuity, presenting religious identity as something already present and the tradition as a natural fit with pre-existing orientations. Lewis (2010a) attributes this pattern to modes of involvement, whereby individuals typically encounter these communities through printed or online sources rather than through pre-existing social ties. He further suggests that narratives of being born a Satanist or 'coming home' to Satanism can be analysed as identity construction rather than conversion. Popular culture plays an important role in supplying narratives and symbols through which adherents articulate experiences of having 'always been' Satanists (Dyrendal 2008; Petersen and Dyrendal 2012). My interpretation of 'coming home' as a socially constituted emotional regime supports the view that conversion narratives are shaped by the rhetorical conventions of particular traditions (Johnston 2013). McKinnon (2022) argues that religious communities cultivate recognisable narrative 'genres' that are intelligible and resonant for their members. These genres reflect both explicit and implicit norms regarding which experiences are meaningful or desirable within the group's worldview. Johnston (2013) conceptualises the trope of 'coming home' among Pagans as a 'rhetoric of continuity', linking it to the

discursive negotiation of legitimacy and authenticity in contexts of stigma. My empirical findings support this interpretation for TST. Participants often report feeling comfortable and accepted in TST-related settings, while anticipating negative stereotyping, unequal treatment, and discrimination outside the community. These experiences are associated primarily with participants' religious affiliation and socio-political views, but also with lifestyle, gender, and sexual orientation. This suggests that experiences of stigma contribute to the formation of 'coming home' as an emotional regime. Persisting structural stigma against Satanic and other marginalised identities in wider society shapes assembling dynamics at both individual and group levels, illustrating how alignment and tension operate across levels.

This study thus supports and extends previous discussions of 'coming home'. First, it highlights the significance of the emotional dimension arguing that 'coming home' is more than a cognitive genre. Closely related to 'coming home' is the emotional regime of 'Satanic joy', through which participation in TST is framed as affirming and empowering. Participants describe this joy as emerging through experiences of self-expression, creativity, and social interaction with like-minded others. Satanic joy can counterbalance experiences of exclusion and stigma. Moreover, it may help participants navigate internal tensions within the movement by reaffirming commitments to shared values and sustaining attachment to the collective. Second, by conceptualising 'coming home' as an emotional regime, I argue that such articulations are not solely a matter of individual identity construction. The study demonstrates empirically that congregational practices in TST play a significant role in cultivating these emotional regimes as mechanisms through which alignment is reinforced. This resonates with Petersen and Dyrendal's (2012) observation that Satanist identities emerge through a combination of intellectual fit, emotional support, and social networks. It also supports Ahmed's (2004) argument that emotions align individuals with communities through shared attachments, and Riis and Woodhead's (2010) conceptualisation of emotional regimes as mechanisms of recognition and belonging. Third, the study places these emotional regimes within an assemblage-theoretical framework, showing how the synergies generated through the interaction of the emotional regimes of belonging with other dimensions of practice stabilise TST's assemblage.

While TST does not appear to be a high-demand religious movement, placing relatively limited behavioural or financial obligations on its adherents, participants nonetheless pay a social cost. The anticipated stigma in relation to surrounding society, especially pronounced in professional contexts, is significant. This social cost may be balanced by positive and empowering experiences within the movement. Emotional regimes of belonging suggest the emergence of community-based resources that mitigate the impact of structural stigma. However, belonging is closely tied to perceived value alignment and can be destabilised when divergent interpretations of shared values introduce points of friction.

7.4 Alignment Through Tension?

Value Alignment and Positioning towards Wider Society

This study shows that TST is not wholly at odds with wider society; rather, it aligns with broader trends while simultaneously differentiating itself through particular commitments. Value alignment is one of the principal mechanisms through which TST assembles as a religious movement. The Seven Tenets provide a shared ethical framework and participants frequently mention alignment with the Tenets as a reason for deep engagement with the movement. The resonance of these principles creates a community in which diverse experiences and identities can be accommodated while remaining coherent.

These principles align with widely shared moral frameworks among American adults, with the emphasis on science and justice more endorsed by non-religious adults (Cragun 2025). Value alignment, emotional regimes, and social trust are mutually reinforcing, territorialising TST's assemblage. Especially within local congregations, the interplay between these factors can foster solidarity. TST participants report exceptionally high levels of in-group trust (96%), signalling strong social bonding (see 6.1.2). Alignment around values such as bodily autonomy and compassion shapes TST participants' orientation towards conditions in wider society, providing a lens through which they articulate social critiques and shared hope for change (see 4.2.3).

The study demonstrates that, when examined through the lens of Bromley and Melton's (2012) typology, the degree of socio-cultural alignment between TST and its surrounding society is complex and multi-layered. Rather than being uniformly low, as Bromley and Melton suggest for an emergent tradition group, levels of socio-cultural alignment vary across different dimensions. They are also shaped by the ways in which these dimensions intersect with participants' specific social contexts. Consequently, TST comes closer to Bromley and Melton's description of an alternative tradition group. Importantly, 'wider society' cannot be treated as homogeneous: within the US, it comprises several competing normative systems. As in many contemporary Western contexts, what sociologists label 'society' is marked by ideological fragmentation, meaning that there is no single centre with which a NRM can align and from which it can distance itself (Zeller 2021: 65).

The analysis suggests that TST participants do not exhibit the strongly exclusionary orientations towards wider society often associated with NRMs. Rather than adopting a rigid 'us vs. them' stance, participants appear to maintain a relatively open orientation towards people outside their community. This contrasts with Barker's (2004) observation that NRMs typically cultivate such attitudes. Trust of people outside TST (42%) is lower than within the community but remains comparable to recent US national averages (32% in 2021; down from 43% in 2016). This suggests that TST participants combine strong internal solidarity with external trust levels similar to the general

population. Likewise, Barker's claim that NRMs divide reality into clear categories of good and evil finds little support in this case.

Points of alignment with broader US society are also evident in terms of demographic characteristics. Many TST respondents report Christian upbringing (76%), closely mirroring national figures (81%), with similar patterns of denominational background. Urban upbringing is prevalent, reflecting broader demographic trends. Age patterns further indicate that, as in other Satanic groups, TST includes substantial numbers of adults, suggesting that its appeal extends beyond a younger segment of society.

Identity-Defining Tension

Alignment within TST is intertwined with identity-defining fields of tension that distinguish TST from wider society and strengthen its internal cohesion. This resonates with Petersen's (2016) observation that contemporary Satanism develops through various forms of tension. The present study also invites a reconsideration of cyclical models in the study of Satanism, such as Laycock's (2020) account of recurrent culture war dynamics and Introvigne's (2002) pendulum theory. While these perspectives offer a macro-level understanding of how tensions between Satanism and wider society periodically intensify and subside, the assemblage-oriented approach developed here conceptualises tension and alignment as parallel and constitutive forces. TST thus assembles not as a predictable swing of a broader pendulum, but as a historically and socio-culturally specific formation in which tension and alignment operate simultaneously and at multiple scales.

In this study, alignment and tension with society were examined through socio-political attitudes, including perceptions of social wrongs, visions of a good society and their translation into emotional regimes and discourses. Ongoing polarisation in the US, particularly the stark antagonism between liberal and conservative values, likely intensifies the tensions surrounding TST's socio-cultural positioning and shape its assembling. In more liberal environments, TST's positions on socio-cultural change may be relatively close to prevailing norms; in more conservative contexts, however, the same patterns can be associated with heightened tension. The analysis suggests that participants in TST experience tension with wider society, particularly regarding national trends in the US. This tension, characterised by dissatisfaction with the direction of the country and a perception that society is in the midst of a major crisis, is conceptualised in the study as an emotional regime of discontent. Although direct comparison with the broader US population is limited, the analysis suggests a degree of alignment with wider public sentiment in terms of dissatisfaction with national conditions (see 1.6.2). Dissatisfaction appears more pronounced among TST respondents (95%) than among the average American adults (75%). Similarly, TST respondents report greater dissatisfaction with local conditions (57%) than the broader population (34%).

Patterns of emotional response further underscore this tension. Reported anger and fear when contemplating the state of the country appear higher among TST respondents than in the general US population, whereas differences in national pride are comparatively smaller.[59] At the same time, TST participants express greater hope about the country's future (64%) than Americans generally (51%). This suggests that the emotional regime of discontent operating within TST coexists with optimism that may motivate engagement for social change.

This study supports Colin's (2025) argument that TST represents a distinctly political form of contemporary Satanism, while extending his analysis. Based on insights presented in Chapter 4, I argue that attitudes to Christian nationalism and abortion restrictions in the US are articulated through discourses of discontent embedded within the assemblage. These discourses intertwine with emotional regimes of discontent and function as identity-defining fields of tension between TST and the US as its primary host society, while reflecting in-group alignment through shared orientations. Strong opposition to Christian nationalism aligns closely with what Whitehead and Perry (2020) identify as Rejecters: Americans most firmly opposed to Christian nationalism (see 1.6.1). Although direct comparison is not possible, the analysis tentatively suggests that TST participants' views resemble those of approximately 7% of Americans in both the intensity of their opposition and certain demographic characteristics, including higher levels of educational attainment.

Views on abortion access suggest a notable attitudinal difference from the broader American population. Whereas 35% of US adults believe that abortion should be illegal in all or most cases (see 1.6.2), no respondents in the TST survey support the illegality of safe abortion. This suggests that, although a majority of Americans appear to be at odds with the Supreme Court's position, the tension is especially pronounced within TST. Importantly, these attitudinal patterns correspond closely with participants' alignment with TST's advocacy in this area: the movement's campaign Religious Reproductive Rights receives the highest evaluation for importance in the present survey. Alignment with this campaign can also function as a pathway to participation in the movement. Thus, TST assembles between alignment and tension through these interconnections, linking its positioning in relation to macro-level trends, meso-level dynamics and micro-level experiences of discontent and belonging.

[59] Emotional responses to the state of the country from the 2024 TST survey and among the wider US population in 2022 (see 1.6.2 and 4.2.1): fearful, TST 88% vs. US adults 56%; hopeful, TST 64% vs. US adults 51%; angry, TST 93% vs. US adults 49%; proud, TST 8% vs. US adults 22%.

Desire for Change

Dissatisfaction with society is not merely oppositional but translates into positive visions of social transformation. In assemblage terms, tension becomes productive, aligning actors around conceptions of a desirable social order. The separation of church and state is central to the type of society participants in TST envision. This orientation is reflected both in expressed attitudes and in respondents' organisational involvement beyond TST, with some respondents reporting current or previous engagement with secularist organisations. Normative commitments to secularism among TST respondents appear largely aligned with wider American public opinion. However, US public opinion on this issue spans a broad spectrum, with approximately one in four supporting some degree of religious influence in governance (see 1.6.1). Within this broader context, TST respondents express a markedly more internally consistent position. In other words, the distinction lies not in the direction of opinion but in the level of consensus. This alignment is also evident in views on the judiciary. TST respondents' opinions that Supreme Court justices should not bring their personal religious views into major case decisions align with broader public sentiment. Again, this stance is unanimous among TST respondents. A clearer point of tension emerges when TST respondents evaluate the current level of religious influence on the Supreme Court. While 44% of US adults feel there is too much religious influence on the Court, all TST respondents share this assessment, revealing a sharper and more unified critique.

Attitudes to religious pluralism also suggest alignment between TST respondents and wider society. A slim majority of Americans (52%) and a larger share of TST respondents (75%) support a society characterised by religious diversity. This pattern also indicates a greater variety of positions within the TST group participating in the survey than on other topics. Several voices highlight points of friction that may arise in pluralistic religious contexts, while others doubt the beneficial role of religion in society. Religious pluralism thus represents a more contested domain, as the community actively explores and negotiates differing viewpoints.

The desire for change expressed by TST participants is also linked to concerns about inequality and marginalisation. Respondents more often identify as working- and lower-class and less as middle- and upper-class, and many hold marginalised, particularly LGBTQ+ identities. These patterns are reflected in participants' visions of a good society, which emphasise support for LGBTQ+ individuals, BIPOC communities, people struggling with addiction, and/or economic hardship. These orientations extend beyond individual attitudes and translate into practices of alliance-building. TST cultivates alliances with organisations and communities to pursue their vision of a desirable society. When reaching out to secularist organisations, TST participants rely on shared goals such as resistance to religious hegemony. Collaborations extend beyond secularist groups, to include local activist initiatives, and, in some cases, interfaith networks. However, these collaborations are also shaped by

the enduring stigma surrounding Satanism. The analysis thus demonstrates how shared orientations correspond to socio-political attitudes, discourses, emotional regimes and inform aspirations for social transformation. At the same time, the analysis complicates understandings of activism as the defining feature of TST. While this study confirms that national campaigns constitute important points of alignment and attraction for members, it also reveals variation in how activism is prioritised and enacted. Direct involvement in campaigns appears limited, with the most common form of participation being sharing of campaign-related information (22%). More invested forms of engagement are less common (see 4.4.1). Participants perceive a gap between national-level activism and local congregational life. Whereas national campaigns are valued ideologically, they may also be experienced as distant or insufficiently accountable. Activism therefore appears as both a source of alignment and a site of potential tension within the assemblage.

This insight has implications for understanding the processes through which TST assembles. Colin (2021) highlights rejection or fear of the rise of the evangelical right as a motivation for joining TST, alongside the appeal of community. There is a notable parallel between his findings and mine. Although activism occupies a central place in TST's public profile and frequently appears as a pathway into participation, the present study suggests that it alone cannot account for the assemblage dynamics. Belonging and the sense of community are other central aspects in participants experiences with TST. The everyday reproduction of the assemblage seems to occur less through campaign participation than through communal life.

7.5 Spirals of Territorialisation and Deterritorialisation

Territorialisation through Congregational Life

Local congregations emerge as key contexts where social relations and experiences of belonging are nurtured (see 6.1). From an assemblage perspective, these congregations provide conditions for the emergence of spirals of territorialisation, as shared orientations crystallise in regimes of social ordering that reinforce attachment to the movement. About 91% of TST respondents report belonging to a local congregation.

At the congregational level, TST assembles as a refuge and a space of belonging. Local communities are frequently described as spaces of empowerment and mutual support, where members encounter others who share similar experiences, commitments, and social concerns. Value alignment thus forms an important basis for communal life. Cohesion is generated through the interaction of emotional and aesthetic regimes with discourses and their enactment in religious practice.

Congregations are also vital for sustaining religious life. Members participate in rituals, celebrations, and informal gatherings that reinforce both

interpersonal bonds and collective identification. Communal rituals transform the values articulated in the Tenets from abstract principles to embodied experiences. Through repeated participation, these practices stabilise the assemblage. Aesthetic regimes further contribute to these communally driven territorialising spirals. Through visual symbols, ritual performances, curated atmospheres, and forms of self-presentation, congregational life creates sensory experiences that affirm collective identity. While such aesthetic regimes facilitate community formation, they may also generate exclusion by presupposing familiarity with particular cultural codes.

The significance of congregational life becomes particularly visible in relation to the social costs associated with Satanic identification. While TST does not appear to be a high-demand religious movement in terms of behavioural or financial obligations, many participants anticipate stigma. Experiences of belonging within local communities can partially offset these costs by providing emotional support, recognition, and validation. Congregational life thus generates resources that mitigate the effects of stigma.

At the same time, these territorialising spirals remain fragile. Congregational life depends heavily on voluntary engagement and limited material resources. Central to the maintenance of local communities are ministers and other highly engaged members who invest substantial time and largely unpaid labour in organising community activities and building social networks. The absence of permanent meeting spaces, leadership burnout, and ongoing negotiations concerning governance and relations with the central organisation create structural vulnerabilities. From this perspective, the relative stability of TST's assemblage appears contingent upon the continued support and recognition of these local structures and actors. Strengthening the conditions under which congregational life can be sustained thus seems central to the movement's capacity to maintain itself as a religious formation over time.

Spirals of Territorialisation Connecting Levels

While TST emphasises individual autonomy, this study demonstrates that personal practice is never entirely individual. Through shared orientations, ritual forms and boundary-making discourses, alignment and dealignment dynamics connect micro-level with meso-level practices in the assemblage. Territorialisation occurs through these levels' mutual reinforcement. Participants frequently express a desire for autonomy in shaping their own Satanism and local congregational life, yet they do so while negotiating shared frameworks that provide continuity and coherence. Ritual templates and emerging traditions contribute to temporary stabilisations within TST's assemblage. For example, the practice of opening services with a Satanic invocation creates a recognisable form of participation that connects individual experiences to collective patterns. The coexistence of institutionalisation and improvisation makes practice recognisable without eliminating individual flexibility.

Approaches to individual practice demonstrate how alignment and dealignment operate simultaneously as assembling dynamics. Participants draw upon diverse cultural and religious repertoires, selectively adapting these for Satanic purposes. Such approaches involve reflexive engagement with Significant Others (Hammer 2003), negotiating influences through inter-religious and secular-religious diffusion (Tremlett 2021), whereby elements are borrowed, reconfigured and incorporated into TST's assemblage. The assemblage permits considerable variation, yet this variation remains structured by shared frameworks that connect personal practice to organisational norms.

Central in this regard is the rationalist discourse that permeates TST. The present study contributes to scholarly discussions on the relationship between Satanism and science by demonstrating that engagements with a rationalist rhetoric function as mechanisms of alignment and dealignment. The analysis shows that science-oriented discourse is used to claim legitimacy, consistent with Hammer's (2003) and Lewis's (2010b) observations. References to evidence-based thinking validate individual approaches to Satanic practice, distinguishing them from positions perceived as incompatible with TST's self-understanding. Through such appeals, practitioners dealign from supernaturalism and align with the community's shared values, navigating the space for individual creativity. Anchored in the Tenets, TST's rationalist discourse contributes to territorialisation by creating a shared epistemological orientation that connects individual and organisational levels. Personal practice remains creative and fluid, but structured through alignment with shared norms.

Similar dynamics of alignment and dealignment can be observed in the movement's adoption of religious language and institutional forms. The emic negotiation of religious vocabulary illustrates how alignment and dealignment unfold in parallel, shaping one another. By aligning with recognisable terminology (e.g., 'minister' and 'congregation') and established templates (e.g., 'religious services'), members engage in inter-religious diffusion, translating familiar religious forms into a new Satanic context while dealigning from their associated theological meanings. Such adaptations can be understood as pragmatic efforts to navigate broader conceptions of legitimate religion. Consistent with Taira's (2013a) observation that NRMs strategically invoke religion as a category to gain public visibility, and Laycock's (2013) argument that minority religions frequently employ the grammar of established traditions to pursue rights and recognition, I interpret these processes of assembling as forms of strategic alignment with regulatory frameworks in the host society.

Spatiality in a Hybrid Assemblage

Assemblage theory foregrounds the distributed character of agency, emerging through relations between actors, material arrangements, and the regimes of social ordering that condition and connect them (Deleuze and Guattari 2013). While the present study has primarily focused on ordering regimes, it also demonstrates the significance of the spatial dimension. The analysis of central

themes such as congregational life and stigma management indicates that space is constitutive of the assembling processes.

Colin (2021) argues that what distinguishes TST from other forms of contemporary Satanism is that it is not merely a virtual phenomenon. The present study extends this observation by demonstrating that TST is best understood as a hybrid assemblage in which online and offline forms of engagement coexist (see 6.1.1). Participants move between digital platforms and in-person gatherings, establishing connections across local, national, and transnational scales. The spaces through which TST assembles shape possibilities for participation and belonging: online fora, social media groups, private homes, rented venues, and public spaces each afford different forms of interaction. Physical gatherings create opportunities for embodied communal life, while digital environments enable dispersed participants to sustain interaction despite logistical and other pragmatic obstacles. Furthermore, congregations employ digital platforms for membership vetting and community management, demonstrating how boundaries are maintained and mediated through technological infrastructures. At the same time, digital platforms may become sites of tension, as demonstrated by the role of Facebook interactions in the conflicts preceding the 2024 schism (see 6.2.1).

Rather than separate spheres, online and offline communal spaces are complementary and intersecting, contributing both to the territorialisation and deterritorialisation of the assemblage. This hybridity also reflects the movement's material conditions. Unlike many established religious organisations, local congregations typically lack permanent meeting spaces and often organise their gatherings in private homes. These material constraints shape patterns of participation and influence how communities develop and endure. Admission into domestic spaces involves a specific form of boundary crossing, creating opportunities for deeper social bonds and reinforcing perceptions of mutual commitment. In this sense, spatial arrangements support the production and regulation of belonging.

Crisis, Fragmentation and Consolidation

The analytical value of focusing on assembling through alignment and tension becomes particularly visible when accounting for moments of crisis. The material analysed in this study was collected in 2024, a year in which TST underwent renewed external pressure, including two violent attacks on the headquarters, alongside growing internal tension. Conflicts over authority and trust appear to have destabilised the assemblage, prompting fragmentation. New schisms followed leadership disputes and the cancellation of SatanCon. While some communities dissociated from TST entirely, others sought to incorporate displaced members, illustrating divergent strategies for preserving integrity and organisational continuity.

Such moments foreground the effects of tension on assembling dynamics. As Simmel (2024) suggests, external pressure may intensify internal relations,

rendering latent tensions more acute or eliminating them. From an assemblage perspective, crisis can accelerate and reconfigure the relational becoming through two parallel and partially opposing processes. It may strengthen spirals of territorialisation through clearer boundary-making, stronger identification with the movement's values and goals, and relegation of internal dissent. Alignment across both individual and organisational levels is thereby intensified in the interest of resilience and continuity. The same tensions may generate lines of flight that propel spirals of deterritorialisation, amplifying dissonance and resulting in withdrawal, disengagement, or the formation of new trajectories that seek to detach from the assemblage. In this sense, tension functions as a productive force in the assembling, reordering relations across multiple scales.

The analysis of the 2024 survey indicates that overall satisfaction with TST and satisfaction with local congregations are high. Participants highlight democratic structures, value alignment, and inclusive practices as important sources of trust and belonging. Satisfaction is often framed as a calculated balance between activist ambition, limited resources, and the voluntary nature of the organisation. Positive evaluations coexist with critical perspectives that expose underlying tensions. While many participants feel that TST reflects their expectations and commitments, there is a notable contrast between perceptions of local communities and the national organisation. Respondents report strong intra-community alignment and positive experiences at the local level but also express disconnection from the movement's national campaigns and concerns about central leadership. Points of frustration are over perceived lack of transparency and accountability in the Executive Ministry.

Although participants broadly agree on TST's mission as a socially engaged religious movement, disagreements arise over the scope and style of activism. Some advocate provocative tactics; others favour cooperative approaches. These divergent strategies reflect competing interpretations of what constitutes effective and ethical activism. Participants also navigate boundaries between personal and organisational activism. While some argue that as an institution TST should limit its engagement to issues directly tied to its core values such as religious freedom and bodily autonomy, others advocate a broader activist agenda. Such disagreements generate friction at both national and congregational levels and illustrate the fragility of alignment when individual commitments collide with organisational constraints.

Highly engaged members frequently hold multiple roles to sustain their communities. The ongoing schisms underscore the vulnerability of membership commitment in NRMs, a dynamic identified by Barker (2004). Examining TST's internal divisions in 2018, including the departure of former spokesperson Jex Blackmore and the disaffiliation of several local groups, Laycock (2020), drawing on Finke and Scheitle (2009), argues that schisms are more likely in the absence of stable institutional frameworks. TST presents an instructive case in this regard. Ministers are not salaried by the organisation but

instead pay to participate in ministerial training programmes. Moreover, although congregations must meet general requirements to maintain affiliation, they retain significant autonomy in determining leadership structures, membership policies, and community organisation. Much of the practical and economic support sustaining congregational life appears to be generated locally rather centrally. Under such conditions, significant disagreements are more likely to culminate in schism (Finke and Scheitle 2009). These recurring divisions revolve around enduring questions concerning central leadership, organisational accountability, and the boundaries of activism. Experiences of belonging are closely tied to perceived value alignment and may become unstable when competing interpretations of shared values emerge, particularly regarding whether central leadership is seen as embodying those values. Such tensions create points of friction that generate lines of flight, propelling processes of deterritorialisation and fragmenting the assemblage.

7.6 Limitations of the Study

Integrating several forms of empirical material enables attention to the distributed and multi-sited character of TST as an assemblage. At the same time, the empirical material is shaped by particular pathways of access. Rather than providing an exhaustive representation of TST, the study offers a situated account that foregrounds certain forms of participation while rendering others less visible. The recruitment strategy, centred on congregational networks and self-selection, likely privileges participants with relatively strong ties to the local branches of the organisation. As a result, individuals with looser or more peripheral forms of affiliation, such as campaign supporters or self-identified allies, may be less represented in the material. Relatedly, actors involved in the organisation and leadership of campaigns remain less visible. This reflects both limitations in access and transparency at this level of the organisation and the practical constraints of time-bound research.

The study cannot address discussions taking place within closed TST groups or restricted digital spaces, and thus the material may be skewed towards more curated, outward-facing forms of communication, potentially underrepresenting internal debates, disagreements, and everyday interactions among members. While critical perspectives are present in the empirical material, including accounts of participants who left TST during the period of contact, those who were less engaged or had left the movement prior to recruitment are generally absent. It cannot be ruled out that some individuals represented in the material (e.g., ministers participating in recorded services, interviewees or survey respondents) may have left TST subsequently, particularly in light of internal developments during 2024. If so, their perspectives reflecting their later status of ‘disillusioned’ are not captured here.

Analysis of digital material is based on mediated documentation, connected to both practical and ethical challenges of conducting synchronous digital ethnographic work on the platforms where the services were held. While the interviews, survey data, and observational notes provide a snapshot of assembling processes in 2024, the digital material—spanning a longer period (2021–2024)—enriches these findings by tracing longer-term discursive patterns. Although the study adopts a practice-oriented approach, its engagement with regimes of social ordering benefits from this context. The regimes identified in the study are therefore not treated as emerging solely in 2024, but as pre-existing formations. Their presence in the digital material supports an analysis of these regimes as socially structured, mediated and partially sedimented, rather than isolated or individual articulations.

Methodologically, the survey results must be interpreted with caution. Direct comparisons with previous quantitative studies of Satanism or TST are limited by differences in sampling frames, recruitment strategies, survey design, and modes of distribution. The present survey relied on non-random sampling and an extensive online questionnaire. Such conditions may favour participation among highly engaged members and individuals with higher levels of education, potentially producing a sample that is not fully representative of the wider TST population. The age distribution likewise requires careful interpretation. Recruitment strategies shape samples: Sprankle et al. (2020) recruited primarily via Twitter and Instagram, producing a sample roughly a decade younger than the present study. By contrast, this survey—targeting a similar demographic—was not distributed via social media for ethical reasons, but through emails and internal congregational channels, likely increasing participation among older cohorts. Holt's (2022) survey similarly relied on email distribution. Lewis's first survey (2000–2001) recruited via email addresses posted on Satanist websites; the early stage of internet adoption at that time may have contributed to younger samples initially and to a gradually ageing cohort across subsequent waves. Technology adoption and communication preferences mediate who is accessible, and thus who participates in research. For these reasons, the findings presented here should be understood primarily as a snapshot of the respondents who participated in this particular survey.

7.7 Assemblage as Relational Becoming

The aim of this study was to apply an assemblage-informed analytical framework to the empirical case of TST in order to examine a contemporary religious movement engaged in social change. The study demonstrates empirically how desire operates as a generative force within TST's assemblage. By conceptualising desire as manifested through processes of alignment and dealignment, the study provides a framework for tracing how relations between elements of the assemblage are formed, sustained and contested. Processes of

alignment, dealignment, and tension unfold through identity-defining discourses, value alignment, emotional and aesthetic regimes. Stigma emerges within these interactions, modulating trajectories of becoming. The resulting dynamics generate both spirals of territorialisation that stabilise relations and spirals of deterritorialisation that transform them, producing the ongoing reconfiguration of the assemblage. In this dynamic, both alignment and dealignment can bring temporal stabilisation to an area of TST's assembling, structuring the elements there in a coherent way. In TST, such stabilisation occurs through synergies between different regimes of social ordering that reinforce spirals of territorialisation in the assemblage.

Tension is not a separate mechanism but unfolds in close relation to processes of alignment. While discourses, value alignment, aesthetic and emotional regimes function as important sources of internal cohesion in TST, they can, under conditions of pressure, also become potential sources of conflict. For example, the strong consensus around foundational principles, such as scepticism of arbitrary authority, generates division when members and leaders interpret or enact these principles in different ways. Likewise, commitment to activism as a shared orientation can intensify negotiations over appropriate goals and strategies, occasionally creating conditions for spirals of deterritorialisation. Thus, the assemblage is continually shaped by the interplay of alignment and tension, which together organise the dynamics of cohesion and contestation, establishing connections between individual, collective and wider society.

Future Directions

This synthesis of conceptual approaches provides a framework for understanding the findings of the present study and demonstrates the analytical value of an assemblage-informed perspective. It also identifies several options for future research. Developing operationalisations for studying regimes of social ordering and their role in assemblages could advance understanding of the relationships between individuals and broader social contexts. Methodological approaches such as multimodality, observational participation, and autoethnography could generate further insights into how these regimes intersect in processes of religion-making and social engagement. Such approaches may also facilitate closer attention to material dimensions of assemblage formation, including the spatial organisation of belonging.

While gender and sexuality were included in assemblage dynamics in this study, a fuller picture requires examining other stigmatised identities that intersect with participation, such as disability, neurodivergence, poor mental health, professional precarity and BIPOC experiences—all of which surfaced in the empirical material. Future research could explore how these identities shape dynamics of alignment and tension.

Another important area concerns processes of internal alignment and territorialisation over a longer time period. What forms of restructuring may occur

when the original founders and spokespersons are no longer in leadership positions? Whether the movement continues to exist, institutionalises further, decentralises, or fragments, each trajectory carries implications for how alignment and tension are negotiated within the assemblage. Relatedly, future studies could examine how internal tensions and processes of fragmentation generate new socio-political positionings. For example, splinter groups emerging from disagreements over the scope or character of activist engagement may adopt positions that are either more radical or more accommodating in relation to their socio-political environment.

The broader shift toward religious unaffiliation in the US provides an important backdrop for TST's future positioning. If this trend persists, non-traditional identities and practices may become increasingly normalised, potentially expanding the pool of prospective members. Such developments may affect TST's growth, its experience of structural stigma, and its strategies for public engagement. Likewise, broader transformations in the socio-political environment that reduce tensions between TST and the wider society may reshape organisational priorities, forms of activism, and collective identities. Examining such developments would provide valuable insights into how changing relations between religious movements and their host societies influence processes of alignment, tension, territorialisation, and deterritorialisation over time.

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Appendix I

Information for Participants in the Survey

We want to ask you if you would like to take part in a research project. Here you will find information about the project and what it means to participate.

What is the project and why do you want me to take part?

This research project examines The Satanic Temple as a religious movement and as an agent of social change. The study aims to advance knowledge about the role of religion in social change, the relationship between religious beliefs and engagement in socio-political issues, and the development of communities in hybrid online and offline environments.

You are being asked to participate in a survey because you are involved with The Satanic Temple, for example by being a member of a local congregation, participating in the movement's campaigns, or identifying yourself as a friend of the movement. Only people over the age of 18 can take part in the study.

The research principal for the project is Uppsala University. Research principal means the organization responsible for the project. The application has been approved by the Swedish Ethical Review Board, registration number 2023-06082-01.

How does the project work?

Your participation in the study consists of answering a questionnaire. The survey is completed online and includes questions about your involvement with The Satanic Temple, your socio-political values and attitudes, and some demographic questions about yourself. Before you begin answering the survey, you will be asked to give your consent. You agree to participate in the study by clicking “I agree”. The survey will take approximately 20 minutes to complete.

Possible consequences and risks of taking part in the project

Participation in the research project does not involve any direct risks for you as an individual. The purpose of this study is in no way to contribute to the ridicule, stigmatisation, shame or blame of people involved with The Satanic Temple. As you are participating in a survey that is not distributed personally, but via a link, you will have access to the survey without providing any personal information and without a username and password. Artologik Survey&Report does not store IP numbers or browser information of respondents. There is therefore no link between answers and IP address. It is not possible to link your survey answers to you as an individual and to know what you have answered to the questions.

What happens to my data?

You complete the survey using the Survey&Report tool developed by the Swedish company Artisan. The data collected through Survey&Report is processed in Artisan Global Media's own data centre in Sweden and no data is sent to third countries. Both Artisan Global Media's operations and data centres are ISO 27001 certified for data security. After the survey is completed, the survey data is exported into a SPSS file that is stored and managed on the researcher's password-protected work computer. The survey data will be analysed using statistical methods.

The project will collect and record information about you. This personal information will include your religious beliefs, political views, sexual orientation and activist experience. Your answers and results will be processed in such a way that they cannot be accessed by unauthorised persons.

Uppsala University is responsible for your personal data.

The data protection officer can be contacted at dataskyddsombud@uu.se.

If you have any questions about the study, please contact Zhivka Koleva, Uppsala University, zhivka.koleva@teol.uu.se.

If you are dissatisfied with the way your personal data is processed, you have the right to lodge a complaint with the Swedish Data Protection Authority, which is the supervisory authority.

How do I get information about the results of the project?

The results of the survey will be processed in the form of larger categories so that individual data will not be identifiable. As a survey participant, you will not have access to your individual data. If, when completing the survey (using the comment option), you provide information about events or factors that are not related to the survey and the project, this information will not be processed in the study. The results of the analysis will be published at an aggregated level in a PhD thesis and in scientific articles in peer-reviewed journals.

Insurance and compensation

You will not be covered by insurance. You will not receive any financial compensation for your participation. There will be no financial cost to you for taking part in the study.

Participation is voluntary

Your participation is voluntary. You can choose to not answer a question. If you choose not to complete and submit the survey, you do not have to give a reason.

Responsible for the project

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☐ **I refuse** ☐ **I agree**

Let's begin with some questions about your involvement with The Satanic Temple (TST). How long have you been involved with TST?

- [ ] Less than a year
- [ ] Between 1 and 3 years
- [ ] Between 4 and 6 years
- [ ] Between 7 and 9 years
- [ ] 10 years or more

What describes best your involvement with TST?

- [ ] Registered member
- [ ] Probationary member
- [ ] Ally but not a member
- [ ] Minister
- [ ] Organisational and/or representative role
- [ ] Other

Which TST congregation do you belong to, if any?

- [ ] Don't belong to any congregation
- [ ] The Satanic Temple [local congregation name]

How did you learn about TST?

- ☐ Television
- ☐ Radio
- ☐ Printed newspaper or magazine
- ☐ News website or news app
- ☐ Social media
- ☐ Podcast
- ☐ Documentary "Hail Satan?"
- ☐ The Satanic Temple website
- ☐ Event you attended in person
- ☐ Family/partner
- ☐ Friend
- ☐ Co-worker
- ☐ Other

How often do you interact with TST?

	Daily	Weekly	Monthly	Yearly	Never or almost never
In person	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Online	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

What is the main way you get involved with TST?

- ☐ At local level
- ☐ At state level
- ☐ At national level
- ☐ Not applicable

How much do you know about TST's campaigns?

- ☐ A lot
- ☐ A little
- ☐ Nothing at all

How important for you are the following TST campaigns?

	Very important	Important	Somewhat important	Not important
After School Satan	☐	☐	☐	☐
Grey Faction	☐	☐	☐	☐
Protect Children Project	☐	☐	☐	☐
Religious Reproductive Rights	☐	☐	☐	☐
Satanic Good Works	☐	☐	☐	☐
Satanic Representation Campaign	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sober Faction	☐	☐	☐	☐
Expert Witness Services for Trans Members	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

In which of these campaigns are you personally involved?

- ☐ After School Satan
- ☐ Expert Witness Services for Trans Members
- ☐ Grey Faction
- ☐ Protect Children Project
- ☐ Religious Reproductive rights
- ☐ Satanic Good Works
- ☐ Satanic Representation Campaign
- ☐ Sober Faction
- ☐ None

Which activities describe best your involvement with the campaign(s)?

- ☐ Keep informed about the campaign
- ☐ Share information about the campaign
- ☐ Support the campaign through volunteering
- ☐ Support the campaign financially
- ☐ Take on organisational responsibilities
- ☐ Start a local initiative
- ☐ Other

Comment

How much do you agree or disagree with the following statements?

	Completely agree	Mostly agree	Mostly disagree	Completely disagree
TST represents my views on religion as non-theistic.	☐	☐	☐	☐
TST represents my views on what role religion should play in the public sphere.	☐	☐	☐	☐
TST represents my views on whether law and policy decisions should be based on secular or religious grounds.	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

Which of the following describes your upbringing in terms of religion?

- ☐ Protestant
- ☐ Catholic
- ☐ Orthodox Christian
- ☐ Jewish
- ☐ Buddhist
- ☐ Hindu
- ☐ Muslim (Shia, Sunni or Sufi)
- ☐ Some other religion
- ☐ No religion

Are you currently involved in a secularist organisation*? (*an organisation that promotes separation of the state from religious institutions)

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Not currently, but I have been

If you are or have been involved in a secularist organisation, please specify which

Are you currently involved in other Satanic communities than TST?

- [ ] Yes
- [ ] No
- [ ] Not currently, but I have been

If you are or have been involved in other Satanic communities, please specify which

Are you currently involved in other religious or spiritual community than TST?

- [ ] Yes
- [ ] No
- [ ] Not currently, but I have been

If you are or have been involved in other religious or spiritual community than TST, please specify which

How often, if ever, do you worry that the following might happen because of your engagement with TST?

	Never	Rarely	Often	Every day
You might be threatened or attacked	☐	☐	☐	☐
You might receive unfair treatment	☐	☐	☐	☐
You might be negatively stereotyped	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

How comfortable do you feel or would you feel to 'come out' as a Satanist in the following contexts?

	Very comfortable	Somewhat comfortable	Somewhat uncomforta-ble	Very uncomforta-ble	Not applicable
Family	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Work	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
School	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Among friends	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Open online community	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Closed online community	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

Thinking about people WITHIN TST COMMUNITY, to what extent do you agree with each of the following statements?

	Completely agree	Mostly agree	Mostly disagree	Completely disagree
They probably share many of my values and goals	☐	☐	☐	☐
Most people in TST community can be trusted	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

Thinking about people OUTSIDE TST COMMUNITY, to what extent do you agree with each of the following statements?

	Completely agree	Mostly agree	Mostly disagree	Completely disagree
They may feel differently than I do about TST, but they probably share many of my other values and goals	☐	☐	☐	☐
Most people OUTSIDE TST COMMUNITY can be trusted	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

Thinking generally about your experiences WITHIN TST COMMUNITY, how much do you agree or disagree with the following statement: I feel that I receive equal treatment in relation to my…

	Completely agree	Mostly agree	Mostly disagree	Completely disagree	Not applicable
Gender	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sexual orientation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Race or ethnicity	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Socio-political views	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Religion (other than TST)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Lifestyle	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

Thinking generally about your experiences OUTSIDE TST COMMUNITY, how much do you agree with the following statement: I feel that I receive equal treatment in relation to my…

	Completely agree	Mostly agree	Mostly disagree	Completely disagree	Not applicable
Gender	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sexual orientation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Race or ethnicity	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Socio-political views	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Religion (including my engagement with TST)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Lifestyle	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

If you think about how alternative religious movements are presented in the public debate, how much, if anything, have you heard or read about the Satanic Ritual Abuse Scare?

- ☐ A lot
- ☐ A little
- ☐ Nothing at all

Which of the following is closest to your view of the Satanic Ritual Abuse Scare?

- [ ] Very bad thing for the country
- [ ] Somewhat bad thing for the country
- [ ] Somewhat good thing for the country
- [ ] Very good thing for the country

Comment

How much, if anything, have you heard or read about QAnon?

- [ ] A lot
- [ ] A little
- [ ] Nothing at all

Which of the following is closest to your view of QAnon?

- [ ] Very bad thing for the country
- [ ] Somewhat bad thing for the country
- [ ] Somewhat good thing for the country
- [ ] Very good thing for the country

Comment

All in all, are you satisfied or dissatisfied with the way things are going in your country today?

- [ ] Satisfied
- [ ] Dissatisfied

Comment

All in all, are you satisfied or dissatisfied with the way things are going in the LOCAL COMMUNITY where you live today?

- [ ] Satisfied
- [ ] Dissatisfied

Comment

Thinking about the state of your country these days, would you say you feel…

	Yes	No
Fearful	☐	☐
Hopeful	☐	☐
Angry	☐	☐
Proud	☐	☐

Comment

All in all, are you satisfied or dissatisfied with what TST is and does today?

☐ Satisfied

☐ Dissatisfied

Comment

If you are a member of a TST local congregation, are you generally satisfied or dissatisfied with the way things are going in your congregation?

☐ Satisfied

☐ Dissatisfied

☐ Not a member of a local congregation

Comment

Thinking about TST's position on socio-political issues that matter to you, would you say you feel…

	Yes	No
Fearful	☐	☐
Hopeful	☐	☐
Angry	☐	☐
Proud	☐	☐

Comment

Next are some questions that will help us understand how you feel about a number of things. Do you think each of the following is generally good or bad for society?

	Very good for society	Somewhat good for society	Somewhat bad for society	Very bad for society
Greater social acceptance of people who are transgender (people who identify as a gender that is different from the sex they were assigned at birth)	☐	☐	☐	☐
A decline in the share of people belonging to an organized religion	☐	☐	☐	☐
Same-sex marriages being legal	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

For each of the following, please indicate whether you think we're spending too much money on it, too little money, or about the right amount.

	Too little	About right	Too much
Improving the conditions of black, Indigenous and people of color	☐	☐	☐
Dealing with drug addiction	☐	☐	☐
Assistance for the poor	☐	☐	☐
Supporting scientific research	☐	☐	☐

Do you think that access to safe abortion services should be

- ☐ Legal in all cases
- ☐ Legal in most cases
- ☐ Illegal in most cases
- ☐ Illegal in all cases

Comment

To what extent do you agree that it is sometimes necessary to discipline a child with a good, hard spanking?

- ☐ Completely agree
- ☐ Mostly agree
- ☐ Mostly disagree
- ☐ Completely disagree

Comment

Now some questions about your opinion on religion and society. In general, do you think the fact that a society is made up of people of many different religions, as well as people who are not religious…

- ☐ Strengthens the society
- ☐ Weakens the society
- ☐ Doesn't make much difference

Comment

To what extent do you agree with the following statements?

	Completely agree	Mostly agree	Mostly disagree	Completely disagree
Religion should be kept separate from government policies	☐	☐	☐	☐
Government policies should support religious values and beliefs	☐	☐	☐	☐
Most things in society are too complicated to be clearly divided into good and evil	☐	☐	☐	☐
Most things in society can be pretty clearly divided between good and evil	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

Regardless of your own religious beliefs, how important, if at all, do you think it is for a person to believe in God in order to be considered good and moral?

- [ ] Essential
- [ ] Important, but not essential
- [ ] Not too important
- [ ] Not at all important

Comment

Do you think churches and religious organizations have

- [ ] Too much influence in politics
- [ ] Not enough influence in politics
- [ ] About the right amount of influence in politics

Comment

Now some questions about your views on religion and the state in the USA. Thinking about the Supreme Court, do you think justices should or should not bring their own religious views into how they decide major cases?

- [ ] Should do this
- [ ] Should NOT do this

Comment

In their recent decisions, how much do you think Supreme Court justices have relied on their religious beliefs?

- [ ] Too much
- [ ] Too little
- [ ] About the right amount

Comment

The Supreme Court has ruled that no state or local government may require the reading of the Lord's Prayer or Bible verses in public schools. What are your views on this - do you approve or disapprove of the court ruling?

- [ ] Approve
- [ ] Disapprove

Comment

How much do you agree or disagree with the following statements?

	Completely agree	Mostly agree	Mostly disagree	Completely disagree
U.S. laws should be based on Christian values.	☐	☐	☐	☐
Being Christian is an important part of being truly American.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The U.S. government should declare America a Christian nation.	☐	☐	☐	☐
If the U.S. moves away from Christian values, we will not have a country	☐	☐	☐	☐

Comment

Do you think the founders of America originally intended for the U.S. to be a Christian nation?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Comment

How much, if anything, have you heard or read about "Christian nationalism"?

☐ A lot

☐ A little

☐ Nothing at all

All in all, do you have a favorable or unfavorable view of Christian nationalism?

☐ Very favorable

☐ Somewhat favorable

☐ Somewhat unfavorable

☐ Very unfavorable

Comment

Finally, a few factual questions about yourself. What year were you born?

Do you describe yourself as a man, a woman, non-binary or in some other way?

- [ ] A man
- [ ] A woman
- [ ] Non-binary
- [ ] In some other way

Regarding sexual orientation, do you consider yourself to be…

- [ ] Heterosexual
- [ ] Gay, Lesbian or Bisexual
- [ ] Other

What is your level of education?

- [ ] Less than high school
- [ ] High school diploma
- [ ] Some college
- [ ] College degree
- [ ] Advanced degree

If you were asked to use one of these four names for your social class, which would you say you belong in?

- [ ] Lower class
- [ ] Working class
- [ ] Middle class
- [ ] Upper class

Which of the categories comes closest to the type of place you were living in when you were 16 years old?

- [ ] In open country but not on a farm
- [ ] On a farm
- [ ] In a small city or town (under 50,000)
- [ ] In a medium-size city (50,000-250,000)
- [ ] In a suburb near a large city
- [ ] In a large city (over 250,000)

In which region do you live?

- [ ] Northeast (USA)
- [ ] Midwest (USA)
- [ ] South (USA)
- [ ] West (USA)
- [ ] If you live in other country than USA, please specify which

What part of the Northeast do you live in?

- [ ] New England (Connecticut, Maine, Massachusetts, New Hampshire, Rhode Island, and Vermont)
- [ ] Middle Atlantic (New Jersey, New York, and Pennsylvania)

What part of the Midwest do you live in?

- [ ] East North Central (Illinois, Indiana, Michigan, Ohio, and Wisconsin)
- [ ] West North Central (Iowa, Kansas, Minnesota, Missouri, Nebraska, North Dakota, and South Dakota)

What part of the South do you live in?

- [ ] South Atlantic (Delaware, Florida, Georgia, Maryland, North Carolina, South Carolina, Virginia, Washington, D.C., and West Virginia)
- [ ] East South Central (Alabama, Kentucky, Mississippi, and Tennessee)
- [ ] West South Central (Arkansas, Louisiana, Oklahoma, and Texas)

What part of the West do you live in?

- [ ] Mountain (Arizona, Colorado, Idaho, Montana, Nevada, New Mexico, Utah, and Wyoming)
- [ ] Pacific (Alaska, California, Hawaii, Oregon, and Washington)

Appendix II

Information to Interview Participants

We would like to ask you to participate in a research project. This document provides information about the project and what it means to participate.

What is the project and why do you want me to participate?

This research project examines The Satanic Temple as a religious movement and actor of social change. The study can increase knowledge about the role of religion for social change, about the connection between religious beliefs and engagement in socio-political issues and the development of communities in hybrid online and offline environments.

You are being asked to participate in an interview because you are involved in The Satanic Temple, for example by being a member of a local congregation, participating in the movement's campaigns or identifying yourself as a friend of the movement. Your contact details have been provided to the project by representatives of local congregations or by study participants who suggest other suitable informants. Only people who have reached the age of 18 can participate in the study.

The research principal for the project is Uppsala University. Research principal means the organization responsible for the project. The application has been approved by the Swedish Ethical Review Board, registration number 2023-06082-01.

How does the project work?

Your participation in the interview consists of answering a number of questions about your involvement in The Satanic Temple. Before starting the interview, you will have the opportunity to ask questions about the study. After the researcher has answered any questions, you will be asked to give your consent. The researcher will send you a form by email where you can give your consent to participate in the study by checking boxes and sending the consent form back to the researcher by email.

The interview is conducted either in writing via email over a period of 3-4 weeks or via Zoom with the camera function turned off. If you choose to do the interview by email, during the first week you will receive the first set of questions that you answer in an email. Once the researcher has received your initial answers, you will be asked to answer some additional questions in the following week. In the final week, you will be asked to raise or elaborate on any topic that you think is important and that has not been covered by the interview questions. At the end of the interview, your answers will be transcribed and then the original (email correspondence or saved Zoom file) will be deleted. The transcribed responses are imported into qualitative analysis software and analysed there by the researcher.

Possible consequences and risks of participating in the project

Participation in the research project involves no direct risks to you as an individual. The purpose of this study is in no way to contribute to the ridicule, stigma, shame or blame of people involved in The Satanic Temple. As a participant in the study, you will not be identifiable as your responses are depicted in the form of larger categories.

However, it cannot be excluded that the interview may provoke difficult emotions and reactions in you. Please inform the researcher if you feel that an interview question or a topic raised by it is too sensitive or difficult to handle. If you feel uncomfortable or become very upset during the interview, you can stop participating in the study. If the interview gives rise to feelings that you cannot handle, you are advised to seek professional support by contacting your primary care physician.

What happens to my data?

As an interviewee, you will be given a fictitious name. The code key to your real name and your contact details will be stored in a locked location at Uppsala University. Any personal data that may appear in the interview and may lead to your identification—such as your exact age, place of residence, workplace, family, etc.—is removed when the interview data is transcribed and imported into qualitative analysis software. The original (the email correspondence or the saved Zoom file) is deleted after this. Collected data about you will be handled by the researcher conducting the study on their password-protected work computer provided by Uppsala University. At the end of the research process, all information about you collected during the interview will be archived in a secure storage facility for ten years and then destroyed, according to the rules of good scientific practice prescribed by Uppsala University.

The processing of your personal data is necessary for carrying out research in the public interest (GDPR, Art 6, p. 1e). The project will collect and record information about you. The personal information will include your religious beliefs, political views, sexual orientation and activism experiences. Your responses and results will be treated in such a way that no unauthorized persons can access them.

The results of the analysis of the interview will be published in a doctoral thesis and scientific articles in peer-reviewed scientific journals. This will be done by showing patterns and categories and by quotes with pseudonyms.

According to the EU General Data Protection Regulation, you have the right to access the information about you that is processed in the project free of charge. You can read through the transcript of your interview, read quotes from your interview that will be used in the thesis and, if necessary, have any errors corrected. You can request to have your data deleted.

Responsible for your personal data is Uppsala University.

The Data Protection Officer can be reached at dataskyddsombud@uu.se.

If you wish to access the data, please contact Zhivka Koleva, Uppsala University, zhivka.koleva@teol.uu.se.

If you are dissatisfied with the processing of your personal data, you have the right to lodge a complaint with the Swedish Data Protection Authority, which is the supervisory authority.

How do I get information about the results of the project?

The interviews will be printed and used in a doctoral thesis and scientific articles in peer-reviewed scientific journals. If you wish, the researcher can provide information on where these can be read after publication. You are always welcome to contact the responsible researcher for further information about the results of the survey. However, you do not need to see the results of the analysis. If unanticipated themes and experiences not included in the interview questions are shared by you, these data will not be processed without your consent.

Insurance and compensation

You will not be covered by insurance. You will not receive any financial compensation for your participation. Participation in the study will also not entail any financial costs for you.

Participation is voluntary

Your participation is voluntary and you can choose to withdraw at any time. If you choose not to participate or wish to withdraw your participation, you do not need to give a reason.
If you wish to cancel your participation, please contact the project managers (see below).

Responsible for the project

Prof. Dr. Mia Lövheim
Department of Theology
Uppsala University
Box 511, 751 20 Uppsala
Sweden
Mia.Lovheim@teol.uu.se

PhD student Zhivka Koleva
Department of Theology
Uppsala University
Box 511, 751 20 Uppsala
Sweden
zhivka.koleva@teol.uu.se

Consent for Participation in the Project

I have received written information about the study and have had the opportunity to ask questions. I can keep the written information.

I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I have the option to withdraw my participation at any time.

I understand that for further questions about my participation I can contact the researcher conducting the study, PhD student Zhivka Koleva, zhivka.koleva@teol.uu.se, and the responsible researcher at Uppsala University, Professor Mia Lövheim, Mia.Lovheim@teol.uu.se.

On these terms, I declare that I am willing to participate in the research project.

☐ I agree to participate in the study The Satanic Temple: Struggle for social and religious change.[60]

☐ I agree that my responses will be processed in the manner described in the research subject information.

Place and date:

Your name:

[60] The consent form included the project's working title, which was used during data collection. The title of the completed thesis was adopted at a later stage.

Interview Guide

Your Journey into Satanism

Could you describe your journey into Satanism and TST?
Why did you join TST (or start a new congregation)?
What is your form and level of involvement with TST?

TST, Socio-Political Values and Social Change

Which socio-political issues are most central to you?
Which of TST's campaigns are most important to you?
What styles of activism do you prefer?

Local Social and Religious Landscape

How would you describe the social environment where you live in terms of religion, politics and values?
Are there secularist organisations you could have joined?
How are their aims and activities similar to or different from what TST can offer to you?

TST as Practice

How do you practice your religion?
Do you engage individually or collectively, online or in-person?
Who organises the activities in which you take part—the national organisation or the local congregation?
Could you describe the settings where these activities take place?
What role do rituals play for you?
What is most important to you at TST?

Identity

How important is TST to your identity?
How does it relate to other aspects of your identity?
What do you think about being a Satanist and an American (or of other nationality)?
When do you disclose your Satanist identity?

Emotions and Experiences

What emotions have shaped your religious journey?
How do you experience emotional support within TST?
How do you experience emotions in ritual and activism?
How do you experience emotions at TST events/visiting HQ/meeting other members?

TST and Culture

What do you think about how Satanism is portrayed in popular culture?
What about the culture created by TST?
What aspects of TST as a cultural experience resonate with you?

Community

How important is community to you?
How would you describe your experiences of TST as a community?

What gives you a sense of belonging?

Organisation and Governance

How do you relate to TST as an organisation?
What do you think about its governance?
What are the requirements for formal alignment of a congregation or campaign with TST?
What is the role of voluntary work in TST?
What are the rules for inclusion and exclusion of members/congregants and how have they evolved?
Does TST cooperate with other organisations? What is your opinion on that?

Closing

Is there anything else you would like to add?

Appendix III

Thematic Overview of TST Services

This thematic overview is based on approximately 220 TST services conducted between 8 June 2021 and 24 March 2024 and should be understood as a rough mapping, derived primarily from the original descriptions and tags rather than from the study's theoretical framework. The numbers next to each theme denote how many service episodes engage that theme; individual episodes may be assigned to more than one theme.

Satanic Philosophy and Ethics

Tenets 43
Ethics 29
Belief and Evidence 13
Conspiracy theories 2

Satanic Practice

Satanism and other religions or cultures 32
Rituals 21
Holidays 16
Non-US perspectives on TST 13
Ministry 7

Self-care and Community Care

Mental health 24
Religious trauma 11
Relationships 9
Death and Grief 9
Parenting 5
Addiction 4

Diversity perspectives

BIPOC 23
LGBTQ+ 13
Neurodiversity 9
Disability 4

Activism

Protest and Everyday activism 19
Reproductive rights 11
Secularism 8

Identity and Self-expression

Self-expression 11
Privacy 9
Stigma 4
Disclosure 3

Aesthetics

Pop culture 11
Ritual design 9
Style 5

Codes and Analytical Levels

The numbers next to each theme denote instances where codes related to the theme were applied across the interview material, digital material (Minister Mondays and selected TST services), and observational field notes.

Macro Level: TST and Wider Society

- Demographics 11
  - Religious upbringing 9
- Satanic and national identity 9
- Social wrongs 68
  - Christian nationalism 32
  - Abortion 34
- Emotions 17
- Visions of a good society 45
- Alliances and strategies 54
- Diversity (BIPOC, LGBTQ+, neurodiversity, disability) 39
- Campaigns 21

Meso Level: Internal Dynamics

- Community 52
- Community events 45
- Belonging to and identification with TST 47
- Congregations 17
- Voluntary work 27
- Forms of engagement 19
- Collective practice 24
- Aesthetics 20
- Emotions 19
- Polity 53

Micro Level: Negotiation of Identity and Practice

- Stigma experiences 27
- Stigma management 32
- Individual practice 34
- Ministerial practice 23
- Individual vs. collective practice 15
- Blasphemy 13

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